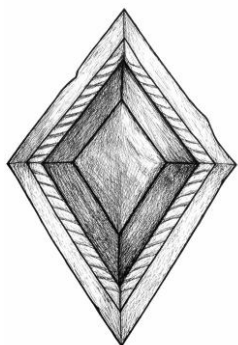


The Song for Light and Dark: The Morrow's Dawn



The Song for Light and Dark: The Morrow's Dawn

By: *Killian Bies*



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*For the ones who walked with me in shadow and never let go of
the light.*

*"The light shines in the darkness, and yet the darkness did not
overcome it."*

— John 1:5 CSB

Of Balance

One bright everlasting light to guide them all
In the land of light where the moon doth shine
One dark ever-present shadow to corrupt them all
In the land of ever night where all horror dines
One *mystic* unknown behind them all
Who *pulls* the strings to let his creations thrive
An order of five placed to balance all alive
Six rings of power for a chosen dark master
One circlet for her protector
One sword for man to wield till time's end
One amulet for the lost king to be held forevermore
In the lands where the sun *shines*, and dark shadows *lie*.

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Preface

The World of Varis Mogul

The world of Varis Mogul is a tapestry woven from a lifetime of inspiration. The groundbreaking works of J.R.R. Tolkien, C.S. Lewis, Ed Greenwood, R.A. Salvatore, and the creative minds behind tabletop adventures like Gary Gygax and David Ameson have fueled my passion for fantasy storytelling. Likewise, the immersive worlds brought to life by Todd Howard have shaped my understanding of deep, lived-in narratives. With their influence as a guiding light, I have sought to carve my path. This work would also be incomplete without the contributions of two dear friends, Evan Paul and Daniel Pasquale, whose insights and collaboration breathed fresh vitality into the creation of Varis Mogul.

In the early days of crafting this world, the three of us delved into the heart of this vast landscape, building characters, cultures, and histories. Many afternoons were spent in the Corum Student Union, brainstorming ideas, discussing what would become the foundation of this first book. Evan, Daniel, and I brought our different imaginations to the table, but together we worked as one. Our efforts to shape this realm led us to question, refine, and at times discard entire ideas. Often, the sparks of these conversations would linger long after, and at random hours, I would find myself texting one of them with new concepts or revisions. From those raw beginnings, we formed a core cast of characters who would grow to be historians and voices of Varis Mogul, chronicling its epochs and recounting its legacies.

Whilst trying to describe Varis Mogul, I hope to convey a land of grandeur and contradiction, from lush forests teeming

with life to dark lands of foreboding mystery. As readers, you'll encounter forests shaded by ancient pines, cities bustling with mortal purpose, rivers winding through kingdoms, and towns that, although humble, carry untold stories. Through each description, I hope to kindle vivid images in your mind that resonate uniquely with each reader. Some images will remain unwritten, left to your imagination, where they can evolve and become as real as the ink on the page.

The story that unfolds within this book centres on the venture of a young man named Ulfar Val. Born to peasant parents, he discovers that God—or perhaps the gods, in his understanding—has a unique path set for him, as if the dreams and ambitions of his youth are finally coming to fruition. Ulfar will face many powerful foes and venture to ancient places thought lost to the ages. He will witness the glimmer of stained glass from eras long past and behold the rising sun on new days that carry the hopes and dreams of his youth.

Along the way, he will forge great relationships, finding companionship and loyalty even in unexpected places. His journey will lead him to experience a love he had never imagined and to rekindle old friendships that serve as pillars of strength and joy. Memories, both bittersweet and cherished, will resurface as he meets friends both old and new, including one such friend who was once a joyful companion in his youth. Together, these experiences will shape Ulfar as he ventures across the small northern continent of Onu-Arith, now home to the vast majority of the Valkorian people. Ulfar's journey will be one of growth, resilience, and revelation, unfolding across landscapes both familiar and strange, as he grapples with his purpose and the grand design he was born to fulfil.

The journey to complete this work was long and, at times, gruelling. I balanced my writing with the responsibilities of being a full-time student and the demands of work, sports, and social life. Writing was, in many ways, a sanctuary and an

adventure of its own, a hobby that grew into a true calling. What began as a sporadic venture into fantasy evolved into a consuming project, taking on a life of its own and rising to the top of my priorities. This journey did not come with a timeline; it grew organically over the years, with the support of friends who believed in the story I wanted to tell.

As the foundations of this world developed, Varis Mogul grew richer and more complex. Initially, the races were few—humans, elves, and dwarves—but over time, they evolved and took on new dimensions. There were moments of fervent brainstorming, where each race would morph in function and meaning. Humans, created in the image of Goht, were destined to embody both courage and flaw, creatures capable of sin yet also of nobility and grace. The elves took their place as curators and protectors, warding against an ever-present darkness, while the orcs, bound by their twisted allegiance, played the role of darkened pawns. The dwarves emerged as beings of mystery and inner struggle, marked by both their greed and their loyalty, steadfast in times of need. Each race, culture, and kingdom serves a purpose, and each has its place in the grand story of Varis Mogul.

I recall vividly those moments of creation, the conversations with Evan and Daniel, the initial concepts, and how they transformed over time. Seeing these ideas evolve into a cohesive world brings me great joy, and I'm forever grateful for the companionship and creativity of my friends throughout this journey. Together, we've built something that fills me with pride, no matter where the story leads from here.

If I could impart two pieces of advice to readers and fellow dreamers, it would be this: No matter your age or occupation, let your imagination soar, and set goals that challenge you, even if they seem out of reach. As Norman Vincent Peale said, "Shoot for the moon. Even if you miss, you'll land among the stars." Our time in this life is but a speck in the

vast desert of existence, yet we've each been given the gift of imagination. Embrace it, dare to dream, and never stop creating.

With that, I welcome you to the expansive, mystical, and wondrous world of Varis Mogul.

Prologue

To You, A World Away 100,000 Years in the Future

I write these words to you, dear friend, whom I shall never meet. These words are a bridge between worlds, from mine to yours—a thread of memory and truth that I weave for you to grasp. Take these stories and legends how you may, with all their triumphs and tragedies, their whispers of long-forgotten realms and echoes of ancient wars. But please remember, within each tale lies a message from our Lord, a hidden truth woven into the fabric of these words.

Each line I pen, each story that rolls from my tongue, carries a fair truth of the world in which I lived—one filled with light and shadow, hope and despair. I know, in the deepest part of my heart, that you and I shall never meet nor see the gleam of the sun upon each other's eyes. Yet, within these stories, there is a chance for you to know me, to catch glimpses of my soul, reflected in the tales of heroes and villains, of places that linger on the edge of dreams.

Each story I share with you, dear reader, is a piece of me, a fragment of my life, offered so that you may hold it for but a moment. Now, dear friend, welcome to the world I was born to—a world of beauty and danger, of whispers in the wind and shadows that stretch long under the fading sun. Let my words be your guide through lands you've never tread, to places you may only know through the ink and paper that bear this message. For though we may be separated by time, by fate, and by the very

essence of our worlds, my stories are a path, a lantern, a small piece of me left behind for you to find.

This vast, forsaken, and accursed world stretches beyond the reaches of mortal comprehension, a boundless realm where shadows stretch long over valleys and the mountains pierce the heavens. It is a land filled with many great creations of the Unknown creator, a being whose name drifts through time like a forgotten whisper, whom some will come to call Goht. Among the sages and poets, questions stir like the winds that sweep across desolate plains: is the destiny of man controlled by some bygone entity, or does a hidden god pull the strings of fate from realms beyond the stars?

In the beginning, Goht spoke the world into existence with a single word: 'Erá.' From the void came land, sky, and sea, and with them, the first spirits, the Amaér, who wove the fabric of nature itself. Yet Goht was not content, and so from the earth, he shaped two beings in his image—Vaeimea, the Light, and Vareiké, the Wanderer. But where one sought beauty, the other sought power, and so began the first betrayal. Vareiké, now Valkar, turned from Goht's light, drawn into the whispers of the abyss. His rebellion scarred the heavens and the earth, and from his fall, darkness took root in the world. It would come to be that Vaeimea would be given a gift, its power would be one which allowed her to create life in the image of Goht, this gift would come to carry the name Alundél, which came to mean the Gem of Life, and so she would begin to populate the world.

First would be of my kin, the elves whose being was immortal, yet we drew difficulties in rising to the Eden paradise forged by Vaeimea. So then came whom she called her greatest of creations, man, who would be endowed with the greatest gift of mortality, yet swayed by the temptations of power in the still fallen world. She would bring forth two versions of man, first the Dalmithe, but their time on the earth was brief, averaging a lifespan of merely a hundred years. They were beings of swift

brilliance, like a comet that streaks through the night sky only to fade all too quickly. Seeing the limitations of the Dalmithe, Vaeimea sought to create a second group, one that would carry the essence of the elves' longevity yet still retain the mortal gift. Thus, she brought forth the Valkorians—humans made in the likeness of her, but with a lifespan that stretched to nearly four hundred years. To the Valkorians, this gift was a mark of divine favour, a symbol that Vaeimea had placed a special love upon their kind.

Yet, as with all great gifts, this divine favour came with its burdens. The elves, seeing humans granted the gift of mortality and the possibility of an afterlife with Vaeimea, felt a growing envy and sense of rivalry. This natural rivalry would open as both races came to be in the First Era of Varis Mogul, yet it would be the Dark Elves, the Vaidir, who drew a staunch rivalry with that of the humans, those of the Valkorian Empire, who lived longer lives than most, ranging from two hundred to four hundred years.

The first King of Men known by the name of Tirín, who would come to name his line Valin which in the ancient tongue of man meant 'shining lord' a name which would ring the dreams that he had for the Valkorian humans, he had the visions of vast endless gleaming white stone built cities that spit to the stars rivaling the works of the elves. And so then he came to declare the Valkorian Kingdom, in his reign, the capital of Argolin, the most beautiful and elegant city of man. It was said that the Vamir, the high elves of Arkámëndrón, had come across the seas and helped man build the glowing white city. And then, as the line of Valin ruled, the names of many great kings would come to be and pass, and the balance of peace between the elves and men would continue as peace between the two races ensued. Yet as the rise of Tón the Elder, who was key in Men helping end the War of Vengeance.

Here at the turning of the second millennium and the

rising of the third, a promise would be made by the greatest of all elven smiths, the Vamir Frenar, who had taken the idol of Vaeimea, the Alundél, and as its light faded, he immortalised it in the form of five gems. The elves had promised that all of them to be given to the kings of elves: Vaxar, Draxel, Thrindél, Frenar and Féalbor. Yet one was never given to Draxel and was rumoured to be given to the King of Valkoria. This angered the dark elf and left him in a sense of rivalry renewed; he swelled in his ferocity for many years, as then came the rise of the eighth King, Tavar.

The gem he beheld, which was known to Draxel and thought to be promised to him, was quite the opposite during the War of Vengeance waged by the Dark Lord Valkar during the second millennium. The King of Valkoria, Hurgon, resisted the temptations of Valkar and was so cursed, he would come to find a gem, which seemed to gleam with the light of a mountain's heart, yet it was said to be the very gem which led to Hurgon's tragic demise, which came by pure accident. This gem was taken by his eldest son and one of only two children who lived past the age of twenty, Hónir would challenge the curse of Valkar, taking the gem and forging the Amulet of the Kings. He had sought to pass with the sword, Arenith down with each king who sat on the throne in Argolin. This was the gem which Draxel had thought to belong to him, and thus began an age of blood between the races of dark elves and men.

With the rise of the elf Draxel and the building of his kingdom in the southern reaches of Onu-Derith, the king of the Teldaré murdered the eighth king of Valkoria, Tavar, son of Tumás. Here would come a bloody clash known to the tomes of history as the War of Elves and Men, for it was not merely a clash of swords but a struggle for dominance and survival. Decades passed in bloodshed, and with the vanishing of Draxel and the fall of Talor, son of Tavar, the war reached a critical turning point. But as history would show, war never truly

ends—its echoes ripple forward, shaping the ages to come.

The lord and ascended king of the realm of man, Talor, would lead the effort of this war; his resolve was unyielding, his words carried on the wind as a promise to his people. He would be the one to lead them through the darkness, the beacon in their hour of need. The humans, though divided in their own ways, found unity in his leadership, for Talor possessed both the wisdom of a king and the strength of a warrior. Talor's presence on the battlefield became legendary. With the Amulet of the Kings hanging from his neck—an ancient symbol of authority—and Arenith, the Sword of the King, clenched in his grip, he became a rallying figure for all of mankind. His strategic mind turned what might have been a hopeless defence into a campaign that pushed back Draxel's forces time and time again. As Draxel's shadow sought to spread over Onu-Derith, Talor led his armies with unyielding resolve, bringing them together to face the invading elven force.

The climactic moment came at the Battle of Dalmulog, a place that would be etched into the memories of both elves and men. The plains of Dalmulog, once flat and endless rolling green lands home to the horse lords of Valkoria, had succumbed to relentless rains, turning them into a harsh marsh. There, amidst the jagged cliffs and river-choked valleys, Talor's strategic brilliance was put to the test against Draxel's cunning. The night air was thick with the smell of steel and the cries of warriors, as the fate of Onu-Derith hung in the balance. With Arenith blazing in his hand, Talor stood at the forefront of the human host, embodying the hope of all who fought alongside him.

It was a war that would shape the future of the world, leaving scars upon the land and its people, as blood soaked the fields of Dalmulog. And through it all, the figure of Draxel loomed like a shadow, ever lurking, with his designs to dominate and reshape the world to his dark vision. Yet for every strike of Draxel's cruelty, Talor's unwavering determination countered it.

Their battle was more than a clash of armies; it was a struggle for the very soul of the world, a battle of light against shadow, and of the future yet to unfold.

Talor made his final stand amidst the marshlands of the Dalmulog. As the armies of men retreated, rallying around the steadfast leadership of General Taklu, Talor remained behind, facing the encroaching darkness alone to safeguard his kingdom. It was then that a seemingly human warrior named Melin struck him down, a moment that would echo through history. It was puzzling as the army was not led by the Elven King Draxel, yet he was nowhere to be found.

The Amulet of the Kings, its magic glinting in the mud, slipped from Talor's lifeless grip and vanished into the swamp. As the weeks mounted forth, the war would dissipate with the disappearance of Draxel and the death of Talor, the Dark Elves would make flight of the land, though it was not known where they would go. The amulet so coveted by the lords of men would later resurface, found by a human named General Cartem, who bore it with a burdened heart as he ventured with General Taklu to the fiery streams of Haranaku.

With the churning lava before him, Cartem stood at the precipice, the amulet hanging from his hand, ready to cast it into the abyss. Taklu's voice cut through the air with desperation: "Do not cast it away, Cartem! With the Amulet, we can revive the line! With its power, we can build a land that no elf would ever dare tread!" But Cartem, his face etched with sorrow, stared into the seething molten depths, the weight of the cursed relic pulling at his soul.

He called back, voice cracking under the strain, "Taklu! We cannot keep this accursed item! We must cast it away! No man can carry this—this cur—" the lava flowed below his feet.

Before he could finish, Taklu's blade flashed in the twilight, striking down his closest friend and fellow leader. The

amulet fell from Cartem's grasp into Taklu's hands, a relic whose power would twist and corrupt many men who followed. With that single, treacherous act, the seeds of ruin were sown. Talor's death marked the first pillar in the slow collapse of the once-mighty Valkorian Empire, as his legacy crumbled beneath the ambitions and dark influence that spread like shadows across the land.

And so the Desolation of Valkoria would come to pass after generals would claim the right to rule the Empire. Famine would sweep the land as volcanoes came to erupt, driving the people from their lands of Onu-Derith.

Melin, the mysterious man who dealt the fateful blow to Talor, would become a figure shrouded in myth and dread. By the turn of the Third Era, he was known as the Lord of Vouldorth, Curator of Shadows, the Lord of Darkness, and Master of Evil. He embraced a name that struck fear into the hearts of all who heard it: Malachar.

In the long years of the Second Era, he orchestrated much of the strife that ravaged humanity, pushing them into relentless wars and sowing division among the Valkorians. Through his influence, his darkness seeped into the world, eventually giving rise to the Neirmar Imperium, a remnant of the Valkorian bloodline twisted by ambition and malice.

Though Talor fell, his legacy was not forgotten. The amulet he once bore—the symbol of a shattered empire—vanished into legend, lost to time and war. But such relics do not remain buried forever. Centuries later, beneath the summer sun, a halfling named Greyon wandered the greylands of Onu-Derith, unaware that fate was about to place that very artefact into his hands.

The sun shone brightly with scattered clouds in the sky, looking like small collections of bubbles on an endless, vast blue ocean. With the sun beating down, the coolest spots of the land lie beneath the giant deep green oaken trees with their bases

covered in a soft coat of moss, useful as a bed for napping, and then the areas just by streams or lakes. Not knowing of the tree's great use, he had decided to walk by this ancient stream that extended for miles in both directions. As he followed the stream, the colour of the water went from a crystal clear, untainted liquid to a more muddy and mucky image as he approached a small ridge line. As he climbed over the ridge, his eyes expanded in complete astonishment and confusion.

His curiosity began to draw him ever nearer. As he approached these age-old remains, Greyon was singing a tale of immortal life, "For long live my life, long live my soul, immortal was he, Greyon the Great!" The little half-man danced around with the joyous spirit of a child still. He belted out the tunes of ancient wonders and great dead and placed his name where the mentions of heroes would be.

As he gaited over, he saw the shine of the glowing golden metal which encased the vibrant blood red diamond gemstone, that seemed to glisten with a different hue held deep within. At the very centre of the pendant was this odd gem that seemed to change with the winds of the world, which was encased—held by deep black obsidian shards covered by the same golden material that made up the base of the amulet. It called not for this creature's touch but for something long lost, as if it were that drop of a mug of ale left for the flies and gnats to enjoy.

The small creature stood up and yelled out, "For it was I, Greyon, King of Man, who stayed the hands of evil once and now I shall once more slay those who do fell deeds once more..." As he yelled out his constant idioms, this one replaced King Uriel IX, the legacy King of the once-known Kingdom of Tarédiel.

A friend of Greyon's yelled, "You ain't a dragon fool." The halfling had stopped his verbal dreams and legacies. There was a look not of distraught but of concentration on his little

face.

There was a gleam of a strange, golden metal beckoning to the halfling's gaze, glinting faintly under layers of dust as if it had been waiting an age to be seen once more. Greyon stepped closer, his bare, cautious feet moving lightly over rusted relics and dented armour, each one a shell encasing the bones of those who had fallen long ago. The air was thick with the scent of time and forgotten glory, and a hush seemed to settle around him as he neared the object, its shimmer sharp even in the dim light. "What... what is this?" He murmured, breath catching in awe as his fingers traced the cool, smooth surface. As he lifted the treasure with trembling hands, he marvelled aloud, his voice no more than a whisper. "Shiny... beautiful... powerful."

The young man picked up the amulet and looked deep into the bleeding gemstone, and was instantly mesmerised by the presence and feel of power emanating from it. There was what seemed to be an eerie, wispy voice coming from the pendant, as the dulmir man looked ever deeper into the gem, getting lost in the endless maze of promises, "This is my power," he claimed as he grasped it tighter.

A voice that came to the air strong, yet dissolved and as faint as mist, whispers, "Claim me as your own."

As he gazed upon the crystal, it seemed to change its very form within his hand; the golden metal stayed the same, yet the gem was no longer what it once was. "Take?" Greyon's voice wavers, curiosity flickering in his gaze. Then, with a fervent whisper, he answers, "Yes... Yes, I will take."

Here again, the faint whisper came across the mind of the little one. A voice that seemed not of goodness, but of some work of a more evil nature. The voice called to him, "I shall give you your dream of eternal life, Dulmir Greyon, son of Greygor."

His eyes gleamed at the promise of eternal life; this is the one thing the halfling had always sought for. "You are mine forever, forever, forever!" He yelled frantically, jumping up and

down, holding the amulet up towards the sky. His words echoed, and his friend downriver heard his scream. Startled, he began running towards where the sound emanated from.

The friend of Greyon chaotically runs over, calling out, “Greyon! Greyon, where are you?” He runs, eventually finding him after a few minutes, standing over the long-dead bodies of men. “Hey, what are you doing?” he exclaimed with fear deep in his voice, “and wh...what are all these bodies doing here?”

Greyon grabs the arm of his friend and drags him away, leaving the lands by the river, failing to mention the new trinket he had collected as he grasps the powerful amulet with a choking grip in his pocket. Then he abruptly grabs his friend and says, “Nothing, we are going now.”

As the relentless years wore on, both he and his friends watched each other grow, lives evolving with time—yet an unyielding truth began to haunt them. His closest friend was first to see it: while the world aged, Greyon did not; if anything, he seemed to grow younger with each passing season. This agelessness was remarked upon often, each mention driving him further into the thrall of the amulet he bore. It stirred his heart in ways dark and unfathomable, deepening a hidden fury that gnawed at his core. The amulet took root within him, twisting his desires until he began to ache as though becoming the very shadow he feared, drawn to a lust that clouded his every thought.

In time, each question spoken to him felt a threat, not to his life, but to the amulet he now held above all else. For nearly a century, Greyon—a once noble dulmir—battled the pull of this ancient power, though each day it corrupted him further. His descent culminated when he raised his hand against his old friend, the one who had once shared peaceful rivers with him, slaying him in a blind fury born of suspicion. Convinced that all who knew him sought to steal his treasure, he abandoned the lands that had been his home for ninety-five years. He wandered beyond the familiar valleys and streams, carrying the burden of

his transgression, haunted by the knowledge that he could never return.

For the next sixteen centuries, Greyon wandered from one distant land to the next, his form altering with each passing age as he grappled with darkening and relentless temptations. The pull of darkness clashed against his will, leaving its mark upon his body, ageing him beyond the natural span of his kind. His eyes grew shadowed with ancient burdens, his frame bent yet unbroken, each step weary with the toll of resisting his own soul's undoing.

And yet, his path continued, leading him back to the continent of Onu-Derith. By the two-hundred and thirty-first year of the Third Era, the lands he returned to had become a patchwork of clashing tribes—the Dalmithe and Valkorians, their cultures and loyalties as tangled and fierce as ever. Here, on the eve of midsummer, he felt the old magic stirring beneath his feet. Compelled as if by fate's invisible hand, Greyon set forth to Onu-Arith, seeking the cavernous depths of the Tellmithe mountain range in the continent's northeastern reaches. It was there, amid the shadowed labyrinth of stone and ancient whispers, that his fate—and perhaps that of the entire world—would be forever altered.

By the dawn of the Third Era, history became legend, and legend became whispers told around dying fires. The Valkorian people, once mighty, had become fractured, their stories lost to the sands of time. Yet, history has a way of repeating itself, and in the far north of Onu-Arith, destiny stirred once more. Ah, but history does not sleep, does it? It merely waits, shifting beneath the weight of time until a new soul stirs the embers of the past... And so we turn to Ulfar, a child unaware of the storm that awaited him.

Among the scattered remnants of these people, this boy named Ulfar Val was born into poverty, his family struggling to survive amidst the chaos of the ever-raging civil war among the

fractured Valkorian factions. Ulfar's father, Aelfred, a resolute leader in the revolution, returned from the battlefield to witness the birth of his only son. And his mother, Lalia the daughter of a notorious adventurer and explorer of the world. Though Aelfred despised war, he knew its inevitability and spent the next ten years teaching Ulfar all he could, preparing him for the burdens that he, too, would one day bear.

As Ulfar grew, so did his resolve. His life would be defined by his defiance of the Imperium's tyranny. Rallying the scattered remnants of his people, he would ignite the flames of rebellion, vowing to reclaim their lost glory. Yet, in the shadows of this tale lies Malachar, a figure whose dark influence weaves through Ulfar's journey like a serpent coiled in secret, biding its time.

But now the world has changed, I can feel it in the wind which catches my hair, the light which shines and glimmers off the twin moons, and I feel it through the ground as my feet glide across the moss. The evils of this world have been thought to be dispelled, though it is as if their shadow yet looms, and the events of history have come to pass yet again. My eyes have come to see the rise and fall of two Dark Lords, yet this is different, a new wisp of wind, one unfelt by many.

As this new Era dawned, the Valkorian people were still only pebbles compared to their former glory. They lay scattered throughout the lands of men, and in the northern earth, they lay embroiled in a bitter civil war. The conflict gave rise to two factions: the Stormfangs, a defiant force determined to reclaim their heritage, and the Imperium, an iron-fisted power built upon the ruins of a lost legacy. It is in this turbulent time that Ulfar's story begins, a tale of fire and resolve, of struggle and redemption. We start by looking back at the events that forged him into the man who would rise as a revolutionary leader and hero—a hero whose story unfolds in the first centuries of the Third Era...

Chapter 1

A Seed is Sown

There came a sunrise unlike any in the memory of the eldest, though they had heard whispers of such a dawn in the fading tales of old. It was a light that stirred not only the earth but the very bones of those who watched it rise—a gleam of power, not born of the turning of days, but of an age reborn. The sun climbed slowly and resolutely, as if to herald the strength long promised in the songs of the fathers, a strength whispered on the lips of those who remembered.

The village was in uproar on this eve of midsummer, its centre strewn with tents and tables as the countless men, women, and children of the village ran dancing, prancing and having a ball for it was the tenth birthday of one special boy, the son of Aelfred, Ulfar. It was a celebration of age for in the culture of the Valkorians, there were two major celebrations for men, their tenth and their twentieth birthdays, both of which it was common for the boy to be given a blade. On his tenth, he would receive his first training wooden sword, and then his first sharpened steel would arrive a decade later. This was an extravagant time for celebration, and the village folk celebrated Ulfar's date of birth. Some families had even ventured from villages far away. On this day, there were plenty of notable people, distant aunts and so-called uncles of the young boy who did nothing but endlessly

run through the streets and meadows of the village singing his wooden blade as if he were a hero of the First Era.

The song and dance was that of the human legends of heaven, Ulfar took a pause from his endless quests and ancient tales of slaying giants, dragons, and he gazed at his father and mother who stood talking to a tall man draped in blue with a large intense gray beard which stretched from his head and upon the top lay a great old hat and in hand, a staff which seemed to be older than this man. To the young boy, this older gentleman seemed to have had more years than everyone in the village combined. The three talked as old friends or near relatives, yet the young boy wondered who this man was and why they seemed so close, yet he had no memory of this old man. He shrugged it off as he ran over and swung his blade into his father, proclaiming as he did, "I will strike you down, warlord!"

It was not the normal feeling of his father's arm or body, which was what the recent hours had come to know as the normal feeling, yet something harsher and the sound of a loud crack came to echo; it was the wood of the staff of the old man, which scared the young man, forcing him to hide behind his father. The three adults burst into laughter at the actions of the young kid; he backed away from the space between the three adults and himself when Ulfar was approached by his father.

As he came down to a single knee and placed a hand upon the shoulder of Ulfar he said to his son, "Ulfar, my first and only son. Here take this but do not open it until your twentieth birthday," he handed his son an envelope sealed with wax, "or if I still am here on that day bring this to me and we both will talk, one which the strings of fate will weave in time. Now run and slay the monsters of this village, my little birthday boy!" As Aelfred's words trailed off, his voice came from the earlier serious tone to something much more playful, as if to be frivolous speech in the trying times before a charge of war. The party would go on, and the day came to night as the celebration of age and life had come to a close, and there sat the family of

Val in their simple yet elegant house that could only be described as home itself.

On this night of Ulfar's tenth birthday, men ventured to their soft, calm and modest place for a home. They dragged his father from the clutches of his mother while he beckoned to her, "It will all be fine, my dear, raise our son right, I will return when this all ends. I love you both, my wife and son!" This would be a principal memory that the young Ulfar would never forget. He would carry this memory as he once again picked up the wooden sword that his father had once taught him how to wield.

That very wooden sword would serve Ulfar for many years, its weathered wood becoming a silent witness to his growth and the trials of his youth. In the absence of Aelfred, the villagers—though bound by their own toils—sought in small ways to fill the void left in Ulfar's life, but none could replace the man who had shaped his earliest steps. Yet, there was something about Ulfar, an aura that set him apart, drawing others to his side as though destiny itself whispered his name to the wind.

The boys of the village flocked to him, captivated by an unspoken charisma that neither his tender age nor his humble beginnings could explain. Together, they formed a band of restless souls, their laughter and shouts echoing through the glades and meadows that stretched between the clustered villages. His generation, born from the bloodshed and resolve of their fathers, was a harvest of youth in a land scarred by war. Nearly six villages lay within a few leagues of one another, and their people, once bound only by trade and necessity, were slowly knitting themselves closer through the bonds of their children.

It was not uncommon to see Ulfar astride a sturdy pony, riding off with the village blacksmith—an old soldier turned craftsman—and a loyal band of boys trailing behind him, their wooden swords bouncing at their sides. They would venture to the neighbouring hamlets, exploring the unknown with the

wide-eyed curiosity of youth, though their purpose was never entirely innocent. Ulfar's mother often watched him vanish over the horizon with a mixture of pride and apprehension, her heart heavy with unspoken fears. She never pressed him for details upon his return, though she could see the truth etched into his growing frame: a fresh cut across his cheek, a swollen bruise on his arm, or the jagged dents marring his wooden sword. Each mark told a story of mischief, of scuffles that tested his mettle, and of lessons learned in the hidden corners of their world.

Though she knew not where he went, she could sense that these ventures shaped her son in ways she could scarcely understand. The boy was growing into something larger than the life their quiet village could offer—a force that even in youth seemed bound for legend.

One moonlit evening, as Ulfar and his companions returned from their longest journey yet—a venture to the farthest village he had never before seen—he carried with him more than just the weariness of travel. It was on this trek that he had, for the first time, glimpsed the endless expanse of the ocean, its waves glinting like molten silver under the setting sun. The sight had stolen his breath, a moment of wonder etched forever in his memory, yet his youthful pride kept him from speaking of it to the others. Upon their return, the old blacksmith lingered at the threshold of Ulfar's modest home, his hand resting on the well-worn pommel of his belt knife.

The boy had already disappeared inside, his wooden sword clattering against the doorframe as he passed, leaving the two adults in the quiet glow of the hearthlight spilling onto the cobbled yard.

The blacksmith turned to Lalia, his face shadowed with the weight of words he had carried for some time. “My dear Lalia,” he began, his voice low and steady, like the forge fires he once tended in a time of war. “The boy has grown much in these last few years. Each day, I see more of Aelfred in him—not just in his face, but in the way he stands, the way he carries himself.

In the villages, his band of future soldiers grows stronger by the day. He fears no fight, no matter the odds or the age of his opponent. Many of the wounds he bears come from his stubborn will, his refusal to yield, even to those far older and stronger than him. Yet, somehow, he still finds victory.”

Lalia's face, illuminated by the faint glow of the rising moons, betrayed her weariness. The blacksmith's words stirred a storm in her heart, one of pride and fear that wrestled for dominance. She had seen the changes in her son, the subtle hardening of his spirit, the spark in his eyes that was both familiar and unsettling. It was his father, it was Aelfred's spark—a flame that burned for honour, for battle, for something greater than the simple life of their village. Her hands trembled slightly as she clutched her shawl tighter around her shoulders. “I see it too,” she admitted softly, her voice tinged with a sadness she could not conceal. “And it frightens me. I've already lost one to the toils of war. If the gods are cruel, they will take him from me as well.”

The blacksmith hesitated, his weathered face unreadable. “He is his father's son,” he said after a moment, his voice thick with both admiration and pity. “The same strength runs in his veins. But, Lalia, he's more than that. He carries the fire of something greater—something I've not seen before, even in Aelfred. He is bound for a path that none of us can walk, none, not one of us can grace his side in, but it will not be without purpose.” As the blacksmith's words faded into the stillness of the night, Lalia stood motionless, staring after him as he made his way into the darkness. Inside, Ulfar slept soundly, unaware of the burdens carried by those who loved him most.

In his journeys with the village smith, young Ulfar would often recount the many interesting people he encountered along the way to his mother, Lalia. One evening, with the excitement only a child could muster, he described one such figure. “He was a tall wizard man who had a big stick; he seemed to use it as a cane, yet he moved far too quickly to need

such.” He said, his words tumbling out with unfiltered wonder. Lalia chuckled at the simplicity of his description, yet a knowing glint flashed in her eyes. Few in this world could rightly be called wizards, and even fewer carried the proper staff to match their title.

Curious, Lalia turned to her son, her hands brushing back his unruly hair. “Could you bring this man back with you one time? I would very much like to meet this wizard-man.” She said as her voice filled with gentle amusement. A thrill lit up Ulfar’s face, his youthful enthusiasm shining through. He bounced in his seat, brimming with the excitement of having impressed her with his tale. His eyes sparkled in a way Lalia hadn’t seen in some time—an innocent joy she deeply cherished and missed.

Only a week later, the smith returned to the village with an extra passenger seated in his wagon. This newcomer bore robes as if woven from the very essence of the sky itself, the finest blues shimmering with a subtle brilliance that seemed alive. His long beard, featuring one braid to the left side, a cascade of ancient grey and white, framed his face, giving him an air of timeless wisdom. As he stepped down from the wagon, his piercing gaze found Lalia almost immediately. A warm smile spread across his face—not one of mere politeness, but the unmistakable smile shared by two old friends reunited after many years apart.

Lalia rose from where she had been seated, the surprise clear on her face. Yet, as her eyes truly took him in, recognition dawned, and her expression softened into a smile of her own—one filled with nostalgia and quiet joy. “Good day, my dear sir,” she said. Her voice was tinged with warmth and familiarity.

His smile did not fade even as he let a ring of smoke from his mouth, the old wooden pipe in his hand as he walked up to Lalia and spoke soft yet knowing, “I do hope, my dear friend, that you mean to wish me a good day—though whether it is a

good day or merely a day to be good on, remains to be seen.” His face, which became stern as he spoke slowly, softened as he broke into laughter, “Ah, my dear little Lalia, how I have missed you so. Is this the child born of you and Aelfred?”

She looked upon the elderly man and hugged him, “Oh, how I did miss you, Travers, yes, that is me and my husband's only child.” She motioned for Ulfar to come towards her as he did without question, “I suppose you already know the little man, but this is Ulfar Matthew Val, son of Aelfred Paul Val. He's growing to be much like his father.” She choked up at the end of her last sentence, which gave the wizard a chance to speak.

He moves closer, grabbing the hand of the woman, “Lalia, I cannot speak of your husband's fate, for such matters are veiled even to me. But this I know: for your safety, he would have chosen no other path, no matter the cost.” He turns his gaze to the younger man, “You, Ulfar, remind me greatly of your father in his younger years. Though, if memory serves, by this age he had already forged his first sword—one of his own making, no less.”

The young boy turned his gaze toward his mother, an eager question poised on the edge of his lips. But before he could speak, the smith interjected, his deep, steady voice carrying a note of anticipation. “Pardon me, but if you do not mind, Lalia, I would be honoured to craft him a fine sword for his twentieth birthday. He is coming of age after all, should it not be celebrated? It is only a few years away, after all.” His words lingered in the warm evening air, the kind of promise that carried weight, a commitment forged from respect and admiration.

Lalia's head motioned in a quiet nod, a gesture as graceful as a leaf dipping in the wind. The simplicity of her affirmation was enough to send Ulfar into a frenzy of excitement. His joy burst forth like a dam giving way to a rushing river, and with a sudden, spirited whoop, he bolted toward the field where his friends often gathered, his laughter echoing like bells through the fading light.

As the boy disappeared into the horizon, Lalia turned back toward the door of her modest home. The faint creak of its wooden hinges greeted her as she paused and glanced over her shoulder at the wizard, Travers. Her voice, soft yet tinged with a playful edge, broke the quiet. “I do believe it is four on the dot. You are always welcome for tea, my dear friend.” Her words were accompanied by a subtle smirk, a knowing curve of her lips that carried the weight of an old, cherished memory. It was a private jest, a reference to a story Travers had once told her in their youth—a tale spun with the fervour of young hearts, back when the world was boundless and full of promise.

Travers stood still for a moment, his weathered hands resting on the handle of his age-worn staff. His heart could feel the joy of her heart, as if it were a tree that bore its fruit for the first time in many ages, he knew the woman had felt a full joy for her first time in many years and it was not a joy born of children that is inevitable but one that is reminiscent of a child's wandering mind of creativity. His eyes softened as he watched her retreat inside, the faintest trace of nostalgia flickering across his features.

For a fleeting moment, he no longer saw the poised woman standing before him but the spirited young girl he had once known—a girl whose laughter had once rung like chimes in the summer breeze, whose youthful mischief had once matched his own. The door closed behind Lalia with a soft click, but the memory lingered like the scent of wildflowers after a storm, vivid and unyielding. Travers remained rooted where he stood, his heart warmed by the knowledge that time, though relentless in its march, had not entirely eroded the bond they had shared.

Just as times long past the two shared tea for what was the first time since the birth of young Ulfar, they talk about nothing more than the lives of those around him. Yet there were very few things that stood out in the conversation, after a few hours had passed it was question that always lingered in her mind, one which she never could quite glean the answer yet she

needed to know, “Have you...you ever gone back to the places in the stories?”

Relaxing back the large statured old man took a sip of tea then looked at the map on their wall, it was one he knew quite well for it had been in his possession for many years his eyes came back to her and had a soft tone that matched his soothing demeanor, “To there,” he said, his staff resting upon the map, where a red cross marked a valley long forgotten. “I have not been since that journey. It was ever your father's dream to return, though neither he nor I ever did. He wished to show you the shining halls of that valley, to walk with you in its splendour. Yet I do not believe the time has come to return. The world shifts, my dear Miss Lalia—a shift I have only now begun to sense in this realm of men. But worry not for your father; he rests peacefully among the elves of Elendaiél, where the stars sing softly of his deeds.”

It was then that the two heard the sound of children falling by the windows. Ulfar, amongst others, had been snooping on their conversations, though the mention of elves was shocking to them. A young boy and close friend by the name of Vivel Valdrión turned to Ulfar and gasped, saying, “Elves truly exist, and your grandfather lives with them?” This astonishment was echoed by all of them, including Ulfar, who was clueless about his grandfather's existence.

Travers the Wizard continued, saying, “The curiosity of young children never ceases to amaze me. I know your heart drifts toward fleeing to Elendaiél. Yet, the boy's place is here. I sense he has a greater part to play in the tale of men, though whether it shall be for good or ill, even I cannot yet discern.” And with that, their tea had finished, and the old man was off once again. As he walked through the worn door, he turned to his dear friend once more, “You are his mother, yes, but not even you can hide him from the weight of the name you bear. The blood flows with power on both sides—whether from the Vals or

the Carasans, it matters not. And I, my dear Lalia, shall miss you once more, as I have before.”

As he finishes his sentence, Lalia hugs him once more. In her hand, he places a paper, folded and neat.

“I know, Travers. Please do not forget you will always be welcome at any time, for tea or any business. Blessed travels, my dear friend. I will miss you as well.” The old wizard begins to walk away when one final question comes from the woman as she says, “Will I see you again?”

A soft chuckle comes from the bearded man as Travers replies with, “Oh, yes, my dear little one, you will. The world may be vast, and my years far greater than most, but I shall be with you again. And there will come a time when you, perhaps, will ask me to leave.” And with that final assurance to the mother of Ulfar, her dear friend leaves once more with fond memories and smiles on both of their faces.

While he walks away, she opens the paper to find a poem inscribed, one which she had heard once before from her father, a small nod to her youth. It read:

*Not all who are silent are empty,
Nor every quiet heart weak;
The stone that lies dull in the river
may hide the fire you seek.
Not all splendour is clad in silver,
not all crowns are forged of gold;
The hand that bears no signet
may yet the kingdom hold.
From ashes the ember is kindled,
from shadow the true light springs;
The blade long forgotten in darkness
still knows the song it sings.
Look not to the roar for wisdom,
nor the thunder to know the way;
For oft in the hush of the twilight*

the mightiest truths will stay.

The days had turned to months, the months into years, and the years into memories that bore both the weight of loss and the resilience of a life yet lived. Ulfar's twentieth birthday arrived with the quiet inevitability of the passing seasons, and for Lalia, it was a day of lament and remembrance. A promise whispered years ago echoed in her heart—a promise to gift her son a sword forged in the image of the one his father, Aelfred, had wielded in life and left behind in death. She had always known this day would come, yet the thought of it was like a shadow that never left her side.

Ulfar awoke that morning with a peculiar blend of determination and melancholy. His steps carried a fire that seemed to pulse from within, and as he emerged from his room, his presence filled the home like a tide rising to meet the shore. Without a word, he approached his mother and wrapped his arms around her, holding her in a silence that said more than words could convey. When he finally spoke, his voice was soft, carrying the gravity of a vow. "I promise you now, Mother," he said, "I will see to it that his dream will be made true."

Lalia pulled away slightly, searching his face, her brow furrowed in confusion. "What dream do you mean, my son?" She asked, her voice tinged with both curiosity and a mother's quiet fear.

Before Ulfar could respond, the door creaked open, and the village blacksmith entered, his steps deliberate, his weathered hands cradling an object wrapped in fabric as dark as midnight. Ulfar reached into his pocket, producing a piece of parchment that had aged alongside him, its edges frayed and its ink faded. He handed it to his mother, who took it with trembling fingers. As her eyes scanned the words, the voice of Aelfred seemed to rise from the page, carried on the breath of memory:

My son, my dear Ulfar,

I hope you never need to read this, but if you have, it means I am no longer with you and your mother. As a child, I dreamt of ancient Valkoria—a kingdom so perfect it seemed the work of the gods themselves. But that dream was shattered with the death of Talor, and our people turned on one another. Yet I believe it can be restored. We must defeat the Neirmar Imperium, for it is they who have bound us in chains. I was not taken by the Queen's men, as you may have been told.

I returned to the rebellion I once forged in secret. I am sorry I could not tell you, my son. I dreamed that you and your mother would one day walk freely in the halls of the capital city, unburdened by the yoke of oppression.

You must start anew where I could not succeed. The rebellion of old will never win, but you—Ulfar, with the heart of our ancestors and a charisma I lacked—can rally our people.

Be a defender of those who cannot defend themselves.

Tears welled in Lalia's eyes as she read her husband's words. She had always known, deep in her heart, that this day would come—the day her only son would step onto the path his father had dreamed of, the path of rebellion and war. Yet the knowledge did little to soften the ache of a mother's love. The blacksmith cleared his throat, drawing their attention. Lalia turned to him, her sorrow masked by a quiet dignity. She stepped forward, taking the bundle from his hands with the care one might give to a sacred relic. The silk shimmered faintly in the firelight, a dark

and ethereal veil over what lay beneath. Her steps were steady but heavy with purpose as she carried it to Ulfar, her gaze locking with his—a gaze filled with the fierce love of a mother and the unspoken grief of knowing she could not shield him from the path he had chosen.

“Ulfar,” she said, her voice steady but laden with emotion, “if you truly mean to fulfil your father’s dream and avenge him, then you will need a blade worthy of that purpose. This is no mere sword. It was forged for a hand destined to change the course of our people’s history.” She handed the bundle to her son, her fingers lingering on the fabric as though trying to impart her strength, her resolve, her blessing. Slowly, reverently, Ulfar unwrapped the silk, revealing a blade that seemed almost alive in the firelight. The patterns of grey and silver Damascus swirled across its surface like rivers of molten steel, a testament to the blacksmith’s unmatched skill.

The old smith stepped forward, his voice heavy with pride and reverence. “Ulfar, this is the finest work I have ever forged. Years it has taken me to craft a weapon worthy of ancient Valkoria. It may not be Arenith, but it is a fine sword all the same—fit to fell generals and queens alike.”

Ulfar grasped the hilt, feeling the weight and balance of the blade. It was perfect, an extension of his will and a link to the warriors of old. Swinging it lightly, testing its heft, he turned to the two who had given him so much—his mother and the old blacksmith. “Thank you both.” He said, his voice firm and resolute. “This weapon will be the one that slays the wicked Queen. She deserves no more than the eternal night which lies in her future.” He held the blade aloft, the firelight catching on its edge, casting a gleam that seemed to pierce the shadows. Standing proud and powerful, he gazed out the lone, tainted window that overlooked the open fields stretching southwest toward the Queen’s lands.

Wrapping his arms around both his mother and the blacksmith, Ulfar allowed himself a moment of gratitude, of

quiet resolve. Then, without hesitation, he raced outside, eager to test the weapon. In the village square, the other boys gathered, their simple wooden swords and daggers a stark contrast to the weapon Ulfar now wielded. Yet in their eyes, he saw the same spark, the same yearning for something greater. They looked to him, not for the blade he carried, but for the strength and purpose that now burned within him.

And so, in that moment, the seeds of Ulfar's destiny were sown. He was no longer merely a boy, no longer just the son of Aelfred. The weight of an ancient legacy settled upon his shoulders, and though he bore it with the grace of youth, its enormity was not lost on him. Ulfar was now the future of a rebellion—a beacon of hope for a people long burdened under the yoke of oppression. His new blade, forged with care and purpose, was not just a weapon in his hands; it was a symbol of his resolve, a key to unlocking the destiny etched into his bloodline. The fire ignited within him burned fiercely, driving him forward with unrelenting determination. Sleep became a distant luxury, for every waking moment was spent sharpening his skills and planning his path. The sword, gleaming with the marks of craftsmanship and sacrifice, never left his side. Yet, for all his newfound purpose, doubt lingered at the edges of his mind. Why him? Why should he, of all people, be chosen to bear such a monumental task? His heart wrestled with these questions. In his solitude, he found himself drawn to a single name: Talor.

Talor, the legendary hero, the last king of the Valkorian Empire, loomed large in the collective memory of his people. The old tales told of his ascension, how he rose to become not merely a king but a god—a living embodiment of hope and unyielding strength. For generations, every Valkorian child had grown up idolising Talor, envisioning his deeds as the pinnacle of valour and honour. Ulfar had been no different. As a boy, he had pored over the tattered books and listened to the stories spun by the elders around the hearth. He had imagined Talor's image

countless times, a figure of radiant power and resolute calm, a king who bore the weight of an empire with dignity.

Yet now, when Ulfar conjured the image of Talor, it was not the mythical figure of the stories that came to mind. It was his father. Aelfred's face, weathered and strong, appeared in his thoughts with haunting clarity. He saw the same fierce determination in his father's eyes, the same unyielding strength in his posture. In that moment, Ulfar felt as if the past and present had intertwined, as though his father had been the echo of something far greater—a link in a chain stretching back to Talor himself. The realisation sent a shiver down his spine, but it also solidified his resolve. If Talor had risen to godhood for the sake of his people, then Ulfar, too, could rise—not as a god, but as a leader, a defender, a warrior for those who could not fight for themselves.

As the years passed, Ulfar's purpose evolved, shifting like a blade forged in fire—its shape hardened, its edge sharper, yet its core increasingly veiled in shadow. What had begun as a thirst for retribution, a noble vision of rebuilding and reclaiming the greatness his people had lost, twisted into something far more complex and sinister. To those who stood beside him, those who rallied under the banner of the Stormfangs, he remained the steadfast young leader, unyielding and resolute. His speeches burned with passion, his actions exuded conviction, and his followers saw him as a beacon of hope. But beneath the surface, a quiet storm brewed. Resentment festered within him, hidden from the world but ever-present in his thoughts. It found its focus in the figure of Anne Hargath, the newly crowned queen of the Neimar Imperium. She had ascended to the throne after her mother, the infamous Mad Queen, had met her end—a victory celebrated by many, yet one that brought Ulfar no solace.

Though he had never seen Anne Hargath's face nor heard her voice, he harboured an unrelenting discontent for her. To him, her name alone carried the weight of every atrocity committed against his people. The sins of her lineage, real or

imagined, were enough to condemn her in his eyes. She was no mere monarch but the living symbol of all he despised, the inheritor of a legacy he had sworn to destroy.

This hatred became a fire that fueled him, a shadow that lingered even in moments of triumph. Every victory on the battlefield, every ally who joined his cause, seemed to deepen his resolve rather than quench his thirst for vengeance. Anne Hargath was not just an enemy to be overthrown; she was the culmination of everything wrong with the Imperium. In his mind, her bloodline was a stain on the history of his people, and he became consumed with the thought of erasing it. He didn't need to know her personally—her existence alone was enough to ignite his wrath.

That wrath, unspoken yet ever-growing, began to manifest in ways both subtle and profound. Ulfar's strength seemed superhuman at times, his determination unshakable, his charisma almost otherworldly. To his followers, he was a warrior, a king in the making, a leader who could restore the glory of Valkoria. Yet to himself, he was something darker—an avenger, a blade forged to cut down the Hargath name and all it represented. Each passing day only hardened this resolve; every sunrise was a reminder of his purpose. His hatred became his anchor, his weapon, and his curse, intertwining with his dream of freedom until the two were inseparable. And so, Ulfar strode forward, his path illuminated not by the light of hope but by the searing flames of vengeance, his shadow growing longer with each step.

Chapter 2

Of the Tellmithe

In the two-hundred and eighty-eighth year of the Third Era, Ulfar lay resting in the modest home where he had spent his entire life. The night was peculiar, for both moons hung full in the sky—a rare celestial alignment over Varis Mogul. Many considered such a sight a dark omen, a sign that the gods themselves might walk among mortals before the night was through. Ulfar, too, noted the eerie glow of the twin moons as their pale light spilt through his window, illuminating the room with an otherworldly hue. Though he tried to shake the unease gnawing at his thoughts, it clung to him as sleep finally took hold. In his slumber, Ulfar dreamed of a vision so vivid and profound it felt more real than waking life.

Before him stood a glowing woman, radiant beyond comprehension, as though she embodied all that was pure and good in the world. Her hair shimmered like threads of spun silver, a cascading river of light. Her gown seemed alive, woven from the very essence of life itself—vibrant greens flowing and shifting as though made from leaves and vines kissed by sunlight. She stood in a realm that could only be described as Eden, a place untouched by the flaws of the mortal world. Immaculate and serene, it exuded an otherworldly perfection, a sanctuary devoid of pain or corruption.

The woman's gaze fell upon Ulfar, and for that fleeting moment, it was as though his soul was laid bare before her. He felt his heart lighten, as if the burdens of vengeance and hatred that had weighed him down for years had been stripped away. In their place, a renewed sense of purpose began to take root—a clarity he had not known since the days before his people's oppression. The purity of her presence reminded him of the greater good he once sought, of a vision of hope and redemption that had long been overshadowed by his quest for retribution.

Compelled by the vision, Ulfar attempted to step toward her, his arms outstretched, yet the dream would not allow it. The more he tried to move forward, the further away he seemed to drift. The ground beneath him gave way, and he was carried backwards with increasing speed, soaring southward over the land. Mountains rose and fell beneath him as the Tellmithe peaks loomed into view.

The dream carried him relentlessly until he found himself hurtling back to his own bed, to the very place where he had begun. With a sharp gasp, he awoke, his body drenched in cold sweat, his heart pounding as if it sought to leap from his chest. The vision lingered in his mind, vivid and unshakable. The glowing woman, the perfection of her world, and the overwhelming sense of purity she had instilled in him all pointed to one undeniable truth: he had to venture north. Something was hidden within the Tellmithe Mountains, something the gods themselves wished him to find. Though he did not yet understand what lay ahead, Ulfar knew his path had been chosen. The journey to uncover what awaited him in those peaks would soon begin, and with it, the destiny he had long sought to claim.

As he rose in the morning, Ulfar gathered the fierce-hearted people of the plains, those who had come to believe in his cause and yearned for the same dream of restoration.

Standing among his devoted followers, he addressed them, his voice steady and weighted with purpose. “It is not yet

time, my brothers and sisters,” he said, his gaze sweeping across their eager faces. “We must build our strength. I am called northward to the Tellmithe Mountains, to the peak of Mount Maierr, to find whatever fate awaits me there.” The people before him began to talk amongst themselves, confused why, after so many years, he would leave without much explanation, yet those who knew Ulfar since his childhood knew this to be his nature. Before him, a map of the vast continent of Onu-Arith was spread across the table, the parchment marked with inked trails and borders as if foretelling the path he would take. His hands rested on the table's edge, clenched with silent resolve, as the two men beside him—his closest friends and now loyal fists, Gunmar and Vivel—looked upon him.

In almost unison, they responded, their voices brimming with a fierce resolve that matched his own, “Then both of us shall accompany you, drengar?” The question was more a vow than a request, as the two, his closest allies and dearest friends since his youngest days, awaited his word with fierce loyalty gleaming in their eyes.

He waves his hand as a chuckle comes across his face, followed by a simple smile in jousting fashion, he says, “I must complete this journey alone with only me and the gods. I trust you two to be here and continue to spread the message and train this army; this is a greater deal than protecting me.”

Ulfar walks past the two and points out towards all the young sons of the surrounding villages, proclaiming, “While I am gone, it is up to both of you to take these poor fools and turn them into the grand men who will reclaim our lands from the pathetic cowards in Valkoria. I implore you both, for however long my journey takes, please continue what we have begun together, and no matter what may happen to me, you both must promise to carry on and continue to spread the reasoning for our war. Do you both swear to this?”

With hesitation, both of them again in unison say, “Yes, we agree, Ulfar.” Then they nodded their heads, and a face of

anger came across Gunmar, and his dear counterpart Vivel was more or less accepting of his dear friend's wish. They did all they could to prepare Ulfar for his grand first venture.

Ulfar walks away from the two, holding his sheathed sword in his left and his helmet in his right. Ulfar knew, as he walked off, it may be the very last time he sees his childhood friends. He walks towards his horse and begins to ready it for the long, few-day journey up to the cavemous mountains. As he prepared his steed, his mother came to him, "I will not try to stop you, but I will say my son, your people here will protect your dream and make the wave of fire coming ever bigger. May Vaeimea, the Mother, bless you on your journey." She finishes her blessing with a large hug for her one and only son.

With preparations complete and armour gleaming beneath the morning sun, Ulfar mounted his midnight-black steed, a powerful, sinewed creature encased in polished steel that shimmered like a dark river at dawn. He turned to face his gathered followers, his voice unwavering and charged with solemn resolve as he called out, "Fear not, for I shall return to you by autumn's eve, at the first light of dawn. Then I will stand before you once more, having proven myself worthy of your admiration and loyalty. In Talor's great name, I bid thee farewell."

With that, he spurred his steed forward, galloping across the windswept plains, the dark form of man and horse merging with the shadowed landscape as he set out toward the distant, looming peaks of the Tellmithe Mountains. His journey began on the second day of Vaeim, and he vowed to conquer the wilderness, its unknown perils, and whatever trials lay ahead in those sixty fateful days.

A week passed, and he reached the foot of the mountains. That night, as he lay encamped beneath their stark and jagged slopes—sharp as broken blades that tore against the darkened sky—a deep, unsettled feeling washed over him, whispering in the chill mountain air. Sleep finally claimed him,

yet it brought neither peace nor rest, only a vision both strange and wondrous. In his dream, he sensed the mighty presence of Talor himself, like a spectral voice brushing through the shadows of his mind. Before him, the stark black cliffs melted away, revealing a verdant oasis on the mountainside—lush, green, and alive with colour. This place, vivid and surreal, was bathed in shades of emerald, with towering ancient trees whose branches touched the heavens, creating a canopy of life. At the heart of this haven lay a pool, its waters as clear and brilliant as a cloudless sky, shimmering with a serene blue light. The scene was in sharp contrast to the bleak, rocky terrain around him, a vision so real and tantalising he could almost feel the coolness of the water, smell the earth, and hear the whispers of leaves in an unseen breeze.

When he wakes up, Ulfar remembers the vision vividly, having next to no context about the importance of this place, which is stuck in the eye of his mind. As he shuffles through the countless stories his father and mother, and the old wizard, had told him in his younger years, he comes to the realisation that it can only be the mythical Lake of Eden. He begins to climb up the jagged, violent mountains, leaving his horse behind, bidding farewell to his trustful mount on the open plains, “Goodbye, Blackmere, run free now if you still seek to serve me. I will be back in a few weeks' time.”

Progressing up through the mountain, he begins to drop his pieces of armour from heaviest to lightest to stop from being dragged down by the heft of his full kit. With the sun rising past noon, he sought to find a place to rest for an hour or two and eat a meal. His initial scan of the mountain face yielded no results, leading him to continue his journey on what energy he could draw from down deep. Looking ahead on the face of the rocks, Ulfar saw what could be a cave a few hundred feet further up. He planned to climb there and rest for a short period. A few hours passed before he finally came to the small cutout. Seeing

dried plants which once held life, but no more, he knew it would make good kindling.

Gazing out over the horizon, it was as if the sun dipped beneath the waves of a deepened ocean, casting a deep, tranquil blue across the sky. He murmured, "An ocean's sunset. The elders would say rains will come by nightfall, sweeping through this land as sure as the tide." The air grew heavy, as if anticipating the storm, carrying the faint scent of salt and distant thunder. Shadows deepened, stretching across the ground like the fingers of the night, but the last traces of sunlight lingered on the water, painting a fleeting path of grace before vanishing into darkness.

Reading the sunset, he walks deeper into the cavern, as it grows darker, Ulfar sees the outline of the remains of a forgotten soldier. He approaches, unsheathing his sword, and approaches the rock-like shape. As he wanders closer, he pauses to make a torch to hold in his off hand. Igniting the small section in a warm, rosy orange light, he uses the tip of his blade to turn over the ancient corpse bearing a shining white and silver armour. Turning over the body, the breast plate reveals a golden cross encased in ivory vines with an elegantly detailed sword tied to the cross piece with a single strand of ivory vines. "By the Seven, could that really be? It's the sigil of the old Empire. Why here?" Ulfar notices a note clenched in the hand bones of the long-forgotten soldier. Ulfar glances at the note whilst reading it softly aloud.

By order of General Taklu:

Deliver the sword of Valin, Arenith, to the lake of Eden as was ordered upon us by Talor in his death if he were not to have a legitimate heir. It is unknown what lies in the nameless mountains except rumours of a powerful magic wielder. You five are not to return until the white queen has had her sword returned to her.

As he scanned the order's faded ink, a distant echo from the depths of the cavern stirred, reverberating softly through the cold stone walls. It was as if the voice of the mountain itself whispered back, luring him onward. Ulfar paused, glancing into the shadows and calling softly, "Talor, is this the path you wish for me to take?"

He knelt beside the ancient soldier's remains, carefully lifting fragments of rusted armour, his touch reverent, as though piecing together the lost stories of the fallen. Rising to his feet, Ulfar gripped his sword firmly in his left hand, while his right held the torch—its flames casting a warm red-orange glow, flickering against the chill of the darkness beyond.

He stepped forward, his voice drifted into the silence, "I wonder... did they ever deliver the sword?" His gaze swept the empty blackness of the cavern, his mind racing with fragments of forgotten battles. "If there were four others... where, then, do you lie my ancient kin?" It was a question of false hope; deep within, he wondered if he truly wanted to see the fates of the others who ventured here.

Progressing through the dark, the ominous sounds move from path to path, with him never growing closer to the origin. Eventually, his previous query was partially answered when he found what was some sort of struggle scene where there was clearly fire and shock damage done to the elegant armour of the knight. "Could that be? That has to be some sort of arcane magic damage. It looks as though the sword only struck hard rock; it cracked through here," he runs his finger up the base of the blade around eight inches, "the blade towards the end has chipped too." The movement of a shadow catches his eye, causing him to abruptly get startled and decide not to brandish his blade but rather the torch. "Come out, beast of the shadows!"

The fleeting shadow darted down a darkened tunnel to the left, vanishing with the silence of the grave. Ulfar's instincts flared, and in an instant, he was in pursuit, his footsteps echoing

against the ancient stone. The shadow moved with an inhuman agility, slipping through the cavernous maze. Just as he pressed onward, he felt something odd—a faint current against his cheek. “A breeze? From here?” He muttered, halting and turning to a side passage. This tunnel, less cloaked in darkness, seemed almost to beckon him forward with an eerie familiarity. As he ventured deeper, the shadows fell away to reveal an inhospitable stretch of jagged rock walls, their rough edges exposed in the dim light.

Squinting against the approaching brightness, he pushed onward, finally emerging into a light so vivid it nearly blinded him. “By the gods... the Lake of Eden!” The words escaped him, barely more than a whisper as he fell to his knees on a carpet of jade and emerald green. His fingers brushed the dewy grass, vibrant and alive—a sharp contrast to the barren landscape beyond. Rising slowly, he took his first steps forward, mesmerised by the sheer beauty before him. The oasis stretched in an otherworldly expanse, lush and verdant, sheltered like a precious gem in a sea of desolation. In the distance, amidst the fragrant bloom of orchids, roses, and crimson spider lilies that scattered like stars across the meadow, he saw her—a feminine figure draped in light, pure, gleaming as though the very sun shone through a veil of white jewels.

His eyes closed slightly, his heart pounding with a mix of awe and caution. “What... or rather, who is that?” He murmured, unable to look away. Drawn to her, he moved forward, feeling as though he crossed into some sacred realm. Each step brought him closer to the radiant vision, through fields of blossoms that seemed to breathe with life, untouched by the harsh world outside. He knew the form, the figure; it was something that was planted in his mind. It was then that he realised that she was the epitome of good.

A soft and elegant, yet calming voice whispered through the air, as if it was plastered to the gusts of wind itself. It was faint and distant, but he could make out what she said, “So you,

you are the last one. The last of the line, whom I blessed so many years ago. Even to me, who cannot age it, it has felt like a lifetime since I've known your kin."

Ulfar approached with extreme caution, but he had sensed no danger. "Do not be wary, I shalln't hurt you; the one you must be wary of lurks in the shadows where even I can no longer reach." The simple hearing of the mysterious woman's voice was a blessing to the ears, almost reinvigorating the soul of Ulfar.

His expression became one of ignorance, yet spun with confusion as he had not even the slightest of clues for what this voice was coming from. He yelled out for anyone living around to hear, "Who are you?" The only three words to come from his mouth as he was enthralled by the utter beauty of the mysterious woman. She stood around five and a half feet tall, similar to that of a normal human. Her deep midnight hair contrasted with her pale snow white skin; her blue eyes were endless oceans that glimmered in the sunlight, and her white dress danced in the wind as she approached the young man.

The woman appeared then circled him, her steps slow and deliberate, as if savouring each moment of his unease. Her eyes held a glint both knowing and playful, a tease that was as ancient as it was familiar. With a voice soft but laced with an edge, she broke the silence. "You, of all men, must know who I am... Ulfar Val, the Stormfang." Her tone was honeyed, but there was a hint of iron beneath it. She paused only long enough to let the words linger in the chilled mountain air. "For it was I who sent you on this perilous journey, guiding you through these inhospitable peaks. Do not dare claim ignorance. Of any man who walks this earth, you alone can truly know the answer to that question."

In complete and utter shock, Ulfar stumbles, "By the seven! You claim to be Vaeimea? It is said none besides Talor could see her until they rise from the dead. There is no way in oblivion you are the mother of all."

The woman's voice turned sharp, almost daring him as she halted, fixing him with a piercing gaze. Her soft voice failed the air once more, "Then ask yourself but one question," she intoned, her voice laced with a subtle, indomitable power, "if I were merely some mortal fool, seeking to play tricks, how would I know that it was Talor himself who guided you on this path? After all, you told only three—your mother, Gunmar, and Vivel, did you not?" She let the words hang like a challenge. A faint smile played on her lips, a knowing glimmer in her eye. "Tell me, then—what proof would you wish to see, that I am your curator, your light, the mother of your kin?"

Ulfar dropped to one knee, his breath steady but laced with reverence. He plunged his blade into the rich earth, anchoring it deep as if binding himself to the world around him. With his head bowed, he murmured, almost as if the words themselves were a sacred offering, "If this is truly the Mother of All, then grant me the strength to see clearly, to discern the truth from any shadow of lies or deception. In your great name, Talor, I pray."

The air thickened around him, alive with a subtle energy that pressed in from all sides, as though awaiting his plea with silent approval. A faint warmth pulsed through his sword's hilt, coursing through his hand and spreading upward like a quiet fire in his veins. The surrounding blooms seemed to lean toward him, their petals catching the light in new hues, as if they too bore witness to this solemn promise.

As Ulfar closed his eyes, a vision overtook him, vivid and flowing like scenes from a long-lost story. He saw a figure—Tón, a legend among legends—standing by the Lake of Eden in the same lush sanctuary, bathed in the ancient glow of twilight. Before him was a woman, radiant and ethereal, her very form woven from light and grace. In silence, she extended her hand, presenting him with a sword gleaming with purpose, its edge catching the reflection of countless ages.

The vision shifted, and now Talor himself stood within the oasis, his gaze filled with reverence and warmth as he addressed the woman. “My Light,” he called her, a voice like deep thunder softened by awe. “Mother of my kin.” She inclined her head, her eyes holding a wisdom that stretched beyond mortal bounds, as if the essence of life itself had found form in her. The scene faded, but the truth lingered: this was indeed no ordinary encounter. Here, at this sacred lake, he stood before a being who was part of the fabric of creation, bearing the names and light of the gods themselves. One half of the duality of this world. With renewed certainty, Ulfar understood he was in the presence of the very Mother, and his heart swelled with the magnitude of this encounter.

Ulfar steadied himself, brushing the earth from his hands before sliding his blade back into its sheath. His gaze hardened as he looked upon her, but there was a flicker of curiosity, of resolve, as he took a measured step forward. “Talor has shown me much,” he said, his voice firm, yet laced with a hint of wariness. “If you are indeed the mother of all, then I shall humour your request.” His eyes narrowed as he spoke, his tone carrying the weight of his journey and the trials that led him here, yet filled with an arrogance. “But tell me, *First of the Mysteries*—why am I here?”

She turned to face him, her expression unreadable, though a glimmer of something ancient and profound lingered in her eyes, as though she had awaited this question for countless ages. First, she chuckled and let out a sarcastic remark, “Humour me, you say? I will let that slide, follow me, and you shall then know.” The woman walks in the direction of the lake, where a small isle appears in the middle with a large cherry blossom tree that begins to bloom as the two walk towards it. As they walk closer, a male entity appears on the small patch of land. Ulfar has a look of confusion on his face as they walk, “Do not have fear nor worry, Ulfar Val, leader of the Stormfangs, all will make sense in due time.”

They simultaneously step onto the land as the male figure who gleamed as bright as the sun. In the blinding shine, Vaeimea walks towards the male figure, and Ulfar attempts to glean all he can from the conversation between the two, when suddenly the endless shine ends.

The abrupt darkness stunned the man. As he regained his eyesight, he saw a man standing in black and white armour with streaks of gold covering the creases. The armour was elegant with slow curves and sharp edges; each plate of the pauldron was intricate with what seemed to be an ancient language carved into it. At the very centre of the chest pauldron lies a sharp, beautiful golden cross made of two swords, the cross is encased in both ebony and ivory vines with a green jewelled amulet resting atop his breast in the very middle.

He recognised this sigil, and this brought to him a realisation that the man was no ordinary man, but Talor. Ulfar's eyes widen as he approaches, reaching out towards him as he begins to drop to his knees, "You, you are Talor."

The man catches him, refusing to let Ulfar bow before him, "You need not bow before me. I am no higher than you, I am no greater than you. You walk through the land of Eden, no man less than I." The man picks up Ulfar, placing him back on his feet, then he places his arm on his shoulder, "You bear much resemblance to one I have met very recently who now walks the halls of Valingard."

A pure gaze that held nothing but confusion and curiosity about the previous words of this man overcame Ulfar. He asked but a single word, "Who?" Ulfar questions with a stern, confused face, looking directly at the divine man. He walks closer and grabs the shoulders of the man, yelling, "Who!?"

Talor placed his firm yet gentle hands on Ulfar's shoulders, slowly drawing them down, his touch a mix of comfort and purpose. His gaze, as deep as starlit skies, held an unreadable glimmer. "A man you have not met in many years is all I will say, son of Valin." The mention of the name Valin

confused the mind of Ulfar. Talor spoke, his voice a quiet, restrained echo in the stillness, each word woven with mystery and caution. With that, he turned, his figure radiant yet subdued, like a flame at dusk, and began to move toward Vaeimea, whose presence shimmered softly nearby.

Talor nodded to her, a silent understanding shared between the two as old as creation itself. “I must now take my leave,” he said, his voice carrying the weight of countless journeys, as though this parting was but one of many in the endless cycle of time. Then, in a quiet flash, he was gone, leaving Ulfar in the quiet company of fate and the stirring whispers of divine purpose.

The figure of Talor slowly vanishes into thin air like a pile of sand blowing away in a light breeze. Vaeimea walks towards the small pond with a cherry tree that wraps around and simply points to the water, implying Ulfar is to interact with it. “I will leave you here; the rest is for you to figure out. There will be many who will enter your life and play their part in your journey, but remember, there are those who shall build you and others meant to break. You must break from your chains to fulfil your dream, you must grow from a bow into a man.”

Vaeimea's form dissolved into the air, scattering like stardust, each shimmering mote drifting to the ground and melting into the still waters of the pond. Her fading light left a soft luminescence across the landscape, and in the lingering silence, Ulfar's mind buzzed with questions. “What does this pond symbolise?” He murmured, gazing at the tranquil, mirror-like surface. “Why have you brought me here to it? What do you mean by breaking from my chains?” His voice echoed quietly, fading into the depths of the surrounding grove, but the air held its silence, as if guarding the secrets of the world.

Stepping closer to the water's edge, Ulfar's eyes caught a glint—a flash of something radiant resting on the pond's shallow bed. His heart quickened as he peered into the pristine blue waters. The object seemed to pulse with a glow of white and

gold, alive with an ancient essence, as if calling to him across the ages. While he inched ever closer, the pond's surface began to ripple and swirl. From the depths, two slender, spectral hands rose, each movement delicate yet unyielding, as if performing a sacred rite. They held forth an exquisite blade, its slender form and gleaming edge catching the light like a shard of dawn. The sword was paired with an intricate sheath that tapered gracefully, bearing a hue somewhere between a steely blue and a muted silver. Its surface held inlays that shimmered with an iridescent glow, casting subtle rainbows across the sheath and the blade's elegant taper.

Ulfar took in the weapon's details—the crossguard flaring like wings unfolding, with lines etched in a flowing pattern reminiscent of wind or water, and its ends adomed with gemstones, blue-green as the depths of an untouched lake. The hilt was wrapped in a fine midnight-blue leather, embossed with swirling patterns evoking stars meeting the sea. And crowning the pommel, an opalescent stone sat in a delicate cradle, its light echoing the soft glow of the pond itself. For a moment, Ulfar was rooted in place, awed by the vision before him. This weapon, he knew, was more than mere steel; it held within it the promise of purpose and power, an emblem of the path that lay ahead.

The blade stretched close to thirty-nine inches, reaching an impressive forty-seven inches when counting the hilt. Its darkened steel shimmered with swirls of grey that ranged from the brightest chrome to a deep midnight black, like storms captured within its metal. Each fold and curve of the blade's surface seemed to breathe, as if alive with shadows and light, a testament to its fine craftsmanship and the secrets it held. Starting at the cross-guard, intricate carvings spiralled along the blade, their lines delicate yet commanding, curling like vines on ancient stone.

These markings suddenly flared to life, glowing with a spectral light that gave off a faint hum, resonating in Ulfar's

bones. It was a language he barely recognised yet felt he had always known, the ancient script of High Valkorian, hidden for ages and now revealing itself in this moment of awakening. The letters shimmered as he read aloud, each syllable weighty with meaning: *“Le Veiki’s enil ón alumineo evieé”*—the old tongue weaving an incantation as his voice carried it. It resonated with the profound truth that the sword, like a star’s glimmer in the night sky, was bound to the essence of the heavens and earth, to the ancient calling of his bloodline, and to a destiny he could no longer deny.

Its meaning unfurled in his mind as he spoke it—*“The King’s yield of forever light.”* Yet, he could not fully grasp its deeper significance, the revelation that this was the sword of his dreams, the weapon of legends: Arenith, the blade of the Valin line. It did not look like the legends described, for Talor held a blade of fifty-two inches, much longer than this. His mind whirled. Arenith, thought lost to the sands of time, now glimmered anew, drinking in the light of day for the first time since the young King Talor rode to battle as the undisputed sword-bearer of the mighty Valkorian Empire.

Ulfar reached for the hilt, his grip fierce and unwavering, as if attempting to bind himself to the blade through sheer force. His eyes traced each exquisite detail, captivated by the perfect curvature of the steel, its elegance tempered by the ominous allure of its darkened shade. The sleek, metallic cross-guard of a lighter grey shimmered like starlight against the stormy blade, each side adomed with three flawless white diamonds. Their pure light seemed to pulse, echoing the promise of destiny etched into every curve, and Ulfar found himself entranced, barely breathing, as he held the weapon he was born to wield.

Ulfar moved through a series of training movements, each sweep of the blade flowing with an unearthly ease. The blade cut through the air as if it belonged to him, as if it had known his grip all along. A disbelieving murmur escaped his lips, “This cannot be... this... this sword.” His words hung in the

quiet air, questioning yet reverent. The weight of the blade felt balanced with the wisdom of ages, as if its past battles whispered into his very bones.

Attaching the sheath to his girdle with careful precision, he paused. "This sword... It vanished with the death of Talar." His voice grew taut with bewilderment. "But why? Why would I be led here? This... is not the vision I saw. What does this mean?" His plea echoed through the grove, a whisper of eamest desperation. "Vaeimea, I beg you... show me your light." The silence that followed was deep and watchful, as though the ancient grove held its breath, waiting for an answer that would reshape Ulfar's understanding of destiny.

Falling to the ground, Ulfar let out one last cry, one which many would call heresy, a call to the faith in which Talar followed, Jeda. "Oh Lord, I beg ye. Grant me the clarity of your mind, the wisdom of you to discern why I have come here."

He was given a single echoed reply, one which gleamed with the power of the almighty, its force so strong on his will he knew not if it was a being even beyond Vaeimea, the voice said, "But it was." Before succumbing to the sounds of nature in the land of Eden.

For days, Ulfar sat in his own squalor, making claim to the endless bounty of the mystical oasis. The fruit, with its lush colours and otherworldly sweetness, sustained him, though he ate more out of restlessness than hunger. He continued to plead to the Lady of Light, his words echoing unanswered in the still air. Days bled into one another, marked only by his silent frustration, his heart heavy with confusion as he waited for a sign that refused to come. The sense of purpose that had driven him to the edge of the world felt distant, almost forgotten, like a memory slipping beyond reach. Each night, he lay on the soft, vibrant grass of the isle at the pond's heart, his gaze lifting to the stars that spanned across the night sky in silvered constellations.

One night, as he looked up, a cluster of stars took shape above him, their familiar pattern stirring something deep within

him. The constellation *Dovarkelle*, the figure of a warrior, shone brightly—a figure known by another name to all Valkorians: Talor, the hero himself. The sight struck him, igniting a fire he had nearly allowed to die out. He gazes upon the constellation, and just about where an amulet would hang from the constellation's neck, a green star shines brighter than the rest for a brief instant, then and only then, he is given a new spark. There must be more within this mountain for him to find, he thought. The sight of the amulet around Talor's neck many days ago rang in his head; he knew what that was, but it had also vanished upon the field of battle, and no one knew of its fate.

The man paces away from the Lake of Eden and enters the very same dark and void-like cave he had exited from nearly 4 days prior. The man feels an eerie presence as he walks through the slight fog that seems to cover the cave floor like grass on dirt. His steps echo with every small pebble touched by his leather-clad foot. Continuing through the deep cave, he remembers the sight of the mysterious shadow figure when he traversed these pathways before, unknowing of where he was heading or what the proper way was, he followed his gut instincts on each twist and turn. Through the blackness, he finds an old usable torch, prompting him to light it, creating a soft, ambient orange glow to protect him from some of the darkness, though it creates more shadows. Walking for what felt like hours to him, seeming to only be more lost, Ulfar began to mark certain stones to track if he was walking the same paths, continuing in a circle.

Upon proving to himself he was not circling the same tunnels, he decided to take a few hours' break. Around an hour into that break, the old shadowy figure had returned. Watching him from around a hundred feet down a tunnel straight ahead of him, the simple light of his torch was nothing near enough to reveal the mystery. All that was able to be articulated of this shadow's appearance was the beady, glowing red eyes ever present, locked on him; an uneasy feeling would rush over Ulfar

. Every time he gazed into the red portals, they seemed to burn like hell itself. The eyes refused to move from the middle of the tunnel as if it were a challenge to Ulfar, asking him to chase after. Knowing of the mysterious tales of dark tunnels and caves, he knew better than to chase after shadows, even if they were more than just shadows. There was but a single problem: Ulfar knew the way he must go was straight, straight into the blood-eyed shadow itself.

Ulfar collects himself, taking in a few breaths before he arises and calls out, "You are the darkness my sword shall cut, you stand in my way, Beast of the Dark, I do not fear you." Ulfar stands dropping the torch that has seemed to keep him protected from this strange being, whilst he unsheathed his sword, holding it single-handedly, crossing his face, covering his right eye.

With a deep breath, he walks towards the shadow, who simultaneously moves towards him. Ulfar brings Arenith to his side, then in a position to strike the oncoming unknown shadow, who draws an astral blade of its own, preparing to clash blades. The oncoming shadow changes instantly to reveal its true form, something of bones and ancient mage robes, with magical rings, necklaces and a circlet adomed across the bony yet astral figure. As he continues to walk towards the creature, it throws out a ball of fire, illuminating the twenty-foot area between the two, showing every detail of the creature.

A cold shiver crawled down Ulfar's spine as a voice, jagged and hollow, slithered through the darkness of the cavern. It was an eerie, grating sound, one that seemed to scrape against the stone walls themselves, echoing back in twisted reverberation. The shadow, once shapeless, twisted and coiled, was almost alive with a sickening vitality. "You wield the sword," it hissed, its words drawn out like a long, dark threat. "You will feed my hunger!" The creature's voice was laced with a hunger that felt ancient and insatiable, a bottomless void reaching out to Ulfar. Its form shifted in the dim torchlight, solidifying into something both ethereal and monstrous, a being

whose very presence seemed to sap warmth and light from the air around them.

Ulfar's grip tightened on the sword, the weight of Arenith reassuring in his hand as he held it between himself and the looming shadow. His voice was steady, though his heart hammered with both fear and resolve. "If it is hunger that drives you," he replied, voice low but unwavering, "then face me, creature. So that is what you are."

He pauses, acknowledging the use of magic and the visible shadowy appearance of the being, "A Hunger-Lich. I thought your kind were only figments of imagination, ideas to scare young children. I cannot imagine how long you have lain dormant, waiting for your next prey to enter this cavern, far too long perhaps."

The pace of the two increases as the impending clash moves closer with each moment. Then, with an explosion of light as the astral blade meets the Erinstihl blade. This thunderous, magical explosion echoed throughout the cave, ringing the ears of Ulfar, prompting him to fall to one knee while glancing at his blade, his eyes filled with wonder and amazement for its strength.

Walking, yet making no sound, the shadow moves towards him as Ulfar glances towards the feet. He glanced and noticed there were no physical feet on this creature as it seemingly floated ever closer. Not speaking, yet making strange feral sounds and screeches as it gains on him, ever closer, red dots focused on the kneeling man. The lich tilts its head to the right, stopping for a brief moment as it changes again, drawing an astral blade in both hands. It charges, Ulfar draws blade to his left, contacting the shadow blade, laying it off to his right, thus spinning and slicing the shadow in half, finishing his opponent with one final blow, ending the quick dance.

The being begins to melt back into the shadows. What seems to be an astral creature even more ghostly than the lich itself comes from the bones and robes that shelter them. With its

last parting words, what turns out to be the long-lost soul of a man tells a secret left for ages, “In this mountain, you find a power only the blood of Valin could ever hope to tame. A curse to mankind.” The cryptic message given to him by the entity leaves him enthralled in a multitude of questions.

Grasping at the ethereal remains as they turn to dust in his hands, “What did you mean? What were you in your past? Why were you here?”

Even he knew how futile the questions were; whatever the being was, it had long ventured beyond his own perception. Thus, he returned to his quest of searching beyond the caves towards the outer mountains to find what was drawing him to this barren land of death.

Navigating through the endless midnight caverns took Ulfar another few days of lonely travel, when finally his sweat-encased face felt cold with a distant breeze. He follows the feeling on his face, and a distant moon glow is seen in the distance. When he walks towards it, his mind dances, throwing the idea that he is hallucinating. Whilst he approaches ever closer to the moonlit opening as his vision hazes, causing him to stumble, falling to his knees, a mere few feet from exiting this eternal purgatory. He falls, and a shining light collects out of nowhere, catching his collapse.

The light swirls him, a recognisable female voice echoes through the air, the voice of Vaeimea, “You shall rise to find what was lost so many years ago. Your quest will not end before you exit the dark. You are a sword of light, meant to brighten the darkest areas of the land, revealing the evil that cowers in the darkest corners. Rise, son of Valin, you shall not come to an end here.” The poeticness of such a voice graced the mortal ears of the man; he was blessed with such a guide that one could only place such experiences in the realms of fantasy and dreams.

As her voice fills his ears, Ulfar finds an inner strength empowering him to rise from his knees, drawing his blade to use as a cane, grasping on the cave wall beside him, helping him to

exit the blackened purgatory. Ulfar screams, his words mashed into an incoherent mess, echoing through the caves behind him as if to mimic his final gust of strength.

Upon exiting from the cave, it is revealed to him that there is an endless formation of daggered rocks that shall serve as his path to the peak of Mount Maierr, where his dream had shown. Knowing the difficulty of his journey, he held his side, wincing in pain, “Queensbreath, it should grow near here.”

Ulfar knew the weed-like plant would help with the pain and the overall healing process, leading him to postpone his quest in search of this plant. Knowing the plan is prevalent in the cracks of large rocks where moisture often collects. He feels a slight mist as he searches the surrounding jagged rocks, stumbling as he begins to lose balance often when wandering, looking aimlessly for the slightest hint of the speckled flowers.

“I... I know... I h-h-have the strength. I-I am strong!” He breathes deeply, calling this out for whatever creatures lie near to hear. A distant noise of rustling draws the little attention that Ulfar had left to spare. When he began to blank and his vision blurred, not even his arms were there to extend, breaking his inevitable fall.

Chapter 3

Immortal Savior

Upon awakening, Ulfar's vision was cloaked in mist, the shapes around him little more than shadows wavering in his blurred sight. Yet as his senses sharpened, one form stood out against the haze—a silhouette slowly taking shape, feminine, elvish, and strikingly vivid. She stood almost his own height, and as he took her in, he saw that her features held an elegance as if crafted from the earth itself, touched by some ancient hand that sculpted beauty from stone and root.

His gaze lingered on her pointed ears, each extending gracefully to a length just beyond that of a human's—a subtle, unmistakable mark of her elvish heritage. Her armour, woven from enchanted leaves and vines, clung to her figure with the grace of natural artistry. Delicate leather bands and plates of bronzed steel held the leaves together, each piece designed to mimic the veins of a leaf, catching light in a muted spectrum of greys, mossy greens, and shadowed browns. The tones of her armour harmonised with the rugged landscape, as though she were an elemental spirit risen from the stone and soil around them.

Her hair, dark as deep forest moss, fell down her back with an emerald sheen, catching the soft light in brilliant glints. It flowed freely, yet gathered at the base of her neck in a braid that spoke of both wildness and purpose, as though nature itself had

braided it. Her eyes, warm and radiant gold, held his own gaze with an intensity that seemed to draw the very light from the world around them. They shone with an ethereal wisdom, as if they carried the secrets of centuries, hidden in their gilded depths. Her skin, olive-gold with a sunlit sheen, seemed to absorb the glow of the mountain light, lending her a vitality drawn from days spent under the open sky, a life attuned to earth and wind. There was a sense of timelessness to her, as though she was both ageless and deeply ancient, belonging more to the wilderness than any mortal realm.

At her hips hung two short blades of bronzed elvish steel, their edges glinting with a subtle, otherworldly sheen. Runes etched into the metal glowed faintly, their secrets pulsing like a heartbeat beneath the surface—a testament to the magic of her kind. Each blade was a masterpiece of elvish craftsmanship, a balance of power and elegance, made to serve with deadly precision.

Across her back lay a quiver of arrows and a bow, its elegant curve shaped from the sacred wood of ancient Taimia trees, as smooth and graceful as the branches from which it was born. The wood was carved with delicate images and inscriptions in her native tongue, a silent hymn to the ancient forests of Onu-Derith. Here was a warrior of her people, clad in nature's armour and carrying the lore of forgotten forests in her very presence. Ulfar gazed upon her; he felt her power—the fierce strength of a protector and the quiet depth of an ancient soul. In her presence, he sensed a force both wild and wise, an essence beyond time, a living embodiment of the mystical lands from which she came. She was a part of the very fabric of this world, woven from earth and starlight, and her gaze reminded him of the forces that watched over him in the shadowed mountains and forgotten vales.

Regaining consciousness, he begins to try and get up, unbeknownst to him, this mysterious woman had already treated his wounds. He struggles, “Hold yourself, do not get up, you

must regain your strength. The *neeima-thorius* is a potent herb, yet if you move, you will only lengthen the time it takes. You are safe while here healing, fret not.” Lightly pushing him down to the ground, her hand hooked behind his head, she lowered it slowly.

Falling like a baby in its mother’s arms into a deep slumber, he mutters out, “W..h-h..who are,” breathing heavily as his eyelids move to cover like stone doors, “a-a-are, y-yo-ou?” While he finishes his words, he fully nods off in a tired rest. As he lies, she notices a symbol, two chains come from his neck and one of which was something far more ancient than she had anticipated. One pendant was a circle holding a square and a diamond inside; besides it was a chain on a blackened steel, and from it hung a cross, not the cross of Valkoria, but one which held the symbol of Jeda. To her, it was somewhat ironic.

Her eyes were captivated by the figure upon the cross, such a small figure, smaller than the palm of her hand; it was a standard cross which held the man, and in an instant she knew what it was. Her mind ran endlessly towards the image which came to her mind as the figure suffered in silence on this cross. Her lips moved, and words came out without even the thought in her mind:

“It was the words of Isaviel from the fourteenth chapter of his book:”

*13 But it was not for His own transgressions that
He suffered,
Nor for His own iniquity that He bore the
stripes.
He was crushed for the sins of others,
Pierced for the rebellion of the nations.
The punishment that brought us peace was upon
Him,
And by His wounds, we are healed.*

She paused after reciting this verse aloud from pure memory, her voice tenses as she realised the meaning behind the words, “This is the lamb who shall be the blood which washes clean the fallen world. I wonder if he ascribes to the faith of Tumás or the faith of Koory. For does he hold reverence for the One or does he hold reverence for the angels?” She flipped the necklace and read upon the back a short line, written in a script older than even herself. It was the language of man, and all it read was:

“Deo un al gratias - glory unto God”

Placing the necklace back, she gained a full sight of the current situation. Softly she laid his head down, she caressed the side of his face and forehead, checking his temperature, “By Lord, he is burning. I must find some cloth to wet, cooling him down. There must be some river or stream near here, for if not this, would not grow.”

Venturing out, she searches in the slimmest of cracks for even drops of water, like a bird in a deep drought. Searching as a rat for even the smallest pool of water, to which there was but one avail, a small stream let cold mountain water down from the high peaks. Slashing off a piece of her cloak, she drowns it in the water while also filling a canteen she carried on her side.

Returning to the man's side, she pressed the cold, wet cloth to his forehead, hoping to lessen the strain he bore while fighting the wound. He lay there visibly struggling, jolting and shaking from time to time.

She attempted a common elven healing spell, but to her confusion, it had no effect. Then she remembered the words her father had once spoken—a verse she never fully understood, yet it stirred within her like a flame:

“Behold, a man of blood rises in the north, whose hands are stained beyond the sons of dust. He shall wield the blade long lost to time, a sword hidden

from the eyes of an age. His name is Alluendar, and his coming is as the storm from the mountain—swift, terrible, and foreordained.”

The memory struck her with sudden force. An awakening passed through her like thunder. She realised with trembling breath—she had used an enchantment far too weak for one such as this man.

A few hours pass, and Ulfar regains full consciousness, along with being healed enough to move. Standing, he had next to no memory of the mysterious woman whose presence alarms him, prompting him to draw Arenith in her direction, yet he's still too weak to truly wield the blade. “Who are you? Speak now or taste your blood, elf.” He saw the cross no longer around his neck but lying beside him, the soft and tender tanned face of the elf before him as he moved to place a blade at her throat.

She knew there was nothing that the weakened man could do to her yet she still entertained his play of power over her and with her neck being at knifepoint she was left no choice but to tell the human who she was, “I am Ariendria, first daughter of Lord Eluiar of Elendaiél,” she spoke, her voice soft and lilting, like the echo of a distant stream. “From the elven lands far to the west, in the vale of Onu-Derith, where ancient forests meet eternal skies.” She firmly announces to the man lying on the ground. “Then it is known to you,” she murmured, her voice like a soft breeze weaving through ancient trees. “And you hold upon your neck a piece of reverence which was crafted in the very lands I have walked through, a symbol of what many of your kindred would claim heresy, a mark of crucifixion.”

Her voice seemed desperate to know why this symbol was on his person; she had unleashed a campaign which would not end until some sort of answer was brought to light.

He gazed at her, processing what she had just asked, yet still captivated by the sheer beauty of the elf; she was the first and only of the race of the elves his eyes had ever graced. He had

heard from the old wizard of the existence of elves and inquired many such times into their culture and even heard legends of some of the greatest elves of the First Era.

He looked at her and said, "It is a cross which has been passed down through many generations since my ancestor found it." He struggles to get up in a desperate attempt to show his own strength. His voice rang with a sense of wonder, "Tell me, what does this mean to you, for me? It is just a symbol of the crown of Valkoria. I have read the Book of Isaviel, the Psalms of Judas and Koory, the Proverbs of King Tinún, and the Covenant of Jeda, along with countless other texts that age far beyond any number I can even comprehend."

He paused for even a brief moment as if to gather some more strength in this effort to make a point, "I know that many will call me a heretic and many more would never dare take up a sword for my cause, yet I will place my faith not in a religion but in who shows themselves to me first. Now, why are you here?"

The elf gazed at him and said, "Indeed, it is you. A figure who, from all my current knowledge, resembles you is mentioned in one text you did not give notice to, a prophetic text said to be penned by the hands of Idrill, the last daughter of Hurgón."

She made the motion for the man to still and rest, yet he could not. She thought of ways to stall the man for the few more hours he needed. Then she said, "Yet first to know if this simple folk tale is rooted in some truth, there is a single question I must ask. Why do you wander such a desolate place?"

Ulfar rested back and said to her, "You said your name was Ariendria, is that right? This sword, Arenith, you know this sword well, I assume? It was an Item which may have only been held by the hands of man for a few generations, but lives on in both story and song. Yet this tale you speak of refers to something older, a symbol which serves as both an omen and a blessing to Valkoria." He spoke almost like a mystic figure trying to tell the tales of the world.

The tension had released, and no longer did they have one another at blade. There was a certain glimmer seen in the eyes of Ulfar that was so prevalent, though clouded with some sort of darker presence, something she would not have noticed unless she had stopped the man for just a few seconds. It was a glistening of impurity which scaled over a heart which was once so pure, as if to long for something. She turned to him and spoke in a soft, melodic tone, "Then let us arise and find this item of mystic wonder. You should be rested enough for our travels; the night comes fast, and this mountain is treacherous enough in the light of day."

He grunted as he moved to a sitting position. Ulfar answered the elf with such a curt response, "The mere fact that this sword happened upon me gives me reason to believe that what I may find is something else that can unite my people." He paused for a few brief seconds, then looked with a strange depth at the elf, "You are not an elf of the First Era, are you?"

The man's question caught her off guard, "No, I was born in the years following the dawn of the Second Era. Yet tell me, what stirs such a question in your mind?"

Ulfar looked upon her as he rose from the ground and said, "An old wizard, rather an old friend, told me many tales of the great deeds and immense power of those elves who drew breath in the First Era. He also said many of them fell in the wars of the two Dark Lords. For a she-elf, you send a sense of strength. Are you an elf of the woods? A Velmar? Those elves who dwell in the woodlands and build their lands as part of the trees. I heard tales from my mother that the greatest of all cities, Elendaiél, is made purely from the fallen woods of the valley, and it connects two forests cut off from one another on both sides of the valley."

The voice of Ulfar was shown with a tone that reflected the excitement of youth, yet was filled with the knowledge of his time in the world. He showed a growing strength as they now walked towards this seemingly shared goal.

A smile passed Ariendria's face, one which brimmed with the comforts and beauties of home as a sense of joy came to her voice, "Indeed, I am of the Velmar. Elendaiél is my home, where my father reigns as lord of the city. Perhaps, in days to come, when peace has returned to the world, you might journey there and behold it for yourself—the endless greens and browns of nature, woven seamlessly into the living shapes of its halls and towers, a place of peace and tranquillity."

He showed no change in his emotions nor presence, yet he stayed firm and then turned to her, "I am curious, is it true that your culture once made blood pacts with those of other races?"

He gazed around, seeing the jagged teeth which stood erect from the surface around him. It was as if each part of this mountain was a mouth waiting like a trap for its next victim. The question continued to ring: why would such a palace hold something worthy of visions to the youthful human?

She moves to catch up with him, "Indeed, you speak with a hint of wisdom. Yet such a practice was seldom employed, and as the long years passed, it became rarer still. Oftentimes, those bound by it knew little of one another, save for a shared purpose—or, in rare instances, a common foe. What stirs your curiosity about this?"

He looks to her with curiosity as if he did not hear her question. He says to her, "You have come here with a purpose, an elf, especially one who dwells in the woodlands a continent away, would not be simply venturing these lands. What is it?" His face became somewhat more stern as he now only focused on the motives of the elf, as if deep down, he did not have any trust for her.

She let out a soft chuckle, the sound carrying like the playful rustle of leaves caught in a gentle breeze. Her gaze wandered, sweeping over the jagged expanse around them, as if searching the horizon for something unseen. With an air of measured grace, she lowered herself onto a nearby rock, its cool, uneven surface weathered by countless winds.

Her countenance held a mix of contemplation and mischief as she spoke, her voice steady yet laced with a playful edge. “If I were to tell you,” she began, her words unfurling like the first rays of dawn piercing through the veil of night, “it would be this: there are those across this wide world who know of you and your coming, one of whom you have known for many years. Among them are many great and noble forces—beacons of good who walk paths you cannot yet imagine. Some whisper of a man, a figure foretold, destined to reclaim the King’s blade and the gem that is his birthright. One of which, as fate would have it, you already bear.”

Her eyes, sharp and unwavering, held his gaze for a moment longer, the weight of her words lingering in the space between them like the last note of a ballad fading into silence. Then, a flicker of something—sass, perhaps, or the unspoken amusement of someone privy to a secret—lit up her features. With a sudden and confident movement, she rose, her cloak brushing against the ground as she strode forward. “I am here,” she continued, her tone turning matter-of-fact yet tinged with a certain poetic rhythm, “at the behest of those who believe you to be that man. Yet, as of now, nothing has been proven.”

Without waiting for a reply, she stepped past him, her silhouette cutting a striking figure against the jagged rocks that rose like ancient sentinels. The light shifted, catching the edges of her form as she wove through the craggy terrain with the ease of someone who had long since mastered its challenges. There was a defiance in her gait, an unspoken declaration that the path ahead—whatever trials it may hold—would not deter her. The air seemed to hum faintly in her wake, carrying with it the promise of things yet to come.

His mind becomes puzzled, he wonders why there would be anyone around the world who levied a care of the lands of Onu-Arith, he knew of the world beyond, yet it still was held in mind that there could not be anything beyond the lands of his country. That small child who knew and heard the tales of lands

beyond, though his mind could not conceive the expanse of the world. His mind's eye then turned to this gem of the king, he thought and thought for what could this gem be? It was only one possibility in all conceivable paths; he now knew the trail he and this elf followed.

Abruptly, the elf stopped in front of him, she turned and had a look which reflected the leagues her mind was racing as she made a decision a split second later. The elf unsheathes her bronze steel dagger at her hip, slowly bringing it to her hand, before she moved from there, she spoke simply, "If you wish, we could commute that oath, granted it is you who will be stuck with me for all your life then."

The man looked confused but felt as though he had experienced this in a life before; he had a single question to pose to this woman, who had brought nothing but confusion to the man. His voice was soft, "Why to someone you have just met? You do not even know me."

Giving a nod to him, acknowledging their lack of familiarity, she loosely grasps her dagger, then in an instant rips it down, drawing a slim and small red line in the palm of her hand, slowly crying red tears that explode upon the stone below. "As I said, many of these vows were made, to use an expression of man, on a whim. If all else fails, I hold solace in the fact that this vow will be a mere blink in my life. So, if truth indeed dwells in your words," she said softly, shimmering in her gaze, "my blade shall stand by your side, bound to you until the end." There was an odd logic to her request; it bounced around his head for a few minutes

As she lets out a soft laugh, "I knew Aelfred, your father. I had sworn my sword to him, yet he commanded me to you when he left. He had given me a final request that I be there to guide you from the error of his ways." From the rear of her belt, she removed a dirk from cloth; he recognised the hilt of the weapon.

His eyes grew wide at the sight of the dirk, one he recalled from his childhood; it was the first blade his father ever let him hold, he said to her with a sense of fear, "Is my father alive or dead?" His voice seemed to crack and shake as his mind swirled around the possibilities of his father's fate.

Her tone changed, gaining an underlying sense of seriousness, one that gave a slight unease to Ulfar as she continued. "No, it does not mean such; the fate of your father was unknown to me. Yet tell me, Ulfar, the blade you now lean upon, Arenith. Who was the last to wield this weapon? And who, in turn, entrusted it to you? What, in all the gods' names, has been normal about the week that has passed?" A tone of pure sass and sarcasm unexpectedly overcame the elf as she had a near outburst, but righted it in a few moments. "Unbeknownst to you, the world itself struggles against many forces of darkness that have risen. None of them possesses the strength of the Dark Lord, whose night seemed endless. Many believe him to be dead, yet if he still lives, no power in the world of the living can stand against him. The Elves of the First Era were old and few in number, and many who stood before the War of Shadows fell during the countless campaigns. The world of man has slumbered for too long. It is time for you, Ulfar Val, to awaken it and show the world the true strength of man once more. I never saw the might of Valkar, yet my father feared Malachar more; my kin may have immortality, yet our purity is fleeting in this fallen world."

Ulfar lies in utter shock, coming to the realisation that the world he lived in was isolated beyond belief and that somewhere, he believed to be a world away, people he may never meet wrote him about. "Why would that fall to me?" He rhetorically asks, looking down at the ground as he slowly falls to his knees. Mid-fall, it was as if his strength returned to him, prompting him to catch his own body, simultaneously remembering the quest he had been sent on. "I came here on a quest. I search for something at the peak of Mount Maierr. I

assume you will accompany me on this? I know my father had meant for me to take up the reins of the rebellion, yet to change the world? Does this not seem beyond a mortal man like me?"

She tries not to laugh at the weakness of the man, yet a small giggle comes out. Her gaze looked him up and down, the muscles on his body seemed to work once again and Ariendria said unto him, "Talor was a mortal man, Augustus the Great as well, it is inevitable that Men will come to be the race of the world, the time of the Elves is fading it is the will of mortals who decides the future of the world. Of course, I pledged my service to you in blood wherever you go, I follow."

A simple nod of his head is all the affirmation he offers her, a wordless acknowledgement that carries the weight of new unspoken trust. Without another exchange, they press on, their journey stretching over jagged rocks and uneven terrain. The path to the base of Mount Maierr is unforgiving, a harsh testament to the land's unyielding nature. The day drags on, much of it spent in reflective silence. Ulfar trails behind the elf, watching as she navigates their way with a sense of ease born from experience.

Her every step seems deliberate, as if she's always known the path, even when it appears unclear. When they finally arrive at the base of the highest peak, the air feels heavier, charged with the promise of the gruelling ascent ahead. Both of them take a moment to steady themselves, adjusting their gear and preparing for the climb. The jagged, inhospitable slopes rise like the jagged teeth of some primordial beast, daring any who approach to scale its perilous heights.

As they begin the climb, the mountain shows no mercy. The incline grows steeper, the rocks sharper, and the cold more biting with each step. By the time they reach the halfway point, any trace of plant life has long vanished, leaving behind only barren stone and an eerie stillness. The absence of life presses against them, a silent reminder of the mountain's hostility. They will not be able to rest until they reach the summit; the thought

weighs heavily, but neither speaks it aloud. Hours pass in a haze of effort and determination. Their muscles burn, their breaths grow shallow, and the mountain seems intent on testing every ounce of their resolve.

Just as fatigue begins to claw at the edges of their endurance, they stumble upon a cut in the mountain. It is a natural pathway, carved by some ancient force, with walls that rise high on either side but leave the sky open above. The surface here is flatter, offering a brief reprieve from the punishing climb. As they step onto the smoother ground, the sky begins to shift into hues of twilight, casting long shadows across the mountain's face. Ulfar looks out and feels a rush of realisation—they have reached the summit. The world stretches out before them, vast and unbroken, a canvas of valleys, rivers, and endless skies. Yet his attention is drawn to his right, where something remarkable catches his eye.

Nestled improbably among the desolation is a single plant, its vibrant colour stark against the grey monotony of the stone. It is a red spider lily, its slender, emerald-green stalk rising defiantly from a crack in the rock. The petals unfurl in delicate, spidery tendrils, a deep, almost otherworldly crimson that seems to drink in the fading light. Each petal curls gracefully, its ends tipped with gold as though kissed by the sun itself. The flower stands alone, its beauty unyielding against the harshness around it—a vivid symbol of life's persistence in the face of adversity.

Ulfar steps closer, captivated by the sight. For a moment, the weight of the journey seems to lift, replaced by a quiet reverence. He cannot help but marvel at how such an exquisite thing could exist in a place so barren, so inhospitable. The flower sways gently in the faint breeze, a silent guardian of the mountain's peak, its presence a whisper of something greater—a reminder of resilience, beauty, and the enduring spirit of life.

As Ulfar begins to walk down the pass under her breath, Ariendria whispers, “*Reio-Licty Radia*, an omen, the mark of death is here, one will die soon.” Her ominous words are

followed by the blow of a slight breeze. Such a flower held much mystery in the world; it was the most beautiful of all, yet had the omens of death and damnation.

The duo passes through the crevice, sliding through slim cracks between the faces of the mountain. Neither says a word, just the sound of the wind whistling through the small cracks. Ulfar stares with determination, leading down the sharp path towards whatever awaits at the opening seen in the distant distance. “We are nearing there. I do not know what awaits, stay ready.” Speaking the only words between the two since they began their climb. The eerie silence began to eat away at the pair, yet there was a depth of onset courage—or rather pride—that held both of their tongues, one which did not dare to lose a battle of silence between them.

After around another hour of weaving through the expanding and contracting crevice, the two walked through the space, which opened up to be a more circular arena standing area with a small waterfall directly in front of the opening the two walked through. There by the small pond with limited growth, mostly moss, with again a single blood red spider lily flower fully bloomed, sprawling out with its small red arms. Crouched on the moss, reaching for something within the pond, is a small, half-human being who looks clearly aged, resembling the figure of a smaller orc or even goblin. Around the neck of the creature is what seems to be an amulet that instantly catches the eye of Ulfar.

He waves his hand to the female elf while telling her in such a voice, “Stay here, ensure that creature cannot escape.” Ulfar begins to approach the creature, who notices the full-sized man walking towards him, prompting the creature to grab a small shiv resembling an ancient, long-forgotten dagger showing both time and wear upon the form.

The shrivelled beast before Ulfar mutters in a tone of high pitch as if his very throat had been cursed, “You. What you want, long man?”

The gaze of Ulfar comes drawn to the amulet that is strewn across the breast of the shrivelled creature. He then says to the little one, “That around your neck, what is it? I will take it off your hands, for it does not belong to you.”

The halfling creature, which seemed like the shrivelled remains of a mortal being. It was as if the thing had seemed to long outlive the life it was supposed to leap at Ulfar with shiv in hand while screaming, “Nooo! You can't has it! It's *mine*, it is!”

Ulfar catches the hand of the smaller creature, then throws him against some rocks, knocking the shiv free. In an instant, the whole world around Ulfar freezes with a glowing hue around him, “Do not kill the creature, give pity for he is not wrong, he protected it for you to find now.” As the figure of Vaeimea appears around the small creature, running her hand across his face. “Greyon has done no wrong; he is far from pure and innocent. Give him your necklace now, he will take it.”

As the scene returns to normal, Ulfar draws Arenith while removing his own amulet, given to him by a friend many years prior. It was nothing of any unique qualities, yet it was beautiful, and there seemed to be an aurora on it that drew the gaze of the creature. “Here, Greyon, is it? Take my amulet for the one that has brought you nothing but trouble since you found it.” Its shine was greater than that of the one on the small halfling; it showed with a special gem that hummed with a faint energy. He offers the amulet in his right hand as the little creature removes the one around his neck, quickly grabbing the one in Ulfar's hand. Then, he placed it around his neck without even unclasping it.

Taking the amulet, there are visible changes in the halfling, making Ulfar pity him more. Followed with a scream of agony as the pure amulet of healing touches the chest of the goblin-like creature, “AGHHH! Nooo, nooo! AGHHH! Why does it burn?! Why?!?”

He rolls around the ground while screaming, which calms down as the creature accepts the blessing. It was not a

bum that came to his skin, but a purity and holiness that came from the blessed necklace. A good nature which came to meet the swell of evil that engulfed the creature in its years. For in his agonising rolls, he came to show the symbol of holiness, a simple cross.

Ulfar held the amulet within his hands, its weight carrying the echoes of ages long past. As he paced towards the small stream, the soft gurgling of water met the quiet rustle of his movements. Kneeling by the bank, he dipped the ancient piece into the cool embrace of the stream. With care, he began wiping away the years of dirt and wear, his calloused fingers revealing glimpses of the forgotten splendour beneath. The gold and platinum of the amulet caught the refracted light, glistening like liquid sunlight scattered across its intricate frame. The filigree, once dulled, now sparkled with life, its curling patterns akin to vines unfurling at the touch of spring. At its heart, a gem that had seemed lifeless—a sullen, blood-red stone—began to stir as if awakening from a long slumber. The colour shifted before his eyes, crimson tones fading like embers into the darkened stream.

A brilliant green began to pulse within, spreading outward like fresh shoots bursting through frost. Slowly, the dead hue gave way to the vibrant glow of an elegant emerald, a gem alive with depth and vitality. Its surface, faceted like the still waters of an untouched lake, captured and refracted every shard of light, sending ripples of verdant fire dancing across the stream. As the gem fully emerged, it seemed to draw in the very essence of the surrounding forest—the rich greens of moss, the shimmer of dew-kissed leaves, and the quiet vitality of life itself. The amulet's transformation was mesmerising, the golden filigree now gleaming with renewed brilliance, like veins of sunlight threading through the emerald heart.

Each intricate curl and flourish in the design seemed alive, as if it had been forged by nature's hand rather than mortal craft. The small green jewels encircling the central stone caught the light as well, glowing softly, like the watchful eyes of the

forest peeking through a canopy of gold. It was no longer merely an ornament—it was a living relic, imbued with an almost palpable energy, humming with a presence that seemed to reach out, breathing life back into the air around it.

He knew this amulet. The sight of it sent shivers down his spine, for the legends of mankind spoke of only one relic that matched such a form: the Amulet of the Kings. Lost to the annals of history with the tragic death of Talor, its very existence was a whisper on the tongues of the learned, a myth preserved in fragmented lore. Yet here it was, gleaming faintly in his hands, as real as the air he breathed. His thoughts spiralled in a tempest of disbelief and possibility. Could it truly be that sacred artefact, the one said to have been forged in the days of the Third King of the Valkorian Empire, back when he was but a prince, in the second century of the first millennium? The amulet's story was steeped in sorrow and hope, its craftsmanship a labour of both grief and redemption.

Its delicacy had been moulded by the masterful hands of Hónir, the third son of the noble line of Valin, an artisan-king whose skill was unparalleled. Legends spoke of how he dared to take the cursed gem that had brought ruin to his father, Hurgon—a stone that had carried a malediction as dark as the void. With unparalleled artistry and an iron will, Hónir transfigured that malevolent stone into a beacon of purity, a relic imbued with protection and fortitude. It was said that the amulet would shield the bloodline of his kin, undoing the shadow of his father's folly and binding his descendants to a destiny of strength and light.

Its beauty was unlike any other. The golden filigree, intricate as the branches of the oldest oak, intertwined seamlessly with the deep emerald centrepiece, which glimmered as though it held the light of stars trapped within its crystalline heart. Symbols of ancient power, etched with painstaking precision, adorned its surface—markings of a bygone age, when men walked with gods and the world was still young. The amulet was

a testament to kingly prowess and divine favour, a relic that marked Hónir's ascent to the throne after his father's untimely demise in a fatal accident—a death whispered to have been more than mere misfortune. But now, here it lay, improbably clasped around the neck of a beast—a Greyon, no less. The incongruity of such a noble artefact being found in the possession of so base a creature gnawed at him. It was as though the amulet itself had endured untold horrors to arrive at this moment, its journey a mystery as tangled as the histories it embodied. He turned it over in his hands, the smoothness of the gold cold to the touch, yet brimming with an unspoken energy that seemed to hum just beneath the surface.

In recent weeks, so much had happened that might have broken the resolve of a lesser man. Yet even now, standing on the precipice of revelation, with the weight of history pressing against him, he found himself awed. For all he had seen, for all he had endured, this was something rare—a moment where the past and the present collided, where the myths of his forefathers breathed life anew. He arose from the pond and placed the amulet around his neck, replacing the one he had just given up. The small creature had, by this point, calmed and enjoyed this new piece of jewellery around his neck and was much more merry than even a few minutes ago.

The little one jumped up and down as Ulfar came to a knee while calling to the creature, “Greyon, could I ask you where you came by this Amulet?” The words of the man were soft, yet there was such a deep tone that seemingly foretold of a darker thought that lingered within his mind's eye. A deep, felt wandering lingered in the air; it was as if the very air had thoughts of its own, a living being created for the sole purpose of filling the space.

The small creature looks with an odd fascination at the man rather than the Amulet, which once belonged to him and croaked out, “We found mine on a dead man.” In a few more attempts, that was all which came from the small being.

After failing many times to glean any further knowledge, he realised the effort was pointless. As he rose, the amulet seemed to lose its emerald hue for but a brief moment—yet a moment that stirred something deep within the young man, a feeling so strong that even Ariendria sensed it, though she could neither see nor hear the words of Ulfar. A sense of pity overcame the man and faded the amulet back into a vibrant shade of emerald. He takes a few steps away as if to leave the creature behind, but he pauses. This pity leaves Ulfar's body, thus he begins to stare at the shrivelled creature, then glance at his sword, followed by the sound of metal scraping stone, along with the two thuds of differing strengths separated by a few seconds. Then he walks away towards Ariendria, who stands far from view, not witnessing what had just occurred.

Chapter &

Valkoria

As the days stretched onward, Queen Anne and her generals began to believe that, at last, the scattered skirmishes and battles littering the land—peasant dissenters clashing with her armies—might finally fade, with all eventually bowing and pledging fealty to her alone. Far to the north and nestled along the continent's western rim lay Valkoria, the capital of the Neimar Imperium. For it was one of the few places where a true siege would be needed to take the city. Each tier and avenue of the city was studded with towering wooden beacons meant to flare into light at the faintest whisper of siege, yet they had never been called into action, standing mute witnesses to generations of peace.

Centuries ago, it was Queen Anne's great-grandmother who, entrusting her family's wealth to a bold plan, changed the fate of the realm. She had allied herself with a wily general who swore he could end the endless civil strife—with but one condition. In exchange for the gold and silver that would fund his troops, he vowed that her bloodline would claim the throne, and that her daughter, and her daughters' daughters, would one day reign as queens.

With this wealth, General Tul hired the fabled Veileiar mercenaries, commonly known as the Blood Elves, an enigmatic and solitary people. Known to shun the gentleness of a quiet life, the Veileiar favoured instead the brutal clarity of war. Their

fierce, indomitable spirits became the blade of the Neimar Imperium, pushing forward with relentless resolve.

Now, in the two-hundred and eighty-eighth year of the Third Era, Queen Anne sits upon the high throne, claiming dominion over the Valkorians of Onu-Arith. Her heart, tempered by years of uncontested rule, now yearns for peace; a peace that could not be achieved during her mother's time only through her reign. Those who dared resist her have dwindled into whispers of rebellion, flickering out like smoke in the dawn. Yet even as Ulfar traversed the distant northeastern mountains on his own journey, the Imperium moved forward, unaware of the force stirring beyond their sight. The strength of Anne's reign pulsed steadily, a quiet heartbeat of a realm that might, for now, rest but always readied itself for the changing winds of fate.

The Grand General, a man of wiry build and seasoned visage, bore the marks of countless battles, the weight of many campaigns etched into the hardened lines of his face. Standing before the queen, his voice took on a tremor of urgency as he pleaded, "My Queen, I tell you—we must raid the peasant villages to the southeast, just as we did those long years ago. We would crush any whisper of defiance before it even breathes. In doing so, no one would dare challenge your power, Your Grace."

His words, fervent and unyielding, were underscored by the unspoken resolve etched into every scar and calloused muscle, as if his very being echoed what his voice could not. His battle-worn stance, his hands knotted in fervent supplication, spoke volumes. The weight of his experience lingered in the tension of his shoulders and the quiet intensity of his gaze—a man who had both bled for and preserved the throne. To see him there, offering not just his counsel but his unwavering loyalty in every inch of his scar-laden frame, was to understand the depth of his resolve. He was a warrior of unbending conviction, asking his queen to draw upon his wisdom, just as he had drawn upon the scars of his past.

Queen Anne rose from her throne, descending to the stone floor where the bowed General Seidel knelt, her voice sharp as polished steel and laced with a quiet fury that left the air heavy with tension. “You would do well not to forget, *I* am the divine ruler of this land,” she intoned, each word measured and cold, as though his very suggestion bordered on insolence. “You may stand as my closest advisor, General, yet I am she who dictates law itself. Those pathetic peasants—could they ever muster a force worthy of my concern? At best, they are ants beneath our boot.”

Her footsteps echoed in the grand hall as she crossed to the arched window, stopping beside a potted flower of Vaeimea—a sacred blossom of royal import. She reached out, plucking the delicate bloom with an indifferent grace, only to crush it in her palm, the petals and stem crumbling between her fingers like forgotten dust. “I may have been chosen by her,” she declared, an eerie edge sharpening her words as she fingered the extravagant bracelet on her wrist, the dark gleam of obsidian intertwined with brilliant sapphires casting spectral patterns against her hand. “But know this: I am beyond the gods and the trifles of this mortal realm.” Turning her gaze back to the general, her eyes cold yet blazing with sovereign fire, she concluded, “Do as you will. But I will not have my soldiers sully themselves in some pig-strewn mud pasture without cause.”

Seidel bowed his head once more, pressing it low with an air of careful reverence, the faint hint of apology woven into his posture and the solemnity of his stance. He lingered for a heartbeat longer, as if to absorb the gravity of her words, then straightened, his gaze respectfully lowered.

With a calm resolve and a final nod, he spoke, “As you command, my liege.” Turning on his heel, Seidel made his departure, footsteps silent yet steady as he carried her orders from the chamber, leaving behind only the echo of her dominance and his quiet acceptance.

As Seidel strode through the grand halls, his thoughts were interrupted by the swift approach of his lower commanders. They fell in step beside him, their eyes sharp, voices lowered as they questioned in near-unison, “What troops shall we move, General?”

Seidel's gaze remained forward, his expression a mask of steely resolve. He took a moment to respond, as if weighing the gravity of his orders, then, in a voice edged with iron, he replied, “Prepare the Third Legion. They will be ready to move south towards the outer villages. Let no one leave or enter without command.”

The commanders exchanged brief glances, nodding in acknowledgement. The Third Legion was known for its unwavering discipline and ruthless efficiency—a choice that left little room for resistance.

With orders understood, Seidel gave one last glance to the throne room doors in the distance, murmuring more to himself than to his subordinates, “The Queen's will is absolute. No hesitation.”

The group takes a walk to the barracks as Seidel waits to answer the question until they enter the security of the building. He raises his hand, rethinking the previous orders given to his men, then he speaks to them once more. “Prepare the legion, but by no means do we send them out until I have gotten at least a hint of desire from the Queen or we hear words of something rising there.” Seidel slams his door closed in frustration whilst rolling his eyes.

As night draped itself over the land, for the first time in many years, flickers of candlelight and murmurs of prayer rose from scattered villages. It was the birth-night of Talor, the divine man who had laid down his life at the fabled Battle of Dalmulog for the brave souls who stood beside him. According to legend, Talor's spirit had departed on this very day, only to return days later, walking among mortals once more as the messenger of a divine will. In this rare celebration, villagers marked his sacrifice

in whispers, beneath the watchful gaze of the stars, united in remembrance of the man turned myth.

But that night also heralded the dawn of a dark chapter, for it was then that Queen Anne, ruler, resolved to wage a war that would sear her name into the pages and tombs of history—a crusade against the very heart of all mortal faith. Her decree was stark and brutal: the followers of the ancient Valkorian faith, the Seven, Scalvic, were to be rooted out. The queen's edict swept through the land like a winter gale, swift, fearless and demanding that all those who worshipped the Seven gods submit, renouncing their beliefs, or face death.

This mandate was but the latest in a series of calculated strikes against the old faith, for years earlier, Queen Anne had outlawed the veneration of Talor and Halfar, questioning their legitimacy as divinities. It was a move that had sown quiet but persistent unrest among her people, for even under the shadow of persecution, the Valkorian heart had clung fiercely to the Seven. Now, her ultimatum would spark a resistance that would endure beyond her reign, unyielding as stone, for the memory of the Seven was carved too deeply into the soul of the Valkorian people.

The Queen's decree, an attempt to erase this faith, would instead etch her actions into history as a grave miscalculation, for the spirit of Talor and the lore of the Seven endured, woven indelibly into the destiny of her land. Those of the cities would in public bend their knees to her decree, yet many still venerated their gods in quiet darkness outside the eyes of their overlords.

The Queen prepared to address the lords of Onu-Arith with a proclamation that would shake the foundations of their ancient faith. She declared they must uphold her banning of the old religion, the Seven, known also as Scalvic, replacing it with a new creed she called the True Three, or Scalvor. This reformed faith exalted only three of the former Seven: Drukain, Viviana, and Vaeimea, each now renamed and retitled to fit her vision. By erasing Halfar, Drenamir, Vekar, and, long ago, the revered Talor,

the Queen had already sown a dangerous rift among her people. Now, this purge struck closer to the very roots of the Valkorian soul.

Her purge began with swift brutality. Statues of the erased gods vanished from temples, streets, and sacred groves. The Sanctum of Berenith—a revered sanctuary known for its relics and rich heritage—was her first target in a campaign designed to stamp out every trace of the gods from Valkorian memory. Yet as her crusade advanced, it provoked murmurs of dissent, even among her most trusted advisors.

Her council, often compliant in her schemes, grew uneasy; the once-loyal voices wavered, none more so than Heron Dugg, the Minister of Welfare. With an uncharacteristic boldness, he implored her to cease what he called a “pointless holy war,” pleading that this course could fracture the unity of the realm. Deep within his mind still lay the visions of this woman's very mother, Queen Deidlee, who in her final decade came to be known as the Mad Queen. He could still recall the voice which echoed deep within Ann's calling out, “Burn all who dare speak ill of me!”

He dreamt that Anne would not become that very same monster, for the one who dared to put a stop to the madness had long since vanished with that Queen. But the Queen's vision of the True Three only seemed to sharpen with the backlash. Every protest seemed to fuel her fervour to erase all but her chosen deities from the hearts of the people. And yet, in her unyielding pursuit, the air grew tense with quiet resistance, the kindling of rebellion sparking within every forced devotion and empty temple.

The sharp, staccato echoes of heels striking wood and stone filled the chamber—a herald of power, of presence, one that commanded all eyes to lower and all words to cease. Queen Anne had entered the room. The weight of her authority rolled over the gathered council as she swept forward, her gaze burning with unrestrained fury.

Her voice cut through the silence, fierce and resonant, each word a blow meant to remind them who held the reins of their world. “You shall know your place! I am the Queen of this land—not you. Me!” Her voice surged in intensity, striking like a hammer against the timid murmur of the council, “This ‘pointless holy war,’ as you have so dared to call it, is not yours to question. It is mine to judge, to lead, and, if I will it, to conquer. I alone decide its purpose, not you.”

She let her gaze settle on Heron Dugg, the Minister of Welfare, each word laced with contempt. “I appointed you to your position of power; it was I who made you none else, not you nor any fellow fool of this court. Do not tempt me to undo such a bold choice I once made.”

Her hand moved suddenly, slamming a heavy book onto the worn wooden table, its sound filling the small conference room where her council huddled beneath her gaze. “I would strip you of your title in an instant if it meant I could place someone in it who truly understands their loyalty and worth.” The Queen stood poised, her figure a blend of controlled wrath and absolute command, her eyes daring any to respond, knowing that in this hall, defiance was but another name for folly.

Queen Anne strode from the room, each step a sharp, unforgiving staccato that echoed through the halls, the force of her heels striking the stone with the weight of her simmering rage. She moved with the swiftness of a gathering storm, her strides unyielding, fury barely leashed beneath her regal poise. Low mutters tumbled from her lips, half-formed curses aimed at the ministers who dared question her authority. Her guards scrambled in her wake, silent shadows bound by duty and awe, their movements tense under the pressure of her wrath. As she passed, General Seidel stood stationed in the corridor, his stance unflinching, a silent sentinel amidst the rising tempest. His gaze remained steady, watching as she swept by, her expression fierce and unreadable.

Her eyes didn't meet his, her focus fixed on distant thoughts as she continued down the corridor, her presence lingering, thick and tangible like smoke clinging to the air. Then, as if unable to contain it any longer, she released a pure, unbridled scream, the sound ripping through the quiet halls, carrying with it a frustration that felt raw and ancient, matured by countless years of sovereignty. “ARRRRGGHHH!”

Her voice reverberated, filling the spaces around her with a primal, unfiltered fury, a sound that seemed to come from the deepest recesses of her being, unchecked and untamed. It was a cry that left the guards rigid, their faces pale, the echo lingering in the hall long after she had moved on, like a ghostly imprint of her power.

Once she had swept away, Seidel straightened, his gaze sharpening with a renewed clarity. He turned, entering the dim chamber Queen Anne had just vacated, the air still thick with the remnants of her fury. There, slumped and hollow-eyed, sat Minister Heron Dugg, his shoulders hunched beneath the weight of the Queen's scorn, his figure curled inward as if to shield himself from the memory of her wrath. He seemed a man who had felt the foundation of his purpose crumble beneath him, his spirit drained to shadows. Seidel paused, surveying the broken figure before him, his face a mask of stoicism. Yet behind that disciplined exterior, a flicker of something calculating passed through his gaze, a glint that hinted at gears shifting, adjustments being made. He stepped closer, his boots soft on the stone, each measured stride echoing faintly in the room. He studied Dugg with an unreadable expression, allowing the silence to stretch, its weight pressing down on the battered minister like a silent judgment.

Dugg's voice cut through the silence, his tone sharp with desperation and fury. “You, my friend, are an imbecile of a man, General—an utter imbecile!” He paused, catching his breath, his eyes flickering with a frantic determination as he fumbled for the right words. “I cannot oppose that insane, witchy woman alone.

But if I had the backing of a few others... a handful from the eleven ministers, perhaps..."

He took another shuddering breath, the plea slipping into his voice as he continued, "You know as well as I do, Seidel, that she'll have my head for speaking out, sooner rather than later. You saw her, the way she stormed from this room like a force unhinged. Tell me, does it not bear utter resemblance to that crazed mother of hers? Replacing one of us? A trifle for her. But replacing multiple... now, that might give even her pause." His voice grew softer, almost pleading. "I beg of you. Help me rally them. You understand, don't you? Alone, I am as good as dead." The weight of his words lingered, and he stared at Seidel, his gaze hollowed by fear but laced with a flicker of hope.

Seidel's eyes narrowed, his voice rising, tinged with a steely disdain. "I have given you every tool to play the long game, Dugg. But each time she approaches, you cower, bending under the weight of her wrath like a beaten dog. You call her a madwoman and yet let her put you back in your place, cowed and trembling." He strode closer, his steps slow, unyielding, the plates of his armour glinting ominously under the dim chamber light.

The minister shrank back, but Seidel pressed forward, his voice cold and cutting. "Even now, you flinch at me, a mere mortal—when I hold no power to end you as she does. I have an empire on the brink of war to prepare, Dugg. And while I align this nation against a tide far greater than you can imagine, *your* task—gathering others to your cause, stirring them to support—is your burden to bear." He pointed a leather-clad finger at Dugg, who recoiled, eyes wide, his face stricken with a mix of shame and fear. "She cannot conquer without our minds, nor crush without her ministers, yet if you wish to cower and beg while our land comes to burn—then do so alone. The time is yours to either rise or fall."

As Seidel departed, the echo of his heavy footfalls fading down the hall, Minister Dugg remained in the dimly lit

chamber, the air heavy with the weight of Seidel's reprimand. Steeling himself, Dugg pushed aside his lingering unease and reached for the thick parchment and quill on his desk. His hand trembled only for a moment before steadying, the ink flowing across the page with purpose. He crafted each letter carefully, aiming his words at those who bore influence yet found themselves at odds with the Queen's erratic rule.

Of the six ministers he would petition, his most critical targets were Saul Nornin, Minister of War, and Peitro Hulle, Minister of Coin. The Nomin and Hulle bloodlines were two of the only ancient Valkorian houses to survive the last thousand years unbroken. Their lineage and power held sway not only within the court but resonated throughout the Neirmar Imperium—a power formidable enough to be reckoned with, should they choose to unite. Dugg leaned forward, his brow creased with the weight of his message as he penned his first words to Saul Nornin.

Salutations, Minister Nornin,

I hope this correspondence finds you well. I shall keep this brief and simple.

Many years prior, the line of the throne made a covenant with the House of Seidel. That covenant remained undisturbed until the Lady Anne took the throne. I have observed the subtle skirmishes between the two of you during council meetings. From this, I propose a preposition—one of grave importance.

It has come to pass that the wretch Anne has no place leading this fledgling kingdom. It is our obligation, as ministers of this land, to excise this cancer before it can spread further. Thus, I extend my hand in confidence, seeking to unite

our spheres of influence into a secret coalition—one formed to preserve the very beauty we both seek to see flourish.

I pray you accept this offer. Alone, we are but dust. Together, we shall endure.

Thank you for your time, Minister Nornin.

Farewell. I await your reply.

—Minister Dugg, of Welfare

After carefully inscribing the final line of his letter, Dugg rolled the parchment with measured precision, a delicate tension evident in each movement. With a practised hand, he pressed a dot of black wax against the edge, watching as the dark bead pooled like a drop of midnight ink. Then, instead of reaching for the familiar stamp bearing his own mark, he selected the council's official seal—an insignia carrying weight far beyond his own name. As he pressed it into the cooling wax, he felt the quiet gravity of the council's power settling upon the rolled parchment, a silent oath held within that darkened crest. Clutching the message close to his chest, Dugg left his chamber, winding his way down toward the keep's lower reaches where the loyal courier waited in obscurity.

Each step of his descent echoed faintly, a reminder of the great distance separating his high, secluded chamber from the bustling, shadowy depths below. The air grew cooler, and the stone walls seemed to press inward as he ventured deeper. Still, as he reached the Queen's hall, what was a calm stride faltered, his pulse quickening despite himself. Suddenly, the heavy doors of the Queen's hall swung open with a slow, ominous groan, revealing Queen Anne herself, her gaze like twin blades as she strode forward with a bearing that spoke of fire and iron. Her

steps were swift, her eyes fierce, and Dugg felt the space around him shrink in her presence.

Instinct jolted him into action, his fingers deftly slipping the message into the folds of his robe, nestling it against his chest as if hiding a fragile bird's egg. He forced himself into a posture of rigid composure, heart thudding beneath the hidden letter, praying she wouldn't hear the desperate rhythm beneath his calm facade.

The Queen approached with an intensity that seemed to heat the very air, her eyes flashing with a ferocity few dared to meet. Her steps were sharp, purposeful, each one underscoring her undeniable authority. Yet there was something else—a cold, calculating edge tempered by a restrained disdain that made even her simplest words feel like thinly veiled threats.

She stopped just short of him, her gaze piercing as she said, “As Minister of Welfare, is it not your duty to care for the poor, the weak, the homeless, and the weary of this land? And further,” she continued, her voice a low, simmering demand, “to ensure proper relief during times of disaster?” Each word dripped with a certain menace, though her tone was strangely subdued—less wrathful than earlier, yet still laden with the weight of her expectations. She leaned in, her face a mere breath away, eyes narrowing. “Isn't it?” she repeated, her voice barely above a whisper, yet carrying a weight that crushed any answer he might give. She demanded a response, her silent fury a storm on the verge of breaking, leaving the Minister stunned and scrambling to steady himself, his mind racing to catch up with the sudden interrogation.

The meek, unsuspecting minister, caught entirely off guard by the Queen's sudden and cutting inquiry, managed a reply, his voice soft and wavering as if each word might break beneath her gaze. “Yes, it is, M'lady.” He murmured, the humility in his tone unmistakable. His eyes darted from her face to the floor, unable to hold her fierce gaze, while his fingers trembled slightly, fiddling nervously at his waist as he awaited

her response. The anxiety crept over him like a chill, rising with every heartbeat, his mind racing through the possibilities of her demand. He struggled to maintain his composure, but his posture betrayed him, shoulders drawn slightly inward, as though he could shield himself from the weight of her expectations.

Queen Anne rolled her eyes, the motion sharp and steeped in unfiltered disbelief, as though even her gaze could mock him. “What I need from you,” she began, her voice laced with thinly veiled disdain, “is for you to do your job.” Each syllable dripped with impatience, and her gaze bore into him as she continued, her words a whip meant to flay. “Shall I remind you yet again of the power I hold over you, or is it still fresh in your mind?”

She taunted him, her tone carrying the bite of their last bitter encounter. Her lips twisted into a cruel smile, the sarcasm flowing as freely as venom. “Please, take all the time you need while the people of my kingdom suffer.” Her laugh was sudden, harsh, a sound cut off abruptly as her face hardened into something chillingly resolute. “One week,” she declared, her eyes narrowing, “to do your job and to better the welfare of this godforsaken place. Or I will find someone else who can. Don’t test me.”

With her final words hanging in the air, a sinister smile came over her face. She turned on her heel, her presence like the weight of a storm as she left him standing there, stripped of words. Dugg watched her retreat, her silhouette disappearing down the dim corridor, leaving him to clutch his sealed message and continue his journey to the courier, the ultimatum ringing in his ears.

When he reached the dimly lit quarters of the courier’s chambers, Dugg’s face was shrouded in grim resolve. He extended the sealed parchment toward the messenger, his hand steady yet his gaze a hard, unyielding command. “You show, you tell, you speak to none other than Lord Saul Nornin,” he instructed, his voice low but edged with a warning. “If any

approach you—any at all—you burn it. This document does not touch another hand.”

The courier, sensing the weight of Dugg's words, nodded solemnly, his own expression mirroring the urgency in Dugg's eyes. Dugg held the gaze a moment longer, ensuring the seriousness of his command was deeply impressed upon the young man. In the silence that followed, the message passed from one set of hands to another, a fragile link in a chain that could be their undoing. With a final nod, Dugg turned on his heel, his footsteps echoing in the hollow halls as he disappeared into the shadows, leaving the courier to fulfil his secret charge.

The courier nodded in silent affirmation, his expression neutral yet intent, before he turned and started the brief journey to the residence of the Minister of War. Though it was but a few minutes' walk—a path Dugg himself could easily have taken—he chose not to. Dugg, ever cautious, preferred to keep a deliberate distance from those who might suspect his motives, limiting his exposure to those he knew held no loyalty to the Queen. Each step of the courier's journey echoed softly against the stone corridors, a quiet yet determined cadence that underscored the importance of his mission.

Every corner he rounded was another turn away from the bustling heart of the keep, a sanctuary for secrets and shadows. Dugg's decision to remain apart was a calculated one, a separation that allowed his presence to remain hidden and his intentions obscure to those who might stand in his way.

Lord Nornin's eyes moved over the letter again and again, his gaze hardened with each read, furrowing slightly as he weighed its implications. With a sigh, he folded the parchment and placed it beside him, then looked up to where his eldest son, Heron, stood by his side. The young man, just seventeen, watched his father with a mixture of eagerness and caution, his posture as straight and attentive as a soldier's.

“For one,” Nornin began slowly, his voice carrying both irritation and apprehension, “simply being sent this asinine letter

already puts our family at risk, let alone the notion of responding to it.” He paused, his fingers tapping rhythmically on the table’s edge. “This is no small matter, Heron. These are tides best navigated carefully, or not at all.” Heron’s expression remained stoic, though a flicker of curiosity crossed his face. He knew well his father’s tendency toward prudence, but the gravity in his tone hinted at a threat much closer and more treacherous than the political games he had thus far been trained to observe.

Heron’s words hung in the air, sharp and perceptive, yet layered with the quiet boldness of youth. “Father, why not turn him in? To the Queen, I mean.” He ventured, his brow furrowed as he considered the idea. “Would it not benefit us to expose him?”

Lord Nornin’s gaze sharpened, and he paused, assessing his son with a thoughtful look. He admired the practicality in Heron’s suggestion, but beneath the surface, his face softened with the subtle patience of a father guiding a young mind. “There is wisdom in what you say, son. But exposing Dugg means more than simply currying favour. To act now would mark us as partisans in this power struggle, a risk in itself.”

The elder Nomin leaned forward, eyes narrowing. “This world of shadows, Heron... even those who speak the truth are bound by oaths and allegiances far older and more treacherous than any words on parchment. One misstep, and we might find ourselves entangled in something far beyond our control.” He paused, letting the weight of his words settle on his son’s shoulders. “Patience, boy. We must see where the pieces fall before deciding whose hand to take.” The belly of the ageing politician was round, showing his love of mead and glutinous behaviour. “Well my boy, first, I do not disagree with the statements, but why did he send a letter?” He points to his family guard, “You, go find that messenger and bring him back this instant.”

The guard, clad in gleaming steel armour that seemed more suited for ceremonial display than the brutal demands of

war, stood rigid, his polished cuirass reflecting the faint glow of the room's torches. Every plate and edge bore a lustre that marked it as untested, armour that had known neither blood nor grit nor the unforgiving strike of a blade—a common sight among those tasked with keeping order in the capital, where protection often meant appearances over purpose.

“Yes, M'lord?” He replied, his voice obedient yet hollow, his words an echo of duty without the weight of conviction. With a practised nod, the guard turned on his heel, each step brisk and precise as he exited the room, his figure swallowed by the dim corridor beyond. The soft clank of metal on stone faded quickly, a reminder of the facades that filled the halls of power.

The minister raised the cup before him, tilting it back to take a long, thoughtful swig. The liquid—a dark mead, perhaps, or some potent spirit—caught the light as he drank, its warmth seeming to settle the rough edge in his voice, though his tone remained gravelly and sharp.

Setting the cup back down, he leaned over the letter again, his eyes tracing the words with a hard, unyielding scrutiny. “Now, if we do accept this,” he began slowly, his gaze still fixed on the parchment, “we must have the support of Seidel. Without him, this entire scheme falls to ruin.” He paused, the silence heavy with intent, before turning to his son, who waited attentively at his side. “Heron?”

The younger man looked over, his expression thoughtful yet restrained, offering his father a quiet, steady gaze. His response was simple, respectful, and tempered with the deference owed to the man who held both the family's legacy and their future in his hands. “Yes, Father?” He replied, his voice soft but unwavering, each word carrying the weight of both obedience and unspoken understanding. He awaited his father's next words, his own posture still and composed, though a flicker of curiosity danced in his eyes.

The lord held his son's gaze with a steady, calculating intensity as he extended his hand, revealing a bracelet of solid

gold, its surface etched with intricate designs that gleamed faintly even in the dim light. “Venture out to Minister Dugg’s manor and deliver this,” he instructed, his voice low but resolute. “This will serve as a token—an understanding of our terms. Tell him we will ally only if Seidel is already in support. Should he decline, return without delay.”

His son received the bracelet carefully, the cool weight of the gold in his hand grounding him with a sense of purpose. The young man nodded once, determination flickering in his eyes as he turned to make his way toward the doors. The sound of his footsteps soon echoed down the stone corridor as he departed, already preparing himself for the short journey ahead.

As whispers of dissent grew, morphing from simple tales and folk words to the stuff of consistent rings and the echoes of unrest, then began to fill the halls of her kingdom, Queen Anne faced a storm fiercer than she had anticipated. The first wave of opposition swept toward her with an intensity that made even the iron-willed queen pause, their voices defiant, their loyalty to the old gods unyielding.

In the face of this groundswell, she established the Zealots of Judd—a powerful and ruthless order that would act as both her shield and her sword. Led by Zek Judd, the fervent head of the new church and a man whose devotion was as cold as steel, the zealots were a symbol of her resolve, her response to the swelling tide of resistance. She had played a hand which she dared not until it was absolutely necessary, as these zealots would be granted a power only held by the royal guard. Under Judd’s guidance, these fanatics moved through the city with an unrelenting determination, enacting Anne’s will to crush the remnants of worship for Talor, Halfar, Drenamir, and Vekar.

With the backing of the city guard, they patrolled the streets, their presence a reminder of the queen’s unyielding stance, their orders to imprison or brutalise anyone who clung to the forbidden gods. The streets grew tense and watchful, for the ‘True Three’ had become more than a creed—it was the queen’s

command, etched in fear and enforced by those who bore her mark of judgement.

The people's dissent simmered like embers, sparking into small uprisings and scattered protests that flared briefly before being ruthlessly extinguished by the Zealots of Judd. Though modestly armed—wielding mallets, clubs, and crude poles rather than blades—the zealots had become an overwhelming force in the kingdom, an iron wall against the public's unrest.

Their presence grew more oppressive with each passing day, their brutal tactics unrestrained by the lack of steel in their hands. Even in their simplicity, the tools they wielded became symbols of terror, wielded with unwavering devotion to their queen and her “true trifecta of gods.” The cobbled streets bore the bloodstains of those who dared to resist or to speak the names of the old gods. Some tried to raise their voices in defiance, while others attempted quieter forms of rebellion—small gatherings in hidden corners, whispered prayers in abandoned alleyways. But each attempt was met with swift and merciless force, as the zealots moved with a single-minded purpose.

The Queen's edict was clear, and the Zealots of Judd showed no hesitation in carrying out their charge. This would brand all who resisted as heretics, unwilling to “accept the true trifecta” and therefore unworthy of mercy. A mark of a cross as if to make light of the symbol so tied to their religion, some would even be given a broken cross. These marks would be placed in areas always visible to those around, which was almost meant to be a shameful act to those who dissented. In their wake, fear gripped the populace, silencing some while pushing others further into desperation.

Nights would pass as the Queen seemingly disappeared behind the stone walls of the keep, hiding from her people who hoped she would rest this abuse of those under the crown, yet nothing came. In a dimly lit chamber far from her watchful gaze

and the ever-present eyes of her zealots, a handful of ministers gathered in uneasy solidarity.

Minister Dugg stood at the head of a long, polished table, his countenance steely as he addressed his so-called allies, each a pillar of the realm in their own right. Beside him sat Hellion Hugarand, the refined and often unflinching Minister of Culture, whose influence over the intellectual elite had swayed the kingdom's opinion before. Grant Denoso, the Minister of Trade, sat next to him, his hands drumming softly on the table as he mentally calculated the risks and potential fallout of their plan. Saul Nomin, Minister of War and the closest thing Dugg had to a peer, held a stern face, dark eyes fixed on the task at hand.

Across from them, Vernon James, the Minister of the Sea, leaned forward, his face etched with the weathered lines of a man used to braving storms, even the ones that raged on land. Peitro Hulle, the man whose double duty as Minister of the City Guard and Minister of Coin made him invaluable, looked grave, his power over the kingdom's defences and coffers central to the scheme.

These men, who each held sway over crucial parts of the kingdom, now found themselves united by a single ambition: to dethrone Queen Anne. But the path to her downfall would be far from easy. As they murmured plans and exchanged strategies in hushed tones, the weight of the Queen's newly forged religious army—the Zealots of Judd—loomed over them. With their fanatical devotion, the zealots had become Anne's personal shield, watching, listening, and ruthlessly silencing dissent before it could gain traction. The ministers knew that if they slipped, the zealots' mallets would come for them next.

Dugg's voice cut through the silence, steady and low. "We cannot afford any mistakes. The zealots are everywhere. And as long as they stand by her, any open move could see us crushed before we even begin."

Peitro Hulle's voice rose, carrying a faint tremor as he dared to break the heavy silence. It was a voice that typically commanded with authority and confidence, yet tonight, a subtle crack betrayed the unease nestled deep within him—like the whisper of trembling leaves perched high on a tree swaying in a gentle yet insistent wind.

His words, though firm, seemed edged with a hesitation that no mask of bravado could fully conceal. “I have... one idea,” he ventured, his gaze drifting briefly to the faces surrounding him before lowering to the map sprawled across the polished surface of the round table. Seven pairs of eyes turned with cautious curiosity toward him as he placed a finger on the southeastern corner, a region marked by hills and dense forests. “My little birds have been chattering... they’ve heard whispers of a man stirring up the south.”

He paused briefly before he continued as if he contemplated his next move like a gamble which would mean his life. His voice hardened slightly, as though trying to steady himself against the significance of what he was suggesting. “A man who’s been rallying the loyalty of men—a group he’s called the Stormfangs.” He tapped the map where the Stormfangs supposedly gathered, the name lingering in the air like a spark ready to ignite. He lifted his eyes, searching the room as if for approval or caution, his confidence bolstered slightly by the weight of his words. “From what I hear,” he pressed on, his voice growing a shade bolder, “the man who leads them is fierce, a leader as strong in his ideals as he is with a sword. I believe... he might even be able to lead this nation in a way that we, in this moment, cannot.” The weight of this final admission lay heavy between them, casting an air of potential—and peril—over the chamber.

As Seidel strode into the dim chamber, his presence cast a palpable tension over the room. “No.” He declared, his voice a low thunder that silenced any murmurs. “The whispers are false. Any man in that land is nothing more than a savage

wamonger—no true leader, just a brute with more ambition than wisdom. Entrust this land to him?” He shook his head with a sneer. “We’d be no better than a pack of wolves.” Seidel’s gaze swept across each minister seated around the table, pinning them with the authority of his presence. His voice hardened further as he laid out his command. “Here is the plan,” he stated, his tone brooking no argument. “Each of you will rally your houses, muster your armies, and bring them under one cause. Together, you’ll demand her abdication—call for her to relinquish her power during a council meeting. Make it clear that her reign has run its course. But if she refuses,”—he straightened, his armoured frame casting an intimidating shadow—“then leave the rest to me. I’ll see to it that she never sits on the throne again.”

Minister Denoso leaned forward, his eyes narrowing with scepticism as he shook his head. “Now, how in the gods’ name do you expect *us*”—he spat the word with a tinge of bitterness—“expendable ministers, to stand up to her in a council meeting?” He looked around, searching the faces of his fellow conspirators for a hint of reassurance.

His fingers drummed anxiously on the table, and his voice grew taut with frustration. “She has eyes everywhere, Seidel. Zealots, guards, sycophants—every council meeting is more her arena than ours. We would barely get the words out before she’d have her dogs at our throats.” The room fell silent, the doubt seeping through the assembly as Denoso’s words hung in the air, echoing their shared fear. He leaned back, crossing his arms, his gaze challenging Seidel to explain just how he intended for them to pull off such a feat.

Seidel’s voice sliced through the tense silence, snapping with sharp impatience, “Then don’t be a fool and challenge her with a full council present! Ensure that when you confront her, you seven are the majority—or, if need be, sway more lords to your side.”

There was vast chatter amongst the ministers; they seemed to boil over this one moment, each one had their own

opinion. The lone knight who kept guard wondered if they would ever quit being politicians for a second to hear each other out.

Seidel stood, his gaze unwavering, cutting across the table as he met each of their eyes, as if daring anyone to argue. Seidel continued, his tone low but forceful, “You’ve all spent years watching her movements, grumbling behind closed doors while she amassed control. Now is your chance to act—not to squander it with timid talk of fear. We wanted her mother off the throne, and did we not have that mad witch killed?” He leaned forward, the metallic plates of his armour catching the dim light, casting an iron sheen over his face. “This is no time for hesitation. Choose wisely who you want by your side. When the time comes, we must be united, or everything you risk will be for nothing.” A heavy pause followed his words, each minister absorbing the weight of what was being asked. Shortly after he left his final words, Seidel arose from the table and left the ministers in peace for the night.

The ministers had fallen deep into the throes of plotting, voices hushed yet fervent as they laid out a labyrinthine array of plans, meticulously sifting through every angle, every potential manoeuvre. Maps and scraps of parchment littered the table, smudged with hurried notes and hastily scrawled names, dates, and marks of where guard loyalties might be swayed or alliances formed. They had even begun discussing how power would be distributed within the council once the throne was seized, speaking in muted tones of their collective vision for a new order.

Hours passed, nearly seven in total, as each minister grew wearier yet more resolute, the dim barn air thickening with the tension and sweat of their conspiracy. Saul Nomin and Kel Morrow were the first to push back from the table, their faces drawn and voices lowered as they bade the others farewell and stepped outside. But no sooner had their footsteps fallen silent beyond the barn door than a thunderous crash shattered the tense quiet. The entrance burst open, splinters of wood flying in every

direction as Almek Muun, commander of the Queen's guard, stormed in with a collection of city guards and zealots in tow. The sudden influx of torchlight cast jagged shadows across the stunned faces of the council members, each scrambling to conceal incriminating documents or reach for a hidden blade. Almek's gaze scanned the ministers, a smirk of cold satisfaction twisting his features as the Queen's voice rang clearly in his mind, commanding him to make an example of any who dared question her.

Almek's voice sliced through the room, booming with authority as he pronounced their fate. "You are all hereby placed under arrest for crimes against the Imperium," he declared, his voice echoing in the wooden confines of the barn. "Each of you stands charged with high treason against the crown, for conspiring to murder the Queen and incite a coup against her sovereign rule!"

At his command, the zealots surged forward, torchlight glinting off their iron mallets and clubs, their faces obscured by hoods bearing the mark of the Queen's crescent seal. The city guard followed close behind, their armoured hands moving swiftly to bind the ministers' arms, offering no quarter or pause. The ministers—once prideful, powerful men—were reduced to struggling figures, faces drawn with the realisation that all their careful plans had been snuffed out in a single, ruthless ambush.

Almek's gaze lingered on each of them, a glint of satisfaction flickering in his eyes as the ministers met his stare with shock, anger, and, in some, a flash of dread. The room filled with the low hum of murmurs and the shuffling of feet, a grim orchestra of defeat as the zealots and guards tightened their grip on each of the ministers. The hard reality of their position settled in, an iron weight that clamped down on any last remnants of hope.

As a zealot seized Minister Dugg's arm and began to drag him toward the door, Dugg twisted and thrashed, his face contorted in rage and desperation. "What in the gods' names do

you think you're doing?" he roared, his voice cracking as it echoed through the bam. "What proof do you have, you fool? Release me now! I am a minister of this kingdom!" He tried to wrench free from the zealot's iron grip, his face reddening as he struggled, but the zealot only tightened his hold, a smirk barely visible beneath his hood. Dugg's eyes darted around the room, seeking allies among his fellow ministers, but they, too, were held fast, their faces a mixture of defeat and despair. He turned his gaze to Almek, desperation flaring into fury. "You have no right, no authority to do this! I serve the crown, the people of this realm—unhand me!"

Almek strode over to Saul and Kel, his armour catching the dim light in a sharp, steely glint. His lips curled into a slight smile as he looked over the two ministers who stood beside him, untouched and unbound. "You two are good men." He said, his tone holding a note of satisfaction, though there was something colder beneath it. "Thank you for reporting and helping to deal with these incels."

Saul gave a curt nod, his expression stern but tinged with relief. Kel's face, however, held a glint of something sharper—a satisfaction barely concealed. The two men exchanged a brief, knowing look before turning back to the restrained ministers, who stared back with wide eyes and looks of betrayal, their once-allies now exposed as informants. Almek's gaze lingered on each of the conspirators, his smile never quite reaching his eyes as he surveyed the tangled web of loyalty and deceit unravelling before him.

As the day turned and the next council meeting commenced, a haunting silence draped over the grand chamber. The five remaining ministers shifted uncomfortably in their seats, their eyes continually drawn to the five empty chairs beside them, once occupied by their now-absent colleagues. Each man bore an expression of anxious curiosity, darting glances at the Queen, silently urging her to explain. But she sat

in unyielding composure, her gaze sharp, her posture regal and unmoved, as though nothing had changed.

Finally, their questions broke the silence. All of the voices rose, each inquiry a probing plea, but they received only her cold, dismissive words. “I tell you,” she replied, her voice cutting through their murmurs like steel, “all that matters is you not commit the sin they have.” With that one ominous sentence, she silenced them all, leaving an atmosphere heavy with unspoken threats.

The ministers fell silent, but their minds spun feverishly. Her words echoed in their heads, the unyielding certainty of her authority forcing them to reconsider any whispered doubts they harboured about her rule. For as they gazed upon her—this woman who held them all in quiet, calculated contempt—they felt a chilling sense of dread. They each pondered, in guarded silence, why they feared such an abhorrent creature. Yes, her power was formidable, but it lay not in blood or birthright. Her strength came from the armies that marched at her command, the zealots who held no morality above her will, and the lords who bent their knees in trembling loyalty. And yet, it was not her lineage nor her own deeds that upheld this brittle structure of governance—it was the silent complicity of men, who, sacrificing themselves upon altars of loyalty and fear, upheld her reign. In that silence, each minister wrestled with a growing fear: the realisation that this power she wielded could turn on them at a whim, as it had on the others. And yet, none dared challenge her, for they too felt the weight of the invisible shackles binding them to their Queen.

Chapter S

Road Less Travelled

The journey taken by both Ariendria and Ulfar took less time than the one up the mountain. While the two navigated through the blackened caverns, they stumbled over the ancient bodies of men long forgotten, and the elvish woman saw the remains of the folk legend that was the very Black Beast, shadow of the cave that roamed those hallowed cavern halls. During the time they took to return to the base of the mountain, few if any words were shared between the two. Both of them knew what now encircled the neck of the young mortal man. Though neither knew the true meaning of why the Amulet of the Kings had shown itself millennia later. All that remained within the head of Ariendria was what had happened to the small creature they had seen; she had her fears, and yet she did not doubt their truth; she hoped they were quite wrong, though.

The two finally reach the base of the mountain range, revealing the two mounts waiting for them. There stood Blackmere, the gunmetal grey and charcoal black beast, as a unique horse stood next to him. The horse contrasted the colours and figure of Ulfar's steed, bearing a more elegant and noble pose in stark contrast to the brute, muscular beast that Blackmere is. This other horse is much more slim and fit for tight turning and manoeuvring through the wooden elvish lands.

The man's voice, strained and brittle from the physical trials he had endured, carried a raw coarseness that grated against the soft, attuned ears of the elven woman before him. Each word emerged jagged, as if forced through a throat hardened by countless struggles. "Your horse," he managed, his tone rough and unyielding, "is decent, for one of an elf." His voice tailed off in a tone that was seemingly meant to be sarcastic, yet he was not accustomed to this form of teasing, which was obvious to Ariendria.

She let out a soft snicker, amusement flickering across her face like the dance of moonlight over water, her eyes gleaming with a hint of intrigue at the unexpected compliment. A playful lilt coloured her voice as she replied, "Is it not a curious kindness, to hear such words from one whose disdain for my kin is oft as clear as the morning light?" Her brow arched ever so slightly, her expression a mixture of curiosity and bemusement, as Ariendria cast a long, appraising look at Ulfar, as though searching his face for the source of this uncharacteristic civility.

Ulfar swung himself up onto his horse, his movements smooth but laden with a restrained energy, the leather of his saddle creaking under his weight. He turned, casting a steady gaze back towards Ariendria, his eyes narrow yet earnest as he spoke. "It's not distaste I hold, but a wariness. So many of your kin are little more than whispers and tales spun by firesides, more myth than flesh. There are few who even believe that the Elves have long since left the lands of living mortals." His voice, rough and edged, carried a tone that was neither harsh nor warm, an unembellished honesty. "The journey to my village will take nearly a week's time." He continued, pausing to glance down the winding path ahead, his gaze sharpening with expectation. "Though I'd wager it won't be a simple ride—there'll be hazards enough and likely a few surprises along the way."

With that, he clicked his heels against the horse's flanks, urging it into a slow but determined gallop, his back turned as he waited—perhaps impatiently, perhaps merely testing her

readiness. Dust kicked up in his wake, leaving Ariendria to prepare herself for the road ahead.

She caught up to the man with ease; her mount, which was raised by the elves and bred for their kin, had the most subtle advantages over that of even the steeds the Valkorian Horse Lords of the First Era raised for their cavalry.

She glanced at her companion and said, “Your people truly believe that?” It was a simple question, yet one which rang in the depths of her mind.

He turned over his right shoulder and said to her, “Until you, it has not been since the lifetime of my great-grandfather that elves have been seen by men who drew Valkorian blood.” He paused as he gazed upon the vast landscape for a few brief seconds and then continued, “and it was not that of your kin but the Veileiar, and yet there was no more than one hundred employed by them. The elongated ears of those Blood Elves are something that brings fear to most men.”

His tone was one of resentment towards the elvenkin who were pivotal in placing the very people he so hated atop all Valkorians.

He did not stop, he continued by saying, “It was said many prayed for the great elves of the First Era, the name of Vaxium was said to ring in the minds of men. Yet as those elves decimated, killing men, women and children alike, none came. It was the same which happened during the Desolation of Valkoria: none came to help humanity who had done all they could as a young race for the Dremoré and Thaloré during the War of Vengeance”

“What do you mean all that man had done for the elves?” It was not a question of mere conversation; she had truly desired to know what he had meant. Her mind warped around the events that man had played such a pivotal role in, to expect the help of the greatest of elven clans and kingdoms.

He ushered in a deep, centred breath as he spoke unto her once more, “It was Hurgon, he had ventured south to the

lands of Pharolax and led an army that decimated the goblins Valkar had hoarded, for this is how the King of Man was cursed. Then came Hónir, who fought against the first Dark Lord just as his father, though it was his sister Idril who struck down the blow to Valkar's goblin king, bringing a swift end to his army for over a hundred years. We can talk more as we camp for the night.” Though both had endless questions, they placed them on hold, at least for the next few hours of their ride.

Sensing the silent press of Ulfar's impatience, Ariendria moved with swift elegance, mounting her horse and falling in line behind him. The first day of travel passed in a muted stretch of sunlit hours, with words as scarce as the autumn leaves still clinging to the branches above them. Shadows grew long as they wound their way through dense woodlands and open stretches of grassland, their silence filled only by the steady rhythm of hooves on earth and the occasional, distant call of a bird breaking the quiet.

When at last they stopped to make camp, the firelight softened the rough edges of the wilderness around them. They sat across from each other, eyes meeting for the first time with a kind of unspoken readiness to break the day's silence. The flames cast warm shadows on Ariendria's face as she leaned forward, a curious gleam in her eyes. Her gaze fell upon the amulet that hung from Ulfar's neck, its worn surface catching the firelight, hinting at countless stories held within its dulled metal. “That amulet,” she began, her voice gentle yet probing, “do you know its history?”

“It is the Amulet of the Kings.” His voice was a low rumble that held both reverence and finality. The gem, once a fierce blood-red stone clutched in the cold, shrivelled hands of Greyon, had long since shed its shadowed hue. Now, it gleamed a vivid, earthy green, as if touched by the first breath of spring itself. This new colour spoke of promise—of brighter horizons and endless green fields where light would reign. Yet, as the firelight flickered across its polished surface, there remained, just

barely visible, a darker edge in the depths of the stone, a faint remnant of its blood-drenched past. That small shadow seemed to whisper a silent warning, a reminder that even in the promise of light, darkness can linger.

She fixed her gaze upon him, a hint of amusement dancing in her eyes as she chuckled softly at his stony response, sensing his deep-rooted unwillingness to grant her the respect she believed was her due. “Yes,” she replied, her tone light but cutting, “that is its name, its title. But I ask you, Ulfar—do you truly know it?” Her words carried a weight, a veiled challenge that lingered in the space between them, as if daring him to see beyond the relic's name, beyond its mere surface, to the layered history woven deep within the gem's core.

Ulfar's gaze dropped to the amulet in his hand, his fingers closing around it as if seeking strength in its touch. He hesitated, the words heavy on his tongue, before finally giving in. “Fine,” he muttered, almost grudgingly. “All I know is the legends of old.” He lifted the amulet slightly, the soft firelight glinting off its polished surface. “This amulet was passed down through generations of Valkorian kings, each one claiming its power as a symbol of peace and unity for my people. It was said that only in the hands of the true king, the blood of Valin, this green emerald would glimmer once more.”

His voice softened, a trace of reverence breaking through his usual guarded tone. “It's been lost for hundreds of years, perhaps even a millennium.” He continued, his thumb running over the intricate metalwork framing the gem. “And now, somehow, it's here again. The finest work of King Hónir, son of Hurgon and brother to the legendary Idril. Yes, I do know. ”

The flicker of flames played across the amulet's surface, casting fleeting shadows, as if hinting at a story that only time itself knew, waiting for the right moment to reveal it.

She pauses for a brief second, acknowledging that what Ulfar said was only a small part of the truth. She takes a deep breath in, “Yes it is that but the history of the amulet,” she places

her hand underneath Ulfars touching the amulet, “that very amulet you burden across your breast has seen many different holders and that gem has travelled from the flames of the fires of the Crevice of Latarvia all the way to the snows of Mount Maierr. Yet you are right, only the blood of Hónir can show the green spark of purity once again.”

Ulfar's gaze sharpened, an edge of curiosity breaking through his usual guarded demeanour as he extended the amulet toward her. “Tell me of it then.” His voice was laced with intrigue.

The amulet dangled between them, swaying slightly as if caught in the tension of the moment. Its emerald core shimmered under the firelight, casting a faint, green hue across their faces. His hand remained steady, fingers loosely curled around the intricate silver chain, as he held it out to her—a small gesture, yet one heavy with unspoken trust. For the first time, his gaze softened, shifting from the cold formality of a warrior to something closer to wonder, as he waited, hoping she held secrets that might finally illuminate the mysteries of his inheritance.

Ariendria takes a deep breath in, “The history of this amulet predates me by many years. The origin of this amulet dates back to a name you have mentioned just earlier, the Dark Lord of the First Era, Valkar. In the second millennium of the First Era, the Dark Lord Valkar descended upon the world and came to wage the War of Vengeance, yet he gave many gifts, and through this, the Line of Valin, specifically Hurgon, came to find the gem of that amulet, though it cursed the man to die a pitiful death. From my knowledge, it was given to Hurgon not by the hands of Valkar but by his then apprentice or lieutenant, whose name still rings in the minds of mortals and immortals alike, Malachar, the Dark Lord of the Second Era. My father has taught me that this amulet was the very thing that led to the Desolation of your Valkorian Empire. General Taklu, lacking the blood of your kin, was corrupted by it, and so were all who followed.

According to the tomes in the library of my father, that amulet in the hands of he who bleeds the blood of Hónir can be purified and feel what vengeance or anger held within fade over time, though that is nothing more than a folk tale in my opinion.”

She pauses, realising that the night is late. “We both should retire for the night.”

Ulfar nodded in agreement, his tone resolute. “We’ll rest until just before dawn; then we move. The journey is long, and we’ve already lost too much time.” He set about preparing his bed for the night, laying out his cloak upon the cold earth and positioning his pack as a makeshift pillow. Each movement was methodical, as if he were not merely preparing to sleep but performing a ritual born of countless nights spent under an open sky. Once satisfied with his arrangement, he glanced up at Ariendria, the flickering firelight casting shadows across his weathered face. The weariness of many battles lingered in his expression, yet his eyes remained sharp and determined.

When dawn broke, they stirred and wordlessly gathered their belongings, leaving the remnants of last night’s fire and conversation behind them. For the next few days, their journey passed in silence, each focused on the path ahead as they navigated winding trails and forested hills. It was only as they rode through a narrow pass on an overcast morning, where deep grooves scarred the dirt and tracks crisscrossed heavily underfoot, that Ariendria broke the silence. Her sharp gaze traced the wheel ruts and hoof marks that littered the ground, unmistakable evidence of a recent passage. “There was an army that moved through here,” she murmured, her tone both knowing and wary, as if tasting the weight of unseen forces in the air.

“How do you know? It could have just been a handful of horses or a passing caravan,” Ulfar remarked, his voice laced with scepticism as he studied her intently. His gaze lingered on her, probing, as if trying to unearth the reason behind her certainty. Doubt shadowed his expression, creasing his brow, and his eyes narrowed slightly, their usual steel-grey darkened by

suspicion. There was a challenge in his voice, though his question was wrapped in a cloak of genuine curiosity, veiling his reluctance to accept her intuition without proof.

She chuckled softly, the sound carrying a hint of mischief as it drifted through the crisp morning air. “Ah, you forget so quickly, don't you?” she teased, a playful glint dancing in her eyes. “Us elves, we're more attuned than you simple humans could ever hope to be.” Her laughter lingered, light and airy, underscoring her words with a gentle taunt as her gaze swept over him, a mixture of amusement and pride written on her face.

Ulfar paused, his brow furrowing as he processed her words, until a sudden understanding dawned on him. He leaned forward, his eyes narrowing with curiosity. “So... it's true then?” he asked, a note of genuine intrigue slipping into his voice. “Your elven eyes, they actually see more?” There was a glint of reluctant admiration in his gaze as he studied her, caught between disbelief and a growing respect for the mysterious depth of her abilities.

Ariendria dropped lightly to the ground, her movements fluid and graceful as she scanned the earth with sharp, practised eyes. Her fingers brushed the dirt, pausing as something caught her attention, and she leaned closer. “Here!” she exclaimed, a faint gleam of triumph in her voice. Holding up a small piece of metal, she examined it briefly before turning it over in her fingers. “It's a pin,” she said, her eyes narrowing as she studied the faded etching. “Look, I'm not familiar with this symbol.” She held it out to him, her brow knit with curiosity, as if daring him to solve the mystery she'd uncovered.

He offered a brief, almost curt reply, though it had come to her knowledge that this was his normal tone, “As you wish,” his voice steady but softened by a hint of respect that hadn't been there before. Though his face remained reserved, there was an unmistakable flicker of admiration in his gaze as he looked at the elven woman. In his curt expression, something shifted—a subtle

acknowledgement of her skill and insight, veiled by his pride yet glinting like a spark in his otherwise stoic demeanour. Even now, she saw a change in the man she had first met; he seemed to be grateful in a sense, which threw her into a whirlwind of confusion.

The pair pressed onward, urging their horses nearly to the point of exhaustion as they followed the path, their eyes trained on the well-worn trail of hoofprints and wheel tracks that snaked steadily in the direction of Ulfar's homeland. Each mile was a test of both the riders and their steeds, with neither slowing nor pausing for even a brief reprieve over the span of two gruelling days; they only rested for a few hours and left just enough time to eat and nourish themselves before returning to their catch-up chase. Only as the dawn of the third day began to bleed faint light over the horizon did a subtle change in the path catch their attention—a slight shift in the spacing of the tracks, a heavier impression in the earth, as if some new weight or presence had joined the journey ahead.

Ariendria reined her horse to a halt upon the rocky cliff's edge, her sharp elven eyes narrowing as they traced the winding river below. Her voice, low but resonant with a quiet urgency, broke the silence. "We're close now, no more than a few hours behind," she called back, gesturing down the steep path to the glistening waterway that snaked through the valley. "Their numbers are substantial—at least a few hundred soldiers, by the look of it. They're following the river's path." The weight of her words lingered between them, the distant shimmer of armour faintly visible along the banks far below.

"They're taking the long way," Ulfar said, his tone brisk, his gaze already scanning the rough terrain ahead. "But there's a pass through these cliffs. It's tight, but it'll cut hours off our ride—enough to close the distance." Without another word, he spurred his horse forward, the animal's hooves digging into the rocky path as they surged ahead. Ariendria nudged her own steed into motion, swiftly falling in behind him, her keen elven eyes

taking in the steep ridges and sharp twists of the terrain. She could feel the urgency in his pace, the determined rhythm of their ride matching the unspoken understanding between them. Each turn drew them closer to the distant shimmer of armour along the riverbank, the stakes growing with every mile.

The two ride down a much more covered and cluttered path filled with various obstacles and trees that the two weave in and out of, riding with haste. With only a few hours' journey, the path opens up to vast rolling green hills and plains scattered with various shades of green shrubbery. Ulfar turned to the elf beside him and said, "We now should be a full half day ahead of them; we need to get to my village and warn the people of what is coming."

Ariendria gave a firm nod, her gaze stretching far ahead, scanning every shadow and subtle movement as she held pace with Ulfar. Their horses pounded the rough ground in a relentless rhythm, the sun steadily climbing until it blazed overhead at high noon. At last, a sight appeared on the horizon—a small wooden wall encircling a village, its ramshackle huts peeking out like jagged teeth above the rough-hewn fortifications. As they neared, they saw the village gates were open, allowing them to pass without hindrance. Dust rose from their galloping hooves as they swept inside, the villagers casting wary glances from beneath hoods and hats. Both riders dismounted in one swift motion, the silence settling around them as they adjusted to the stillness after their feverish pace. Here, within these simple walls, the quiet held a weight of expectation, each step drawing them deeper into the heart of the village.

"Ulfar!" His mother's voice rang out with relief, breaking the quiet, and before he could fully take in his surroundings, she was there—throwing her arms around him. The embrace was fierce, filled with the weight of weeks of worry and hope, as if by holding him close, she could make up for every day he'd been away. Her grip softened for a moment, and she pulled back, her hands still clutching his shoulders, her eyes

searching his face as if to confirm he was truly home, safe and sound. “You’re home, my son,” she murmured, her voice both trembling and steady with joy.

Ulfar returned her embrace, but only briefly. Duty pressed upon him like a heavy mantle, and he gently eased her arms from around him, giving her a look that held both warmth and urgency. “Apologies, Mother,” he said, his voice steady but softened by affection. “I must meet with the men—time is of the essence.” She nodded, understanding his resolve, though a trace of concern lingered in her eyes. With a reassuring squeeze of her hand, he turned, already scanning the village square for his lieutenants, his stride quickening as the weight of his purpose settled over him.

His mother watched him go, the grave resolve etched into his gaze both prideful and unnerving. As he moved toward the training grounds, a glint of gold caught her eye—the amulet hanging around his neck, its once-darkened gem now gleaming in a radiant shade. Ariendria hurried in after him, pausing briefly beside his mother to offer a polite greeting before darting forward to catch up with Ulfar.

“Gunmar! Vivel!” Ulfar’s voice rang out, firm and commanding as he called to his lieutenants, urgency heavy in every syllable. “We need to move, now!” From the nearby barracks, the two men appeared in a flurry of armour and weapons, faces set in grim acknowledgement. There was no need for questions—they knew the summons meant a fight was upon them, and that their commander’s resolve would lead them forward.

In unison, Gunmar and Vivel echoed, voices taut with anticipation, “Why now? What did you come by in the mountains?” They both stood as if the language spoken by their friend was something new and unknown to them.

Ulfar’s gaze was steely, his eyes set with the weight of both warning and readiness. “The Imperium has sent men; they are quite a ride ahead of us. We took the pass, but they’re closer

than we hoped,” he replied, gesturing toward the trails they had so desperately followed. “They march along the river, only hours behind, and their numbers are far greater than anticipated.” The men exchanged a look, jaws set in grim determination as the reality of the looming battle sank in. The quiet urgency in Ulfar’s tone was met with a flicker of resolve in their own eyes, the kind found only in warriors who had faced countless trials together.

Ulfar locked gaze with both of them, “Ariendria and I caught up to them on our way back. Though it is a standard legion, we either hide the men or we must fight.” Ulfar walks with his two commanders, who begin to rile up the men and soldiers preparing for his decision, while they walk into a planning room.

Their brows furrowed as confusion swept across the men at the mere sight of the elf; to them, the Elves were nothing more than just fairy tales and legends spun of times long gone. Now, very few lived in the world of man who saw the physical being of the elves. It was her form, though, an unexpected presence amidst their ranks, one which blasted the men into a frightful confusion. Questions spun in their minds, could she be an elf of the First Era? Yet they knew her presence was not that of those insurmountable legends, though a power lingered within her, one which was felt by all. Though none dared voice the questions that lingered—who she was, or how she had come to stand here, shoulder to shoulder with them, in the heart of their village. Instead, they clung to the urgency of the moment, their eyes shifting back to Ulfar, looking to him for direction.

Gunmar, resolute and unshaken, gripped the hafts of his axes, the polished blades glinting as he raised them high. “We have the men, Ulfar.” His voice was like iron. “We are the Stormfangs, the true sons of Valkoria. We know the tales of old, and I believe we can weather storms far worse than this.” A murmur of assent rippled through the gathered warriors, their loyalty and fierceness etched in the hardened lines of their faces, each one a mark of their dedication. Though confusion and

curiosity simmered beneath the surface, they were warriors first, brothers united beneath the Stormfang banner, and the unspoken trust in Ulfar held them steady in this moment, as it always had.

Vivel points his blade to the map, pointing at their small village, “You know as well that if we do strike back, it will mark the time our crusade begins.” He pauses and looks at the intricate hilt of Ulfar’s sword then he glances and sees the amulet, “You have our support, you are our leader, our lord and I know Valkorians have no king, yet you can be the next, and I speak for all when I do say, each one of us is willing to bathe in our own blood to place you on a new throne. We need not hide out in the distance any longer, it is the time for...”

Ariendria’s voice sliced through the heavy silence, each word a spark catching flame in the eyes of those around her. “Thus will begin the Stormfang Uprising.” Her tone was jagged and sharp and unyielding.

With a swift, precise movement, she withdrew a dagger from her side and drove it into the table with a resounding *thunk*. The hilt bore a distinctive design, the ancient symbol of old Valkoria—a fierce wolf entwined with the roots of a mighty tree, its teeth bared, a reminder of the strength and resilience of their ancestors. The sight of it struck the men deeply, their gazes fixed on the blade that now claimed the centre of the table like a call to arms. Ulfar, Gunmar, and Vivel regarded her, eyes flashing with a mixture of respect and renewed determination, each one feeling the weight of what lay ahead. This wasn’t merely a fight—it was a reckoning, a battle that would be etched into the very bones of their land, sung by their descendants for generations. The Stormfangs would rise, as fierce and untamable as the symbol that bound them to their heritage.

“Then let us arm the men, fortify the walls, and light the beacons! Signal the other villages to ride here with haste; this will be the Battle of the Talion Fields. Defend our faith, our freedom and recon for the new red dawn! We will not falter,” Ulfar commanded, his voice cutting through the brisk morning

air as he strode with resolve into the training yard. “The soldiers of the Imperium have come to seize our lands, to strip us of our freedom. But no, we will show them our strength!” His words rang with conviction, each one carrying the weight of their shared hope and defiance. “For months, we have bided our time, planning our rebellion—now the hour is upon us, my brothers and sisters. It is time for us to begin our crusade, to reclaim what was lost so many years ago!”

With a sweeping gesture, Ulfar signalled to a few soldiers at the edge of the yard, who quickly nodded and sprinted off to gather the rest of his army by the gate. The hum of readiness filled the camp as the soldiers assembled, armour clinking, eyes alight with the fire of purpose.

A soldier hurried to a barn-like building, shouting, “Ulfar wants us at the gate, ready to fight!” His voice echoed through the beams, and soon the clamour of boots on dirt and the hurried shouts of comrades spread through the camp as messengers ran to every corner, calling out to all who had trained. Within an hour, nearly four thousand men and women had gathered, armoured and armed, their breaths steadying as they looked to the gate. Standing atop a crate, Ulfar gazed out over the assembly, his figure framed against the towering gates, the strength of his stance mirroring the resolute spirits of those gathered. Each face looked to him, eager yet determined, ready for the call to reclaim their home.

Now he stands before the brave men and women who have sworn their blades to this cause, gazing out upon them, Ulfar prepares himself for what would be one of many battle-hardening speeches he would give. It was but the first pillar of a crashing building, the first of many charges he himself would lead in the field of battle. The skirmish to come was not one his will could ease or soothe—not enough to still the storm within. So, instead, he gave them what he could: the courage that remained, quietly burning in his heart. Ulfar stood atop the

village gate, gazing down upon the brave souls who dared to seek an end to the Queen's tyranny. He begins his war speech:

My fellow sons and daughters of Valkoria, we stand here today on the brink of a new era, an era of freedom from tyranny. For too long, our land and our fellow brothers have suffered under this yoke of oppression, shackled by the chains of the Imperium which has forgotten our strength, our honour, our sovereignty, and our blood! But no longer, no longer shall we bow our heads to the whip and bend our knees to those who not even know what it means to carry the blood of the Old Empire, we will no longer yield to those who forsake our great gods such as Talor, Vekar, Halfar and Drenamir and throw away our traditions!

Look around us now, my friends. Look at the faces of the undaunted brave who dare to defy the tyranny of the Imperium, who have chosen to bear arms with our noble cause, and not just in our village but in all that lies here in the east. We are not just soldiers; we are brothers and sisters, united by a common goal, a shared vision of a free land for our people, where every man, woman, and child will live without fear of oppression!

We must make no mistake, my comrades, the road will be long and hard, many will die. The Imperium will not yield without a fight. Their soldiers will come, their armies will march, and their war machine will rage. All of this they will throw at us, armed with steel and false hope, in

an attempt to crush our rebellion before it ever begins. On us now marches one of those legions.

Yet! We shall not falter, nor shall we waiver! We fight not just for our own selves, but for those who cannot bear arms, the generations who have not yet been bom, and for our ancestors who suffered through this tyranny, and for the very soul of Valkoria itself! Our cause is just, hearts pure, and our will is one that is unbreakable!

So I say to you, my fellow Stormfangs, my allies, my comrades, let us march forward into this battle with our heads high and steel higher! Let us show the Imperium and the world the strength and will of the true sons and daughters of Valkoria and the spirit that flows through our veins!

Now, today, we write the first chapter of a new saga, a saga of freedom, of honour, of glory, of Valkoria! Let the winds and breaths of Vaeimea guide our blades, the ghosts of our ancestors watch over us, let the valkyries watch as they take our honoured dead to the kingdom above and as we march towards victory!

For Valkoria! For freedom! For our blood!

As Ulfar's final words echoed and settled among the soldiers, a powerful horn cut through the air—a deep, resonant call that struck every heart with the pulse of imminent battle. It signalled the arrival of the Imperium and its soldiers. The wooden gates groaned and then creaked open, revealing a scene that sent a shiver through the gathered troops: the Imperium's legion, a

disciplined line of soldiers numbering hundreds strong, their gleaming armour catching the light, a forest of spears raised as one. Ulfar's eyes met the advancing force, and with a single, silent nod to his commanders, the battle began.

With a fierce battle cry that echoed across the field, Ulfar surged forward, Arienth raised high in his left hand, its blade gleaming with a tempered brilliance that seemed to pierce the dawn mist. Behind him, thousands of Valkorian men and women roared in unison, their voices rising like a storm as they charged together, their footfalls thundering against the earth. The legionnaires, unprepared for such a surge of defiance, faltered in their ranks, their initial confidence replaced with disbelief and sudden fear.

Their commander, Mitel, scrambled to steady them, bellowing orders in an attempt to rally his forces, but his voice was nearly lost under the rush of arrows loosed from Ulfar's archers. The arrows scattered through the legion's front lines, feeling some and disrupting their formation.

The gap between the two forces closed, the clash promised to be brutal, and Ulfar's gaze remained fixed on Mitel—a single point in the whirlwind of battle to come. “We are the soldiers of the Holy Kingdom, we are the legionnaires of the Imperium, find yourselves men, we mustn't let these farmers stir us, rally and we will charge them and face them!” Mitel calls the men to action, though a sure rain had fallen in the few hours it took them to arrive at the fields, he realises the field is far too muddy and rough for any mounted charge. This prompts him to dismount, calling the cavalry to do so along with him, “Calvary, dismount, the horses are of little use here.”

Ulfar and his warriors crashed into the legion's ranks in a focused wedge, driving through the lines with relentless force. The impact split the Imperium's forces, scattering their ranks and forcing them into two disjoint groups. Ulfar moved at the forefront, cutting down one enemy after another, the blade of Arienth drenched in dark red. His father's blade, which sat much

shorter, lay sheathed upon his back, the legendary longsword's gleam now buried beneath a maroon sheath of blood. His eyes, fierce and unwavering, scanned the chaotic mass of soldiers as he carved a path, each swing clearing his way toward his target—their commander, Mitel.

The legionnaires, stunned by the ferocity of the rebels' charge, struggled to reform under Mitel's frantic orders. Yet Ulfar pressed on, his movements swift and lethal, embodying the wrath of a people who had waited long to reclaim what was theirs. The battlefield became a blur of clashing steel and cries of war, as Ulfar's every step brought him closer to his foe, determined to strike down the heart of the invading force.

Gunmar's voice thundered over the clash of battle, his tone as rough and unyielding as the blade he wielded. "Continue forward! Break their lines!" His voice spurred his men onward as his mighty battle axe cleaved through the legionnaires, each swing felling multiple foes in a single stroke.

The weapon's handle, slick with the crimson lifeblood of fallen soldiers, stained his hands, marking him a true son of Valkoria. Gunmar fought like a force of nature, unrestrained and brutal, his relentless strikes carving a brutal path forward, inspiring his warriors to press on through the legion's wavering lines.

The battle progresses as Stormfang and Legionnaire die, clashing steel with one another. The sparks of the steel mixing with the blood coating the blades began to leave a coppery haze in the air. Various archers ignited fire arrows and sent them into the far out legionnaires who still sat in their centuries distant from the clashing steel of their comrades, leading to the smell of the air changing from a crisp, clean spring day to a haunting aroma thickening as the crimson miasma spreads, covering the battlefield.

Ulfar carved his way through the battlefield, each swing of his sword cleaving down another Imperium soldier, his path marked by a grim line of fallen foes. When he finally reached the

head of the legion, his gaze locked onto Commander Mitel, a man distinguished by the ornate armour that set him apart from the ranks.

Without breaking stride, Ulfar dispatched a nearby legionnaire with a swift, brutal stroke, sending his head rolling to the ground. He levelled his blade towards Mitel, his voice carrying an edge as sharp as his weapon. “Your armour—it marks you differently,” he intoned, the weight of his gaze intense. “I take it you’re the one leading this legion?”

Mitel faltered, his voice trembling as he spoke, the shock of Ulfar’s unexpected arrival evident in his stammered reply. “Y-y-yes... yes, I am Commander Mitel of the Neimar Imperium.” His eyes darted between the bloodstained blade and Ulfar’s unyielding gaze. “Have... have you come to surrender?” The question hung in the air, a weak attempt at reclaiming some authority, though his voice betrayed his unease.

Ulfar chuckles, the armour he bore rattling as he gives a deep and full laugh to the world, “No, I have come to take your head as a trophy for my wall. You will be the first example of what happens when you seek a fight with me and my people.”

He slowly advances towards the commander. His blade drawn at his side, the handle of the elegant blade did not hold anything; rather, it reflected the shine of the light before them, the glimmer of the midday sun. He spoke in an unusual manner for the man; it was like the thrills and death of battle had spun the young man’s mind to a point where it was temporarily crazed. It was indeed the first full battle he had ever fought against his fellow man, yet it was like he had been there before, with the obvious psychological exceptions; this crazed behaviour was common for men of this time when they clashed their steel for the first time.

With each passing moment, the commander of the legion, Mitel, sends countless men to slay Ulfar, sword drawn, and the boy cuts them down. The words of the commander of the Imperium rang with fury, “You.” He pointed to a soldier, “Kill

him!” He repeats this a few times, as each time Ulfar wastes nearly no effort in taking the men's lives.

As the number of soldiers dwindle, with those who did not come to know the blade of Arenith running out to face the countless soldiers of the newfound rebellion rather than charging at the seemingly invincible man, until there was one soldier, a man named Dolin, who drew the blood of Ulfar. He dealt a light blow which marked the face of the man, letting a crimson waterfall slowly flow down his face. Yet he found not the blade of Arenith but Ulfar drew his other sword from his back, pushing the steel through the centre of the man's body, then dropping him lifeless.

In arrogance, Ulfar spoke, “What now? Your pawns are gone. I would say surrender, but even if you did, you would never make it off this field alive.”

“If that be your way, then have it.” Commander Mitel draws his sword, citing a prayer of the three, “O True Three, Judia, and Mortha, Ere this battle, I beseech your guidance and strength. Heliao, keeper of chaos, may thy fury empower me, as I confront this great evil that threatens to consume.” With the finish of his prayer, Mitel takes a deep breath before seeing Ulfar charge him.

Ulfar charges, preparing for the inevitable clash of steel, followed by the sparks that come. When he reaches Mitel, his muscles tense as the blade cuts through the air, slicing the thick crimson haze. The sun still shining through a break in the black clouds ignites the blade, giving it a gleaming trail as the blade comes down towards Mitel. With each passing moment, the two dance an endless dance of sparks and sweat. Ulfar spins off of Mitel's slash, giving distance between the two for the first time since the duel began.

“Your prayer was in vain.” Ulfar breathed heavily as his grip upon Arenith firmed, the mythic steel glistened as if it seemed to glow in the daylight, and he tensed his muscles, preparing for a second charge. In an instant, Ulfar pushes from

the ground, the sound of steel clashing hard with the sound of tearing leather and flesh. A yell is heard coming from the commander, and he falls to a knee, dropping the remaining hilt of his shattered blade.

Sitting on the ground bleeding, Mitel grasps his right side in an attempt to stop the inevitable, his voice cracked and was wispy as if the breeze blew what life was in him to the world. “W-w-wh-hat i-i-is y-your pla-a-n?” He coughs up blood as he forces the burning question to Ulfar.

Ulfar lowered himself to the level of the man; his eyes seemed to have little pity within. The gaze of the man seemed to teem with things he had not the time to say to this foe he faced, “I will come to rule this land, these people that have been thrown away by those who have claimed dominion since the time of Talor.” Ulfar paces towards Mitel, crouching as he gets closer.

The blood cascades from the gaping wound, pooling at Mitel's feet as his trembling hand struggles futilely to staunch the flow. His strength wanes, the arm pressed to his side falling limp, streaked with crimson. His lips quiver as he forces out fragmented words, “A-are y-y-you... t-t-the S-storm B-bringer of the fa-ar lands?” Each syllable is a battle, punctuated by a wrenching, blood-choked cough.

Mitel collapses against a jagged rock, its cold surface offering no comfort as he slumps, his life ebbing away with each laboured breath. The dark stain of his blood creeps outward, soaking the earth beneath him.

He moves to still catch the gaze of the dying man, “You know who I am, Revel Mitel.” Ulfar crouches closer to the man, looking when Mitel has an internal revelation. “I am Ulfar Val. Son of Aelfred and Lalia. You once lived among us, and it was you who first taught me how to command a sword and the men around me when my father vanished while the smith and I visited the coastal village. If you believe the prophecies, then yes, I am the one known as Stormbringer. But beyond that, you and your family once dwelled behind walls just like these.” He points his

right hand towards the village, “But you, you sold out our land, gave up on the dream of freedom, then you helped the very people you had taught me to loathe.”

Ulfar arises, he readies his blade to end the man's suffering, “When I was young, I always looked up to you. Without having a father for most of my life, you were one of the few I had admired most. Irony, you became the very thing you had taught me to destroy.” Ulfar pauses, taking his blade back and sheathing it as a line of crimson runs down the sheath, showing the carnage he had waged. “One either meets the gods, a hero, or lives until they become the shadowed evil they sought to destroy. I will not end your life with mercy; suffer a coward's death. The Valkyries will not take you to the hall of honoured dead this day. For you yielded years ago, the halls of Valingard are a place only for those who died without yielding their honour.”

His voice was faint and cracked, though a new stream of blood came from his mouth as he came to his last moments. “M-may Halfar c-c-urs...” Mitel's voice gurgles over blood as his body goes limp, collapsing to the ground as the remaining life is suffered out of the shell that was his body.

Ulfar chuckles, walking back to the body, grasping the chain around his neck, adorning the Symbol of Legionist, which was worn by the commanders of legions. “In the end, you begin a curse of the gods you had forsaken.” He turns and walks away, holding the chain in his right as the remaining soldiers throw down their weapons in defeat.

After the soldiers drop their weapons in surrender, they are collected into a large group where a podium stands for a person to talk from. “I am General Gunmar of the Stormfangs, my lord. Ulfar, the high commander of the Stormfangs, will give you an option. I will advise you to take that option.” He walks away, leaving the vast number of prisoners waiting in great suspense for the arrival of Ulfar.

Many of them begin to talk amongst one another, with some of them having fear fill their very being for their coming future. One turned to another and said, “Hey, do you think that they shall let us join them? They found a way as mere farmers to beat us.”

A second nameless soldier leaned towards chuckles as he turned and said, “I saw that man holding the fabled Amulet of the Kings; he is Valkorian, whereas none in this Imperium truly are. I would not hesitate for a second to fight for the man who holds the jewel of our people.”

The first turns back in response and, with slight doubt, tells the man, “That is punishable by death to say. I would be careful, and what do you even know of the Amulet?”

“I know more than you.” The second soldier, whose name was Aeron, shakes his head, “I care not if they would kill me. I saw the fight of the last rebellion; this is different. They have cause, they have purpose, and they have a leader who has divine inspiration. The days of the Imperium are numbered.” After that final sentence, the man ends the conversation with the other soldier.

Another turns to one who was whispering curses to those who have captured them. A soldier standing right next to him takes his armour-clad hand and clocks him atop the head and says unto him, “Fool. Why curse those who control the fate of our lives?” The gaze of the one who levied curses looked on the fellow soldier with a gaze that seemed to tell the tale of ages to the man.

The eyes of the soldier seemed to shake; each pupil was dilated with absolute fear—terror, a cold and pure-hearted terror that was shaking the man to his very bones. As the seconds turned to minutes, there came a silence over the prisoners, a dreaded and bleak absence of sound which only cemented the fear which encapsulated many of them.

In near silence, the prisoners sat, hearing the sounds of a slight breeze with various red-winged birds and cardinals singing

songs. Small chatter happens between the men as they stand awaiting Ulfar's arrival. After what seemed to many to be at least an hour of standing in the humid open space as the sun beat down upon them, peaking through the charred clouds, a man walked to the bastion before them. The man clad in steel armour with some furs lining it, with a slight tinge of red freshly rinsed upon the suit, arrives when silence overcomes the lot of them.

Here, he addresses those who stood before him, awaiting the words to come from his mouth with a vast and unmatched anticipation:

Soldiers of the Imperium, today, the winds of change have arrived. Fate now blows in a new direction. The sparks of our steel and the cries of battle have subsided; in their wake lies a scene of triumph and of despair. You here stand not as enemies, but as men, as soldiers with a choice. Sons of a new Valkoria.

For too long, our people, the Valkorian people, have sat in a recurrent continuum of war and death. Our people have been bound by the chains of dishonesty, mistrust, and misunderstanding crafted by the Imperium. Today, we break this perpetual cycle. Right now, as I speak, we stand on the edge of a new age, the age of reclamation, where we sons and daughters of Valkoria shed not our fellows' blood.

You, soldiers of the Imperium, are no prisoners of war. You are the first to witness the tide turn, the swing of the pendulum. With this moment, history will be written again. We may have just

clashed our steel, shed our blood, but now I extend my hand.

My comrades, in my hand, I extend you a choice. You have blindly fought under the banner of the Imperium without knowing the truth. Here you stand at a crossroads: remain slaves of a dying crown or join my cause, fight for the true sons and daughters of our land, join the Stormfangs. In our quest, we seek to return our people to their former glory and have peace amongst our fellow Valkorian. Pledge allegiance to me, and together, we shall forge a future that our ancestors would be proud of.

Here and now, I declare to all: I am Ulfar Val, son of Aelfred, now beholder and keeper of the Amulet of the Kings, and by the ancient laws of our land, I am the rightful king of the Valkorian people. The gem shines with the green that the legends of Hónir told us it would. It is only his blood, the blood of Tírun Valin, who can see this gem back to its emerald hue. This is the divine blood of Valkoria, what we thought lost with Talor, through me it has arisen again. Join us, and you too will come to see the white halls of legend once again!

With that, Ulfar ends his speech with many of the soldiers being inspired, yelling the hymns of old as they swear to “He Who Holds the Amulet.” As time passes, the vast majority of the surviving soldiers funnel into the town and pledge their allegiance, becoming members of the new rebellion. Of the hundreds who survived, only a few dozen refused. Ulfar walked

to meet those who refused after Gunmar informed him of their unwillingness.

“Ulfar, there are just over a hundred who refuse.” Gunmar's face grows in anger at those blind to the truth, a truth he thought to be self-evident. Ulfar was the rightful ruler of the Valkorians; he could not even comprehend another thought.

“This is expected, Gunmar. I will walk to meet them myself.” Ulfar walks with his general to meet the loyalists of the Imperium.

When the two arrive in the pit housing the prisoners, one yells to them, “You are no king! That amulet is a fake; it was lost thousands of years ago!”

“Bring him up here.” The soldiers bring up the heckler just as requested, “Do you want to touch it yourself?” He holds out the amulet for the man to touch. “Feel the power of the kings? Truly know what it means to carry the blood of the kings and be a true son of Valkoria?”

One soldier, with a snide tone filled with the anger of seeing his fellow soldiers commit treason in his eyes, snaps at Ulfar, “Why would I, what if it were a trap, and then kill me?”

Ulfar looks upon the soldier and, in a young mistake one he must learn to overcome, he acts and speaks on impulse and says, “Then live in idiocy.” He turns to Gunmar, “Let them all go free as they wish, but keep three of the highest-ranking soldiers. I have a plan for them.”

Gunmar's voice broke the tense air, his words halting and uncertain as his thoughts wrestled with the weight of Ulfar's decision. “B-b-but Ulfar.” He stammered, his usual grit and resolve faltering, “Why let them go? They just bore arms against us. What loyalty can be trusted in men who raised steel to take our lives?”

His hand gripped the haft of his axe tightly, the crimson stains on its blade a stark reminder of the lives already taken this day. Gunmar's furrowed brow and unsteady voice betrayed his unease, the thought of mercy in the wake of battle clashing with

the raw instincts honed by years of bloodshed and survival. His eyes searched Ulfar's, not with rebellion but with the desperate need to understand the mind of the man he had chosen to follow into the fires of rebellion.

Ulfar lets a deep cackle from down in his throat, "They will be the ones to spread our name, to tell of our cause. These cowards will be a voice that reaches those covered in the shadow." Ulfar paces, looking into the prison arrangements, "We have provided them with better arrangements than they had in their camp, with better food and shelter. They may try to slander, yet all evidence defies them." He walks off with the three men he asked for, leaving Gunmar with the main captives.

The tension in the room thickened like fog as one of the three finally summoned the courage to speak, breaking the charged silence. His voice, though steady, carried the weight of uncertainty and unease. "What meaning is there to taking us three?"

The question hung in the air, daring to challenge the conviction etched on Ulfar's face. The speaker's eyes searched his leader's gaze, looking for clarity, for purpose, for anything to anchor himself amidst the storm of Ulfar's fervour. Around them, the room seemed to hold its breath, the flickering light from the fire casting dancing shadows that mirrored the unspoken doubts lingering in their minds.

Ulfar chuckles as the four pass through an archway, revealing an elegant wooden table with three scrolls set upon it. He signals at the three to stop at the archway. One of the three men notices a few flags on a map, two of which have daggers lying on the table pointing to them. Though the man is not close enough to know which city or fortress they signify or represent. The only detail gleaned was that one dagger seemed to be pointing south.

Ulfar moves to retrieve the near sand coloured parchment rolled to form a scroll and sealed with a burnt orange wax stamp. "You three will deliver these to three very specific

people, Zealot Zek Judd, Grand General Tiber Seidel and then your beloved false Queen Anne Hargath. Each letter is addressed to a specific one of those fools, as you can see, they are marked on the scroll. Each of you must hand deliver these, and when the time comes, you may face honour in your final hour. Now scurry along.” He waves his hands, motioning for them to take their leave.

A few hours passed, then both Gunmar and Vivel entered through the amber wooden archway decorated in runic symbols of good fortune. Gunmar places his weapons upon the wooden table, which is seen to be a map of the world, with each intricate detail carved and engraved in. The blood still wet from Gunmar's axes spilt down, filling the various rivers of the continent with a crimson water.

Gunmar grins, bearing his yellowed teeth, peering like torched fangs from his dark red beard covering the lower half of his face. He stares at the five blue flags marking the five small villages of the valley region, “What is our first move, Ándúhar?” He reaches for an intricate dagger with a snow white ivory handle decorated with a carving of a serpent.

Vivel stays the restless hands of Gunmar, “We wait and build upon the strength we have just amassed. We must think of those who had not pledged and sat in uncertainty; now we have the political, rather than social, momentum. Even some of the soldiers of the Imperium have rallied to our cause.” Vivel takes the dagger and points to a flag just an inch from the flag representing their village. “This watch post has sat as the first obstacle to our advance after the battle. I received a hawk from them. They heard from the men let loose of the battle and now are willing to hear our cause...”

In an instance, Ulfar interposed himself, raising his left hand, silencing the two men, leaving the rest of the conversation to their imagination. In three steps, the silent commander stands across from the two at the table, and he extends his left hand towards Vivel. In one instance, a sense of fear has engulfed the

general as he follows the eyes of his commander to the dagger, thus handing it to him. The two generals lock eyes with Ulfar; his gaze pierces into the depths of their souls. In an instant, the tip of the dagger vanishes from the fingers of Ulfar, then a thunderous sound echoes as his fist slams upon the table, inserting the dagger into a marker on the map.

He walks around the table, better facing the men, “We strike Vingólf to the south-west, with it, the region of Duke Balian falls to us.” The blood of the men curdles with the tone of his voice. The idea of striking at such a prominent place just after declaring their campaign puzzled them. “I will take only the men clad in the black, the archers and cavalry included.”

“B-b-but that is only a few thousand men at best.” Vivel stammers, his voice trembling with shock and disbelief at the gravity of the decision just made. The enormity of the task looms over him like a thunderhead, and his thoughts chum with the sheer impossibility of their odds. He knows Ulfar is not blind to the staggering reality of the forces stationed at Vingólf. “Based on the last reports we had,” Vivel continues, his voice faltering as doubt seeps into his tone, “I-its nearly three times that stationed in their garrisons alone.” His words linger in the air, heavy and hesitant. His gaze fixes on Ulfar, searching the man's unyielding expression for answers, for confirmation. “But I assume you already know that, do you not, Ulfar?”

He shook his head, his eyes scanning the room with a fiery intensity. “You worry too much about numbers. They are just men filled with the arrogance of a fortress built to survive any siege. Their blood is not tainted by Aria; they are just mere mortals doomed to death, just like the rest of us. There is but one legend of the fortress falling, and I cling to that as my guide.”

Vivel lets a chuckle at his dear friend, “Perhaps that illegitimate son Boscogn might just become those giants of the tales. Ha! Ha! Ha!” The three friends share a laugh before Ulfar clears the cheer once more.

His gaze, sharp and piercing moments before, softened into something far more vulnerable— a fleeting moment of melancholy that flickered across his face like a shadow. But just as quickly, it faded, replaced by a calm, almost casual demeanour, as though he were merely discussing plans among friends. “The three of us have trained side by side with these men for over half a decade now. I rest confident in their ability to cut down these men. I also have a plan I have dreamt of using since my father first told me of Vingólf.”

“Don't tell me, you are really gonna use that one from when we were wee little rats?” Gunmar taunted Ulfar with not only his words but also his expression, jabbing him in the arm to beat in what he believed to be a poor idea.

Then, like a storm gathering strength, Ulfar's voice hardened, growing colder and more resolute. His pupils shrank, his veins pulsed and bulged with tension along his neck and forehead, and his right fist clenched just inches from his face. The transformation was stark—his calm gave way to unbridled determination. “I will take Vingólf, Reichfeld, Heillmore, Lunden, Valkoria, and every other hold that bends the knee to that witch.” His words were like thunderclaps, shaking the very air around him.

A calm silence climbs over them before some laughter breaks out. Vivel is first to break it, “You know that she-elf you brought back?”

“Yeah, what about Ariendria?” Though curt, Ulfar did neither snap nor answer lax; it was as if he cared much for any conversation of hers, yet tried to cover it as a young child does with their first crush.

Gunmar first interjects, “She looks like the blood-haired lady from the ancient stained glass in the old chapel that fell.” With his words, Gunmar gestures towards the old direction of the now ruins.

In somewhat of a sombre tone, his eyes glazed over with a dream that seemed to be stretched too thin, like too little wool

over too large a loom. “Káerielle.” His voice soft, “Similar? Yes, but different entirely, perhaps we will once again be graced by her mosaic in Vingólf.” He finishes his words with a soft smile, that of a child with his dearest friends.

The three men leave the small planning room, walking each their separate way, Gunmar west towards the training yard with the younger non-combatant trainees, Vivel to the north by the gate garrison, and Ulfar east towards the countless tents black as the dark side of the moon. A vivid sun begins to set, casting a blaze of orange and pink across the black canvases. The horizon slowly consumes the glowing orb as in the few minutes his walk takes, and the slim moonlight coats the field in a soft silvery glow, bathing the land in an ethereal light.

A few days pass as the lord of the rebellion hastens his men, preparing them for an insurmountable siege. This time, there will be no speech, only the silence of men marching to their assumed deaths. They all stand, placing their right hand over their hearts, pledging themselves to a cause for freedom.

Mounting his horse, the rest follow Ulfar, their young commander commanding the presence of Talor amongst them. He knows as well as anyone that they would give their lives to see him move forward. His army of just a few thousand men clad in the well forged armour of the artisans of smithing from the far out villages began a four-day march south-west towards the fortress of Vingólf.

Chapter 6

A Shadow Stirs

In Valkoria, a rare softness lingered in the air of General Seidel's chamber, a fleeting calm amidst the storm of war. The room bore the marks of a commander deeply entrenched in strategy—tables cluttered with rolled and unrolled parchments, letters marked with seals of urgency, and sprawling maps of the vast and fractured continent of Onu-Arith. Each piece of parchment was a thread in the intricate web of conquest, a fragment of the immense puzzle that demanded his focus. Seidel sat at the heart of it all, his imposing frame leaning over the central table.

His gauntleted hand traced the jagged outlines of mountain ranges and river valleys, his steely eyes scanning the markers denoting cities and armies with the precision of a man accustomed to wielding power. Around him stood a half-circle of commanders, their voices hushed as they conferred, their words shaped by deference to the head of the Imperium's army. The moment of quiet deliberation was shattered as the heavy oak doors of the chamber slammed open with a resounding crash. The room froze. Seidel's gaze snapped upward, his cold eyes narrowed into slits, and the tension in the room thickened, suffocating the fragile calm as the air bristled with unspoken questions.

The atmosphere in the room shifted sharply as the towering figure of Queen Anne strode through the open doorway, her presence cutting through the tension like a blade.

Her emerald cloak swept behind her, the fabric shimmering faintly under the light of the chamber's lanterns. Her eyes, cold and unyielding, fixed on Seidel with an intensity that silenced the murmurs of the commanders still gathered around the table.

“Have you done what I commanded?” She demanded, her voice sharp and unwavering, the kind of tone that brooked no defiance. The ferocity of her words filled the chamber, yet she offered no context to the commanders present, leaving their thoughts to spiral in anxious speculation.

Seidel straightened, his formidable presence undiminished, yet his posture betrayed a subtle tension. His eyes did not falter under her piercing gaze, though the weight of her question hung heavily in the air. Around the table, the commanders exchanged wary glances, their unease palpable as they dared not interject. Whatever matter she spoke of, it was clearly of utmost importance, shrouded in secrecy yet brimming with urgency.

Seidel had a sense of dread that came over him; he sought to avoid such long conversations with the Queen. “Yes, your Grace, I have deployed the one legion to investigate the village to the southeast. They should arrive in half a day and then return in but a week.” Seidel respectfully answers her, dropping the plan he was discussing.

Anne looks at the map and walks towards it, “I, for God's sake, pray and hope this dumbfounded fear of yours is nothing more than a few self-righteous farmers.”

She grabs the small figurine from the large map, studying it deeply, “Though it may be more fun if it is not,” she looks dead at Seidel, “perhaps the folk tales of the elves are true, and maybe their hidden king lies in the backwater lands of this place.” She shrugs her shoulders, placing the figure in one of the other military commanders' hands. “I expect a full report when they arrive back here.”

The Queen walks back through the keep, venturing into the council chamber where the remaining five ministers patiently

wait for her. Shortly after her arrival, General Seidel arrives, bringing one extra military commander with him. While in the conference, the group discusses the various issues and common problems surrounding the working of a kingdom. Shortly after the main talking points were finished, Minister of War, Saul Nomin, placed his coin forward to speak. "Your Grace, but two weeks ago, you were hesitant and often refused to send any sort of force out southeast to look into the growing masses out there. Why now did you give in? What made you decide to see our point?" Saul finishes with a smug grin, and he glances towards Seidel, who moves to answer.

She glares at the General, her eyes were like daggers ready to slay him at the very utterance of a word. "I answer for myself, Seidel," she waves her hand, sitting down the general.

"From our most recent census, the vast majority of the population does not dwell within the walls of our great cities, but rather a vast majority lies out beyond the walls in the mud pastures. Alone, the region in question outnumbered the pure loyalists of here, Lunden, Heillmore, and Deidara nearly ten to one. My father was the only man to have any sway on the throne; my mother may have sat it, but he ran it. My father had taught me many lessons growing up, and now I apply one I had all but forgotten."

She walks to the window, gazing out over the city, "If we let even one of those peasants stand up to us, they all might stand up. As I had mentioned, they outnumber us nearly ten to one; if they ever figure that out, our luxurious, easy, and simple way of life ceases. I had realised it is not about being peaceful and promoting love, it is about keeping the peasants in line." The Queen waves her hand while still gazing out the window, signalling an end to the meeting.

Within two days, the first rider sent by Ulfar had come to find his destination. Fate had decided that General Seidel would be the first to know what had occurred far to the east, as the rider had left a few days before the other two. At this time, he had

made an encampment just outside the walls of Valkoria and begun to build a war strategy to face any more dissenters who came to make their voices known.

In this, he had set up a secondary wall around the front gate of the city, and there it showed its purpose, as in the distance, the gate guards noticed a speckle approaching as fast as rushing water down a river.

One of the guards stationed near the edge of the planning room, standing rigid by a tall, arched window, suddenly called out, breaking the uneasy silence. “Hey, you see that dot there?” His voice carried an air of curiosity mixed with mild alarm as he gestured toward the horizon visible beyond the fortress walls.

The others turned their heads, their gazes following the direction of his pointed finger. Sure enough, a single figure on horseback emerged from the wavering heat of the distance, a dark speck steadily growing larger against the vast expanse of the barren landscape. The rider moved with determination, their approach unwavering as the gap between them and the fortress walls began to close.

The commanders at the table exchanged tense looks, the weight of their strategic discussion momentarily suspended. “Who would dare approach unannounced?” One muttered under his breath. The air grew heavier as the faint sound of hooves striking the earth began to echo, a subtle but foreboding rhythm that reached their ears like the ticking of a clock counting down to an unknown revelation.

“That looks to be a rider. Should we open the gate?” The second guard squinted at the figure in the distance, his tone laced with uncertainty as he glanced sideways at the first.

“Well, I mean, they do seem to be in a bit of a hurry.” The first guard replied with a nonchalant shrug, his spear resting lazily on his shoulder. “Might not hurt to let 'em in.”

The second guard frowned, clearly unconvinced. “Oi! Sir!” He called over his shoulder to a third guard stationed higher

up on the wall. “There's a rider approaching. What do you think we oughta do?”

The third guard, a seasoned sentinel with lines of experience etched into his face, sighed heavily and placed his palm to his forehead in exasperation. “You imbeciles.” He muttered, lowering his hand to glare at them. “You question the rider when they arrive. That's what you were taught to do, correct? Or has your training evaporated from your feeble brains like mist in the sun?”

The second guard straightened, his cheeks flushing red. “My bad, Sir.” His earlier confidence drained away.

A snide look came across the third guard's face as he said to the other, “See to it you don't forget again.” The third guard snapped, his tone sharp but resolute. “Now, focus. This isn't a tavern where you can debate over ale.”

The two guards exchanged an awkward glance, a fleeting moment of shared dismay casting a shadow over their faces. Unspoken, the weight of their slip hung between them, a silent plea for mercy from both the rider and any prying eyes within the watchtower. Their breaths quickened ever so slightly as they turned back to the distant figure, squinting against the sun's glare to make out the fast-approaching rider, whose every thundering hoofbeat seemed to echo louder than their own foolish words.

The slight breeze stirred, tugging at their armour and reminding them of their place—small cogs in the grand mechanism of the Imperium. With uneasy hearts, they resumed their vigil, silently hoping their lapse in judgment would pass unnoticed, free from any harsh reprimand or the dreaded ridicule that might linger long after the dust of the rider's approach had settled.

The rider now crests the ridge, plunging down a steep downslope, urging his steed forward at a reckless speed. The horse galloped at its very limits, each breath a strained, laboured sound, nostrils flaring as if in protest. Rocks scattered beneath

pounding hooves, bushes whipped past, and even a narrow ravine did nothing to slow the relentless descent. The rider gripped the reins tightly, both hands braced against the wild rush, one hand still clinging fiercely to a scroll, its edges flapping in the wind.

Gritting his teeth, he guided the horse through every obstacle with a precise desperation, pushing past exhaustion and peril alike. At last, they reached the garrison gates, the ground finally stilling beneath them as they pulled to a shuddering halt. The rider took a steadying breath, knowing that he'd arrived in time—barely, but in time.

With all the force his lungs could muster, the rider's voice thundered through the still air, "Let me in! I must speak to the Grand General *now!*" His words barreled into the guards before they could even think to question him.

Driven by urgency, he pounded his fists against the massive oak gate, each strike resonating with an unyielding demand. The heavy wood shuddered under his blows, and the guards, taken aback, found themselves silenced by the sheer intensity radiating from the man—an urgency too raw to ignore.

The lead guard stepped forward, his voice edged with suspicion as he sized up the frantic rider. "What business brings you here, Nameless Rider? We were not told to expect anyone." He crossed his arms, his gaze sharp and unyielding. "State your name and your purpose." The silence that followed was heavy, punctuated only by the laboured breathing of the exhausted horse and the distant murmur of the garrison. This was no place for strangers with hurried demands, and the guard's tone made it clear: if the rider wanted entry, he would first surrender answers.

The fourth guard leaned forward, peering intently at the emblem hanging from the rider's neck—a polished talisman etched with the unmistakable mark of Commander Mitel. A flicker of unease passed through him as he spoke, "Sir, look at that talisman... he bears the insignia of Commander Mitel's men.

They marched south more than a week ago; by no means should any of them be this far north.”

The lead guard's brow furrowed, his gaze narrowing. The realisation settled uneasily among them, tension brimming in the air. The rider's urgent arrival, marked by the emblem of an Imperium force that should have been far from here, cast a strange shadow over the gathering.

“I am Har—” The rider begins, but his words are abruptly cut short as the lead guard raises a gloved hand, silencing him.

“Your name alone isn't enough.” The guard replies sternly, his eyes sharp with suspicion. “Explain why you've returned north, and with such haste.” He casts a wary glance at the other guards, each one now on edge, fingers lingering near the hilts of their swords.

The rider clenches his jaw, frustration flashing across his face. He steadies himself, gripping the scroll tightly as he attempts to contain his urgency. “I carry a report.” His voice was a strained whisper, as if the words themselves held weight beyond their meaning. “Reports for the Grand General, from the front. Time slips from us, and it cannot be wasted.”

“Open the gates!” The gatemaster bellows, his voice echoing through the stone corridors as he leans over the battlements. His call carries down to the thralls manning the gate-crank system, who respond instantly, their hands gripping the iron cranks with swift obedience.

With a groan of ancient wood and grinding chains, the massive oak gate shudders and begins its slow ascent. Dust falls from the creaking hinges, the gate parting to reveal the weary rider and his foam-flecked steed. The thralls' muscles strain as they turn the gears, each crank inching the gateway wider, and the rider, without waiting for the gate to open fully, spurs his horse forward, slipping through the narrowing gap.

The sudden opening of the gate catches the messenger off guard, causing him to hesitate before entering. Just as the

guards begin to approach, he digs his heels into the waist of the steed, prompting it to rush forward towards the main keep of the base. Kicking up dirt, dust and rocks, the steed makes the few-minute journey in just one. The man jumps off the horse, dashing towards the door that has two guards protecting it.

Ignoring them, he pushes through, blasting through the doors and making his way down the hall to the open room. “Where is General Seidel? This is very urgent, and I must speak to him immediately!”

The sound of heavy footsteps approaching a man adorned in armour is a testament to both artistry and power. It was Seidel himself. The deep crimson breastplate is adorned with intricate gold engravings that tell tales of ancient battles and victories. His helmet, topped with a striking plume of red feathers, signals his rank and commands respect. The ornate vambraces and greaves, reinforced with gold-accented metal plates, offer both protection and a regal appearance. A long, flowing red cloak, fastened at the shoulders with gold clasps, billows behind him as he moves. As General Seidel strides into the vast open planning room, the rhythmic clank of his armoured boots against the stone floor echoes through the chamber, each step resonating with the weight of authority and command.

The general halts mid-step, his steel-plated boots echoing through the hall as he turns to face the messenger. With a slow, yet quite deliberate motion, he removes his helmet, revealing eyes sharp with suspicion and curiosity.

His gaze settles on the weary rider, noting every trace of dust, every scratch on his armour—a soldier of Mitel who should be leagues away, yet stands here before him. “What news compels you to leave your commander's side, soldier?” Seidel's tone is measured, his voice carrying the weight of authority as he steps forward, closing the distance between them. “It must be urgent indeed, to draw you from Mitel's ranks and set you on this path.”

The messenger steps forward, his movements quick yet cautious, hands tightly clasped around the rolled scroll as if it might vanish were he to release it. His gaze flickers briefly to Seidel's face, then away, as if burdened by the gravity of the message he bears. With each step, the weariness in his eyes and the weight in his posture tell of a journey travelled in haste and secrecy.

"I have a message," he whispers, almost reverently, "for your eyes only, Grand General." His fingers, weathered and trembling, extend the scroll toward Seidel, the red wax gleaming ominously in the torchlight.

The parchment, a pale sandy colour, crinkled slightly in Seidel's fingers as he peeled away the dark amber wax. The seal was peculiar—a simple, jagged "X" pressed into the wax with no other identifying marks, no script to offer a name or title. This small, inscrutable detail unsettled him. His brow furrowed in suspicion as he slowly unrolled the note, his eyes narrowing.

He looked sharply at the messenger, his voice low and demanding, "Who sent you?" His words hung in the air, heavy with the weight of the unknown.

The messenger, already trembling from the urgency of his mission, flinched at the intensity of Seidel's gaze. "H—he is a man named Ulfar Val." He stammered, his eyes dropping to the ground as though the answer he sought might be hiding in the dust beneath their feet. "I was simply told to deliver this... to you."

Before he opened the letter, the last name of Val rang within his mind; it was then that he thought to himself. Could it be that Aelfred had a son? He then cracked the letter and began reading this seemingly important message.

To General Seidel of the Neirmar Imperium,

*I, Ulfar Val, rightful heir to the legacy of the
Valkorian Empire and leader of the Stormfangs,*

write this letter as a formal declaration of war against the Neirmar Imperium. Our struggle is not born of mere rebellion but of righteous defiance against tyranny and sacrilege. You and your queen, Anne, have trampled upon the sacred traditions of our forefathers and outlawed the worship of the Seven. The time has come for justice.

The few thousand men you sent to destroy my village have been vanquished with little effort. Their defeat is but the first sign of the reckoning that awaits the Imperium. Armed with the amulet of the Kings and wielding the sword Arenith, I, Ulfar Val, stand resolute in my quest to restore the Valkorian Empire and remove Queen Anne from her ill-got throne.

We fight in the name of Talor, the Valkorian king who ascended to godhood, and the rest of the Seven: Halfar, Vekar, Drukavin, Drenamir, Viviana, and Vaeimea. You have attempted to erase our faith, but it burns brighter than ever in the hearts of the Valkorian people. We fight for our honour, for the legacy of our forefathers, and for the freedom to worship as we see fit.

The Stormfangs are ready to go to Ysengard and feast forever in the Hall of Valingard. Our courage is unwavering, and our spirits are unbroken. We are prepared to lay down our lives for the cause, knowing that we will be welcomed into the eternal halls of glory.

This is your final warning. Surrender now, and you may yet spare your people the wrath of the Stormfangs. Refuse, and we will bring the full might of our cause upon you. The Valkorian Empire will rise again, and the Neirmar Imperium will fall.

*In the name of the Valkoria,
Ulfar Val, Son of Aelfred Val
Leader of the Stormfangs*

General Seidel's eyes scanned the letter again, his disbelief deepening with each word. They seemed too impossible to digest, and yet they lay on the page before him, stark and damning. His mind rang. The man he knew, Aelfred the Rebel, had a son. His jaw tightened, and he looked up from the parchment, his gaze as cold and piercing as steel.

"Is this true?" His voice was a low, dangerous growl, the kind of tone that made men tremble. His eyes locked onto the messenger, a silent storm raging beneath the surface. The poor soul, now standing under the weight of Seidel's gaze, could feel the immense pressure pushing down on him, his breath growing shallow. "Did this common-born runt... kill my men?"

The words spilt from Seidel's lips like venom, each one heavier than the last. He took a step closer, towering over the messenger, and his eyes narrowed even further, becoming twin shards of ice.

The soldier uttered no words, nothing but a simple motion of nodding. There was a tension one which held the vocal chords of the young soldier so tight they could ring no sounds. It was not a nod of knowledge, yet one which sought to calm the commander, whose anger could seemingly slaughter dozens.

The air in the room seemed to grow colder as Seidel's presence grew more suffocating. "And answer me honestly now," he continued, his voice becoming more gravelly and

intense, “Does this man bear the Amulet of the Kings?” The question hung in the air like a death sentence, each word deliberate, cutting through the tension with the precision of a blade. The messenger recoiled at the mention of the ancient and revered amulet, his mind racing, the implications of Seidel's questions flooding in with terrifying clarity.

Finally, Seidel pauses, giving the messenger the time to discern a response, “I haven't the faintest idea what the letter says, General. But I can assure you he killed countless men, and there were even those who threw their blades, going as far as to even take up his banner.” He pauses for a second as if to wince at the thought of the amulet, “No doubt it was the glowing emerald that lay upon his chest, ensconced in the gold lining of ancient stories, tales and tapestries.”

“Then I must get word to the Queen at once!” Seidel's voice broke through the stillness like thunder, his command resolute and urgent. His hand moved instinctively toward the door, his mind already racing to formulate the next step in this unexpected turn of events. The messenger, however, hesitated, his feet shifting uneasily on the cold stone floor.

“Pardon, General, but Ulfar sent three of us out—one for each...” The messenger's voice trembled, faltering as he struggled to maintain his composure under the weight of Seidel's piercing gaze. He had meant to finish his sentence, to explain further, but the words caught in his throat like stones, lodged and immovable.

He took a half-step back, his body suddenly rigid with fear as Seidel's intensity pressed down on him like a heavy stone. The room seemed to grow colder, the flickering light of the torches casting long shadows against the stone walls, adding to the weight of the moment. The messenger's breath quickened, his mind racing, but his tongue had betrayed him. The revelation he was about to make hung between them, suspended in the tense silence that stretched on, the air thick with the promise of something deeper yet to be revealed. Seidel's gaze never

wavered. His lips barely parted, but there was an unmistakable force behind his silence. The messenger could feel the pressure mounting as if the very air had turned to stone around him. He knew he was standing at the edge of something far larger than his simple words could convey.

“What do you mean by ‘three’? Who is the third party to be notified?” Seidel’s voice was low, steady, and full of the weight of authority.

His eyes narrowed, his gaze hardening into something as sharp and unforgiving as a blade. He turned his shoulders, squaring himself more firmly as he took a step closer to the messenger, closing the gap between them with an unsettling precision. With a swift, calculated motion, Seidel slapped the rolled letter against the messenger’s chest, the sound echoing through the stillness of the room like the crack of a whip. The parchment felt heavier than it had moments ago, the weight of its meaning pressing down on the messenger’s heart. Seidel’s gaze was unyielding, demanding answers, and the messenger felt it—like the cold edge of a sword against his throat.

The tension in the air was thick now, almost suffocating. The general’s presence alone seemed to fill the space, drawing out the secrets the messenger had fought so hard to keep, pushing him to the brink of divulging everything. The man stood frozen, the rolled parchment now feeling like a brand upon his chest, as Seidel waited for him to speak. The silence stretched on, thick and uncomfortable, leaving no room for evasion.

“Well, General,” the messenger stammered, his voice trembling under the weight of Seidel’s gaze, “one for you, a second for the Queen, and I believe the third is for Zealot Zek Judd.” He lowered his head slightly, as if to shield himself from the intensity of Seidel’s stare, the words tumbling from his lips with the hesitance of a man caught in a storm. The mention of Zealot Judd seemed to hang in the air like a dark omen, the name carrying a certain heaviness that made even the bravest of men shudder.

Seidel paused, his brows furrowing as he processed the messenger's words. The Queen's name was expected, but Judd—the Zealot—was a different matter entirely. The general's jaw tightened, the muscles in his face hardening as the realisation began to sink in. Judd was no mere ally; he was a force, an unpredictable and dangerous one whose loyalty to the Imperium was matched only by his fanatical devotion to his cause.

“Judd...” Seidel muttered, the name slipping from his lips with an edge that betrayed both annoyance and caution. “Why would this, Ulfar, involve him?”

He took a step back, his mind racing through the implications of such a move. Judd's involvement would surely complicate matters, perhaps in ways even Seidel hadn't anticipated. The general's gaze shifted from the messenger to the letter once more, his hand now gripping the rolled parchment tighter as if it could somehow provide answers to questions that loomed larger by the second. The room seemed to shrink around them, the weight of the choices yet to be made pressing in on all sides.

The messenger paused, his brow furrowing as his mind sifted through the haze of the hurried journey, trying to recollect the specifics of the strange meeting with Ulfar. He felt the weight of Seidel's sharp gaze press on him like a physical force, urging his memory to work faster. For a moment, his mind went blank, consumed by the chaos of the last few days. The only sounds that rose to the surface were the echo of Ulfar's low, confident laugh and the stern orders given at each step of their mission.

Then, like a flicker in the dark, the memory of the war room came to him—Ulfar's orders echoing off the stone walls, the crackle of the fire in the hearth, and the map laid out before them. The messenger's eyes widened as the scene unfolded in his mind's eye, the details slowly coming into focus.

“Grand General,” he said with a sharp breath, his voice suddenly steady, “they had a war map laid out—large, detailed. Various flag markers are scattered across it, some small, some

large. I couldn't make sense of all of them, but they seemed to represent fortresses or towns. I'm not sure which." His fingers fumbled nervously at his sides as he recalled the specific image. "But what struck me most were two daggers on the table."

Seidel's gaze sharpened, his pulse quickening at the mention of the daggers. He leaned in slightly, urging the messenger to continue. "Go on."

The messenger seemed not to need the nudge as his voice was now full and powerful, whereas meek earlier. "The daggers—both of them were lying on their sides, the tips pointed in different directions." His words now come more freely. "One... one was pointed southward. It was subtle, but it stood out in my mind." His voice trailed off, as if the very mention of it carried some deeper significance. The general's brow furrowed even deeper, and for a moment, he said nothing, the weight of the messenger's words pressing heavily upon him.

Daggers. Southward. Seidel could not ignore the ominous sense of urgency those markers seemed to carry. The placement of the daggers could mean many things—perhaps a sign of Ulfar's next move, or a plan that involved more than just the obvious. Whatever it was, Seidel knew that these were not just idle details. Ulfar's strategy was unfolding in ways he had not anticipated, and he needed to act swiftly or risk falling behind. He straightened, pushing his thoughts back into focus, his mind already racing ahead to what this could all mean.

Seidel's mind chummed as he sifted through the names and locations of the fortresses scattered across the continent. His gaze grew distant, his fingers tapping absently on the edge of the table as he mentally traced each stronghold, one by one. His thoughts flitted over the distant peaks and valleys, the dense forests and the walls that had stood firm for generations. For a moment, nothing significant came to mind—just the usual garrisons and outposts that dotted the land. He paused, frustration flickering across his face as the list of fortresses

seemed to blur together in his mind. Then, like a sudden crack of lightning, an epiphany struck him, sharp and clear.

His eyes widened, a surge of realisation breaking through the haze of his thoughts. “He could not be that foolish!” Seidel muttered under his breath, disbelief mixing with a dark laugh. His voice echoed in the quiet room, the sound both bitter and mocking as he let the absurdity of the idea settle in. The pieces were falling into place now, one after the other, each acknowledgement sharper than the last. “By the time any reinforcements I send could even reach General Boscogn, these... Stormfangs,” he spat the name with a sneer, “would either have been massacred or—” His eyes narrowing with a dangerous edge, “they will have taken it.”

Seidel let out a breath, his gaze hardening as the weight of his conclusion settled over him. His laughter faded, replaced by the grim recognition of the enemy's true intent.

A soldier questions, his voice filled with an inquisitive nature unheard of by many in the room. He was full of puzzlement at the vague words which seemed to carry a tone of a thousand stories with them. He asked, “They would have taken what, sir?”

Seidel chuckles, his voice filled with a sense of irony, “Vingólf.” The single word was enough to cause a tremble amongst the men around. It was such a fortress that was rivalled amongst legends.

Meanwhile, the other rider faced a journey that was both nearing a day longer; the first to arrive would be the messenger sent for High-Zealot Judd, who would arrive just a few hours later. Riding upon a brown standard thoroughbred, the sun glared off the shining coat, creating an array of various shades of brown to tan. The man arrived at the gate of The Parcival. In anticipation of meeting the Grand Zealot for the first time, his heart beat like a thousand horses riding across the plains.

Though the rider heading to Grand Zealot Zek Judd at the Parcival was closer than the one sent to the capital, his

journey was slowed by the summer floods of the lowlands leading west to the religious site. A third would come from the village of Ulfar, though much later than the rest, he carried a curated message for that of the lady queen herself. This one in total lagged just a half day behind the second courier, bearing a decree fashioned solely for Zek Judd.

A voice rang out from the crest of the bastion, slicing through the heavy air with an edge as sharp as iron. It was a voice devoid of welcome, carrying a hardened, wary tone, one that spoke of long days spent in vigilance and little patience for unexpected visitors.

The words seemed to echo slightly against the stone walls, reverberating with an authority that brooked no nonsense. “What business do you have with us, lone rider?” The voice held no hint of curiosity or invitation, only the cold, clipped tone of one accustomed to facing threats rather than guests. The figure above stood like a statue, eyes narrowed against the distant rider, and behind him, the men on guard shifted ever so slightly, all senses sharpened as they awaited the rider’s reply.

“I bring a message for the Grand Zealot’s eyes alone! It is my quest to deliver it by hand!” He calls, raising the rolled parchment high, his voice unwavering yet touched with urgency. The scroll, stamped with the faintest symbol, catches the glint of early dawn, marking his purpose.

Moments later, the groaning clank of steel chains fills the air as the massive gate begins its slow ascent, lifted by ancient pulleys and thick iron links that grind against stone. The rider edges forward, his steed stamping impatiently, as the gate finally reveals the path before him, winding and narrow, lined with solemn relics and statues. As he spurs his horse onward, he finds himself passing small star-shaped huts nestled along the path—humble shelters for the monks devoted to prayer and penance within the monastery walls. The rider’s quickened pace stirs whispers and mutters from those he passes, their suspicious

eyes following him from beneath deep hoods and shadowed brows.

Stone walls echo with muttered disdain, while wary glances and guarded expressions dart in his direction, as if his very presence disrupted the sanctity of their hallowed ground. Undeterred, he pushes forward, hooves striking hard against the cobblestone path, past faces hardened by years of discipline and faith.

Dismounting his steed, he quickly ties the reins to a wooden post before grabbing the message and running into the main chapel. He is greeted by all sorts of magnificent architecture, statues, murals, stained glass and a gorgeous gold, blue, teal and cyan mosaic sprawling the whole expanse of the chapel floor. There are a few dozen rows up, sitting down in a pew is Zealot Judd, seemingly oblivious to the man who just entered his holy sanctum.

A voice, like gravel crushed beneath iron, fills the hollow chamber, casting echoes against the towering stone walls. The messenger halts, startled by the unexpected address. “For what cause dost thou intrude upon this sacred sanctuary during my hour of devotion, dear brother?” The words are tinged with authority and an almost unearthly calm, each syllable weighed and deliberate. “Must it needs be of greater import than my communion with the Divine?”

As if he were an embodiment of the very stone, the head Zealot rises from his place of reverence, his robed form towering as he pivots to face the visitor. He makes a motion towards the messenger with his hand, almost cutting his heart in half, then gestures towards him. His gaze, sharp yet veiled by a long life of solitude and severity, takes in the dust-cloaked messenger standing before him, a lone figure amid the sea of flickering votive lights.

With a slow, scrutinising step, he advances. His gaze narrows as it fixes upon the rolled parchment, held tightly in the trembling hands of the soldier. “Is that missive thou dost hold in

thine hands intended for me?" His voice softens only slightly, carrying the faintest hint of intrigue. "I would surmise it is, for thou art not one of the clergy present here."

The zealot's discerning eyes pierce through the dim light, taking in the messenger's worn armour and travel-weary countenance, marking him as an outsider, a bearer of something that dared intrude upon the solemn silence of the monastery.

Caught off guard by the High Zealot's unwavering gaze and direct question, the messenger's composure falters. Words stumble from his mouth as his throat tightens beneath the weight of the sanctified air. He hesitates, his voice barely a whisper at first, the tremor betraying both exhaustion and awe. "F-ff-or y-you."

The simple phrase stutters forth, each syllable laced with uncertainty as he stretches out his hand, presenting the sealed message like an offering to some unyielding deity. His arm trembles, fingertips brushing the wax seal, the darkened amber glinting faintly in the dim candlelight of the hallowed hall.

The High Zealot's brow furrows as he reaches for the parchment, his fingers curling around it with a claw-like grip, nails jagged and caked with grit, like stakes driven deep into the earth. His eyes narrow as he breaks the wax seal, its cherry shards falling away like brittle embers. He unfurls the scroll slowly, every crinkle of the paper echoing through the silent hall, and begins to read. The seconds stretch painfully, each one heavy as he studies the scrawled lines before him, his gaze darkening with each word. At last, after what feels like an endless moment, he raises his head, eyes blazing with a fierce, accusatory light. His voice trembles with contempt, sharpened with incredulity as he speaks. "Is there truth in the words of this?"

The man who handed the note was clueless about the contents of the parchment; he was only the messenger, the one who was told to believe such. His voice was weakened as he uttered, "I apologise, Lord Zealot, I haven't the faintest clue what was inscribed upon the note."

With a sudden, commanding gesture, the Zealot thrusts the letter back toward the soldier, his gaze fierce and unyielding. The parchment trembles in the soldier's grasp as he receives it, his hands unsteady under the weight of the moment.

The High Zealot's voice fills the chamber, reverberating off the stone walls like the toll of a bell, powerful and unrelenting. "Then pray," he declares, each word carrying the force of a commandment, steady and soft, "read it aloud for all to hear." The gathered monks and acolytes, frozen in silent anticipation, turn their eyes toward the messenger, their breaths held, waiting as if for the pronouncement of judgment itself.

The soldier grasps the parchment tightly, his fingers pressing into its worn edges as he steels himself for the task. He takes a few measured breaths, feeling his heart pound beneath his armour, each beat echoing louder in the stillness of the hall. A deep gulp follows, and for a moment, the world around him fades, becoming hazy, almost surreal—as though he stands within a dream, surrounded by the solemn faces of monks, their robes shadowed by flickering torchlight. With one last, steadying breath, he lifts the letter to eye level.

His voice quivers as he begins, but soon it grows firm, resonating through the hallowed stone walls as he reads.

*To Grand Zealot Zek Judd, Head of the Faith,
Neirmar Imperium*

*I inscribe these words not as your enemy but as
a servant of the true Gods, entrusted with the
sacred duty to restore the honour of our
forefathers and cleanse our land of the
falsehoods that have ensnared our people. The
time has come for the restoration of the
Pantheon of old, founded upon the eternal
principles bestowed upon us by the Seven, with
Talor the King as our ascended guide.*

For too long, our people have suffered under the yoke of a false religion, one that has strayed from the path of righteousness and denied the rightful place of the Seven in our hearts and minds. Under the banner of the Stormfangs, led by Ulfar Val, bearer of the Amulet of Kings and wielder of the legendary sword Arenith, we shall rise to cast down the usurpers and restore the sacred rites of our ancestors.

The Hall of Valingard awaits those who honour their blood and lineage, where the brave and faithful shall feast forever under the watchful eyes of the Seven. It is with solemn resolve and unwavering faith that we embark upon this righteous endeavour to purge the land of heresy and reclaim our rightful place in the divine order.

I beseech you, Grand Zealot Judd, to heed this call not with hostility but with a recognition of our shared duty to uphold the true faith. Let us work together to usher in an era of spiritual renewal and unity, where the light of the Seven shines brightly upon Valkoria once more.

If you do not take this hand, I shall only extend this once you fall to the gates of the burning hellscape that is the Infernum. No army, no religious order, nor any peon forced to take arms will stop the will of the Gods.

*In the name of Talor the King and the Seven,
Ulfar Val
Leader of the Stormfangs*

Each word burns hotter within Judd's mind, his grip on the parchment tightening until his knuckles are pale against his flushed skin, as though he could wrest the blasphemy from the page itself. His hands shake with the tension, fingers pressed so fiercely they seem to claw into the paper. Muscles in his jaw clench, and the vein on his forehead throbs, a crimson line pulsing with the wrath building inside him.

His face deepens to a furious shade, breath coming faster, ragged with the heat of his rage. Then, with a wild glare in his eyes, he snaps his gaze upward, unleashing a roar that pierces the sanctuary. “AAAARRRRGGGGHHHH!” He seethes, drawing in a sharp, trembling breath before spitting his curses, “Blasphemy! Heresy! You vile, filthy peasant rat—may you be damned in every realm! Curse you to all damnation, Ulfar Val!”

His words are savage, but even they cannot contain the fury exploding within him. His breaths are jagged, strained, each exhalation a growl as he glares around the room. Finally, he seizes upon the nearest wooden pew and, with feral, unrestrained strength, he slams his boot against it, splintering the polished wood under his heel. His stomping grows relentless, boots crashing down until the pew is reduced to fragments beneath him, scattered across the stone floor like firewood.

Watching all the chaos unfold, the clergy around do nothing to stop their superior. From the back, a newer zealot calls, “Grand Zealot, we mustn't delve so low to desecrate the temple of the divine. I haven't a clue what you read, but if it even pushed you into rage, then this must be dealt with; send a riding party to the capital. We must show the Queen this letter.” The young man finishes his words with a slight tremble as the bloodshot eyes of Zek Judd are locked upon him, and the gaze is one of someone who has just killed a man.

With a deliberate, measured motion, the Zealot lifts his right hand, fingers poised in a delicate pinch near his face, as though gathering the very air around him to steady his mind. He inhales deeply, letting the breath cool his rage, his posture

relaxing as he visibly reins in the fire still smouldering beneath his skin. His eyes soften just enough to acknowledge the messenger before him, and in a tone laced with an eerie calm, he speaks, "You are right... What is your name, if I may ask?"

The young messenger hesitates, his gaze flickering under the weight of the Zealot's piercing stare, as though seeking an anchor in a storm. After a fleeting pause, he musters the courage to speak, his voice barely a whisper that hangs in the heavy air of the chamber. "Cairo." The single word was fraught with uncertainty; his name was a fragile offering in the face of the imposing figure before him.

Judd chuckles, a sound that echoes with a dark amusement, reverberating through the stone walls of the monastery. His lips curl into a smile, though it is devoid of warmth. "Well then, Cairo, you will take five other zealots of your choice," he continues, his voice steady and commanding. "Leave the confines of this monastery by mass time in three hours. Ride straight for the capital and demand from the Queen what she intends to do about this nonsense." His eyes narrow, the weight of his words carrying an unsettling finality. "By the time you arrive, the third rider should be there."

Cairo, his head still spinning with the intensity of the Zealot's reaction, nods quickly, the affirmation lost in the turbulence of his thoughts. Judd's gaze sharpens, the subtle cruelty of his smile remaining.

Without missing a beat, Judd turns his attention to a scribe hunched over a desk, his quill scratching away feverishly at the parchment.

"You," the Zealot barks, pointing a thick, calloused finger at the man, "take this and make them a copy to take, now!" His voice leaves no room for argument, the command heavy with authority. The scribe jumps to his feet, stumbling briefly in his haste, and begins to copy the message with a trembling hand, the flicker of panic evident in his eyes. Judd, meanwhile, dismisses the situation with a casual gesture, as if the

matter were nothing more than a fleeting annoyance. Turning on his heel, he strides away, his heavy footsteps echoing through the chamber, leaving Cairo standing in stunned silence, the weight of his task now upon him.

Just an hour later, the young Zealot Cairo gathers the five others, all eager but tense, mounting their horses with swift precision. Their forms cast long shadows in the fading light as they set off towards the capital. The air is thick with the weight of their mission, the urgency of their pace quickening with each beat of the horses' hooves against the dust-laden earth. They ride in formation, the rhythmic clatter of their mounts mingling with the occasional snap of reins and the distant calls of birds retreating from the sky.

The journey is long, but their purpose is clear—an unspoken agreement between them all to carry the words of the Grand Zealot to the heart of the kingdom. Their destination is just a few hours away, but it feels like an eternity as they push forward, each man lost in thought, the tension of their task hanging heavily in the cool evening air. They are set to arrive after the initial message of Ulfar's—a missive meant for the Queen—has already reached her ears. The weight of that fact sits uneasily in Cairo's chest, the idea of arriving in the wake of such a declaration leaving him restless. But the path is set before them, and there is no turning back now.

As they ride, the landscape shifts, the road bending and narrowing, the looming silhouette of the capital beginning to take shape on the horizon, drawing closer with each passing minute.

The third rider carrying the name Ian was a lowly knight, a proper soldier of the Imperium who was both good with his sword and bow, carrying both on this ride. He was no mere novice to riding through the plains of Onu-Arith and knew of the

near-complete safety of riding the cobbled road. He knew the only dangers came from when you strayed and ventured the road less travelled. Unaware of any dangers, the man rode though the sun was setting, and the night fast approaching, the man was still at least a full hour's ride out from Valkoria. As the knight rides almost mindlessly, he notices the birds abnormally flying all away from the small forest within eyeshot of the road that draws his mind back to the world of the awoken.

Speaking out to nobody except the horse, "I wonder what would cause all of that ruckus? Hmm, probably just some creature..." Suddenly, he is interrupted by the sound of a howl. "Faster girl!" He pats the horse and digs his heels deeper, pushing the horse. "What in God's name could that have been? The wolves have long been hunted from this land, and no coyote makes such a loud sound. Could it be... a dire wolf? Yet I do believe those have not been seen in neither my lifetime nor that of my parents; they are more or less the stuff of legends and mystery."

The knight pushes the horse, hoping to outrun whatever made such a noise, then, after a few minutes, the forest turns farther away from him, prompting a release of the pressure into the horse, easing the pace.

A cold wind blows over, causing the knight to shiver as the sun sets over the western horizon, and a sense of fear encapsulates the rider. For what could that almost howl have been? The horse begins to stumble as she gallops; the overexertion, even for those few minutes, has led to the necessary rest Ian was so dreading. With that, the knight slows down the horse near an older oak tree with a small pool of water beside it for the horse. Upon dismounting, he glances at the tree, the leaves were eerie like black wisps moving with each breeze.

With each passing second, the anxiety builds in the man, and paranoia sets in as he hears the rustling of the tree scaring him each time. He walks towards the horse with the clouds revealing not one but two half moons; their light casts a glimmer

across the elegant plains of Onu-Arith, relaxing the knight as he rubs his hands across the shimmering brown coat of his mount.

A faint tremor disturbs the dried grass behind him, the sound of not two but four steps in sequence, quite unlike the prancing of a horse. The ground quivers and crunches by unseen heavy paws, sharp black claws dig into the soil with each step, then an ominous silence covers the area, followed by a loud thud of a dismounting being much heavier than the knight. The man's heart racing as he closes his eyes briefly, with the sound of a weapon being drawn gives him the final courage to draw his blade.

In both hands, the man grips the blade tight with the fuller lined with his nose, the large creature behind him stops and takes a noticeable breath before uttering, "Ulak arakath, thrakel tal zhul." The creature mutters in an unknown language before chuckling and speaking with a raspy, deep, almost growling voice, "You... are... dead..."

Each word seems like the start of a new sentence with great pauses in between. With a quick breath, the knight whirled around, swinging his blade with a concise sweep targeted towards the sound, but catching nothing but air as the night swallowed his strike. A heavy silence filled the air as the first thud echoed, followed by a second one, with the sound of metal colliding with stone. Now silent lies the warrior engulfed by the still darkness as the same sounds that approached now leave with the wind.

The party leaving the Parcival lags but a few hours behind the knight Ian. Nearly two hours past sunset, he set his

within eyes' reach of the gates of Valkoria. The horse is panting as each click of the hooves on the stone brings the countdown for the travelling monks. Orange fires blaze beacons of success to the men as they arrive at the gates, "We've been sent by the High Zealot! We must needs seek an audience with Queen Anne immediately!" The young man Cairo belts out to the guards, who show little care in opening the gates without question. Riding from the gate, they stir many citizens awake with the rumbling quake that is their horses.

With steeds stomping, the men race through the moonlight. Arriving at the Blue Castle, a group of the Queen's Guard stops the monks' advance. One, placing his hand firmly on the chest of young Cairo questions, "What business do the God's surfs have with the Queen at this hour?"

Boasting the parchment in his left hand, whilst removing the soldier's hand with his right, he retorts, "Good sir, this here parchment contains a message that only the queen's eyes have the grace of God to see. I would be so humble to let us, though, sir it is very urgent."

"Hmph, fine, follow." The guard's voice is curt, his words barely more than a grunt as he turns on his heel and marches into the castle, his boots clicking sharply on the stone floor. The monks, each clad in their humble robes, fall into line behind him, their eyes scanning the grand interior of the castle with quiet reverence.

The heavy wooden doors of the royal keep creak open as they pass, the flickering torchlight casting long, dancing shadows along the walls. They follow the guard down long corridors lined with tapestries depicting battles and triumphs, the air thick with the scent of old parchment and polished stone. The weight of the castle presses upon them, a looming reminder of the power they've come to confront.

At last, they arrive before the study of Her Majesty, its thick wooden door adomed with intricate carvings, each one more ornate than the last. The guard stops abruptly, his hand

falling on the cool, iron-knobbed door, and with a firm push, the door swings open. He steps aside, motioning for the monks to enter, but his gaze locks onto Cairo.

“Only you,” The guard pointed directly at the young Zealot who still clutched the letter tightly, the weight of it pressing heavily in his hands. Cairo's heart skips a beat as the others are left behind in the shadowed hall, and the guard's eyes narrow, his expression unreadable. Cairo swallows, a knot forming in his throat, and steps forward into the dimly lit study, the door closing softly behind him with a finality that seems to echo through the castle. The air in the room is cool, filled with the scent of aged leather and ink, and Her Majesty's presence is almost palpable, though her figure remains hidden in the depths of the room, shrouded in shadows.

After a deep breath and the sound of a thousand heartbeats deep within him, Cairo musters the courage to enter, slowly pushing over the large door, “Your Lady Grace, I have a message that was delivered by hand to Grand Zealot Judd, and he has also tasked me with garnering your response to this Ulfar Val character.” He stumbles over a few words as he talks to the back of the fair Queen.

She quickly twists on her heels, the movement sharp and fluid, her robes swishing with the motion. Her gaze locks onto Cairo, a puzzled frown spreading across her features. Her face, tinted with a warm orange glow from the setting sun streaming through the high windows, twists in confusion. The lines around her eyes deepen as her nose scrunches, a clear sign of her genuine perplexity. She takes a few quick steps toward him, her footfalls soft yet deliberate, the weight of her presence filling the space.

“Ulgar who?” She questions, her voice laced with both intrigue and a hint of frustration. She tilts her head slightly, her brows furrowing further as she waits for a response. The tension in the air thickens as the silence stretches, and Cairo, still holding

the letter, feels the weight of her gaze upon him, the heat of her confusion almost tangible.

“Ulfar, Your Grace, Ulfar Val, the leader of this Stormfangs group. He sent a letter to you, to the General, and to the Grand Zealot,” Cairo stammers, his voice a little unsure as the words tumble out. His grip tightens on the rolled parchment, the wax seal still intact, a symbol of the message's importance. The boy's face flushes with a growing sense of confusion, the pieces of the situation slipping out of place like a puzzle with missing parts.

His brow furrows in a deepening frown, a wave of uncertainty washing over him. Could it be possible? Had the riders who were supposed to be ahead of him—those carrying the urgent message—managed to get here before him? The thought gnaws at his mind, a flicker of doubt casting a shadow over his confidence. Cairo's eyes flicker briefly to the window, as though he might glimpse the answers beyond the stone walls. The ride was supposed to take longer; the messenger had been a few hours ahead. The questions swirl, unanswered, leaving Cairo feeling exposed, unsure if he's misread something crucial or if the situation is more tangled than it seemed.

The Queen began to pace, her steps measured and deliberate as she took the letter from Cairo's outstretched hand. Her fingers brushed over the wax seal for a brief moment before she unrolled the parchment, her eyes scanning the words with a quiet intensity. The silence in the room deepened, a weight settling in the air as she read, her face betraying no emotion, only a slight furrowing of her brow as she absorbed each line. Minutes passed in stillness, the only sound was the soft shuffle of her feet against the stone floor.

Finally, she halted, turning to face Cairo, her gaze sharp and calculating. “No riders came to the keep except for you today.” Her voice was steady but with an edge of uncertainty beneath it. “Are you certain that a rider was sent here?” Her words hung in the air, heavy with suspicion. She studied the boy

closely, as if searching for any hint of deception in his expression, her gaze unflinching. The room, once filled with anticipation, now seemed colder, the question cutting through the tension like a blade. The Queen's mind raced, piecing together the implications of this unexpected turn of events.

Cairo nodded solemnly, his head dipping in confirmation. "Yes, your Grace." His voice was wavering ever so slightly, though his resolve remained firm. The weight of his words lingered in the air, a quiet unease creeping over him.

There was a distinct sense of confusion that had begun to settle in his chest, like a fog clouding his thoughts. He cast a quick glance towards his companions, all of whom wore expressions mirroring his own — bewilderment, uncertainty, and the unsettling feeling that something was terribly wrong. The party that had accompanied him here, a mix of youthful zealots and loyal followers, exchanged subtle looks, their minds racing to piece together the puzzle.

The path they had travelled had been uneventful, without so much as a hint of the rider who was supposedly ahead of them. There were no signs of struggle, no markers left behind to indicate the fate of the messenger. The riders were certain that their paths had never crossed — until much later in their journey. But that did little to quell the mounting questions. Had the rider been waylaid? Or had something more sinister taken place, something unseen and unnoticed by them? The thought gnawed at Cairo, his pulse quickening as the silence stretched longer between them.

The strange absence of the missing rider hung heavily over him like an ominous cloud. What had befallen the man who had been tasked with delivering the message before him? Had he even been in the city at all? The lack of any mark, any indication, only deepened the mystery. The confusion among the party grew, each member contemplating the same unsettling possibility — the rider had vanished, or worse, never made it at all.

She placed a hand over her chin, her fingers tracing her jaw in thought, her brow furrowed in confusion. The weight of the unanswered question pressed upon her as she pondered how a simple messenger could have vanished without a trace. Her mind worked quickly, the possibilities racing, each more troubling than the last.

“Hmmm...” Her gaze narrowed as she considered every angle. “Perhaps he was turned away at the castle gate?” The words tumbled out, though they felt uncertain, as if she were trying to convince herself more than anyone else. Suddenly, she snapped her fingers, her expression sharpening with newfound clarity. “Lord Helios! Come in here now!”

Her voice carried an authoritative edge, the command laced with impatience. Almost immediately, the heavy wooden door creaked open, and the tall, imposing figure of Lord Helios stepped inside, flanked by two guardsmen. The air in the room seemed to shift, the quiet tension thickening as the guards silently took their positions behind him, awaiting the Queen's next command.

“You called for me, your Majesty?” Helios's voice was steady, his tone respectful as he bowed his head before the Queen, his movements precise and measured. The flickering candlelight cast long shadows across his sharp features, accentuating the gravity of the moment. His posture was one of practised authority, yet his eyes revealed a flicker of curiosity, sensing that something was amiss in the Queen's demeanour. The silence that followed seemed to stretch, heavy with unspoken questions, as he awaited her direction, fully aware that the weight of the situation rested on her next words.

She flicked her fingers dismissively, motioning for Lord Helios to rise. “Yes, tell me this—did any riders come to the gate before this group? Any at all?” Her voice, though still calm, carried an edge of urgency. “According to this man and the Grand Zealot, I was supposed to receive a letter from this Ulfar Val character.”

She glanced at Cairo as if to have approval; she got the name correct, her gaze shifting back to the parchment in her hands. As her eyes lingered on the name, she pronounced it carefully, almost as though testing its weight on her tongue, ensuring she spoke it with the precision it demanded. The name felt foreign yet somehow ominous, and her brow furrowed slightly as she awaited Helios's response.

Without a moment's hesitation, Lord Helios straightened, his voice unwavering as he addressed the Queen, "No, your Majesty. There were no riders who entered the city this day. It was almost... unnaturally still beyond the walls. The gates remained undisturbed, save for the faint breeze that swept in as the night began to settle." He paused for a brief moment, his gaze lingering on the Queen, as if weighing the oddity of the situation. "The calm was unsettling, your Majesty. I had thought little of it at the time, but now..." His words trailed off, leaving a quiet tension in the air, the implication hanging heavy.

With a deep breath, Queen Anne looks to the young monk Cairo, "Tell your fanatic that I will not tolerate this fool who thinks he is strong enough to take my kingdom. Now for the note." Anne glances to her right, where both Helios and Cairo notice a shadowed figure. "You two, leave." Both Helios and Cairo leave without knowing who the figure was. Her voice softens, "I want you to figure out what in the gods' names happened to that messenger, by any means necessary."

The shadowed figure, her form draped in an ethereal, mystic aura that seemed to shimmer like the northern lights, gives a slow, deliberate nod. Her presence exuded an otherworldly calm, as if she existed between realms. In a voice soft yet laced with power, she speaks with an air of certainty, "Give me three days." The words hang in the air, as if bound by some unspoken promise. Without another glance, she begins to move, her steps both graceful and deliberate. Behind her, the echo of Anne's deepened laughter reverberates through the vast halls of the keep. The sound, rich and rolling, cuts through the

silence, sending shivers down the spines of those nearby. It is a laugh not born of mirth but of something far darker, something far more foreboding. It lingers in the stone walls long after Anne's voice fades, a haunting reminder of the gravity of what is to come.

The Queen chuckles softly, a light sound that seems to carry the weight of both wisdom and wry amusement. Her lips curl into a smile, revealing the dimples of a younger version of herself, now faded with age but still visible in moments of genuine mirth. Her eyes, however, remain sharp and calculating, reflecting the burdens of a ruler.

As she mutters to herself, the words are soft yet firm, carrying an edge of finality, “Two, no more.” The statement hangs in the air, heavy with resolve, a subtle decree for what is to come—clear, unyielding, and full of purpose.

Nodding her head with a quiet, almost imperceptible motion, the shadowed figure turns toward the window. As she moves, the air seems to shift, thickening with an unseen energy. She reaches the edge of the stone sill and, in a fluid motion, opens the window wide. An abrupt gust of wind sweeps into the room, tugging at her cloak and pulling back the deep hood that had once concealed her face. As the hood falls, her silvery white hair catches the dim light, flowing like strands of moonlight. Her sharp, pointed ear stands out clearly, a telltale mark of her elven heritage.

Without a moment's hesitation, she leaps out of the window, her figure momentarily outlined against the twilight sky. As she falls, she murmurs a single word under her breath, “Fly.” The word carries the weight of ancient power, and as soon as it leaves her lips, her body shudders briefly, then begins to lift, defying gravity. The spell takes hold, and she soars upward, her cloak billowing behind her like the wings of a phantom, disappearing into the night.

Chapter 7

Winds of Change

“For the winds of time may blow the sand of fate, but none more feel power than He who controls the hand above.”

- Anteantodo (1E 4923 - 2E 0256), *Charter of the First Men*, Philosopher, Head of the Guild of the Mystic Arts (1E 4963 - 2E 0256).

After a gruelling four-day march, the rebel army's relentless campaign finally neared its climactic stand before the legendary fortress of Vingólf. This castle, an embodiment of ancient might and mastery, loomed ahead, stretching across the horizon like a mountain of stone. It was said to be impregnable, impervious even to the scorching fury of a dragon's breath. The vast structure stood as both a marvel of lost craftsmanship and a testament to the endurance of magic, with walls towering over twelve metres high and nearly five metres thick, every inch etched with cryptic carvings and enchanted runes from an era beyond memory.

In the muted glow of early morning, the ancient stone shimmered softly, its surface dappled with a pale, otherworldly sheen, an effect conjured by the magic woven into its core. Veins of silver and deep green laced the rock, glistening beneath the dawning light as if alive. Around the stronghold, a heavy fog clung to the plains, shifting in ghostly wisps that stirred the grasses but yielded no warmth. It was as if the land itself held its breath, anticipating the bloodshed soon to come.

From atop his steed on the crest of a far-off hill, Ulfar surveyed the field below, his gaze settling on the imposing fortress. His eyes, cool and resolute, held a quiet solemnity as he took in the placid beauty of the land—a peacefulness that would soon be torn asunder by the chaos of war. To his right, Ariendria sat astride her own horse, her stance alert, alongside Captain Dex, whose keen eyes scanned the approaching battlefield.

A tranquil, almost surreal calm enveloped Ulfar, easing his nerves in a way he had not felt since the campaign's start. For this would be his first true battle fought not for power or conquest, but for the freedom of his people, the liberation of his homeland—a struggle that would define his cause and his fate.

Standing opposite of Ulfar, far across the plains atop the first tower of Vingólf's wall was a man adorned in thick, heavy armour with a blue hue to it. Standing nearly a head taller than the average man, General Boscogn commanded the valiant Lapis Heavy Assault Knights. The man stood with a grimace slathered across his face as he gazed out at the speck which was his opponent. A large scar cut down from his right eyebrow diagonally down his nose to the corner of his mouth, taking a piece of his nose with it. The pauldrons of his armour rose above his neck, showing what looked like the shoulder blades of a rhino. Leaning against the wall was his weapon, a large polearm which looked like a scimitar blade with the hilt of a spear, a glaive named Blood Fang. With a deep breath, Boscogn grabs his weapon, turning to face the men waiting down below.

A loud crack is heard as Boscogn slams the base of his glaive to the stone below him, “Listen up, all of you! There across that field stands the enemy. They believe they can take Vingólf! Ha ha, we are the Lapis Heavy Assault Knights now, get ready to bathe in the blood of these fools!” The speech was short yet enough to cover the men in a faux sense of assured victory.

By this point, Ulfar has returned to his camp, where the men began to build siege machines while gathering the

resources. To his left was the female elf, Ariendria. To his right was Dex, the mysterious soldier with a tormented past forever enshrined upon his skin with the Mark of Krahnn. Silence came over the three as the men struggled to build strong machines with the less-than-suitable willow wood shrouding their camp.

Raising his right hand and calling out, “Stop, we need not any machine to take this fortress. They will be useless, the fort was made to withstand the machines of Valkar, trust in me as the wisdom of the All Father guiding us.” With that, Ulfar and his two commanders, Ariendria and Dex, follow him into the main tent.

The now bustling camp of the Stormfang’s army was filled with zeal and anticipation for Ulfar’s battle plan. The men sharpened their blades, and the squires placed piece by piece the plates of steel set to defend the knights. The men readied their horses for the coming raid. Each soldier said their prayers to the Seven, calling for their guidance and saying their warriors’ prayers.

There one man sits alone with his sword by him, he kneels holding a cross of life in his right, reciting these words:

“Vekar, All-Father, I call upon you,
My sword is drawn, my aim is true.
Talor, fierce Warrior, grant me ye might,
Thou seek great honour in battle, a fearless fight.
Drukavin, Storm-Brother, unleash ye rage,
In your name, we conquer, page by page.
Drenamir, Master, bless thy blade,
With every strike, let foes be swayed.
Gods of War, hear my cry,
In your glory, thou shalt live or die.
Strength, honour, courage - Hail, Hail, Hail!”

Upon finishing his prayer, the knight rises from the ground, putting his sword to the air as he places the cross below his chest

plate, “For our Gods are real, these heretics shall not rule this land much longer.”

The soldier groups up after a few more minutes with the regiment of the Stormfangs. Here lies the vast, simple army of horse-mounted men led by the fabled hero Ulfar Stormfang, a sum of men lying in the number near four thousand men. Ulfar stands before them with his two captains, Dex and Ariendria, one at his right and the other at his left.

He takes a deep breath before he begins to address the army before him:

Brothers and sisters of Valkoria! We stand here today on the eve of our great conquest to repair the kingdom of long ago. We have lived our youth dreaming of the great pure quartz and iron halls of our forefathers. Right now, we sit before the legendary fortress city of Vingólf.

Many of you know that there never has been a successful siege of this bastion of strength. But fear not, some of us will die today and ascend to the halls above on the valkyrie's wings, but today we will see the light of tomorrow, and we will take this land as a stepping stone for our conquest.

I cannot lie to you and say we will win, but God willing, we shall take victory against General Boscogn. Many of you know we are outnumbered and lack the firepower to take Vingólf, yet hold steadfast in our plan, listen to your commanders who have been briefed and fight for not just yourself but for Valkoria!

Now sons and daughters of Valkoria, raise thy arms! Raise thy shields! And fight till the last dying breath, not for you but for each one around you and the countless others back home!

Upon finishing his short but powerful speech, Ulfar takes his sword, Arenith, holding it high above the crowd of soldiers for all to see, giving one final yell, "For Valkoria!" He stands admiring the crowd of men and women yelling out for their land.

Across the plains, there stands the menacing, ominous General Raul Boscogn, a pillar of dark omelette, he gazes at the preparing soldiers with a scowl lathered upon his tanned face. The knights all align in formation, preparing to move at the first sight of the enemy from across the landscape.

The General's captains approach him, one of whom speaks, Adonn Shcoltfield, "General Boscogn, what is the plan of defence for this fortress? Shall we wait them out?"

A gaze that could kill a man pierces Adonn. Boscogn approaches him and brings his glaive just before his face, "Hmphh, I am leaving you and your garrison in here, I want to fight this leader myself. You fail me here, and I shall end your line, Adonn."

Boscogn walks away as if he had not nearly killed his captain. The spirit of Adonn does not flutter as he skips away to prepare his garrison for defence duty. Over the course of the next nearly seven hours, the soldiers take little rest, always alert for the moment they must fight for their nation.

As the hour of the sun rose, a beautiful red sun birthed itself in the distant east. The rosy pink and red sky gave an omen of an ominous future. The sight was one to behold amongst the eyes of man who may only gleam on skies so divine a few times in their lives, and for many, this would be their last. The legionnaires of the Imperium's forces now sat in formation outside the gates of the fortress. Just around two-thirds of Boscogn's forces lie in wait for the charge of the Stormfangs

over the hill far out. With a horn calling from the distance, thunder rocks the ground as a wave of black-iron clad men roll down like a wave of yelling men. The sound of the horses and the echoes of voices fill the early morning air.

Boscogn sits in wait behind his line of nearly four thousand men. He calls out, "Let you all meet them at the cut of the dirt! Ride men! Fight for our freedom! Be a defender!"

He rides behind the men as they charge the field, each thud of the hooves a timer until the War of the King would officially begin. The thud, thud, thud gives a simple beat counting down to the time for man to fight man, once again. The horn blows in the distance as the echo crosses the vast open landscape, the rolling fog encases the ground in a white exoskeleton, with each step of the horse a splash against the ground, pushing away the mist gathered. In an instance, the charges of men collided, and the sound of clashing steel was a sound of thunder in this eerie early morning. With the swing of each man's blade, the sound of steel and smell of blood filled the air.

As the warm sun began to fill the valley, nearly an hour had passed, and without haste, the men had trotted on, clashing steel, yelling out as the cavalry would lead charge after charge, though neither the Stormfangs nor the Imperium had yielded ground. The men of the Stormfangs sat now in an arrowed formation as the Imperium soldiers retreated to regroup. In an instant, the Stormfangs charged their army as Ulfar rode behind the arrowhead aimed at Boscogn, who led his army from the rear. The clash of the men initially left few dead, but the lines of the Imperium split, allowing General Boscogn to meet face to face with the young Ulfar.

Upon their steeds, they sat as the endless scourges of men unfolded around them. It was as if the two sat in a world beyond with the yells of men, screamings of arrows, and the blows of each sword rattled through the air, and sparks flew like shooting stars.

Standing before him as the reinforcements of the Imperium ride from the gates of Vingólf, Boscogn addresses Ulfar, “So, I assume, you are the guy who heads this foolish army? See those,” he points to the riders behind him, “they are my reinforcements, your small force will soon be crushed by those men. But first, let me ask, what is your name?”

The opposing man huffs as he takes a deep breath, filling his breast with air before returning, “I am Ulfar, Ulfar Val. He who is the true ruler of this land. And you, you are a famous general, are you not?”

Boscogn's eyes widened at the hearing of the name Val, for he knew the ancient lore of the name. He questioned internally, there was no way one could carry such a name any longer, the name of Val was the bastard name of Valin and that had been eradicated with the death of Talor.

After a few seconds of pondering, Boscogn looks at the boy, “I am General Raul Boscogn. You truly do claim your line is that of the Kings of ancient times?” Boscogn draws his glaive, Blood Fang, and he holds it at his side. His posture was ready to charge into combat, seemingly based on the next few words of Ulfar.

Ulfar gazes deep into the helmet of the armour-clad general who waits like a lion, ready to pounce at any moment. Drawing his sword, Arenith, Ulfar's gaze cuts cold through the slice in the mask of Boscogn. He stemly says, “Yes, I am the last of the old blood. I am the line of ancient Kings, and I will unite the swaths of Valkorians once again. The days of the fragmented world are numbered. The Imperium, a dying failure of man, now lets us do battle.” He charges his horse towards Boscogn, clashing their blades.

The blow struck with such force that it reverberated through every fibre of Boscogn's being, jolting his arm from the glaive's pole down to his very bones. His grip wavered, and for a moment, his entire body felt as brittle as a dead leaf caught in a bitter wind. Each nerve seemed to sing with a piercing chill, his

hardened resolve cracking under the impact. Boscogn, the unyielding fortress of a man, known for his indomitable will, felt it slip away like sand through his fingers.

His gaze shifted to the blade that had dealt the devastating blow, and he managed, through the rattling shock, to utter, “Your b-b-lade... it is made of Erinstihl...” His voice held a haunted tremor, as though he had glimpsed a spectre from a legend long buried, a ghost wielding a weapon that no mere mortal had a right to wield.

The name alone struck him with a primal fear, a material spoken of only in whispered tales—the rare, mystic Erinstihl. It was no ordinary metal but one forged with a power that could only come from the heart of ancient earth, imbued with the pure essence of the world itself—a gift of the divine. In Boscogn's eyes, this weapon seemed to glimmer with a faint, eerie light, as if it had its own will—a radiant menace that chipped away at his defences in a way no mere blade could. He felt his spirit falter, his hands trembling as if the blade itself bore down on his very soul, each strike carving through the armour of his pride and his duty.

Then, like a thunderclap in the midst of his disorientation, the distant but unmistakable sound of hooves shattered the eerie silence, breaking his focus. A faint tremor pulsed through the ground, growing louder as the pounding of thousands of hooves closed in. Boscogn tore his gaze from Ulfar's blade, forcing himself to turn toward the unexpected sight that unfolded beyond the field. There, at the head of a column that glittered like silver under the sun's early light, was the figure of Adonn. He appeared as a commander born from myth, his armour flashing bright against the dawn, his stance commanding, his voice rising above the din as he led his men in a thunderous charge.

Confusion seized Boscogn's mind, his tactical certainty splintering into a flurry of questions. This was impossible; his orders had been explicit—they were to remain within the

impregnable walls of Vingólf, their purpose clear and disciplined. His soldiers, trained to obey without question, had shown no hint of doubt. Yet here they were, cascading down the field like a river freed from its bounds. The sight left Boscogn shaken; even his grip on the glaive seemed feeble, like holding a ghost of its former strength. The charge of his own men struck him with a horror that was almost unbearable, twisting his once-iron resolve into knots of dread and disarray.

Ulfar then rests with a grin as the mist blows out from far past his gaze onto the walls of Vingólf, the swirls of brown dust and the sun rising from the west open the land for all to see. The banner holding the ancient cross of old Valkoria, the golden blades and vines glimmer in the focused beams of the rising sunlight. The flowing deep oceanic blue and ivory white banner flowed as the breeze blew across it, waving it in and out with each gust. The waving banner marked a pivotal moment in the skirmish.

With this, Ulfar's stare pierced through the thick armour of Boscogn as he commanded him, "Lay down your arms, General. My two captains, Dex and Ariendria, have taken the great fortress of Vingólf. Through this, you cannot, rather will not take it back. You may slaughter me and my men, but you will not see the stone held within those walls again, unless you accept my terms." Ulfar trails off as he sheaths his sword, the blood from battle runs down the scabbard as the blade slides into its resting point.

Boscogn racks the glaive on his back armour plate. He holds his right hand high, removing the hefty helm with his left, as he calls out to his men, "Lay down your arms, this fight is lost."

The one sentence is enough to anger Lieutenant Adonn, who yells out gibberish in refutation before riding off with the few idiotic men who are willing to follow the man. Boscogn looks to his men as they lay down their arms. He gazes behind

himself, looking at the horrors, imagining the punishment he would face if he ever showed his face in the Imperium again.

Raul looks to Ulfar, who approaches his voice still coarse like rough sandstone, “What are your terms?”

With a short breath in a single sentence, he gave his terms to the rivalled General, “I simply would ask you and all who are loyal to pledge yourselves to my cause. There is no need to spill our fellows' blood.” He extends his right hand in a sign of peace between the two of them.

Boscogn looked around to his men surrounding him as if he wanted one to object or even just call him out, but none came. He wondered deep inside if this would taint his honour or if it should bring shame across the name Boscogn for the rest of his life, or worse, all who bore the name for centuries. His name brought great pride amongst the ranks of the Imperium, but he dared to taint such an unblemished record. Though now it was inevitable, the fortress was captured before he could even properly duel his rival commander.

With an incessant movement, he grasps the hand of Ulfar tightly, and with the deep rasp of his voice fully exposed, he says, “I accept your terms, on the sole condition I am given full honour within your army, along with the honour of my family remaining unstained in your new kingdom.”

Ulfar gives a simple acknowledgement, allowing the man to address his men once more. The rugged man arises from his slight bend, his eyes seem to betray his previous words with a sense of regret already seeping through, yet it's as if there is an aura that tells of his truth. His age-worn eyes locked on those of Ulfar, and they cut deep through the steadfast lordly gaze of the young Val.

This had meant the two were at an agreement, and with that, Boscogn addressed the remaining soldiers bearing the sigil of his knights. He announced, “You all have been loyal to the queen and her Imperium, but here we sit bested by this man and, as she would call him, a poor peasant farmer, nothing more. I

would rather throw my blade behind the man wearing the Amulet of the King, who is the same one wielding Arenith, than some rancid creature who calls themselves a woman masquerading as the queen of the Valkorian people.”

“So now say your pledge again, Raul Boscogn.” The voice of Ulfar cut jaggedly; it was more curt than before, it was the same tone he had first used with Ariendria. His eyes tore through the world Boscogn had known for all his many years and now made it clear once again the vow he took as a young man was meant not for an empire, king, lord, or queen but for this man who had yet not been born.

He draws his glaive as he steps down from his horse, moving towards Ulfar, who sits still atop his horse. Dropping to a knee, the general of the imperium bows his head, holding his glaive out towards Ulfar with both hands. He says aloud, “I apologise, but I hold not the gods of either Anne or Tumás. I am Jeda. Here in the name of our Lord Father, in the eyes of the Lamb who will be slain, the presence of the Spirit ever Holy. I, Raul Koory Boscogn, do pledge my blade, blood, honour and life to the return of the king.”

The men seemed puzzled as to why this great honourable man would flip his allegiance over the loss of a single battle. The once ferocious beast now seemed so tame and meek. This sudden change in the composure and posture of their general seemed to foretell a calamitous end to those poor souls daring a return to the northern lands of the Imperium.

With the surrender of their great general, the soldiers all in unison began to sheath their blades and cast down their arms in defeat. With each soldier who was now nothing more than a bystander as the towering war horse trotted through the surrendered men, its hooves sent ripples through the sea of silent bodies. Its dark, gleaming coat shimmered in the fading light, while the armour it bore, etched with ancient Valkorian runes, clinked softly with each deliberate thud of a step. The beast's barding, a dark silver sheen marred with the scars of such a

recent battle, moved with effortless grace, a silent reminder of the destruction it had borne witness to.

The soldiers parted as it passed, eyes low, as if the very presence of the warhorse demanded reverence and submission, just as much as the man who rode upon it. With each step of the horse, the number of men behind the banner of the cross grew; men who had just faced defeat saw the divine presence of the man who had just outwitted their great General. Some would mumble that Ulfar stood like the ancient statues of Talor, the drawings in the long forgotten texts—divine, a godly anointed warrior.

The ride took Ulfar into the city, passing through the large rune-engraved gates, fastened with a gleaming iron, impenetrable; they were slowly opened, letting in the new holder.

He raises his sword and screams out, “Raise the banners! Bring to me the lord of this hold!” He trots through the streets as the citizens open their doors, gazing out in awe, many of the younger men and children look in amazement—rather pride, for they saw what was a strong leader emerging from the swells beyond the walls, many of whom had never seen one before. Dismounting the horse as he approached a set of stairs, Ulfar treaded forward by foot with each stair, and the men surrounding him approached ever closer to the governor of this city, Jarlmin Bulgrid, who stood surrounded by guards.

With a loud and gruff voice, the governor spoke to Ulfar alone, “You, you are the one who leads these drengar?” He pushes away the guards, gaining a better glance at the men clad in the armour of the Stormfangs, dyed with deep hues of oceanic blue and black. Before the answer of Ulfar can be given, the man again speaks, “By the Gods, you do hold it—the Amulet of the King.” He reaches forward, grasping the beautiful emerald in his hands before quickly letting it go, as smoke rises from his hand, “It burns the one who is not its master... *hmp* Why Vingólf first?” The older man rubs the lightly burned palm of his right hand, seeing brief blackened skin atop.

Ulfar ponders over the true intentions for only a second before answering, “This is one of the farthest of the holds from the capital of Valkoria. The Blue Range makes travel here much longer from any of the barracks of the Imperium.” He takes a deep breath and gazes around at the lack of Imperium banners present in the centre of the city, even the ancient statue of King Rijarl the Greater still stands unmoved, and as beautiful as it was when his son commissioned it many millennia ago. After his pause, he continues, “I have also heard rumours that Vingólf was not as patriotic for the Imperium as the other strongholds. The great people of this city hold dear to our old customs and are familiar with some prophecies, am I wrong?” His gaze fixates on the well-dressed Governor.

With a small chuckle the Governor opens his mouth, “You noticed the lack of banners present in the town square, I would guess you are accustomed to the other cities then?” the man gives a small shake of his head, he points towards the large statue behind him, “Many of the families of this city draw lineage back to his Kingdom. We adhere to the traditions of old, and our Gods do not change with the fool upon a throne leagues away. It seems all we need is some fool who is strong enough to call the wretch out for her inadequacies; perhaps you are him. Now come this way, we’ll talk in the keep of this magnificent city.” He motions to the guards to be at ease and follow the beautiful cobbled path with mixed blue and grey colours.

While walking, Ulfar makes a point to see and acknowledge as many denizens as possible—all of whom become dazed by the divine beauty of the gem draped across his chest. As the parade of victory ventured, many would come to shake the hand of the man who would be king, introducing themselves and asking simple questions and inquiries from enlistment all the way to the child's questions of legends when seeing the emerald stone, aglow with the ancient light. Once the party approaches the final set of stairs, marked with towering pillars of unyielding flame on either side, they catch sight of a

peculiar figure leaning casually against a stone support beneath the shadow of the overhanging keep.

He wore a cloaked robe of deep sky blue and shimmering turquoise, its fabric flowing like water in the breeze, catching the light of the ever-burning flames. Upon closer inspection, the robes are woven with threads of silver and glimmering threads of starlight, forming intricate patterns of constellations and swirling sigils that seem almost to move, as if the very stars were stitched into the cloth and their dance across the heavens had not yet ceased. The hems of his garments brush the ground, trailing softly over the ancient stones, each step whispering of ages long past.

In his hand, he grasps a staff—long and gnarled—crafted from a pine trunk stained dark as the forest's depths, yet polished by centuries of use until it shone with a deep, rich lustre. Spirals of runes climb up its length, ancient symbols that pulse faintly with a power as old as the city, or rather, the mountains themselves. Atop the staff sits a gem, a crystal of cerulean hue, glowing with a dim yet steady light, as if a piece of the twilight sky had been captured and trapped within its facets, forever caught between midday and night.

The wizard's hood lay loose upon his shoulders, revealing a face marked by time and wisdom—sharp, aquiline features with high cheekbones, and eyes the colour of amber, burning with an inner fire that seemed to pierce through the darkness. His hair, silver as moonlight upon a winter's lake, falls in wild, unkempt waves to his shoulders, catching the faintest glimmers of the ever-flickering flames with a bear of a short length with the same properties. A soft smile plays on his lips, wry and knowing, as if he had witnessed the rise and fall of empires, as if the secrets of both earth and sky were but a well-thumbed tome to his mind.

There was a power about him, woven into his very presence—a latent energy, humming softly in the air, like the distant rumble of a thunderstorm on the edge of hearing. Yet with

this power, there is a quiet patience, the air of one who has seen the turning of ages and knows that even time itself cannot hurry him. As Ulfar approaches this figure, he cuts in and follows into the keep as if he were there the entire time.

The Governor, who was unfazed by the presence of the nameless man, chuckles and then says, “I see you have come to join us a little late, my dear friend.”

With a deep cough reminiscent of a man who battled a tobacco addiction for centuries, he pulls out a pipe, taking a final hit, followed by a deep clearing of his throat for a final time. He smiles widely, showing through his short but thick beard. Waves his tongue across his drying lips, he lets out in a voice seeming as mysterious and ancient as the world, “I have arrived precisely when fate meant, dear friend.”

With a cough, he lights his long birch pipe once more. With a few ring puffs emerging from his pipe, he takes his gaze towards Ulfar, who seems puzzled by the mere presence of this cloaked man. The man's eye was drawn to the glistening ring upon his right middle finger, one which irradiated power with unmatched intensity. He knew it from somewhere, yet he could not place the memory; it was soft in his mind like bread trying to soak up the last drops of butter from a knife. For the life of Ulfar, he could not place this man who was so vivid in his memory, the ring, the staff, the cloak, the beard, the aura, all of it was so familiar.

The locking of the eyes prompts the inquiry of the young Valkorian, “What are you, some magician or something?”

A loud cackle comes from both the Governor and the mysterious figure, removing the pipe from his mouth, the figure's eyes grow wide with excitement. With a bemused glint in his amber eyes, the wizard straightened, leaning more heavily on his pine staff, as if pondering the question's simplicity.

His voice, deep and edged with a touch of dry amusement, filled the air, carrying an ancient cadence that seemed to roll like distant thunder, “A *magician*, you say? Oh,

no, lad, I am no mere conjurer of parlour tricks and petty illusions. I weave the threads of the world's old songs, stir the slumbering breath of mountains, and speak the words that turn the very air to flame. When the stars themselves were young, I learned their dance, and you would call me a magician? A generous title for those who pull rabbits from hats, but I fear I am something... rather older, and rather less entertaining.”

He paused, a faint, knowing smile curling at the edge of his lips, eyes gleaming with the hint of a challenge. “But if it's entertainment you seek, I suppose I could always make you *disappear*.” He fills the air with a deep belly-filled chuckle, “To you, Ulfar Val, I am the wizard who goes by the name Travers Aramir. But most simply refer to me as Travers the Wise or as you in your youth knew me as simply Aramir.” His eyes grow wide and enlightened upon saying his name.

With a daze of puzzlement encapsulating the young lord, Ulfar takes more than just a handful of seconds to process what was just said, sticking especially upon the last part of his sentence. After what seemed to be quite laborious thought, Ulfar addresses the wizard again, “It's you, Aramir, the name rings in the long forgotten memories of my youth, I have heard it more than once over.”

His eyes pierce directly into the ageing eyes of the old fool, then he grows a childish grin, one of old memories of playing in the warm summer sun and swimming in the pond—of stressless life, pure and innocent before the toils of life and war emerged. The smile takes control of his body, becoming more than just a facial gesture but something of a euphoria across his body. He drops the sheathed blade from his hand as Arenith rings an echoed tone throughout the space he dances in, but a few paces to Aramir, wrapping him in a tight hug—built of memories from days long ago.

The hug spanned the course of many instances while he sought to make up for lost time and his botched memory. From the mouth of Ulfar comes some words, “I hadn't even realised it

was you, old friend! Oh, how I have missed you. It has been what? Well over a decade since I last saw you?”

With a chuckle, Aramir flicks up Ulfar's sword for him to catch, the blade spinning in the air before the young lord catches it with ease. He begins to walk deeper into the keep of the city, his staff still tapping rhythmically against the polished stone. He glances back over his shoulder, offering Ulfar a wry smile as he answers the young man's previous question, “Well, you're what now? Encroaching upon your sixties?”

Ulfar rolls his eyes as he ties the sheath of his blade back to the ash-coloured girdle around his waist. “Don't paint me as that old yet—I am now just fifty-seven. Yet, old man, you have not changed a day in decades.”

The click of the wooden staff adds a mesmerising tone as they walk through the beautiful main hall of Vingólf. Each tap echoes through the grand space, mingling with the distant murmur of wind outside, as if marking time to a long-forgotten melody. Blue and gold stained glass windows cast a soothing, yet powerful light across the intricate mosaic floor, each beam painting shifting patterns of sapphire and gold that move with the rising sun. The air is cool, carrying with it the faint scent of ancient incense, mingling with the memories of countless stories whispered within these halls.

Aramir lets out a deep laugh, the sound resonating warmly in the vast hall, mixing with the coloured light that dances around them like spirits of the past. He pauses to gaze at the stained glass, the blue and gold reflections casting a glow upon his weathered face. “Ah, but time has a way of slipping through our fingers, doesn't it? It makes us hold dear what is important to us and what we love most.” He muses, his voice carrying a note of sadness beneath the humour, as if aware that this moment, too, would soon become another memory.

Ulfar nods, the laughter fading as he follows his old friend's gaze to the glowing stained glass that shows this elegant image of a red-haired elf kneeling before the world. Ulfar knew

this image, and Aramir knew it, for that is why he drew him to glance it once more. The image was of Káerielle, she who had many names amongst the free peoples of the world.

With a short pause, the Governor chimed in, “The Lady Drau, she is said to be many things, yet this is the only image I’ve ever seen of her with ears of point and hair of crimson. I believe she is of the Blood Elves, the Veileiar.” The words etched in Ulfar’s mind, he looked, but no words came from his mouth.

Ulfar’s eyes could not look away. The colours of each glass shard which composed this mosaic captivated him, glowing like fire trapped in crystal—red as blood freshly spilt, gold as the sun on its last descent, and black as the silent sky before a storm. She stood immortalised in glass: wings veined with obsidian, hair flowing like rivers of flame, and eyes fixed forward with the calm fury of one born for judgment. The gem-stone armour clung to her like divine sinew, and behind her head a golden halo of etched suns crowned her in eerie reverence. To look upon her was to feel both awe and sorrow—like beholding the wrath of heaven poised in silence.

Aramir grinned as the young man pondered, “You know this image well—this tale, this sorrow, this truth—for it is no idle myth, but the very saga of the world. In the grey morning of the First Era, when memory was still young, there lived one whom many hold to be the greatest of all Elven craftsmen: Frenar, the Glasswright of the West. He forged five such mosaics, each bearing the same tale, yet each touched by the frailties and failings of the world in which they were wrought.”

Travers pauses for a brief moment to catch his own breath. His eyes appeared to be deeper than the night sky itself as he looked not at Ulfar but the mosaic, “You have heard it called Frenar’s Mosaic, or The Fleeting of the Elves. It speaks of time, and how even for the Firstborn, time runs swift as mountain streams to the sea. Though their years stretch far beyond the reckoning of men, even those who are immortal feel time slip through their fingers like starlight fading before the dawn. It tells

how the Elves must soon depart from these mortal lands, and return beyond the circles of the world—to the Land of Duiné, where silver shores break softly upon the light, and evil finds no haven.”

He paused then again, his gaze weighted now down back to Ulfar, which the force of ages long forgotten, “Yet know this also: Frenar did not fashion these windows as mere records. No—he sought, in his grief and wisdom, to forestall the very doom he had seen. It was said he attempted to forge a light, a wonder, a thing of great power—the Luminarí—to halt the tale written in his glass. But the world is not so easily unmade, nor fate so simply unbound, is it?”

“No... no, it is not,” he says softly, feeling the weight of the years that had passed between them. But for this brief moment, in the company of an old friend, time seemed to slow, and the echoes of their shared past filled the quiet spaces between the beats of Aramir’s staff on the floor. With each step, they get closer to the throne of a long-dead kingdom, a masterpiece of ancient craftsmanship which their eyes had now turned to. It was imposing yet elegant, carved from a single slab of dark obsidian that gleams like polished night. The high back curves upward, flaring into intricate, twisting designs that mimic the graceful flow of tree roots entwining into runic symbols, with veins of gold inlaid to form celestial patterns that shimmer in the light streaming through stained glass windows above.

Its armrests are adomed with delicate carvings of mythical creatures—serpents, gryphons, and great eagles—locked in a dance of eternity, their expressions fierce and noble. The base is encircled with bands of silvery metals, adding an otherworldly glow to the shadowy seat, while a deep-blue gem, the size of a man’s fist, is embedded at the centre of the throne’s back, casting an ethereal glow that pulses like a living heartbeat, filling the hall with a subtle hum of magic. A plush cushion of deep sapphire velvet rests upon the seat, embroidered with golden threads that form a design mirroring

the night sky—constellations and ancient runes said to grant wisdom to those who rule. Yet, despite all its splendour, the throne exudes an air of cold authority, as if the weight of countless kings and queens who have sat upon it still lingers, pressing down upon whoever dares to claim its seat. It is not just a place of comfort, but a symbol of power—a throne meant to be wielded, not simply occupied.

The lord of the city then again addresses Ulfar, “You have taken this city, and as you have seen, we are more than willing to throw our lot behind someone of the likes of you rather than most others. For various reasons, such as the sword upon your hip, the pendant you wear, for the sake of the Gods, even the two lieutenants who took this city. A marked man and an elf, a kin who does little in the world today.”

With a stem look, Aramir steps away from Ulfar, standing more between the two parties. He makes a guttural sound, clearing his throat before speaking, “Indeed, a shadow stirs in the far reaches of the lands, in the deep and forgotten crags of Pharolax, where the sun itself dares not linger. Even here, upon these humble shores of Onu-Arith, a darkness most profound has taken root—one that I have not sensed since the very dawn of my days. Whispers travel like restless winds through the ancient trees, mumuring of a dark sorcerer dwelling within the southeastern mountains, one whose power is like a blackened flame that burns without end. His presence is not mere shadow, but a force that thrums with an ancient malice, a power this world has glimpsed only in the bleakest corners of its history. The name of a dark lord—old, far older than any living man upon these lands—lingers on the wind like a forgotten curse, stirring the bones of the earth itself.”

The countenances of the surrounding men grew in dread with each word, for they knew the tales of old, yet to them it was nothing more than mere folklore and bedtime tales. They could see in the eyes of the old wizard truth in his words, tales such as the War of Vengeance, the tale of the Alundél, Káerielle's Duel in

the Void, Frenar's Stones, and countless others which spanned the days of centuries lost past.

The old man gives a pause to his voice as he watches those around him ponder over his words, as if to, in mere moments, discern the truths of the world. After a thoughtful drag of his pipe, his eyes meet theirs again, "Yet do not discount the elves, for though their time wanes like the twilight fading from the sky, a spark of their ancient strength yet burns. They are still formidable, their hearts bound to the ancient roots of this world. But the time of the elves is passing, as all things must, and the dawn of man now approaches on swift wings; this time has shown that man must take the place of the elves. It is in the hands of men that the future shall be forged, for the age is rising, and with it, new hopes and new perils. Still, the elves shall not abandon the world lightly, not while a breath remains in their breasts or a glimmer of starlight lingers in their eyes."

The entire hall seemed to hold its breath, as if the very air was caught in the gravity of Travers Aramir's words. Soldiers, their battle-hardened faces now softened by a rare unease, shifted their weight uneasily beneath the wizard's grim proclamation. Servants who had tended to the fires and polished the brass fixtures now stood still as statues, hands hovering above their work, each of them captivated by the foreboding message that echoed through the stone chamber.

Shadows flickered and danced along the walls, cast by the crackling torches, as if the very flames were trembling before some unseen chill. The wizard's voice, ancient as the deep roots of mountains, lingered in the air, and for a moment, a silence settled—a silence heavy with unspoken fears. Amidst this stillness, Ulfar's brow furrowed in deep thought, the weight of his own understanding pressing upon him. He was no stranger to tales of old, to legends and whispers that spoke of the world's darker past. He alone, perhaps, among the assembled, dared to meet the wizard's gaze—an intense and watchful look that seemed to pierce through Aramir's ageless façade.

Breaking the silence, Ulfar spoke, his voice steady but edged with uncertainty. “You speak of Malachar.” His words are like a blade cutting through the thick tension. “But he is dead, long since vanquished and banished to the void, chained like his master. A bound ghost cannot rule the world, can he?”

His question lingered in the air, a challenge to the old lore, and a sliver of doubt crept into the hearts of those listening. Could it truly be that a shadow from a time thought buried could reach out and shape the present world? Few dared to think of who else this shadow could be, the one who came before—the first Master of Darkness. Ulfar's face, though resolute, betrayed the glimmer of unease, and as the echo of his query faded among the ancient stonework, all eyes turned back to Aramir, seeking answers that lay beyond the mortality of most.

With a deepened belly laugh, Aramir shakes his head, his bear waving in a delay behind him—he took a bountiful huff of his pipe. Then, after an exhale, the smoke takes the form of an intricate ring. With post haste and a curt tone, he gives a response, “You may be of a higher intellect, young Ulfar, but did you see the dead corpse of Malachar? Was it you who laid the final blow? Did you see the binding of him?”

Taking a harsher breath of his pipe, the smoke dances through the hair decorating his face through the dated nostrils of the man. Calming himself, he finishes his response to Ulfar, “The wiser figures of this world are entirely unsure if the Dark Lord took to the grave. But what we are sure of is that the evil of this world is infinite, as is the good, and all we must ask is that the simple gestures of kindness and love always outweigh the dark deeds of this world.”

The attention of the room turns away from the magic caster as the governor of the city clears his throat deeply, and he then calls all to attention. He poses one simple question to the young man, “Tell me if my only request of you is nothing but a simple mark that a man of honour rests upon that throne again, and that this city is given its due that it has not seen since the

First Era, would you do such as a king?" With a gesture to the empty throne before them, a slight tilt of the man's head occurs.

Ulfar takes a few steps, encompassing the distance of half the room, and he comes to rest his hand upon the aged throne. He runs his hands across the cracking, dry stone, scrapes across the calloused hands, his eyes fixated on the blue heart-stone that beats like a heart with nature.

A small crease of a grin comes across the face of the young man, simply responding with, "I will."

His two words seemed to echo throughout the hollowed chamber as all who stood witness reckoned he had now a full decree of not only his lordship but the winds of change were upon the world of man; he who would be king had now declared it through more than just a letter.

With a final thought, Ulfar turns to the Governor and Aramir, "It will be the capital of this kingdom we forge in these far lands."

Chapter 8

Darkness Ever Watching

The fair elvish lady known to many mortals by the name Fiona set forth, commanded on her quest by Anne, though she lacked all but the road upon which the late knight travelled delivering the message. The main road of the realm, which spanned the course of the entire continent, she was utterly puzzled by how a single man could go missing on such a road with heavy traffic, but for money, she was willing to humour the foul Queen of this realm—even she knew that this horrid woman was nothing eternal. With each click of the horse's hoof, she scanned for the slightest of clues, for anything on this knight, but nothing was seen. Until her gaze caught the glimmering red of a flower by the side of the cobblestone road, she nearly overlooked its elegance.

There, nestled between the cracks of old, weathered stones, stood the red spider lily—a bloom of such striking beauty that it seemed almost otherworldly. Its slender, crimson petals curled delicately like threads of silk, arching outwards from a golden heart. The flowers swayed gently in the breeze, their vibrant hue standing out against the dull, greying stones. Once, long ago, this flower had held a place of reverence within Old Valkoria, serving as a partial symbol of its glory, strength, and beauty—a reminder of the fleeting nature of power, and the enduring elegance that can bloom even from the cracks of ruin. Now, it stood as a lone sentinel, its bold red hues offering a

small, poignant tribute to a time lost to history. Just beyond the immaculate flower, she spotted a tree and with it a horse tied to a watering hole, yet no rider nor master to be found.

She dismounted the simple thoroughbred steed she rode across the plains, the horse exhaling through a slight restless grunt as she waved her hand, motioning for the horse to stay in place. An ominous air overtook the space; it encapsulated the elf as the sliver of moonlight escaped the cover of the clouds, casting a silvery glow across the barren scape. The elf removed her hood, revealing a striking visage—her skin a deep blend of blue and light brown, merging into a lavender hue that seemed to drink in the moonlight.

Her eyes, a fiery red flecked with shards of vivid purple, glowed with an otherworldly intensity, like embers caught in a midnight storm. Flowing down from her head, her hair spilled like a cascade of pure snow, catching the faint light and giving off a subtle, ethereal glimmer. Her ears, sharp and pointed like finely crafted daggers, framed her face, lending her an air of both elegance and danger. In the moonlight, she seemed a spectral figure—both a haunting presence and a vision of cold, unearthly beauty.

She approached the restless horse, its muscles twitching as it shifted in place, hooves stamping hard against the scattered stones that covered the ground. The creature grunted, its breath fogging the cool night air, ears twitching as if catching whispers carried by the wind. She reached out with a gentle hand, her touch as soft as morning dew, running her fingers through the coarse fur of its neck.

“Hm, what makes you so restless, dear horse?” Her hand moved in slow, calming strokes, fingers trailing through the short, bristly mane as her gaze caught a glint—a flash of steel that shimmered under the pale glow of the moon.

Curiosity piqued, she reached out and grasped the dagger hidden beneath the harness, its crescent-shaped blade reflecting the deep, iridescent blue of the night sky. With a fluid motion,

she sliced through the bindings that held the horse captive, freeing it with a swift slap to its flank. The horse bolted into the night, hooves pounding against the earth, vanishing into the shadows between trees.

She turned her attention to the glimmering object that had caught her eye and scurried over, crouching low to investigate. There, half-buried in the dirt, lay the body of a fallen knight. His armour, once polished to a shine, now bore the scars of battle—deep dents and a fatal slice that cut clean through the steel, marking the wound that had ended his life. His right hand still clasped the hilt of his sword, knuckles stiffened in death's grip, while a weathered leather satchel was draped across his chest, stained with dried blood. She leaned closer, eyes narrowing as she pulled a jagged shard from the gash in his abdomen. At first, it appeared as little more than a broken piece of metal, but as she turned it in her hands, its rough, earthy hue and irregular shape stirred a distant recognition in her. This was no common steel—it held a rugged, ancient character, forged from memories she had long tried to bury.

The memories washed over her like a tide, pulling her back to her past—a time when she had known weapons of this forging all too well. These rustic, twisted blades, their edges sharp and unrefined, had been seared into her memory from childhood. She was no child of the gleaming Vampir cities or the lofty canopy homes of the Velmar. No, she had come from the shadowed alleys and towering spires of the Vaidir, the dark elves, born not of the natural world but from the tainted touch of Valkar himself.

She had lived in the once-great city of Courdell during the dawn of the Second Era, the adopted daughter of humble parents, her early years filled with the beauty and grandeur of the city's elegant arches and winding streets. But that all came to an end during the crusade of Malachar. The second Dark Lord's shadow fell over Onu-Derith, and Courdell was razed in blood and fire, its streets turned to rivers of ash. The memory of that

fire—of the screams and the black smoke blotting out the sun—had seared the shape of this blade deep into her mind.

Now, as she stared down at the dagger in her hand, she recognised it for what it was. This was not the work of men, nor the craftsmanship of elves or dwarves. It bore the signature of darkness itself—of the orcs, creatures bred in shadow and hatred, their weapons as twisted and brutal as their hearts. The very sight of it sent a chill through her bones, as if the cold breath of that long-lost past had returned to brush against her skin.

Her eyes focused, locked upon the jagged shape, and words came from deep within her breast, “Orcs this far from the lands of darkness? For why would such vile creations set foot on the bloodied lands of man?” She moves with haste, seeing the prints of the beast who carried the foul creature, they pointed to the southwest, leading far beyond the Parcival, “Could it be, the old ruins in the Sandurin Peaks? They have not held the forces of good nor evil since the times of the Hykellion Kingdom.” She approaches the prints of the creature for many seconds as she gazes at the larger paws and claws that have become one with the earth.

She whistles a call to her mount, which trots over towards her, as the sounds of hooves echo across the empty plains, a soldier of the realm sent to find her. He calls out, “Are you the fair lady Fiona?”

Rolling her eyes in annoyance at the approaching mortal burden, she retorts, “Oh, as if I wish I were not such.”

In pure confusion, the man questions her again, “Apologies, ma'am, but I must know by order of the Queen, are you the lady Fiona?”

She utters a quirky chuckle, “Some refer to me as that, only mortals who shall not see the first wrinkle upon my face. But others call me by my name, which is not uttered by the lips of fools of your sort, Taelmíra.”

Angered and confused by her lack of concise response, he says, “Um... Okay, I shall assume you are her, as you fit her

description and all. The fair Queen has ordered you to return to her; your mission is no more, and you are needed for other duties.”

She huffs then walks towards the staunch man who sits with a looming sense of arrogance, she pulls the dagger of the orc to his neck then says, “Either I am given my time or you shall join your fellow fool on the ground suffering the same fate, to be eaten by dogs. Take his body back to the city and present your liege with her message.”

The response and immediate threat caused the knight to stumble back, ripping away with neither words nor sounds, saddling his horse and beginning to ride north towards the walls of Valkoria once again. The trotting clicks and clacks of the hooves on the cobbled road echo off into the deep dark distance as the shine of his steel plates becomes nothing more than a shadow in the moonlight. With that, she returns to investigating the tracks of the creatures; the question she dared not answer was, what had left them.

Internally, she knew the creatures were no wolf, nor dire wolf, but something much bigger, as it clearly was the mount on which the servant of evil had arrived upon. As she dreaded, the tracks were clear; they came and went in a perfect loop, doubling back to the same place. She saddles the horse, which was quite hesitant to follow the tracks that diverged from the cobbled path, for even that simple creature knew of what lay in the wilderness, and those who did not have their own means of defence should dare not tread. The ground, still soft, left a trail of horse hooves as a simple path for whoever dared to follow her.

The trail stretched out endlessly before her, a narrow scar through the empty plains, where the earth seemed to hold its breath under the silver light of the moon. The barren landscape lay silent, save for the shrill, soft gusts of wind that whispered against the dried grasses, carrying with them a chill that crept into her bones. Each step was a reminder of the emptiness that

surrounded her, a solitude so profound that it swallowed the sound of her own breathing.

She moved like a shadow through the darkness, the stars above casting a faint, cold glow upon the ground, revealing the faint tracks of the creature she pursued. Her heart pounded beneath her cloak, each beat a nervous drum in the stillness of the night, and deep within, she dreaded what awaited her at the farthest reaches of this forsaken path. The moon cast strange shapes across the plains, the undulating terrain taking on twisted forms that seemed to leer and shift at the corner of her vision.

Her mind was haunted by the vivid nightmares that had plagued her youth, visions of twisted shadows and eyes that gleamed with malice, and those fears now resurfaced with every step she took. The trees that loomed at the edge of her sight rustled softly in the wind, their skeletal branches reaching out like black claws against the night sky. Each sound sent a jolt through her, the snapping of a twig or the murmur of leaves feeling like whispers from unseen watchers. The darkness seemed to close in around her, turning the world into a vast, empty void where time lost all meaning. Yet, she pressed on, following the fading footprints, knowing that whatever awaited her at the end of this path might be far worse than the fear that gripped her now.

As the hours passed and she came across the sudden change in terrain, which signified that she had reached the beginning of what the humans called Peter's rest, which was but a few leagues to the west of the Parcival, there was a jagged outcropping in the stone of the plateau to which the tracks led directly. Dismounting, she investigated further to find a scattering of bones across the ground; some were clearly gnawed by teeth much bigger than anything she had ever seen. With each small clue, she was drawn only deeper into the memories of her youth, the screams of those who raised her as the savages slaughtered all they saw.

The tattered bones only fueled the fires she had ignited deep within to find these savages that had come to the land of men. She alone knew the power of the slaves of darkness, and she never thought she would see their like this far from the lands of Pharolax. She again reacquired the trail which simply walked parallel with the mountains guarding the coast, though she knew in many miles that would end and a final stretch of trails would begin, though this time she noticed a second set of tracks different from the ones she had followed up to this point, larger and the claws more jagged the simple idea of more than one sent chills down her spine. This hastened her pace while she kept watch with her great vision, only slowing to hear the noises of nature which each creak and break of a twig brought her to full guard.

The mountains to her right varied in size and shape, their jagged silhouettes rising and falling like the teeth of some ancient beast. Some peaks were bare and sharp-edged, their stone faces like razors against the sky, while others curved gently, draped in wild grasses and patches of moss. A few blended the two, rugged stone softened by tufts of green, but none offered much in the way of cover. As the range tapered off into a gentle slope, she spotted the faint glow of cooling embers nestled among the rocks—signs that something, or someone, had been here recently. She swiftly dismounted her horse, leading it to a concealed spot behind a cluster of boulders, then crouched low, creeping toward the remnants of the camp. Her boots barely made a sound as she slid down a rocky incline, approaching the fire's remains.

The camp seemed deserted, though not for long—the embers still pulsed with a faint, amber glow, like the heartbeat of a dying star. Scattered bones littered the ground, remnants of animals that had met their fate here, and she counted nearly a dozen sets of tracks in the dust. A knot of doubt tightened in her chest—deep down, she questioned whether this pursuit was truly worth the risk. Just then, a distant howl pierced the night,

followed by the low rumble of guttural speech. The sound cut through the wind, reaching her ears with a clarity as sharp as ice on a moonlit night.

The creature's voice carried a sinister tone, uttering a phrase in a harsh, clashing tongue: “Zhar arkanul er elenkath irkal un naz veriax.”

The unfamiliar words grated against the air, sending a chill through her, the fear crawling along her spine like a shadow that refused to be banished. But one word rang within her head, *elenkath*, a single word she heard echoed within her mind, the word meant elf in the dark language of Valkar.

She stood frozen in fear, her breath caught in her chest as she drew her elongated blade, bracing herself for the beast lurking above to make its move. Its reflection shimmered ominously in a small puddle of rainwater before her, a dark, distorted vision of nightmares. The creature's eyes, twin points of burning crimson, pierced through the night like embers in a void. Behind them loomed the shadowy silhouette of a hulking wolf, its frame blending seamlessly with the darkness, holding captive a creature far more horrifying.

Its skin was a sickly olive green, marred with scars that crisscrossed like ancient maps, each marking a tale of battles fought and blood spilt over centuries. Its face twisted into a grotesque snarl, with teeth like jagged knives protruding from cracked lips—tools built for tearing flesh. The creature's torso swelled with unnatural size, its sheer bulk dwarfing that of any man. Its limbs bulged with muscle, each sinew and vein straining beneath the skin, the power within rippling even through the hazy reflection in the water. The creature's armour was a patchwork of jagged metal plates, fitted together with a crude but cunning design that allowed for swift movement—well-suited for his kin, the Hundabald Orcs, native to the rugged Hundabald Mountains of southern Arkámëndrón. It clung to his form like a second skin, offering both protection and freedom as he prowled the night, a perfect predator born of shadow and steel.

These were no ordinary Orcs; they were a breed that Taelmíra knew all too well, for they were the mightiest and most ruthless among the Orc clans of Varis Mogul. These beings descended from the ancient Ugha-alé, a savage lineage that had abandoned the war-torn lands of Phrolax after the fall of the First Era. To face them was to face the very shadows of history, for these were the same orcs once wielded as weapons by the Dark Lord Malachar—a name that still whispered through the darkened halls of time, a terror that echoed across generations. Even in death, the Dark Lord's influence lingered, threading through the remnants of his enslaved armies, his twisted creations, and the unrelenting carnage he had left behind.

Taelmíra's breathing quickened, her heart racing as the reflection of the orc wavered in the puddle, its movements slight but filled with lethal intent. Her gaze sharpened, honing in on the hulking creature as it threw back its head and released a guttural howl—a sound that cut through the night like a blade. Moments later, a distant, haunting response drifted back, carried on the wind from unseen allies. Beside the orc stood a creature that loomed out of nightmares, a twisted echo of a dire wolf, though far larger, its silhouette draped in shadows that seemed to bleed into the darkness around it. Wisps of an inky, dark mist curled and twisted from its body, dissipating into the cool night air.

This was no ordinary beast, but a creature of legend—one known to all who dared meet its gaze: the Shadowbeast or *Sargór* to some, bred from the Void and reared alongside these Orcs not as pets, but as battle-bonded companions, their loyalty forged in blood and violence over many years. The creature was neither entirely a dire wolf ridden by Men nor a Warg wielded by Goblins, but a new entity altogether, its massive frame dwarfing that of any natural predator.

Thick muscles rippled beneath its coarse, shadowy fur, straining against the thin, dark armour that clung to its body like a shell. Even through the dim light, the striations of its powerful

limbs were visible, coiling with strength and tension as if the beast itself were a living weapon, ready to be unleashed upon any who dared to oppose it.

With a few breaths, she gazed upon the reflection and saw the hundabald orc mount his shadowbeast, turning away and riding off over the hills. She sighs in pure relief as if the weight of the world had been removed from her breast, her lungs fill with a great breath, with care she stands as she exhales grasping her sword creeping towards the trail leading south-west towards the Sandurin Peaks, she knew there was but a single place these creatures could have come from, the ruins of Zhal Durath the ancient outpost of the First Era.

Her voice broke the silence of the air, “I must see this darkness for myself; only then will I make my next decision.”

Courage flows across the mind of the elf as she moves, collecting her horse and seeding along to the south, placing greater distance between her and the mountains to avoid the travelling orc riders. Alone, she did think that the orcs' mere presence alone was enough to confirm the rumours of a darkness stirring were all but true. She knew herself; she had to see the visage that was talked about as the sorcerer. Could it truly be the Dark Lord of her past?

The night progressed as her horse grew tired and the path to the ruins up in the mountains came into view. She came to see a shadow, like a void that was the absence of all light, pure utter darkness—evil. Within the dark void came the glow of two eyes, burned within her memory; she had known them before, yet they were new to her mind.

A voice echoed within her mind, “Elenkath, Elf, Unthrel altek thrakel hedar en naz shadows. Thrakel narakana hedar frar merak!” The voice seemed to echo with an intense darkness; the words all but one had no meaning to her. She was completely bewildered by the language; she knew it to be that of the Orcs, yet this was no mere Orc who uttered these words, but that of something darker than any corrupted creature of Valkar.

She felt that echo, that presence deep within her mind, only twice prior, in her youth, she had visited the natural Arcadian city of Vivik, when she had simply walked by the fairest of all the Elven Queens, Dramira, caught her in her glance and spoke words in the same facet to her. The second time was just before the Flight of Dremor, she had a short audience with the elders of the city, meeting the fair maiden Auréa. This third person brought great confusion to the young maiden who had almost forgotten she was concealed within the ruins of Zhal Durath.

Abruptly, she jumped up as the simple idea the shadowy figure spoke to her and vocalised, “I need to get out of here.”

She began to run from the ruins of the once great fortress. As she ran, the vines and old cracks of the ailing structure tripped her up quite a few times. Her simple run became something more of a sprint as she heard the howls of the Shadowbeasts above, but it was not the howls of the living that struck her with fear, but the echoes of something long ago, neither living nor dead, but of the spirit realm itself. She had briefly thought that if she were a mortal, the screams alone could have brought her to death; she had heard the ancient legends of the poor fools who bent the knee to Valkar in the First Era, but she did not believe them—until now.

From above her came a shriek, deafening and chilling at the same time. All that came to her mind was the stories of children—scaring tales of those who once were mortals of the flesh of man. The shriek was followed by a figure as dark as the blackest of nights coming down upon her, its jagged blade barely missing, taking a few hairs of hers along with it and sending a yellow spark into the night air. Her breathing came to be frantic as she did everything to get away from the phantom.

Though it followed her, she yelled out as she left the ruins, “Begone!” Nothing more than a single word, and the wraith was gone, only just a memory to her now.

Though the strident call of the creature, and the overwhelming sense of dread which surrounded it, stayed within her mind, she had seen what darkness now lay in wait on the land of man.

A deep sense of unease swept across the lady elf as she spoke aloud, “A great darkness is but a mere understatement. I know those eyes that gazed deep within my soul. That is no meagre sorcerer nor necromancer.” She paused for a brief second as she made haste to her horse, “But it is *him*, *he* who was slain. It could not be such, though, how could *he* come back?” Her words were nothing but empty in the open night air, a futile attempt to find some consolation in speaking to who might hear.

She steadied the horse, which was filled with nothing but pure unrest, as she made her way towards the Parcival, which was the closest of any settlement in which she would feel the comfort of safety from which she had just seen. It came across her mind that none in the imperium would believe any of what she would recall from this night's travels for the first time in nearly a decade since she arrived on the continent; she wondered if there was but a better option for whom she could turn to on such matters.

She knew that if she rode south, she might come to meet the rebel leader. She wondered if he would find better use in the knowledge she had now of the ruins of Zhal Durath? She did know one thing: the supposed Queen Anne would do nothing but dismiss her. This question plagued the elf who danced over the ideas of finding the lord's road and following it south to Vingólf, for even she knew that Ulfar Stromfang's eyes must have been laid upon that city.

She perhaps wonders a query of much deeper thought: could the wizard known as Travers Aramir be with the young human? Could he be of some help against the amassing darkness in the mountains? Or rather, did the wizard know and have some sort of use for the men of this world to fight the growing evil?

She feared nothing more than for the darkness to be let a foothold in this world and ravage not just the land of elves but the world of man once again; that fear to her was reminiscent of what she felt when the void called out to her and the mere presence of that ghostly figure. Though deep down it was not the voice that troubled her but the presence of those who had lost their peace, the Nirinathé, or rather the poor souls who fell to the false promises of Valkar during the First Era, forever bound to the world of living and of the dead, servants who only sought the Gem of Life—Alundél.

She had decided to ride to the city of Deidara and await her fateful encounter with the Stormfangs and their leader. Her ride would be nearly cut in half and be something much more relaxing as she could focus on placing distance between her and the ruins filled with the darkness. Her ride was swift, yet it was quite the opposite for each step of the horse; it was like the pounding of a thousand drums, the thunderous trot was rather quite contrary melodic, much more ominous and only brought about a fear that had dawned in the ruins she had experienced. She looked over her shoulder and waited for the Shadowbeasts to strike in silence.

The sight of the vast wooden walls and soft orange glow coming from the city did provide Taelmíra with a comfort she had not known in many hours; her eyes seemed to water at the mere sight of pure peace. As the horse galloped towards the gate, she muttered to herself, “Now comes my greatest decision.”

Coming to the gate of the city of Deidara, a guard of the city calls down to the lady elf, “Why does an Elf come to the oaken city?”

With a small huff, she rolls her eyes and, first under her breath, says, “Why do humans always question?” Then she says with a grander voice, “I am here on a quest by the queen. I simply search for lodging and a place to gather my findings!”

With great hesitation, the guard moves to open the gates of the city. The hesitation of the man gave more clues to

Taelmíra; she wondered if the pure hesitation drew back to the creatures of the night that had roamed this continent. As the gates creaked that drew upon with the clink of the great chains holding it, the gate pulled upwards, opening the main road of the city, which she followed until she came to the tavern known as the *Midnight's Rider*. As she entered, her vastly different appearance compared to many humans brought her great stares from the man-dominated tavern. An ugly, potent smell of the drunkards and vile gamblers filled the air, though a sweet and enticing smell of a single burning wooden pipe came to the powerful nose of the Elf, drawing her gaze to its point of origin.

There lay a shrouded man, he seemed to be reminiscent of a *Watcher* of the ancient kingdom, the armour donned on the man was hidden by his cloak, but her eyes knew the ancient Cross of Valkoria when her eyes caught it. Though it was patchy and lacked the completeness it had once had, the armour was still forged with the manoeuvrability that a true watcher would need out in the wild.

The man had a soft beard and was rugged as one who's seen the atrocities of this world. The golden trim of each plate had long been lost to the wear of time, though some flakes still glimmered. The steel itself had lost the glistening tone of white that once encased the unique armour, now nothing more than shades of grey, looking more like a beaten and long-worn steel. Her biggest question was how a watcher of an order which had not existed in well over five thousand years?

She continued to the bar where she would sit and await whatever her next move would be, as the head of the city guard approached her, who simply questioned, "Have you a report for the Queen?"

She knows this shall fall on the deafest of all ears; she only utters a single word as a pint of mead is handed to her, "Orcs." She follows with a large gulp of the poor alcohol, she winces with the sour taste, something even after many years of frequenting a tavern, she has yet to become accustomed to.

The single word confuses the man, who looks in complete disbelief, doubting her. He says, “What proof do you have, Elf?” He places his hand upon her shoulder in a poor attempt to place some sort of authority above her, which does nothing but throw her into a ferocious anger.

Her face grew from the shades of lavender with touches of brown hues to a more amber tone as the red of anger swelled upon her round yet sharp cheeks.

Her pupils tightened as the anger came across her eyes, and in an instant, she removed the hand of the mortal, “Then have no belief in my words, your foolish human.” Her tone cut through the air with a pure ferocity like a blade forged at the dawn of innovation from the purest of all Erinstihl.

The guard chuckled in pure doubt before questioning, “You must be joking, there are no Orcs on this land and never shall be. The evils of this world are long gone. I shall send word to the Queen you found nothing.”

She inhaled softly, steadying herself, tempering the rising surge of disbelief brought on by the foolish man's doubt. Her heart, once set on persuading him, shifted unexpectedly—no longer moved by the desire to change his mind. Instead, an unfamiliar emptiness settled within her, a void where guilt should have been, as if some quiet whisper from the depths of her soul reminded her: those who doubted her now would not be the ones to face the ancient evil. It would be others—yet unseen, unknown—whose names had not yet crossed the lips of fate, whose hands had never felt the weight of a sword.

The night came to a close as the howls of savage beasts echoed throughout the plains, the forces of evil had just hatched and taken to the world for there she would lie in wait for the force of Men, her heart knew was coming.

Chapter 9

An Unexpected Fellowship

Now twice the moon had turned its face to the earth, and the banners of the Stormfangs, those who followed Ulfar, fluttered in the cool winds that swept through the ancient city of Vingólf. The city, once a place of hushed conversations and wary glances, now thrummed with a vibrant life as throngs of supporters poured in from every corner. Streets that had known only the echoes of armoured boots now rang with the music of celebration. Parades wove through the cobbled avenues, children laughed, and old men raised their cups in toast to a new dawn. Even the smallest villages beyond Vingólf's walls had declared their allegiance to the young warrior, Ulfar, swelling the hearts of his followers with a sense of hope that had long been absent from these lands.

Within the city's great hall, the throne room basked in the warm glow of the morning sun, streaming through stained glass windows crafted by the hands of ancient artisans. Each pane told a story of forgotten eras, their vibrant hues mingling with the sunlight to cast living murals across the stone floor. The beams of light danced, bringing to life the veins of ethereal magic woven into the very walls, each gemstone inlaid with precision reflecting the light to its neighbour.

It was as if the spirits of old lingered still, infusing the air with an ancient vitality, the heartbeat of the city pulsing

within the marble columns and vaulted ceilings. It felt as though the hall itself was waking, its breath a whisper that mingled with the murmurs of those gathered within.

Ulfar stood with his arms crossed, his gaze sharp as he took in the sight of the unusual delegation standing before him—envoys not only from the city of Lunden but of a mix of beings rarely seen together. Beside him stood the wizard Aramir, draped in his long cloak and pointed hat, with his staff clasped in his hand as a long cane, the lord of the city, and then his trusted two, the female elf Ariendria and the human Dex. Humans made up the bulk of the company, but they did not wear the insignia of the Neirmar Imperium.

Instead, they bore the crest of Lunden, the ancient city that had stood against time's ravages. Among them stood a dwarf, a halfling, and a woman of strange bearing whose presence seemed to draw the eye like the whispered promise of a long-forgotten secret. The human envoys were of average height, yet each had a distinctive air. One carried a sword sheathed at his side, its hilt worn smooth by use; another held a long spear tipped with iron that gleamed like a star fallen to earth; the third clutched a bow, its dark wood adorned with intricate carvings of nature's design. Their eyes, though wary, spoke of a purpose that had brought them far from their homeland, driven by something greater than mere duty.

The halfling, a cheerful and rotund figure, was unmistakably of Dulmir descent. He wore no shoes, his feet covered in a thick mat of curly brown hair that seemed to keep the chill of the cold night at bay. His cheeks were flushed with a rosy hue, and his eyes twinkled with a mischievous glint, as if he carried a joke tucked away in his mind, ready to spring upon the unsuspecting. It was clear that this halfling had rarely, if ever, denied himself the pleasure of a good meal, and the thought of an empty plate seemed as foreign to him as silence to a babbling brook.

Beside him, the dwarf presented a stark contrast. His stocky frame was clad in armour that bore the marks of fine craftsmanship, with runes etched into the plates, glowing faintly with the enchantments of spells long forgotten. Though it lacked the elegance of elven design, the armour spoke of resilience, forged to withstand the crushing maces of orcs and the piercing cold of mountain battles. A thick pelt of fur was draped across his shoulders, adding to his imposing presence, and his beard—braided and adorned with silver clasps—flowed down like a waterfall of steel-grey hair. He stood only a few inches taller than the halfling, but the weight of his presence filled the space. Travers Aramir, the ancient wizard, seemed to recognise him, his eyes narrowing as if recalling old tales.

Yet, it was the woman who captivated the room's attention most. She remained hooded until now, her presence like a shadow that had slipped from the cracks of the world. Her fingers, slender and pale, reached up and slowly pulled back her hood, revealing a face that seemed to exist at the edge of memory, like a half-remembered dream. Her eyes, dark and sharp, reflected the flickering light of the stained glass, hinting at secrets that none could fathom. As she revealed herself, a hushed murmur swept through the hall, for all knew her kin, which was one that had rarely, if ever, been seen in these lands. Her presence held an allure, a blend of danger and grace, as if she were a blade cloaked in silken shadows. The hall fell silent as Ulfar regarded her, recognising the weight of history that she carried within her gaze.

She alone stepped forward, each movement so light and graceful it seemed as though her feet barely touched the ground, as if she might at any moment ascend into the air like a leaf caught in a gentle breeze. Her slender legs moved with an effortless grace, her steps flowing through the space like water over polished stones, a quiet elegance in every motion. It was as if she carried with her a serenity that contrasted sharply with the tension thick in the air.

Her hand, long and delicate, extended from beneath the folds of her cloak, revealing a ring. It was not a ring of wedding or union, not a token of love given by a cherished companion, nor a pledge exchanged between friends sworn to the death. This was something altogether different—an artefact of a more mysterious purpose.

The ring glistened as if it held within it the glow of a hidden ember, its surface wrought from an ancient, silvery metal that seemed to shift in hue with the flickering light. Intricate patterns wound around the band, like veins of liquid moonlight, etched with runes that pulsed faintly as if breathing with a life of their own. At its centre sat a gemstone, deep and dark, yet shimmering with an inner fire. It was a jewel of indeterminate colour, shifting from deep indigo to a smoky grey, and at times catching the light in such a way that it appeared to flash with a spark of scarlet—like a crimson star hidden beneath a veil of shadow.

The edges of the band were uneven, as though it had been forged by hands that sought to balance artistry with the rawness of the earth, a relic from a time when the boundaries between nature and craft blurred. It held an aura of power, ancient and enigmatic, with the weight of long-lost histories wrapped around its gleaming surface. To those who saw it, the ring spoke of hidden doors and whispered secrets, of promises unspoken and ancient pacts that lingered just beyond memory. It was a symbol of something deeper, a connection to a world older than any gathered here could remember, and its presence seemed to thrum with a pulse that matched the steady beat of her own heart.

The ring carries a single notch hard to catch with the normal eye, but one caught by the gaze of both Aramir and Ariendria. This ring alone had to be the work of the elvish smith Celëfaéor, bom of his father Fëalbor. He crafted many things in his shortened life, and this ring seemed to be of great importance. The air, even though filled with a heavy tension, was light, and

something of an easy if but one conversation were to start, the place would erupt with sound, but who would be the first to garner the questions?

Ulfar would be the first to break the silence, posing a simple question, “Why have you come to me?”

To his surprise, it was not the woman who answered but the halfling, “Och, my apologies, we’re all, save for her, folk o’ Lunden, though I bide outside the city walls. We’re just here tae ask...” He gets cut off by the simple raising of the elvish woman’s hand, who encapsulates the halfling’s gaze.

With nearly no sound other than the rustling of her dress, she begins to speak, and the ears of all seem to be blessed with her beautiful voice, “They are here alone to see if you, Ulfar, are truly the man the birds say you are. If you are the King of the Free Men, those in Lunden seek to ascend one who wields both the Flame of the King and the Emerald Jewel to the throne of old.”

As the discourse continues and then the men themselves begin to speak, “As you are Lord Ulfar we are far to the south and often forgotten about, the Queen has treated us like nothing more than slaves, if you will do us no more than our due respect as free men of this world than we would like nothing more than to serve you...”

The discourse and sounds of the world fade off as a voice comes to the head of Aramir, the same female voice who just spoke, she says to him, for only him to hear, “You support him but do not place full trust in him, why?” A pause for just a moment is broken again by her soft, comforting and mystical voice, “He is as all men are, desiring power most of all. If I were to give him this ring I bear upon my hand, what would he do with it? Would he become the very thing that destroyed his people’s kingdom? You fear that he will, but he has not seen the darkness that lives within this world, has he? But still you believe he is the one?” Her head tilts as she locks eyes with the

rugged old wizard, who nods his head in affirmation to her final question.

The lady turns to all, speaking verbal words of her own. Against the loud commotion of the world, comes to an abrupt halt once again, each word smooth and elegant as if she were not bom of this world but of the stars themselves; even her words carried a beauty known by no man.

She spoke, “If *Ferandír* believes in this mortal man, then you shall have whatever support of the Dremoré you shall need.” She walks past, grasping the hands of both Ariendria and Ulfar, then speaks in a language unknown, yet known to him, “Meir vaeries dara thalé narathé te alathé endiré vea, almé mara fathé eà taimar en duiar marair hina.”

This language puzzled the mind of Ulfar, for he deep down knew it, yet he could not place in his mind's eye how or even why it was so eerily familiar to him. Shaking his head, he looks back at the elf who motions for him to follow her, which brings ripe confusion to the young man. Why would such an elf know her way and lead him, the lord of this palace, through its halls? Then a voice comes through his head, startling him, causing him to jump and scream out, “What was that?”

A chuckle comes from the illustrious elf who seems to dance with each step, a slight breeze down the hallway of far-opened doors blows her dress and strands of her hair. With a slight grin on her face, he recognises the voice he heard; it was hers. She then calls aloud to him, “Have you the knowledge of who I am?”

He hesitates, thinking upon her simple yet unknown question to him—it was as if he had known her for all of his years yet knew nothing all at the same time. His mind danced back and forth like a leaf on the wind, he questioned all the elves he had ever met yet none of the handful were her, but at the same time she was right upon the tip of his tongue—a vague visage visualised within lingered deep in the depths of his mind, he could not shake it but he had no clue who she truly was. He

gazed upon the ring she wore on her finger. Its colours flickered and changed with each step, but the longer he stared, the deeper and more vivid the colours became. His mind became entranced by the pulsating nature of it; each beat was a pulse emanating the power held within.

His mind then broke, his gaze stopped at the sound of her sweetened voice, “You know not who I am by name, but you have seen me before, in your youth.” She holds up her left hand, gazing at the mesmerising ring wrapped around her middle finger. She turns her hand till the gem faces towards her, her eyes then turn to the human Ulfar, locked in gaze at the ring once more. She clenches her fist, the muscles of her hands tense as the widespread hand contracts into a ball. Walking closer to Ulfar, she poses a question, “What would you do with such power?” She then places her missile finger alone upon his forehead, her voice rises with each word getting ever more mystic, she says, “Would you become him?”

A vision of a Dark Lord's crusade, the once-proud city of Dremor lay in ruins, its towering spires consumed by ravenous flames. Countless lifeless bodies littered the ground—foolish humans who dared to defy him, their defiance snuffed out in an instant. Orcs rampaged across the lands of the free, their savage laughter echoing through the night as they slaughtered innocent children, women, and men alike, leaving no mercy in their wake. The greatest monument of the Valkorian people crumbled under their relentless assault, a testament to the chaos they wrought. The orange flames flickered and twisted, morphing into a haunting shade of purple that cast eerie shadows across the devastation. The searing heat faded into a distant memory, like a long-forgotten shooting star streaking across the void of night.

Creatures of unspeakable horror—beasts whose names had long been lost to history—tore through elven cities like Melkor and Dremor, leaving a trail of destruction in their wake. Then, from the smouldering ashes, the eyes of man emerged. But these were no ordinary eyes; they bore the ferocity of a dragon,

set within the visage of a man. They pulsed with vibrant veins, void of all light, drawing the gaze of all who dared to meet them, a terrifying glimpse into the heart of the late Dark Lord's wrath.

Removing her finger, the young man stumbled back, followed by a deep, heavy breathing when the woman again spoke, "Now you have beheld the essence of true evil, a darkness that embodies the insatiable hunger for power that dwells within the hearts of men. I am Auréa, once the Lady of Dremor. What you witnessed was not merely a vision; it was a fragment of my memory, woven into the very fabric of our world. Come, let us walk. They will linger long enough in their discourse."

While both Auréa and Ulfar took their walk, discourse continued in the main throne chamber. To no surprise, the deal was inked between Auréa and Ulfar during their walk, and nothing said would change it. During this time, Ariendria took the chance to interact with the old wizard Travers Aramir as she noticed the man she had followed walk off with this elf she knew much of.

She approached Aramir and, in pure shock, the old man opened the dialogue, "At last, the daughter of my dear friend Lord Eluiar approaches me for the first time, after nearly three months spent in the squalor of this ancient city." He pricks his right index finger with his thumb and lights a small lighter on its tip just enough to ignite the tobacco within his pipe before continuing his words, "Ah, so you have come, drawn by the fears that weigh heavily upon your heart and the dreadful sights you have witnessed with your own eyes. Is it not so?"

Caught off guard, she first begins with, "I beg your pardon for my prolonged absence since our last encounter. I was uncertain whether my memory would linger in your thoughts. Yet, I must confess that such burdens weigh heavily upon my heart. In the Tellmithe Range, we came across a creature, a halfling who came to be known as Greyon. Without a flicker of mercy, he struck down that being. There was no trace of pity or remorse in his eyes during that dreadful moment."

With a puff from the pipe, the tone of Aramir changes, “There is no well of pity in his heart for the atrocities inflicted upon his kin; all semblance of compassion has fled. It was a pity that would have stayed his hand, but a misguided courage that compelled him to take a life, Vaeimea implored him to spare. He is a man who has yet to confront the true face of evil, nor has he felt its deep wounds. Though he is no saint, the world does not call for saints, but for those who renounce evil daily—a path upon which he will soon tread. We must not forget that he is still young, not yet a king. Yet, when the day comes that he claims that mantle, he shall be a man you will learn to cherish once more.”

A small but still noticeable grin of happiness at his final words overcomes her, and she nods her head.

As the two who had walked off earlier emerge from the halls of the keep, she walks over and simply hugs Ulfar unprompted and unexpectedly, the room sits baffled by the actions of the Velmar woman. She grabs the hands of Ulfar and nods as her face shades red as the setting sun, then calls out, “Let’s go to the conference room and discuss this all further.” Leading the way down the halls.

As they entered the grand chamber, the air was thick with tension. The conversation was not driven by the humans or the delmver present but by Travers Aramir and the high elven princess, Auréa, who quickly commanded the room.

It was the elevated Vamir who spoke first, her voice calm but resolute. “We have all gathered here to determine the fate of man.” She began, her words ringing out like a clear bell. “Here stands he who would be king, Ulfar Val, and with him, his fellowship, which grows stronger with each victory—whether on the battlefield or in the hearts of those who hear his call.”

Auréa moved gracefully, her eyes locking with each member present, one by one, as though she could peer into their souls. When her gaze finally met Dex’s, something deeper passed between them.

Without speaking a word aloud, she reached into his mind. “Your past haunts you, wanderer. You have seen the darkness in this world, and it weighs heavily on your heart, more than you care to admit. You worry about what is to come. You trust this man, Ulfar, you value his company... but you also fear him, for he reminds you of another—Melin, a vestige from your past.” Dex stiffened, his thoughts momentarily thrown into disarray, but Auréa's face remained serene as she circled back to her seat. She settled into it with a graceful ease, the power of her words lingering in the room long after she had fallen silent.

One of the men, his face twisted in scepticism, stood abruptly, challenging the room with a voice laced with contempt. “Why, in the name of sense, should we pledge our blades to some unknown fool such as he?”

His hand gestured dismissively towards Ulfar, sitting composed yet quietly in his chair. The man's sneer deepened, his tone sharper as he continued, “What claim does he have? Look at him! Why should we not place our trust in a lord of the land? A man with standing, with the power to sway the hearts of the people? Someone with a name that commands respect, not some poor farmer who parades around claiming divine right. He has nothing to offer us, no lineage, no rapport. How could the people ever rally behind such a figure?”

His words dripped with disdain as he addressed the room, his eyes scanning those gathered. “We sit here debating, wasting breath, over what? There is nothing to be gained from idle talk with fools. Meaningless! No lord in their right mind would support such folly. I won't pledge my sword to a cause doomed before it starts!”

The chamber fell silent as Travers Aramir took command of the discussion, his presence commanding yet calm, like the steady pulse of an ancient river. He rose from his seat with a graceful yet purposeful movement, his eyes sweeping across the room.

When he spoke, his voice was like thunder over distant hills, resonant with authority and wisdom. “My friends.”

He paused, his words carrying the weight of ages, “We find ourselves gathered here not by chance, but by fate itself. We share a singular purpose, a vision we must acknowledge—a goal that surpasses the ambitions of any one man or race. We are here to elevate one who bears not merely the bloodline, but the strength and will of a true king. Ulfar Valin stands before you, not merely as a man but as a symbol—one who carries within him the legacy of ages and the promise of what is to come.”

Aramir's voice grew more impassioned, yet it never lost its measured pace, each word like a stone carefully placed to build an unshakable foundation. “We must unite our strength behind him, for there are two undeniable truths bound to his very being. The first is his lineage, descended from kings of old. The second is his heart, steadfast and unyielding, which beats with the destiny of this land. Together, these truths make him not just a man fit for the throne, but the only man who can hold it.”

He paused, letting his words sink into the minds of all present. Then, with a sweeping gesture, he raised his hands, calling their attention to the greater struggle ahead. “And yet, my dear companions, this is not merely about a crown or a kingdom. We stand on the precipice of darkness. Shadows creep across this world, ancient and terrible forces that would seek to tear us apart, to drown all we know in despair. To stand against such a tide, the Men of this world must be as one. United, we can withstand the storm. Divided, we will fall.”

His voice softened, but it lost none of its power. “Now is the time for action, not for doubt. We must marshal our full strength, every sword, every mind, every heart—bent towards this one cause. Ulfar must rise, not for himself, but for all of us. For if we fail, it will not be a throne that is lost, but the light itself.”

As he finished, the room remained hushed, as if the very air had been held captive by his words. There was a solemnity

now, a shared understanding that their choice, their cause, was far greater than any one of them. Aramir's gaze swept the room once more, then fell upon Ulfar, his eyes gleaming with the quiet certainty of one who had not yet seen much but knew the cost of failure. With his long talk finished and him returning to his seat, the room, still silent, is brought back to life as the halfling, whose plump form was quite humorous to some men, let out soft chuckles.

The halfling let out with a prideful voice, "Och well, I'll just say ye've got my support in this venture. Us halfins are citizens o' this realm too, aye, an' even back in the First Era, we were part o' the Valkorian Kingdom. I know I'm nae warrior, but my blade's still yours, all the same." He comes to a knee, offering his blade in tribute to the young man.

Rising Ulfar says simply placed, "Rise, you do not bow to me as a man of the Stormfangs, you are but a friend and no friend kneels to me, but let me ask what is your name, little one?"

As he finishes, the small man jumps up, sheathing his blade and belting his name out with great pride and power behind, "The name's Rudabest Mereideth Pippin IV, or tae some, just Rudy!"

Without hesitation, the Delmver man rises and follows suit with the halfling, though his pride and realising what was just said takes no knee, only draws his axe and yells out from the deepest reaches of his belly, "You've got the axe of Ummar Gruthic behind you if I can dare to call you friend."

He hoists his axe wield in both hands, holding a peculiar shape not normal for an axe, but something more pointed and yet also triangular, of an ancient form, the runes spoke a long forgotten language. There was a gem which was held in the centre and was something of a mystery that caught the eyes of Ulfar as he heard this short pledge.

This was followed by two of the three humans, the one carrying the sword and the other carrying the spear, while it was

he who wielded the bow that distested the legitimacy of Ulfar, who rose from their seats, bringing to a knee in reverence while drawing weapons, placing their sharp tips. They both in sync with one another uttered the same words, a pledge—oath to their king, “Oh Lord above, blessed be thy way, we swear our swords to the cause of our King, anointed by thee above. Until death, we draw our blade in contests of who challenges us. In life and death, our service shall be to he who holds the amulet, heir of the line of kings, Ulfar Valin!”

A calm sense came over the room as the man who distested felt nothing but embarrassment for his previous statement after hearing the words of Aramir and the stout pledges of the fellows who ventured with him. The dread came over, yet his pride alone left him unable to surrender his blade, something he must swallow to be welcomed as one in this new land. The endless star plastered midnight skies that were the eyes of the maiden elf who came from Lunden with him caused a sense of foolishness over the human who could not do anything but admit his own mistake.

It did not even take the utterance of a single word for him to rise and detest his own words, “All of you are fools, to claim the name of Valin after thousands of years? Each of you runs a fool's gambit.” The man's pride was far greater than any crumb of logic and reason held within the man. As if he were a child throwing a tantrum, he stormed from the city and rode off, for where? None knew, all for certain was that he did not take the oaths of the many as a sign to join; he rebelled.

The lady of pure elegance rose from her seat with a grace that commanded the room's attention, as though even the air itself moved in deference to her. Her gown, woven from the finest silver threads, cascaded down like a waterfall of starlight, each fold catching the dim light of the chamber, shimmering as if the moon itself had kissed the fabric. Resting gently upon her brow was a crown, not one of gilded splendour or heavy jewels, but of delicate flowers, intricately woven in a simple yet

profound display of natural beauty. The crown seemed to grow from her very essence, a symbol of her bond with the earth and the heavens above. Her hair, long and seemingly eternal, flowed down her back in two braids that glistened like rivers of midnight.

It was not a void, but a reflection of the night sky, each strand holding the soft glow of distant stars, as if she had captured the beauty of the cosmos itself. It was the darkness of the night, not feared, but revered—a peaceful, serene expanse that whispered of long-forgotten secrets, the kind that lull the world to sleep with a promise of dreams to come. The slightest movement of her breath seemed to ripple through the room, each inhalation a gentle song of creation, each exhalation a reminder of the beauty the world often overlooked in the light of day. As she prepared to speak, a soft hush fell over the assembly, as if the very walls themselves waited to drink in her words.

She took a single, delicate breath, and when she spoke, her voice was like the soft melody of an ancient song, rich with the wisdom of millennia. Each word that fell from her lips was measured, deliberate, a dance of sound that resonates deep within the soul.

It was a voice that did not demand attention but drew it effortlessly, as though the very stars might bend to listen. “Know this.” Her voice soft but unyielding, “Here, in this hall, a fellowship has been born, a union of Elf, Man, and Dwarf, joined in purpose as in the days of old. Once more, the ancient bonds are forged anew, and once more shall they be tested through fervent trial. The road ahead will not be easy, nor will it be kind. Each of you will face trials not only of strength and sword but of faith—faith in your gods, faith in your pledge, and, perhaps most importantly, faith in yourself.”

Her gaze swept across the room, her eyes dark and unfathomable, locking with each of those gathered. “The darkness that lies ahead is unlike any you have known. It will test the very marrow of your bones, the deepest recesses of your

hearts. I cannot tell you when it will come, nor in what form it will manifest, but come it shall. And when it does, you must stand firm, for it will be the truest test of all that you are. Yet even in the darkest of hours, know this—there is light that darkness cannot touch, a light that dwells not in the sun or stars, but within those who dare to hope.”

She paused for a moment, her voice softening as she spoke the final words, “So be ever vigilant, for the hour of trial draws near. And when it does, may you find the strength to endure, not merely for the sake of victory, but for the sake of all that is worth protecting in this world. The beauty of the night is not in its darkness, but in the stars that burn ever brighter because of it.”

A silence hung over the room, the weight of her words lingering like a mist. The fellowship had been called, and the path set before them, but in that moment, it was clear to all that this was not just a gathering of warriors or lords. This was the beginning of something far greater—a bond that would be tested in the fires of both war and the soul. And it was she, with her timeless grace and boundless wisdom, who had shown them the way.

The group had now been formed, Ulfar's wave of force grew as did those who held their allegiance to him. In the matter of a mere few months, that simple peasant boy had travelled from the Tellmithe Range, collecting the sword of Talor, along with his amulet and now held the two largest cities in the southernmost portion of Onu-Arith: Lunden and Vingólf. This all compounds with the string of villages that had begun the rebellion a few months prior.

By the fourth day, the grand city of Vingólf had fallen, its mighty walls and towers now under Ulfar's banner. Word of the city's capture reached the queen swiftly, like a dark wind

carrying news of impending storms. Queen Anne stood at the heart of her northern keep, her expression unreadable but for the slight tightening of her lips. She had forsaken all her holdings in the south with a calculated coldness, as though she had willingly surrendered nearly half the continent to this rising power. There was no panic in her, no outburst of fear or desperation, but rather a stillness—a predator's patience, biding its time. It was as if she understood that a man like Ulfar was destined to rise, but she had yet to play her hand.

For now, she let him take what he could, knowing that their reckoning was not far off. After receiving the fateful message, she approached General Seidel, her stride sharp and purposeful, the long folds of her royal cloak whispering against the stone floors.

She looked at him with eyes that betrayed no hint of doubt, only the weight of unspoken commands. “You are not to retaliate,” her voice low but carrying the authority of centuries. “We cannot afford for the people of this nation to know of our failures in the South.” Her gaze narrowed, a near snarl curling at the corner of her mouth as she added, “It is inevitable that such a man would rise, but we shall meet him on our terms, and when we do, he will repent for his sins against the Imperium.”

Her words were not spoken with fury but with chilling certainty, each one cutting through the air like a blade honed for execution. The tension between them crackled like the air before a storm as she stepped closer to Seidel, her eyes burning with an unspoken threat. “Just know.” Her lips brushed his ear with an icy breath, “If I hear the slightest murmur of failure among the soldiers, it will be your head that rolls.” The final words slipped from her lips like poison, soft and deadly, leaving the general frozen in her wake.

Seidel stirred with a deepened anger that grew as she spoke, yet he knew his tongue had to be held, as did every man of the army; he knew that one wrong word would lead to a quick or rather painful, death. She was a vicious ruler, one who cared

not for the opinion of others; she was quite like one of the greatest predators, which did not care what small creatures stalked around, only that what her prey lay close. Seidel cancelled the regiments he had planned to send south to Deidara later that day, instead reordering them to the barracks of the city of Valkoria, causing much confusion among the men. This era of confusion would cast an ignorant shadow over the imperium, which would do nothing to prepare for the growing storm to the south.

The queen received the report with an air of frustration, the words falling into place like bitter drops from a long-forgotten well. Her elven agent had returned with nothing, and as she finished reading the brief message.

“What use is an elf if any man in my army could have done the same?” Her tone was filled with biting sarcasm. “She merely stole my coin.” Her words lingered in the air, followed by the roll of her eyes and a sharp exhale, the sound of a woman who harboured deep regret for past decisions.

Disgust twisted her features, her lips curling in disdain as her thoughts turned inward, cursing herself for placing faith in such a creature. Her pace quickened as she stormed down the halls of the keep, her eyes darting from shadow to shadow, searching for the elusive elf who had so blatantly failed her. The queen's frustration simmered beneath the surface, her movements growing more frantic with each step. The absence of the elf was glaring—an insult she could not ignore. Her heels clicked against the stone floor, echoing through the silent corridors as she made her way toward the grand hall.

Yet, after several moments of fruitless searching, her resolve seemed to cool, and she turned back, her expression hardening as she moved toward her chambers. Returning to her seat, she settled into a rigid calm, her posture betraying the controlled fury that simmered beneath her composed exterior. She waited, now with renewed patience, for the faintest news from Seidel. There was nothing else to do but bide her time and

await the next report, knowing full well that when it came, the fate of those who had failed her would be decided.

Chapter 10

The Watcher

It had been but a week since the envoys arrived in Vingólf, a city that now teetered on the precipice of fate. Time enough for a lone rider to reach Gunmar, the loyal commander, and the vast ranks of Stromfangs lying in quiet anticipation. Hidden among the humble huts and scattered villages of the east, they slumbered—waiting, blending with the landscape like wolves poised for the hunt. The message that arrived bore only a single word, yet it spoke volumes—*Parcival*. A name that rippled through their ranks, sparking action where words had long been replaced by silent oaths. It was all they needed to know: the time had come to rise, to take up arms, and ride the cobbled roads toward the holiest stronghold of the Imperium.

The day carried with it a soft breeze, and the air, crisp and cool, whispered the coming of late autumn. It felt like a breath before the storm, a quiet herald of the upheaval soon to unfold. As the men gathered in their scattered villages, preparing for the march, the roads that lay ahead would stretch their journey, doubling the time it took to reach their destination. Yet, it was not a hindrance—it was a gift. Each passing moment gave Ulfar precious time, not merely to plan a siege but to envision the collapse of a pillar upon which the Imperium stood, the first crack in the foundation of their wretched conquest.

The autumn winds stirred the leaves, swirling them like embers from a fading fire, while the Stromfangs sharpened their blades and mounted their steeds, their eyes set toward a future not yet written but one they would soon carve from stone and steel.

The word *Parcival* echoed in their hearts like a rallying cry, a signal that the rebellion was no longer a distant dream but a tangible force set in motion, bound for the heart of the Imperium where the reckoning would begin.

Within the ancient keep of Vingólf, beneath vaulted ceilings that echoed with the weight of history, the fellowship and their leaders gathered, cloaked in the flickering light of torches as they laid their plans. The air was thick with tension, for they awaited the arrival of their army, hastening across the land toward the sacred ground that would soon bear witness to their struggle. Among them, the halfling Rudy moved with quiet steps, his small frame almost lost among the towering figures of men and elves. His gaze, however, was steady as it fell upon Ariendria, the elven maiden whose beauty seemed to belong to realms far beyond the reach of this world.

As Rudy approached her, his heart quickened, and he took a deep breath. There was something in her presence that stirred within him a sense of awe, as though he stood before a living relic of ages past.

His words, though few, were laced with sincerity and reverence, a voice soft yet filled with emotion. “Yer a beauty beyond words, lass. Not a tongue o’ Man nor Elf could rightly speak what ye are. Like the first light o’ dawn on fresh snow high in the peaks—untouched and holy—ye bear the quiet splendour o’ a world long lost. Every breath ya draw stirs the air itself, like the grace o’ time forgot.”

Each word seemed to hang in the air, weaving a delicate thread between them, and for a moment, the tension in the room gave way to the soft hum of something unspoken. Ariendria, bathed in the dim light, appeared as if she had stepped from a

dream, her ageless features touched by a beauty both fierce and fragile, like the last bloom of an ancient tree standing proud in the fading light of autumn.

She tilts her head as a blush comes to her cheeks, the round yet sharp cheekbones highlighted by the red tone that had come to her skin, a smile comes across her face, showing her teeth that seemed of the whitest snows on the highest mountains. With a slight bend to her knees, the elf came to the height of the halfling, where she turned his cheek and blessed him with a slight peck, before gasping the hand of Rudy.

She then let out her voice, which was like the soft breeze ruffling fresh leaves on a midsummer's day, "Thank you, dear little friend." Ariendria replied, her voice soft and melodic, carrying the grace of centuries in each syllable. "Your words humble me, yet they fill my heart with great joy. To be blessed with your friendship is a gift beyond measure. And do not think yourself without beauty, for you too possess a rare and shining light, one not rivalled even by the fairest of Delmver princes."

Her gaze softened as she spoke, the kindness in her tone like the gentle caress of a warm breeze through ancient trees, her words a reflection of the deep bond between them. Hers was a beauty only rivalled by that of only two elves, one of which had crossed the eyes of the young halfling, Auréa.

As the new fellowship of the Stormfangs convened, Ulfar would be first to speak to all, "You all are part of this. May it be your voice or your blade, each one of you will be needed for our next step." He cleared his throat and pointed towards the map that lay on a table before them.

He took in a breath before he continued by saying, "As you can see, the city of Deidara is in our path if we seek to follow the cobble roads to the Parcival. That is our first objective and why we must be ready and on the move with our full force by the morrow." He moves around the table, coming to place his hands on the shoulders of Ariendria and Rudy, his leather gloves fold like wrinkled skin as he brings his grip to a slight tightening.

Ulfar picks up once again with, “This is where our two dear friends Ariendria and the halfling Rudy come into play. Both of you will ride ahead. There should be a Vaidir who goes by two names, Fiona or Taelmíra. You should be able to find her in the biggest inn of the town; a man who dons an ancient armour should be accompanying her. We must all prepare and be ready, for now we shall make our march to the capital, and through this we shall burn down the false church that the queen made. We shall take Valkoria and throw this wretched evil from the land!”

It was Aramir who approached Ulfar, “Taelmíra, do you know her?” His voice was unknowing and inquisitive, that tone which was doubtful of the man.

“I was reading a letter from a man you know. Come with me, I’ll show you my dear friend.” Ulfar makes gestures for them to take a simple stroll under the starlit sky.

With a subtle wave of the hand, Ulfar beckoned him onward, and together they began a slow and silent stroll beneath the starlit sky. The hall they entered was narrow and steeped in stillness, marked by two ascending staircases that flanked them like quiet sentinels. Beyond those steps stretched a blackened corridor—long, quiet, and half-lost in shadow—lit only by two torches, one at the entrance and one at the far end, their flames flickering in opposition like twin beacons across a passage of forgetting.

The tap of Aramir’s staff echoed gently along the stone, a sharp and mellow rhythm that filled the space between their steps. The glow from his ever-burning pipe cast a soft amber shimmer across his robes, and the smoke that followed wrapped the air in a warm, lingering scent—like vanilla steeped in age and memory.

The pair came to the starlit cloister, the sight was one to behold as the moons let a soft blue and white light cascade across the stone. Each beam of light gave life to the carvings and ancient tales told across each stone face, one of heroes and

figures such as Threll Kelmsman, Halvar Eldaric, Leonidus of Talmek, and Ysgrim. Each great master who etched themselves into history forever, yet each had fallen in their dusk years.

Ulfar rested upon a parapet of elegant design, its stone smoothed by time and lined with runes worn thin by the salt of wind and memory. The torchlight behind him flickered across his cloak as he spoke lowly, his voice like cold iron wrapped in velvet. “He gave no true name, nor was the letter sealed with any mark of notoriety to me. Here.”

With that, he reached into his pocket and produced a small piece of parchment, folded with ritual care. Between two fingers, he held the wax seal—now broken—yet still intact enough to reveal its strange mark. He placed it in the wizard's palm with the same weight one might place an heirloom upon a grave.

The wax was deep red, smooth as blood just beginning to dry. Yet it was the symbol pressed within that held Aramir's gaze. A hand—five-fingered, unnaturally thin—stretched wide in the centre, its fingers crowned with tiny sigils shaped like gem-settings. From the back of the palm, where flesh might yield to bone, a heart had been impressed, intricately knotted, as if carved from living light.

There was a stillness about it, and yet... something stirred. The hand seemed almost to twitch beneath the light. Not in movement, but in suggestion—as if it waited. Watched. The glyphs around it were unfamiliar, arranged in a spiral that led the eye inward, downward, toward the heart. They whispered of order, power, and an old dominion long unspoken. It did not bear a name. But neither did it need one. The seal, in its silence, spoke volumes.

“Tell me, what did this letter say?” The voice of Aramir was more inquisitive, as if he knew the seal—a deeper mystery which was captured in the mind of Ulfar.

Ulfar gives a simple nod as he unfolds the paper once more:

To Ulfar Valin, Son of Aelfred, Son of
Aramór—

The hour is not yet struck, but already the bell
tolls. I send this letter not as a greeting, nor a
warning, but as inevitability made ink.

You are the child of many deaths—some yet to
pass, some forgotten by even the gods. You
wander beneath stars that no longer shine,
singing a song you did not compose. Yet it was
written of you, and for you, long before breath
touched your lungs.

The world breaks not with thunder, but with
memory.

You march toward a door that has no hinges,
forged by hands that no longer bleed. I have seen
its threshold. I have watched you stand before it.

The cleansing of this world is nigh.

You will not halt it. You were never meant to.

There is no deliverance in strength. No hope in
fire. The blood in your veins carries both
promise and doom, and every drop cries out for
reckoning.

You walk in daylight, but are followed by a
shadow crowned in silence. You shall know it by
its weeping, for it is you made hollow.

The sands of time do not weep. They grind.

And so grind they shall.

Do not seek me. I am no longer of this world,
nor bound by its threads. I am the thread-cutter,
the dream-devourer, the hand that cast the
second star into the void.

Should you hear my name upon the lips of the
dying, do not speak it back.

To speak my name is to remember the wound of
the world.

—Eins Ocu Shae

The old wizard takes the paper from the man whose countenance bore the signs of fear, and he says but one word, “Eins.” There was a ruffle and scrunch to the face of Aramir; he knew the name, one which drew from great myths amongst those who guard the free world.

Ulfar broke the new silence, which was held for nearly three minutes, “This name, 'Eins', who or what is he?” The tone had changed more to one of Ulfar's childhood when he would bring a question of the greater world to the grey wizard. He had no laugh, no chuckle, nothing but strain over this—not worry but a necessity for this answer.

“Many have come for that question, yet few know anything but folklore, young Ulfar.” Aramir, who now had a stare that was empty and lost in knowledge far beyond the world Ulfar knew.

The man shook his head; the curt tone and short response of his old friend disturbed him. He felt an unease; there was something being hidden by the wizard, something that would bring any mortal man to be shaken to the depths of the Void itself. He could ask no question nor get more than just a few words out as the air grew thick; even though the wind blew, it was stale. “You... you are scared.”

Aramir nodded, "Perhaps, my dear friend..." He trailed off with his last words, the eyes of the old man glazed over, then in an instant, as if he had finally calculated the costs and benefits of truly telling the boy. He lit once more his pipe with the snap of his fingers; a flame appeared, the orange light it bore did nothing but add to the eerie notions of what was to come.

He turned his gaze from the pipe to Ulfar, "That man—if man he ever was—has been thought long dead, buried by the dust of three thousand years. And even before that, none could say if he were truly flesh and soul, or merely the invention of a madman's mind." Travers paused for a few moments, his face giving Ulfar every inclination that gross pondering was happening.

"What I fear more is not the letter itself, but that it was written to you, Ulfar. It grants us no true understanding of the one who penned it—only a chilling certainty that he is real. In truth, it lends weight to a suspicion I have long harboured... one I had hoped would remain no more than shadow and speculation." He moves to stand directly by Ulfar, offering him the lit pipe for a drag or two.

Ulfar obliges the old man, taking in a deep drag, the smoke more potent than any which he had ever tried. "Tell me, there is more you know."

The wizard, for what easily could have been the first time in all Ulfar's life, removed the hat from atop his head. It revealed soft grey and silver hair, which seemed to glow in the light of the moons. "You shall soon meet a man—though he serves a purpose far greater than he may understand. He comes bearing the name of Eins, and with him a collection of letters, one hundred and fifty-five in all, each one written by hand and signed in that same name: Eins Ocu Shae. Yet the earliest bear a different signature—Pentillius Ocullius. What troubles me most, however, is not the name but the seal. A hand impressed into crimson wax—no mere emblem. In our world, such a symbol carries ancient weight. From all I have gathered in my long years

of study, this figure was no ordinary mage. He is said to have been the first of the Elder Magi—one who transcended the boundaries of the arcane and fashioned for himself a paradise beyond the reach of even the gods. Of the man himself, I know precious little. Only the whisper of a book—the *Codex Prismaris*—a tome so veiled in myth that even my greatest searches have turned up only silence.”

Ulfar had heard the folk tales of mages so powerful they could create new life itself, but never once that of a whole new plane of existence. “So he transcended his mortality; he became something beyond time. Will we face him in battle?”

“So far as the histories reveal, he does not tread in the matters of this world—save one: the singular, monumental act of shaping its magic.” Aramir’s voice trails off while he shakes his head once more. “This is not a burden for today. When the war is ended, you and I shall seek the counsel of Lady Dramira and of the Highmaster of my Order. Until then, we must not let shadows yet distant cloud the task at hand.” Ulfar gives a solemn nod, while they both walk away.

As the night descended into a quiet close, the fellowship dispersed, each retreating to their respective quarters, minds heavy with the weight of the journey ahead. The stars blinked overhead like the distant eyes of forgotten gods, watching as the travellers sought what little rest could be found before the break of dawn. In the stillness, only the soft murmur of the wind through the city’s narrow streets and the distant howl of wolves echoed in the night, a reminder of the untamed world beyond the stone walls of Vingólf.

The first light of dawn crept across the horizon, painting the sky in hues of gold and pale lavender, spilling into the waking world like a quiet promise of the trials yet to come. It was in this new light that the halfling Rudy and the fair Ariendria found themselves preparing for their long and uncertain venture.

Rudy, though small in stature, moved with an eagerness that belied his size. His eyes, always full of wonder, now

gleamed with a mixture of excitement and trepidation. The halfling had fastened his own supplies with a care that spoke of experience, ensuring that his blade, though smaller than most, was within easy reach, and his garments—humble, were suited for the road ahead. He looked up at Ariendria, who stood tall and ethereal, the very image of elven grace beside the formidable steed, and for a moment, he felt a pang of awe. The quiet morning air held a sense of anticipation, as if the very world knew the weight of what was to come.

This journey, though only two days by their reckoning, felt as though it stretched into the unknown, where time itself could bend under the strain of destiny's hand. They believed the road ahead was fraught with peril, and though they were prepared for battle, it was the unseen challenges—the darkness that stirred in the hearts of men and the silent pull of fate—that truly concerned them. Together, they mounted their steeds, setting out into the early dawn, their minds united by purpose, their hearts steeled for what lay ahead.

A day and a half had passed, yet the weariness of the journey was tempered by the anticipation of what lay ahead. At last, the sight of the wooden gates of Deidara crept into view on the distant horizon, the city standing like a sentinel amidst the rolling landscape. Its towering gates, weathered but strong, beckoned them onward, marking the beginning of the next chapter in their march. The journey had been long, but the promise of what was to come gave heart to the elf and halfling, as they neared the walls that would soon bear witness to the imperium which lay within. The gates of the city did not pose such hospitality that even when sieging the gates of Vingólf, they projected. The foyer of the guard-watch atop the wall rested as a vantage point for the soldiers who stared as they approached and rather peculiarly did not call out to them, but opened the gate without hesitation or question.

As the two entered the city, they were simply asked a single question: “What business have you here?”

Ariendria hushed the halfling to speak for the pair, “We have simply come to seek rest at the inn.” Her curt tone dismayed the guard from questioning any further. Their ride to the inn was nothing perilous or even near the trouble their short ride was to the city, where they saw the hanging wooden sign which read, *Midnight's Rider*, which they knew must be their inn, thus.

Ariendria helped off her dear friend Rudy, then stepping down herself, she did not tie the horse but spoke a soft word that was unknown to the small one, “Rielara,” which left the horse in some sort of trance of pure tranquillity or peace.

With haste, the halfling jumped and ran through the doors of the inn, presumptuously with the idea of food and drink in his mind. The elf chuckled at her little friend as she removed her blade, bow and quiver from the padding of the horse, which had concealed them from those watchful eyes at the gate. With that, she paced into the inn, looking with her keen eyes over the entire spacious room filled with drunkards and revellers, but far in a corner, her eyes locked with those of a fellow elf whose skin came from something of a field of wildflowers, though all were shades of purple and blues. Her eyes were a sharper shade of violet or maroon that pierced through the room, her face held a small grin, not one of mischief but one of acknowledgement that something was soon to begin.

With a quickened pace, she grabs the collar of the little one who had not one but two full pints of mead in his hands and a platter of food filled with chicken and roasts in the other.

She gave him a stern look, “We are here for neither party nor drunkenness.” As if she slapped him back to a sense of importance, he began to trail behind on his own.

“Yet I remember you, O Zion,” Ariendria spoke as they approached the table, a tone in which Rudy thought to be a poem but one which was beyond his limited knowledge of prose. The pair walked forward and waited for the hooded figures to respond.

Now, the other character was one of pure mystery—a shrouded man whose very presence seemed to echo with the weight of ancient legacies. He sat before her like a wraith from the forgotten comers of history, reminiscent of the Watchers from the ancient kingdom that had once thrived. Yet he came to speak, “Though the earth trembles and the rivers flood, I do not forget your name.”

Though concealed beneath the tattered folds of his dark cloak, the armour he wore bore the unmistakable mark of his lineage. Her keen eyes caught sight of the ancient Cross of Valkoria engraved upon his chest—a once-majestic emblem that had been a beacon of hope and valour. It was a sharp, beautiful golden cross fashioned from three elegant swords, now marred by the passage of time. The blades intertwined with the grace of a dancer, their hilt adomed with intricate etchings that spoke of long-forgotten oaths and sacred vows.

Surrounding this noble insignia, ebony and ivory vines curled and twisted like serpents, embracing the emblem with an almost sentient reverence. An amulet, once radiant and alive with vibrant colours, hung from the centre of the cross, a relic of divine purpose that now dulled to a shadow of its former glory. Beneath it, another slender sword was tied, its hilt encased in a similar vine, a token of his unwavering dedication.

Yet, the passage of years had not been kind. The armour, once resplendent in its craftsmanship, was now patchy and scarred, its surface bearing the marks of countless battles fought and won. The golden trim of each plate had long since succumbed to the ravages of time, leaving behind only scattered flakes that glimmered dimly like stars in a waning night sky. The once-bright steel, once a gleaming tone of white, had surrendered to a weathered grey, resembling nothing more than the beaten remnants of an age that had passed into legend.

His beard was soft yet rugged, the kind that told stories of hardship and sorrow, worn by one who had witnessed the atrocities of the world unfold before him. His eyes, shadowed

beneath the hood, held depths of wisdom and secrets, hinting at a life intertwined with the fate of kingdoms. Each subtle movement seemed to carry a whisper of ancient prophecies, the air around him charged with an unspoken promise of both danger and hope. In that moment, he was not merely a man cloaked in mystery but a living testament to a history steeped in valour and sacrifice—a relic of the past that stood ready to confront the trials of the present.

The halfling had been caught in a daze by the majesty of the elf, but more so by the aurora of history permeating from the man sitting at the table. He was like a strider through the night, mysterious and vague, yet something so familiar. Rudy then abruptly said, “Aye, I’m Rudabest Mereideth Pippin IV, but if it makes things a wee bit easier, just call me Rudy. Whit are yer names?”

The female elf answers first with the simple reply of, “Taelmira.” She moves the hood that places a deep shadow over her being ever so slightly to let the soft amber glow reside upon the various shades of blues, purples, and all the way to lavender that compose her skin. Her hand was clenched, wrapping, soft and delicate yet also worn fingers clasped the circumference of a soft wooden cup filled with a liquid that was somewhat repulsive to the elf, seen through her disgust that came across her face with each swig.

Now, attention turned to the mysterious man whose shroud extended the dubious aurora that surrounded the man. His eyes glowed in the soft glow from the embers of tobacco within his short wooden pipe. His eyes showed a darkened colour of either hazel or brown, the fingers of the man wrapped around the pipe with two of them fanning above the open top. Each finger was dirtied and had seen many more years than those of Rudy, and could have seen as many as the lady elf herself. His nails were darkened with the toils of life, and his fingers rugged and callused.

Then his mouth opened, and words came forth, “Come.” Rising from his seat, his right hand reached out in a gesture to follow. “We cannot speak here, for the enemy’s spies are always watching.” Ariendria and the young halfling followed behind with the elf Taelmíra being the rear. They went up the stairs, venturing into a rented room of the inn.

The human looks around the room and, with his fingers, puts out all the candlelight that casts the space into a bright orange glow. Then he spoke again, “Some know me as a Watcher, others as a long forgotten writer. But to a few, I am known by my name—Judas.” He paused as he glanced out the window of the inn, seeing the dark and miserable streets that had now come to know the rain, making them muddy and even more miserable.

He continued after the short break, “If Ulfar has sent you, then it means he wishes no bloodshed within these walls. That leaves us only a few days to weave our spell upon this city. And that, my friends, is where the two of you come in—to smooth the way, to make our work here swift and silent. The plan is simple: we find ourselves a scapegoat, a fool to bear the blame, and we turn the city’s watchful eyes against each other.”

“Aye, but what’s yer name?” Rudy poses the simple yet oddly unanswered question to the hooded man.

He nods his head slightly, affirming his response with a breath, “I am Judas.” He was so simply stated, yet there was a pure truth felt from the man; he did not lie, for he was Judas, but to the world he was known by many names—and for many deeds.

Areindria looks upon the face of the man, one with the wrinkles of time and age long beyond hers, yet youthful and mysterious as if he were a meagre thirty years old. She spoke in such a tone, “You are the writer of many great verses, yet why do you not claim it to your name?”

The man smiled beneath his age, he let out a small chuckle and yet his words were not ones which were expected by

either the elf or the halfling. “There are few who know my poems, psalms, and verses in this world of fallen men. And yet, even fewer who still believe the words of God.” He lets out a small chuckle, and his voice becomes more cryptic, “It was your people who let the words die, you all know them, but you pushed these pagan gods on the world of man.”

There was no utterance from Ariendria; she stood mute, and she knew of the things said by the man. It was indeed the work of the Elves to change the faith of Men. It was during the latter years of Valkoria that man fell from its covenant, and the elves gifted to men a codex containing a new faith, the faith that held a pantheon rather than a single deific figure.

Taelmíra spoke, “Yet it was the will of Men who were so easily swayed.” She walked up to Ariendria, placing her hand on the shoulder of the shorter elf, “Perhaps the world of Man will once more see the works of the God we see, the one we hold in reverence. Angels are not gods; angels are the beings who live below them, nothing more. Vaeimea is one of them.” Her tone was almost mocking the forest elf who held a certain reverence for Vaeimea.

Judas moves towards an end table and grabs two rolled letters and hands one to each of them whilst saying, “Deliver one to the city guard, another to the hall’s guard. Return and we shall continue the works which are needed here.”

Rudy and Ariendria nodded, then, to not waste any time, both set out to deliver the messages to their desired recipients. Rudy ventured to the gate of the city in search of the guard’s captain, while Ariendria ventured with elegance through the mud streets of the city to the hall searching for a man named Argos Herod. With each step in the various puddles, and each drop of rain merging with the others upon their skin, the two grew closer to bringing a way for a new order to sprout within Deidara.

While the two ventured, Judas sat with Taelmíra, a map of the city along with a long list of names, some bearing a slash through them, others with a simple check after. The parchment

was a tone of cream or off white that seemed to glow much more orange in the casting light of the candle they had lit.

The lady elf would be the first to break the silence of the room by saying, “I know you are not who you seem; you may have ventured much of the world since, but I dare not forget that face, along with the mark you cover upon your neck, dear psalmist.” Her eyes seemed as if they had the knowledge of the world, though at the very same time had nothing of any benefit to offer, an odd contradiction which meant the world to Judas.

He place the pipe that seems to be always lit upon the wooden table, then proceeded to pull back the cloak and armour to reveal the mark of creation upon his neck, a symbol of his true age, for he was no mere man but a human who had traversed the world since the dawn of his people in the distant beginnings of the First Era. His face carried an expression of grief, yet it puzzled her as a slight grin took over the man's face.

Then he spoke something that was both unpredictable yet known to her, he said, “You do recognise me, though years have come between. It was I who saved you from those orcs in your youth. You, along with countless others, fled as prey in their wicked hunt. I was the one who struck down that foul creature when it came for you—I remember it well, for your eyes still carry that fierce, unyielding flame, bom in those days of hardship. That fire has never left you.”

She had but one question to ask him, though she did not know if she could garner the courage to pose such a question. Her heart swelled at the memories of her youth, but then she did not question what she must know.

She then posed him a simple question, “How does a human live the life of an elf?”

He chuckled, but it was not a chuckle of happiness but one of pain, torment and agony, one that has seen much more than the joys of this world. His voice then came out in a sombre tone, one filled with the knowledge of a thousand passes of dear loved ones. Softly, his words floated through the air, not rugged,

which was normal for Judas, soft and angelic—sad to say the least.

“Some call it a blessing; others, a curse. What it may be—that choice lies with you. But know this: to outlive one's parents, to watch all who once knew you as a child fade into the years, while you remain untouched by time, appearing no older than a soul in their prime... Is it truly a gift, this endurance bestowed upon one meant by the Creator to be mortal?” His eyes glistened as he recalled the memories of ones he once held dear within his own arms and those he embraced with a once warm heart, now a stone to the cold winds of time.

Her heart went from a warm flame to something of cold embers, the sense of loss and passing within his echoed voice. She had realised that this man alone had felt much greater loss than anything one such as herself would ever be subjected to; it pained her as she thought through what to say next, yet one more question came to her mind, “Is this why you wrote the words of Goht? Is this why you said praise to our Creator?”

He inhales, then clears his throat; the expression on his face abruptly changes back to the emotionless gaze. The eyes of Taelmíra seem burdened and weighted by the words of her counterpart, who then says, “Perhaps, or maybe it was just the will of the Lord, His Holy Spirit working through a broken man. I love these conversations, yet we must not linger on the past in sorrow; instead, let us look to the ever-brightening path that lies before us.”

When his words conclude, he takes her hand in his while looking deep into her eyes, comforting her whilst relieving the lamenting emotions stirred within. His words pause only briefly before he continues, “This plan hinges on one thing: we must take down a single man, and it must be done within hours. Now, I can slip from sight to most, but to the keenest of eyes, an elf such as yourself would be far better suited.”

There was a smile making its way across her face as she nodded her head, while clamping down on the hand of Judas

once more, she rose from her seat, pulling her cloak upon her hair, slowly losing the hand of the human. She turns and makes her way to the door. With that, the man once more rests alone, left by all he knew, as the plan he so laboriously planned for many moons began to unfold in such a delicate manner.

After a short walk through the rain, the young Rudy reached into his pocket and removed the rolled parchment carrying the mysterious message.

Then, with a swift move of his hand, he called out, “Are ye the head o’ the guard?” His eyes squinted as he questioned the strange man, who was caught completely off guard, startling the figure.

The guard gazes at the little creature for a few seconds before he replies with, “You’d be correct, I am a little one, now what is this in your hand?” The man extends his hand forth, grasping the offered parchment from the halfling.

The man opens and begins to read the short message Rudy responds with, “Some fella up from the main hall telt me tae give this tae ye. That’s all I know.” He shrugs his shoulders, completely oblivious to what the message even reads.

The militant figure studied it not once but many times over, easily eclipsing five or more before he said, “These ingrates! For what reason have they said such? If the Queen told us to wipe her rear, would we?” His eyes were crazed by the absurd words he had just read. The little one still stood oblivious to what words even could have been strewn across the page.

The question, clearly one of satirical nature, had no answer, even though the little one nearly came back with a clever spot. He continues a rant that turns into pure action as he says, “Let us see if they dare to utter these words themselves, do they not know the gate guard outnumbers those gluttonous fools nearly four to one. First, I must converse with the Lord Commander Gruel. I apologise, little one, but please return to your abode. This is no place for you now, for we may be that of revolutionaries soon.” He paces off towards the barracks, which

lie just a few minutes walk through the rain away from the dryness of the canopy.

Meanwhile, the fair lady Velmar, Ariendria, had reached the main hall and confronted a man bearing the last name Herod, whom she found with minimal effort. Seemingly, he was the head of the hall guard, which was distinctly separate from the gate guard and seemed to be of a much higher stature in the city's social life than many others around. After coming to find him, she simply said, "Lord Herod, here I have this parchment meant for your eyes only." She handed him the parchment, which brought his face to a grin.

He, rather than acknowledging her, simply pushed her to the side, coughing at her, then called out, "Raise the arms, we shall slaughter the peasants who guard the gate, as they have denounced our elegant and beautiful Queen!" He chuckles, then lets out a deep belly laugh while he throws the parchment to the ground.

Then he turns to Ariendria and simply says, "Be gone with you, vile elf."

Her blood boiled at the hubris and demeaning nature of the man; her heart told her to cut him down, but her mind said that it would happen by this day's end. She simply left the hall and returned as the city began to scurry with the movements of soldiers. She finally returned to the inn, where she found Rudy and Judas waiting for her and Taelmíra, who was noticeably absent.

The window opened, and the words came from the mouth of the dark elf, "It is done, they support not the queen but he who will be king."

Confusion drew over the two who were clearly more out of the loop than Judas. There, he opened his mouth once again, "In simple terms, the head of the gate guard stood a loyalist—he rejected our calls to turn against the queen. Yet his subordinate, whom Rudy met scarcely half an hour past, would see Ulfar

upon the throne, as would many here in this city, who've heard, carried by wind and whisper, the tale of the rebellion.”

He takes a breath, then continues with, “Ariendria has merely carried out her task, delivering a letter I intercepted a week past and completing its journey as intended.” He chuckled before finishing with, “Now comes the real work—we must ensure the gate guards emerge victorious, and Taelmíra has made certain of it. Traps have been set along each path of the hall guards' march, thinning their numbers with each step. Even now, men of the hall fall, their breaths stolen in silence, and that is where we make our move. Down below.”

He gestures to the road, “The heads of both factions will clash. We, as Ulfar's reinforcements, shall descend upon them and put an end to the hall's pompous guard. Except you, little master Rudy—you'll have your own part to play.”

With excitement, the young master jumps up and asks, “Whit is it?” A sense of pure joy and excitement encapsulated the young halfling whose eyes grew as wide as the Ocean of Galilee.

Taelmíra picks up where Judas left off and gives the little one the task he so deeply wanted to know, “You little Rudy shall be the one to tell the town of the treachery that the Queen dared to do. For she has written on this parchment and signed with her hand and meant it for the governor of this city.” She gives him a document clearly from the capital city itself, “Tell all that she dares to take aged men for service and slaughter all families who dare to object to any law she has imposed, and dares to invade the homes of all to find any splinter of rebellion.”

He jumps up and runs out the door, calling out to all and showing each person the document to prove, who many seem weary but grow ever more trusting as they see the guard march through the streets calling out the hail of the rebellion. For in the manner of but a few hours, the city has gone from a place of peace to one of the highest of treasons, a kettle waiting to boil over at any second.

As the small man ran off to deliver the message—to stir this already boiling pot of a city—the Dark Elf and the human sat in silence, waiting for both Ariendria and Rudy to be well beyond the tavern. Then, from beneath his hood, the throaty voice of Judas echoed out.

He turns towards her, “Have you ever met *him*?”

“No.” Curt yet to the point that the lavender-skinned elf knew who this man was talking of as she paused for a second and continued, “Never once have I even heard his description.”

He seems to chuckle, “Yet here we are, a man neither of us has shaken hands or drawn blade with. Yet again, here we drink and plot his victory.”

Her voice, which seems so pure yet conceited under her cloak hood, matches the seeming glee in the voice of Judas, “Ironic, isn’t it?”

She lets out a more verbal chuckle, and she catches the eyes of Judas, which seem to gleam with a note of history.

“Well.” His voice was hardened as he removed the hood from his head and reached over, removing hers as well, revealing the elegant white hair of the dark elf. The fires of the lamps and lanterns made it almost glow with an unmatched energy. And he continued, “Do you know who Eyánur was?”

She thought for a minute, which began to eerily grow as she searched her knowledge of the world, which spanned thousands of years and the lives of countless mortal men, yet nothing. “I’ve nothing. Who is he?”

He takes in a breath after finishing his ale and calling for two more, “Was.” He paused for a few moments as if sifting through the versions of the man he could share. “Eyánur was no lord, no master, and no hero. He was a simple man who gave his life in service to the ruby crown of Tarédiel. He served a man whose name you do know, Uriel the IX.”

She jumps in, “Was he not the King who was slain by the Red Dusk?” Her voice seemed to just barely convey a sense

of knowing when it came to this man. Her eyes told a different story, as if she knew not Uriel but Red Dusk more intimately.

He nodded, "You are correct." He paused to drink from his ale, "Eyánur was the head of his guard, known as the Dragon Claws. Not the greatest name in my opinion. Eyánur wrote down many things the King said, yet one always stood out to me."

He pulls out a paper which has a longer message inscribed on it, which reads:

My King approached me early this morning and his words were startling. He said, "I know when I die, my Blade, Vekatar has shown me my death. On the 23rd of New Green in the year of Drukavin 503. I will die, and a hero will be born in the coming darkness and he alone will be the force who closes shut the jaws of death itself."

He would continue, "I have ruled as King of this land for 127 years, yet never once have I ever truly had power of my slumber, of my visions. These were ransomed to the Gods and I have seen the darkness which follows the Prince of Evil. Who will rise and fight, who will save us from our greatest adversaries?"

He told me this but a week before that day.

Taelmíra read the note to herself two, if not three times over. She looks at it, then quickly at Judas, "Tell me, I never graced the presence of those from Tarédiel. I steered warily, as did my father. What was Uriel like? What was this Eyánur like?" She looked at the man with awe, and her eyes told him that she was truthful and had never come to grace this ancient kingdom's presence.

Judas pulled out another paper, “I served him, Uriel. It was my job that day to lead him away from the capital. He was a man of honour plagued by the visions and dreams of the Ten. He always spoke of the stars telling our lives, and yet he told us of a face that only he would know. We saw it on that day, and after he passed, I was given that note by Eyánur.”

Judas ran his fingers up the page after grabbing it from the grasp of the she-elf. His eyes bled with the memories of all his lives lived in service. He gathered his voice once more, “Eyánur was the epitome of who a commander of a King's Guard should be, stout, resolute, strong, and fierce.”

The man paused, and so Taelmíra filled the goring silence, “There is more, isn't there?” Her inquiry was one which was more than the mere five words that composed it; it grew within power on each letter, each word was worth a thousand when spoken.

“You'd be correct.” He breathed with angst; his mind was spiralling through memories of his past life. “The Hero of Tarédiel, the figure who is all but unknown except in deed and action, was given the crown in the waning moments of Uriel's life and told to give it to his nephew, Altharion, yet he also was told one last thing.” He paused for a second, and a smile came across his face, “The Amulet of the Kings, the Emerald Jewel, here this note, inked by the unstable hands of the dying King.” Extending his hands with an ancient piece of parchment in his hands, he read aloud.

*By my hand, I [illegible] write the final words of
King Uriel Taun IX:*

*I shall not go any further; this is my end as it
was foretold by the gods. You must bring this
crown to my nephew Altharion. For he alone
can rally the men of this land to defend against
this darkness, this shadow of what is to come.*

*Yet now, as I stand here in the hour of my death,
I see life, I see a world of man in which we
triumph and the Emerald Jewel once again
reigns over this bled crown. Go now, find
Altharion; he knows where Torgen is. Go and
close shut the jaws of hell.*

She smiled and took the wood pipe from the sash of Judas, “So in his final moments, he saw his ancestor's future. *'The blood of fire burns within the heart of those who handle the Emerald Jewel.'* Such words are not idly spoken.”

He pulled out a small pack of pipe tobacco, handing it to her. She packed it into the pipe, then grabbed a match he handed to her. Judas looked at her as she took a drag, “Precisely, it's majestic, the mere fact he saw something that not even we, over two thousand years later, have seen.” He waved his hand as she passed him the pipe, letting him take a drag of this well-aged tobacco. “You once asked me when we first met why did I joined this cause. I knew his father, so when I heard his son had a dream of the amulet, I believe I recalled these words which have sat in on my breast for centuries. So then I came here to fulfil my oath to a lost friend, my promise to Eyánur.”

After taking one more drag from the pipe, she looked up with a grin, one which spoke volumes to the world, for it meant a time had come and now events had been set in motion, ones which would change the fate of the world. She spoke, “A promise we both shall keep then, perhaps when we've the time, I will tell you of what my father said.” And so they rested until Judas awoke to the sound of soldiers in the streets. The loud yells of men clad in full kits, the air stood still, and the coming clash placed a shroud over the space.

As the forces gathered, a grim stillness cloaked the air, thick with the prelude to violence. Herod, his figure looming amidst his followers, spoke with a voice as cold as steel, a cruel

glint in his eyes. “You shall die as all who defy our lady Queen. Fall like fools who cannot grasp their place.” His words hung like a curse before he charged, his men surging forward with him, a tidal wave of hostility.

Their swords met, and the air erupted in a shower of fierce sparks as steel collided against steel, bright embers scattering into the darkened sky. Shouts and cries mingled with the clash of metal, echoing through the streets in a brutal symphony of war. Minutes passed, each one painted in red and punctuated by the flash of blades in the moonlight, until a figure emerged from the fray, cutting through the clash with a presence both commanding and chilling. It was not the head of the gate guard who stepped forward, but Judas himself.

The wom emblem—the Cross of Valkoria—hung proudly across his chest, its ancient design, now dulled by time and battle, glinted in the soft glow of the moon that had just broken free of the clouds. The symbol, once a radiant golden cross entwined with ebony and ivory vines, seemed almost spectral now, carrying with it the weight of an era long past.

The gate guard, bruised and bloodied, struggled to lift his head. In a voice weakened by the wounds inflicted upon him, he whispered the name with a reverence laced with terror. “Judas Preiko.” It was the last thing he uttered before Judas's final blow silenced him, ending the life of the guard and, with it, the last remnants of defence the ruling class could muster. With the guard now slain, the path lay open for Ulfar's march to sweep through the city, ready to claim it as his own.

The night turned to day and with it a new dawn, the forces of Ulfar were not due to arrive for well over another day but here those whose survived the skirmish the past night did not simply say their allegiance to the coming man, but pledged as did a vast majority of the city, those who dissented spoke their thoughts though they fell of deafened ears those who did not care nor dedicate the time to such fools of the world—they had lost their power, their names meant nothing nor did their titles, he

had yet even come to the city yet they banners were crafted in a single day. And as the vast army arrived, it did only grow in size, a force that now should have little problem in its next two goals, the Parcival and then the Capital. For each and every man who drew swords for Ulfar knew that the next stop was the southern fork, which is where the roads to the north, to the capital, came to meet the road to Vingólf and then the villages to the east.

His presence in the city only stirred more support as many came to see him as a normal guy, but also someone who was eerily reminiscent of the ancient legends, one even mentioned him as the second coming that was foretold in an ancient prophecy. Though this only stirred more rumours and speculations about the man, as they knew the forces headed by Gunmar and Vivel needed perhaps a day longer than them to arrive at the fork simultaneously to them—Ulfar made the decision to make camp in the city of Deidara for a few nights. This allowed for a full-fledged meeting of the two who made the capture of Deidara possible.

As Ulfar greeted many of the new men to the army, Judas cut in front or rather, was let in front of many men alongside him was the dark elf Taelmíra. Before even Judas could utter a single word, Ulfar extended his hand and simply said, “We are grateful to both of you.” He smiled a soft smile across his young face, which now had the makings of a beard strewn across it.

He continued with, “I am Ulfar Valin, the one who wrote to you under the pen name Storm. Thank you both for listening to my calls, and specifically you.” He motions towards Taelmíra, “There is something of great importance that my dear friend Travers Aramir has brought to my attention that you may have more knowledge on.”

It was as if the mere mention of his name were a spell to call him. Travers Aramir appeared behind the young Ulfar. He placed his old, worn hands upon his shoulders and uttered greetings to all parties, “Greetings to you, fair folk of this world,

and to you two, most especially. Two souls, I daresay, have not graced my sight since the earliest days of my journey upon Varis Mogul. Judas Preiko, wise as the deep-rooted oak, and Taelmíra, sharp as the edge of a tempered blade—aye, the ever-dangerous. What tales you must bear, what secrets yet unsung.”

The two of them smiled as the words of Travers Aramir praised them both, but it was not Judas who spoke first, but the dark elf. She said, “There is darkness upon this land. I have seen the souls of men who are neither of the living nor dead. In the ancient ruins of Zhal Durath, a sorcerer dwells there, one who raises the dead and is held over even the Hundabald Orcs.” The eyes of Aramir opened in such a facet that seemed impossible for a man of his wear and tear, yet the simple utterance of the word, *Hundabald*, had stirred great fear within the elderly man.

Ulfar, who was much more oblivious to the greater history of the world beyond the realms of man, had simply heard the word orcs and knew it must be some evil beyond his current endeavour. Though deep down he had not a clue what the word *hundabald* even meant, and then declared this, “We cannot worry about this talk of orcs and magical beings, our focus must first and foremost be this dreaded woman, Anne.” His words spoke volumes, words that would echo throughout the ages, remembered in great songs and deeds of history books.

Aramir looked with a gaze of discontent at the man and spoke with a deep breath—one which bellowed his voice, “Ah, your thoughts are shackled, friend—bound in the narrow ways of war and command. You are not merely a general to bear sword and banner; no, you are called to something far greater. The burdens of the free realms shall soon rest upon your shoulders, should you dare to pursue the heights your ambition sets before you.” His voice stirred the thoughts of Ulfar; it was not a slight at the boy but a lesson, said plainly.

“He is right, you know?” Judas gestures towards the younger man and the elderly poor wander lets his voice come once again, “Let me tell you, the worries of the shores beyond

and these 'magical beings' will come to mould your life as they have mine. You are right in one thing, you must first focus on the war you wage, but do not forget of the greater world. I've borne witness to many who do such and seen them fall as well."

Ulfar walked forth, taking the hand of Judas Preiko and simply said, "Then I ask you but one thing, not for your pledge of fealty, not for you to take up your sword in your name and your honour by my side as a warrior of Valkoria, yet just your wisdom—the lifetime of knowledge you have. I know the presence of a Watcher of Valkoria when my eyes come across one. I have studied the books and heard all the stories, enough so that I may just call you friend, eternal walker."

The eyes of Judas became stern as the worn and dusted beard of the man showed not his age but the wear of war. His lips cracked and scarred from events of his past; the words in which he spoke carried a weight no man had ever beheld. He said to Ulfar, "You, Ulfar, I will draw blade with you until the end, all the way until you alone have the blood of Valkoria united under one banner once more. And you have my knowledge." His promise was not one of hope but of truth; his words cut through the air with wisdom and also with passion none could come to doubt.

Ulfar's face softened into a slight, determined smile as he released the hand of his newfound ally. His voice rose, steady and commanding as he addressed those assembled before him. "Tonight, we rest. But tomorrow, we make way for the Parcival, and we shall burn down that station of heresy."

The resolve of the gathered men stirred, shoulders squared, and jaws set in preparation for the trials to come. Ulfar made way into his flock of allies and began a night of festive enjoyment before that long and sorrowful tread toward the edge of fate.

Travers Aramir and Judas Preiko rested upon a worn wooden bench, one of which showed as much age as the two elder men who rested upon it. And so they sat beside one

another, a scene which had unfolded many times in their lives upon this mortal world. For many minutes, there were no words between the two wandering fools until a cough of the bearded wizard broke their silence.

After a rough cough and clearing of his throat, the elder being spoke, “He is young still, but there has been a change in him—real change, and not the sort that flickers and fades. In just these few short weeks, he has begun to find the shape of the man he may yet become. But mark this—his haste, and that gnawing ambition of his, they will be the hardest trials he must master. I’ve seen such fire before, in one you too knew well, old friend. And I tell you now: it may forge a great servant of the free realms, or consume him before he sees the crown of dawn.”

Judas looks upon the man and offers a draw of a pipe, a common habit of these two dreaded friends, as he spoke, “Oh yes, he does remind me of Hónir, especially in his youth. The wild spirit, the untamed stallion who dared to challenge a force so great. Those were times of greater men, though very few still remain and fewer remember their names and deeds.”

After a draw, Aramir lets the smoke take flight in the form of a dragon, a simple, small ghastly Draker. “These quiet nights... aye, I have come to miss them in the long years since that time, yet then I was here on different business. Perhaps he shall follow the path of Hónir, or walk the way of Daryun. But such things are not for us to decide. We can only choose what to do with the paths that are given to us.” His words trailed with the fading of the smoke exhaled from the two.

A chuckle comes from the aged warrior who unveils an amulet which bears the mark of a long lost sacrifice, “What was it you went by then? I believe it was something the Black?” His question comes slightly sarcastic, with a short breath and chuckle, the man turns to stone, his tone much the same, “I would never wish his sufferance upon anyone, even the likes of Malachar or Valkar. A man who suffered the weight of endless lives for his brothers is something only one could ever do. I pray

just once I see that man once, perhaps the Lord will give me this.”

He holds the amulet which glimmers in the light of the moons, etched with the Brand of Daryun—a crimson sigil shaped as an eye wreathed in flame, pierced by three strokes, the mark of the First Warrior's sorrow and unrelenting resolve.

Aramir looked deep within the metal, which told a tale that many would never know, “Few indeed now recall what he did—fewer still remember his name. And yet many come to gaze upon the Mark of Krahn... a curse not cast upon him, but born with him, shadow-bound from the first breath. Tell me, dear friend.” He pauses and takes a draw from the aged red oak pipe handed to him by Judas, “Why was it that you came when I called?”

The smoke which came from the pipe placed a haze on the dimming light and the embers of the tobacco weed within the chamber of the wooden tool. There was a hesitation in the voice of the man before he spoke once more, “Well, it is a question that has shifted through my mind since you called me back after. It is a wonder which has shaped my current vision.”

He pauses as if to pass over a flowing of emotions uncharacteristic of this stoic man, “I have failed once, in what seems another life. Yet I had failed again with Deidlee, perhaps it is this sorrowful nature within me, this desire to have redemption and mercy. A redemption I have in the greater good of God.”

Travers Aramir places a hand upon his friend's shoulder and speaks through the exhaled smoke, “It lies within the very nature woven into us at the first shaping—set there by the hand of the Father. As to why I called upon you, dear friend... There are many threads in that tapestry, each knotted with care and purpose.” He was cut off by Judas, who spoke as if he came to an utter realisation.

“I am scared.” There was a shaken nature to the stoic man, the man who was in all essence embodied by the being of someone who feared nothing except his Creator, yet he showed a

chink in that armour. He continued, "I am afraid, and this, knowing at any moment I could be brought to the end, gives me courage or—rather, perhaps he gives me courage."

The two arise from the bench, and with this, Judas grasps his red oak pipe once more and without a word, both of them ignite their tobacco weed and venture off into a distant walk filled with smoke and laughs yet first as they arose the wise old wizard spoke once more, "Perhaps we both fear what this world has become. Yet somehow—he gives us all courage. In all our long years, few have borne such a gift. And now, in the shadow's rise, he stands—kindling that light anew." The two left with not another word, for all that needed saying had been said, and now it was just a game of patience for the next move of this light in the dark.

As the night settled and the daylight dwindled, preparations for the imminent clash unfolded. With grim determination, soldiers worked tirelessly, felling trees from the nearby woods to gather materials for the tools and machines of siege. The rhythm of axes striking bark echoed through the forest, a cadence of iron and grit as lumber fell to be shaped into battering rams and towers, weapons to bring the zealots behind Parcival's walls to their knees. The fires of the forge roared into the night, casting an ominous glow over the gathering army as iron was smelted, hammered, and sharpened into deadly blades.

As dawn broke, it revealed a scarlet-tinged sky—the final dawn of autumn, when the last golden leaf clings in silence before the hush of winter. The sky was a vicious yet sombre shade of rose and other reds. The trees stood like watchful sentinels in mourning, their branches bare but noble, as if saluting the dying season, yet there was no rain, no tones of depressing nature; it was gleeful yet as if to pay homage to the lives of those past. The wind carried with it the scent of frost and fallen leaves, a fragrance steeped in memory. This was the eve of forgetting, and yet also of remembrance—the revered Day of Alundé.

Named for the Alundél, the divine origin, the spark of creation said to dwell in the first breath of the world, the Alundél had become more myth than memory by the waning days of the Third Era. But even so, men whispered a fraction of its name in reverence, as if some part of the old flame still burned in the marrow of their bones. The books and tomes of mortal men had long lost the names and great deeds of those who forged this; even in this, there was a memory which came naturally in the souls of men. They bound oaths in the hush before sunrise, shaping prayers not only for survival but for the soul, for the things that must be kept whole when the body and blade falter.

For ahead lay a march long and gruelling—through broken hills and forest paths choked with the hush of things forgotten or worst of all hidden within the pages of time. Every step carried them closer to the spectre of battle, to a place where autumn would not return, and the light of Alundé—if still it burned—would be tested in the shadow of war. The world was turning—its breath colder, its silence deeper. And the hearts of men braced, not merely for the clash of steel, but for the reckoning of all that still endured within them.

Ulfar's army gathered along the northern road, where cobblestones stretched into the distance like an endless ribbon winding through the ancient trees and rugged hills. Ahead of them lay the southern fork, and there, as rumours had warned, General Rao's forces of the Neimar Imperium waited, sent under the command of General Seidel to defend the Parcival.

Rao, a formidable commander and ruthless defender of the Imperium's cause, was said to be unwavering—a force like iron—a looming figure in the minds of all who now marched toward the city. As Ulfar's army made its advance, shadows stretched across the land, dark and resolute, moving toward destiny. The men's thoughts turned inward, bracing for what lay ahead, each step closer to the place where words would fall silent, and steel would speak in their stead.

The forces lay in wait, and silence thickened over the land, as if nature itself held its breath before the storm. Blood was destined to stain the fields once more, for humanity, relentless in its nature, had again embraced that age-old inevitability: war. Along the rebel lines, men of hardened resolve awaited not the charge but the call to siege, their hearts steady, their purpose unbroken. This fragile quiet was shattered by the first thunderous release—a catapult's strained arm flinging forth its payload. In an instant, the heavens rained fire and stone, splintered beams and shards crashing from above.

The first collision sent a tremor through the ranks of the Imperium, a feverish frenzy rippling out like cracks across glass. The horn had not even sounded, and already their lines wavered, the enemy's structure cracked before they could mount a proper defence. The General's control slipped through his grasp as the field descended into chaos. Some among the Imperium's ranks lunged forward in desperate aggression, while others turned to flee, and still others, driven by fear, sought refuge within the walls of the Parcival—a haven that had yet to face the siege's wrath.

Ulfar's strategy unfurled with merciless precision, each piece falling into place, each movement showing how the Imperium lacked professionalism. Arrows from the rebel archers streaked through the air like bolts of judgment, raining down in unison with stones and debris, cutting swathes through the panicked hundreds of men who stood so idly and were caught in a trap. The advantage grew tenfold as the second half of the Stormfang army surged forth onto the field, bolstering the aerial onslaught with relentless volleys of arrows and deadly siege machines. The battle had become a tempest, and the men of the Imperium stood as trees in a storm, their fate sealed in the eye of Ulfar's unyielding design.

It was only after nearly an hour of decimating the ranks of the army that once guarded the road north that Ulfar turned his attention towards the wooden hall of heresy. But first he called

out to all the men, “Ride riders and cut down all who still stand, all who wield blade against are cause have forsaken their lives!”

As the cavalry came charging from the lines of the Stormfangs, the world of the Imperium seemed to fall to ash; those who had a sense of their own began to lay down arms and flee into the wilderness, though even that was a sentence to death. It was nothing but a bloodbath; the general of the Imperium, Rao, was only able to gather a fraction of his force into an organised charge against their enemy. Yet even that was proven to be in vain, for he came to clash with Dex, who, with a single swing of his immense sword, sent him to the grave, taking the head of the enemy they fought.

From then on, it was a simple mission of capturing and slaughtering those who still stood, but do not take it as flawless for the rebels; many came to rise with the valkyries and meet their creator in the Undying Havens.

The valiant Captain Leonheart, a man of unwavering resolve and a heart bound to honour, met his fate amidst the clash of steel and the thundering hooves of the enemy's remaining cavalry. His sword rose for the final time, a brilliant flash of silver in the murky fray, as he faced his foes with the same strength he had shown his men time and again. His gaze hardened, his grip steady, he deflected one last blow and struck forward, relentless even as his strength waned. But fate had called him to a higher path, and as the dust settled around him, his body stilled, his spirit unshackled.

In that solemn instant, Captain Leonheart took to the skies, his spirit joined by that of his fallen brothers, who were lost to memory yet never forgotten in all their hearts. Together, the fallen soared above the blood-stained field, bound not by earthly ties but by an eternal bond forged in the fires of loyalty and sacrifice. In the light beyond, the brothers were once again united, champions of an unbreakable oath and a legacy that would echo long after the last sword had fallen. Then came the

horn from the rear of their army, which signified that the bombardment of the Parcival was prepared and ready.

Chapter 11

In Faith

The Zealots of Judd, subservient to only the man who bore that name, were nothing more than a mob which would respond to his every call. Within the walls, they sat with no care of the battle and bloodshed waging beyond the wooden walls, for High Zealot Zek Judd had assured all of them that their Lords were on their side, not those of whom he called the heretics.

He voiced aloud for the entire Parcival to hear, “For what cause dost thou brandish such hubris upon this battlefield, claiming the favour of thy false faith? Know ye not that we hold the might of the true gods close to our breast, not the heresies of those who march yonder? No mortal hand may harm us, for we shall prove unto all who inhabit this world who among us holds steadfast to the truest faith!” His hands extended towards the heavens as he spoke, further rallying those around to his message.

It was as if he thought that their gods would place an invisible shield above them, but even they were mistaken. For as the clock struck the hour of noon, the first of many fiery blows from the heavens would fall like drops of burning water upon the wood-dominated fort. Though they had a cathedral of stone, when they removed all signs of the old faith, they left much to be rebuilt with wood. Some whispered that such fire had not rained from the sky since the days of the Infernal Crisis, when the heavens themselves wept flame upon the earth.

It was a simple man, one who had just seen his life turn. Zealot Cairo, who had recently been promoted within the order,

would be the first to fall. After he finished a prayer, the ball of flames struck and engulfed the building within a fervent flame that quickly burned the supports and brought down a cloth upon the young man and set his robes to flame like an oil-covered torch. His screams were like an alarm alerting all to the false message of their leader, who had sealed the gates before this had begun.

Within the gates of the once proud fortress of the faith, there was nothing but echoes and screams of zealots who had become one with the amber flames that spread wild across the area. The place, built mostly of wood, had taken to the sky in flames and ash. The main place of worship was what remained, as it was mostly crafted of stone; the chapel was the only place untouched by the marks of war.

Ulfar rode his steed, Blackmere. The beast was a sight to behold, a stallion of such might and majesty that he seemed hewn from shadow and steel. His coat, a blend of deep gunmetal grey and dark charcoal, shimmered in the half-light like smoke kissed by embers. Muscles rippled beneath his sleek hide, powerful and ready, each stride a thunderous testament to his strength. His mane flowed in wild waves of midnight, catching the faint glint of light and giving him an otherworldly aura, as if he were some ancient spirit of battle bound in equine form. Eyes dark as the storm-tossed seas reflected both a primal fury and a fierce loyalty to his rider, Ulfar.

Armour adomed his neck and chest, an intricate lattice of burnished steel etched with ancient Valkorian runes that caught and held the light with a spectral gleam, and scars bore witness to countless battles fought side-by-side. As he moved, drawing close to the blackened, crumbling gate, shadows danced on its scorched wood.

The air was thick with the scent of ash and ruin, and Ulfar's voice cut through it like the call of a war drum. "Bring forth the ram!" He commanded, the fire in his eyes mirrored by Blackmere's steely, unflinching gaze. "Let it shatter these feeble

remains; we must carve a path to the heart of this cursed ground, to the chapel where darkness festers.” Whispers clung to the stone walls like soot, and even the boldest claimed the chapel echoed with shadows no mortal war had cast—not since the days when hell itself breached the veil.

With a rumble, the men gathered, heaving the mighty battering ram into position, each hand on it steady, their faces set in grim determination. The gate loomed before them, a towering monolith of charred wood, its once-majestic carvings now reduced to smudged shadows of a forgotten glory. Jagged fissures spider-webbed across its surface, and the acrid scent of scorched timber mingled with the moist air, a testament to countless failed assaults. As the ram swung back, the thunderous roar of men and wood combined, striking hard, like a storm crashing upon a frail shore.

The gate seemed to tremble in anticipation, each strike reverberating through its battered frame. Another blow followed, the impact echoing like a war drum, and with each assault, the ancient timbers groaned in protest, splinters erupting like shrapnel into the air. The hinges, rusted and weary, squealed in anguish as they strained under the relentless assault, while the ground shook with the fury of their efforts. Dust swirled around them, swirling like ghosts of the past, and in that moment, the gate was not merely wood and iron but a formidable barrier steeped in history, standing defiantly against the tide of men determined to break through.

The siege engine shuddered violently as the massive wooden wheels creaked under their immense weight, each groan a sinister herald of the destruction to come. The air grew thick with tension, as if the world itself held its breath, anticipating the splintering crash that would soon echo through the night. With a final, earth-shaking roar, the iron-banded ram lunged forward, its heavy frame groaning and buckling against the relentless forces at play.

In a cataclysmic clash, the ancient gate of the Parcival gave way, splintering into ruin like the brittle bones of a fallen giant. Fragments of wood flew in all directions, some striking the ground with a hollow thud, while others embedded themselves in the earth, reminders of the gate's former glory. Through the newly formed breach thundered the riders, Ulfar's vanguard pouring in like a dark flood, a tide of chaos and fury that surged past the remnants of the barricade.

The riders cleared a path with ruthless precision, their fury and purpose forged in the fires of rebellion. Their blades flashed in the dim light, reflecting the crimson hues of battle as they swept through the defenders, a relentless storm of steel and resolve. The clash of weapons rang out, a symphony of chaos that reverberated through the air, drowning out the cries of the fallen and the desperate shouts of those trying to defend their crumbling stronghold. With each sweeping strike, the riders carved their path, relentless in their pursuit of victory, embodying the very essence of the storm they had unleashed upon the unsuspecting fortress.

Men and zealots from the Parcival shouted slurs and curses, voices filled with anger and fear. One voice rang out, shrill with a bitter curse: "I pray the gods bring ruin upon thy blood! May they smite thy firstborn!"

Arryn, a young rider clad in battle-worn armour, wheeled his horse around to face the man who cursed him. The light of fierce resolve blazed in his eyes as he rode past, his blade flashing in a swift arc. "Choke upon thine own blood!" He spat, his voice cold and unyielding. With a single, fluid motion, Arryn's sword bit into the throat of the zealot, silencing the curse with a spray of crimson.

All around him, his comrades carved their way forward. Riders leapt over rubble and broken bodies, hooves striking sparks as they surged deeper into the courtyard, slashing aside defenders who dared bar their way. The zealots' fury grew more desperate, hurling insults as they fell, some shouting oaths,

others hurling their shields in a futile attempt to halt the advance. But it was as if Ulfar's riders had become shadows, moving like a storm as they paved a path of blood and terror through the sacred grounds.

Further in, the high walls of the Parcival's main chapel loomed. Its stone facade cast an imposing shadow, but the riders were relentless, spurred on by the promise of liberation and revenge. Amidst them, Arryn wiped his blade on his cloak, readying himself for the final push. Here, they stopped as more riders of the rebellion took to the deeper alleyways of the city, cutting down all who still detested them.

The darkened steed of Ulfar carried him to the main chapel, for which that fortress got its name, the Parcival. He stepped down from his horse, removing the standard yet decorated helmet he wore and calling out a single name, “Zek Judd! Come and face me with honour, and maybe the Gods shall see you with some fortune!” The soldiers who surrounded him were confused as to why he would call for such a loathsome creature who created this religious order. Ariendria, Taelmíra and Judas were the only ones present who had the answer.

For several long moments, silence hung heavy in the air, thick as fog, and not a whisper or sound could be heard. Then, almost imperceptibly, a shadow shifted, stepping forward into the dim light—a figure of authority, cloaked in regalia so rich and intricate it seemed to capture and refract the very essence of the room. The man's robe was no ordinary garb; it was a tapestry of shimmering gemstones and finely worked metals, each rivet a gleaming piece of a mosaic that told tales of ancient bloodlines, esoteric oaths, and an order steeped in the mysteries of ages. The fabrics were layered and woven in patterns that suggested both wealth and heritage, marking him unmistakably as a figure of prominence.

In his hand, he bore a weapon unlike any other—a khopesh, its blade fashioned in a deadly, elegant arc, curving forward with the sharpness and cunning of a serpent. The metal

shimmered in the light, its edge honed to a razor's bite, each curve meticulously crafted to embody both lethality and grace. This was no simple sword but a relic, its style rare and enigmatic, a weapon chosen as much for its symbolism as for its deadly purpose.

The man's face was framed by a beard of modest length, meticulously groomed, hinting at his reverence for both tradition and discipline. His beard lay between a light stubble and a fuller growth, as though he lived in careful balance between the grizzled wisdom of age and the keen edge of youthful strength. His eyes, sharp and unyielding, flicked across the room, assessing, calculating, yet betraying no hint of surprise or fear.

Around them, the air was thick with tension as Ulfar's gaze bore into Judd, his expression twisted in disgust. With a swift motion, he drew Arenith from his hip, the blade glinting ominously in the dim light. "You." He growled, his voice low and seething, "You will pay for what you have done, Judd."

The words hung in the air, heavy with the weight of unresolved anger and the promise of retribution. They sparked an immediate reaction in Judd, who began to pace back and forth, a predatory grin spreading across his face. The religious leader tightened his grip on his own blade, emboldened by his perceived advantage. "Oh, indeed," he retorted, his voice dripping with mockery. "Thou dost still anguish over deeds long past—over what was wrought by my own hand those many years ago. I perceive that my letter hath found thee at last, and the proof therein sufficed, did it not? Ha!"

The sound of his laughter reverberated through the air, deep and mocking, as if he revelled in the pain he had caused. "Aye, he did scream as he met his end, though he did not plead for mercy—ah, but that was beyond him, for I had stripped him of the very breath to beg. My only regret? That I did not draw his suffering longer, that I did not make the old fool grovel before the blade found its mark. Your father was a pleasure to torture

until the queen stood her before him... as, soon enough, you shall be in the same position.”

Each taunt pierced Ulfar like a dagger, each word twisting the knife deeper into the raw wound of his past. Yet amid the maelstrom of emotions, a calm descended upon him, fortifying his resolve. He clenched Arenith tighter, feeling the familiar weight of the weapon in his hand, grounding him. Without further hesitation, Ulfar lunged forward, the clash of steel ringing out as their blades met in a dance of death. The sound echoed ominously in the clearing, reverberating through the tension-laden air.

Judd countered swiftly, his movements fluid and calculated, but Ulfar met each strike with a precision born of desperation and anger. The duel unfolded as a tempest of strikes and parries, each warrior pushing the other to the brink. Ulfar's focus sharpened; he felt the blood of his father surging through his veins, urging him on, driving him to vanquish the man who had wrought so much pain. As the fight raged, Judd's laughter faded into heavy breaths, and the smirk that once graced his face twisted into a grimace of exertion. Ulfar pressed forward, channelling every ounce of fury he had pent up over the years into each swing of his blade.

With one final, powerful strike, Ulfar sent Judd stumbling back, the edge of Arenith glinting in the waning light, poised at Judd's throat. The moment hung suspended in time, the world around them fading into silence as Ulfar's eyes locked onto Judd's, filled with the fire of a thousand battles, the fury of loss, and the weight of impending justice. The tip of the blade hovered mere hairs from Judd's skin, poised to deliver the final blow that would end the reign of terror he had wrought. Ulfar inhaled deeply, his heart racing, his purpose clear, but the finality of the moment stretched endlessly before him, leaving the outcome yet to be determined.

Then from far beyond came a voice, the voice of Travers Aramir, “You are no butcher of men, Ulfar Val, no ruthless

marauder. You are the one who seeks the throne, the one who would lead this land. Is that not true?" He approaches, kicking the fallen weapon of Judd away and knocking his staff upon the head of Ulfar.

He continues with, "Have you no wisdom in that heart of yours? A king truly worthy of that sword and amulet does not strike for vengeance, but lets the scale of justice serve those who have suffered. Keep him as your prisoner, then place him before the people of this land—the ones he has so grievously wronged—and let *them* decide his fate. That is the mark of a just ruler, Ulfar. There is still much you must learn, young king."

Ease came with the words of the elderly man, which let them send a sense of calm through the young soul who breathed a soothing breath through his nose before he took the blade back as he motioned for his soldiers to detain the man.

"There was a time I still would have taken your head, your time shall come, and it will not be I who gives you your sentence but the people of my kingdom." He sheaths Arenith the class out to all the men, "Let us give them a chance to surrender, but not at the stake of your life, though."

Though it was a simple battle and one siege that would be nothing near what lay in the future for this grand army, they must take the time to mourn those who fell and came to rise with the valkyries on this fine day. The men of the land sang songs and celebrated as the day came to night, and at the fork of the great road, made camp, in which they would rest and build the strategy for the greater steps of their king's campaign.

The land that had seen the loss of much blood was now glowing in an amber haze. This was a place that would forever bear the stain of man's blind indifference to their fellow man, just as others across this great world had also. The night seemed to go with ease as the next day had dawned, and with it, the men of the army did all they could to stay prepared for their coming battles.

Judas Preiko approached the second elf of their company, "You still have the mark of the Imperium, perhaps you would make good use of seeing the path ahead?" Asked the lady Taelmíra, his voice was somewhat more casual than his previous one.

"Perhaps you are right, a rare feat, rarer for a human." Taelmíra lets out a chuckle to fill the air as she shakes his hand. Giving a nod, letting her hair show once more in the early morning, a sight which was unique even to Judas' long life. As she walks away, she pulls the hood of Judas' shroud over him, prompting the halfling who stood by the two to also laugh.

The shrouded man was approached by a familiar face, which at first he only caught the old man Aramir, until he gazed lower and, with a grin, noticed his dear little friend Rudy. He said to both, "How does this day find you, my dear friends?"

The first to answer, to no one's surprise, was the little halfling Rudy, who jumped and said to his dear friend, "Aye, the night's sleep was no' bad at all, if ye ask me. But the fact we've only had the one meal—now that's a right worry! We Dulmir are used to at least six or seven a day, ye ken?" His face is serious, but also adorned with a grin that turns into a cackle of laughter from the little one.

The age-old wizard drew out his usual pipe and was taking puffs from it while the little one spoke. His face was wrinkling over the change of tobacco present within the pipe, a snarl, but then an odd look of good taste overtook his countenance. From his mouth, the wizard blew a stream of smoke that came to take the form of an eagle that flaps its wings with grace and danced through the air until it too became one with the world again. His brows bent up then down as his eyes widened when the little Rudy reached for the pipe, he had a smile come across his old wrinkled face as if to laugh at an outcome he knew to happen already.

With a shake of his head as if to ready the little one, he took not a small breath but one of great stature, even for your

average man. The little creature, as if he were no mere novice to such tasks, blows a perfect ring that glides through the air, prompting Judas to take his pipe and shoot a stream of smoke, like an arrow, straight through the fading ring.

They erupt in laughter as the old wizard takes his pipe back and says, “You may find yourself regretting such a hearty draw, my friend, for this is no common leaf from the farmlands you know so well. This tobacco is of ancient stock, aged and tended by elven hands for nearly a thousand years—a taste rich with history, not easily forgotten.” His face is taken by a hearty smile in which he locks eyes with Rudy and takes yet another deep inhale from the pipe.

He continues with, “The day, it seems, has shown us all its kindness. Even in these grim times, it is moments like these—moments of laughter, of shared joy—that brace our spirits against the shadows pressing in. A smile or a jest among dear friends warms even the most hardened of hearts. But tread carefully around those whose hearts are neither hardened nor darkened, but rather shattered, worn thin by sorrow and loss. Even now they dwell amongst us, and be not afraid but warming to them. Such hearts are delicate things; they bear scars too deep to be seen, wounds that time may mend only in quiet patience. To press them for joy would be as futile as demanding the winter thaw before its time, only offering gentle light and patient company until they choose to rise.”

The three newfound friends still sit and talk as Judas again speaks, “I presume you know it, but this war is one that has spanned centuries, little master.” He kneels and takes the hands of his friend Rudy, “This war has claimed the lives of Ulfar’s father, Aelfred, and his father before him, Talus. It has taken countless others, and will yet take countless more. For even as we lay siege to the capital for years, we shall see the bloodshed of those who remain ever loyal to Anne. They will not yield, nor will they falter; they fight as though bound by oaths older than memory, driven by a loyalty that neither time nor reason can

unbind. And so, we must steel ourselves—this road will demand much of us, perhaps all that we are.”

The voice of the man is filled with wisdom as if each word was spun from the threads of one who has seen much of the world. He then continued the words he said to the young one, “For I ask but one thing of you, my friend: protect the women and children we must leave behind. This path ahead is not yours to tread, a road marked by darkness and dread. Promise me this, dear friend, that you will keep them safe in our stead.”

The eyes of Judas are as pure and quaint marbles, orbs that paint the very emotions of passion and deep-felt love for the little one upon his face. Rudy knew without even uttering a word that he had inked a promise to the man. For he had not known him long yet felt as though they had been companions for a hundred lifetimes.

Before Rudy dared part his lips to form a single word, he managed but a quiet nod of agreement. In that stillness, Travers Aramir stepped forward, his old, weathered hands settling firmly on both their shoulders. His fingers, rough as bark yet steady as old stone, bore the wear of a life etched by years of toil and wisdom. With the slow, creaking sigh that only age could muster, Travers lowered himself—not quite to their level, but just above, casting a long shadow. His knees bent, a testament to the strength that had weathered many winters, yet now bore the weight of years more than battles. His gaze, however, held the vitality of a flame undimmed, and as he peered down at them, his presence seemed both tender and solemn. His closeness, his grip—gentle yet strong—was enough to impart unspoken guidance, as if the wisdom of ages passed in silence between them.

The greyed wizard then left them with an utterance, he said, “He is right to ask that of you, as you are right to ask him to protect those you care for so much. I will say that the darkness on this continent is not before us but to our rear, something in which you may come to face Rudy. In all my years, no race has

brought me greater surprise than you simple Dulmir, such small creatures—but ever filled with great excitement.”

The gaze of the three is then directed to Ulfar, who moves, weaving in and out of the way of training soldiers, helping them as he goes. To the unsuspected person, you would think nothing more of him than a normal soldier, perhaps a commander of some sort. They watched as the man was seemingly on a direct mission, a single goal in mind, though he would occasionally get distracted with the minor correction of one's form.

He walked through the plains; it was clear he was in search of someone, a particular someone—Ariendria. She sat alone at the most northern point of the encampment, the area which seemed to be the farthest away from the gait of the young Ulfar, who turned into something more of a run as he made his way in such a quick fashion to the elven lady.

After what felt like an hour of relentless running, of swords clashing as he passed men who trained, Ulfar finally emerged before her. A place sparse with trees, where a biting wind whispered through the branches. There, upon a weathered stone, sat the very one he sought—Ariendria. A calm settled over him as his gaze fell upon her, and for the first time in a long while, the weight of his journey lifted, if only for a breath. Here, in the stillness, he could feel his mind ease, his heart steady. And as his eyes beheld her fully, truly, it struck him how words were feeble vessels to capture what lay before him.

This woman, poised in a world of silence and twilight, was beyond the simple language of men. In that instant, without thought, a word passed his lips, unfamiliar to his own tongue yet flowing with a strange knowing. “Lindé.” He murmured, a Thalorian word for beauty—yet more than that, for it spoke of beauty that transcended, reserved only for moments that defy the ordinary, for sights that inspire the soul to silence.

Yet her ears, which were much keener than those of any man's, had heard his words, and it brought a blush and grin to

the woman's face, as she had now received the compliment and eye of Ulfar she had so wanted in the long months of knowing him.

She then turns to him upon the stone, their gaze locks, and she simply greets him with a smile, saying, "Hello... Ulfar. Your Thalorian needs a bit of work." The smile strewn across her face told a much deeper story, even to Ulfar, who, for a brief second, did not even register that she had spoken to him.

The words had been heard, but his mind had yet to process them as the look upon her face, one of excitement and happiness to see him, had given him the confidence to speak even though his mind was lost in endless wonder at her. His words did not take to the air as he first opened his mouth to speak.

But then his voice came from nowhere, and his words were as if he had never spoken to a woman before, quite different from any previous interaction of the two, "Uh...greetings, Ariendria. How—how are y-you...doing?" His face is overcome with a red blush, which is contrary to something that would happen to a man of his stature and persona.

She chuckles at the blunder and stutters of Ulfar as she herself is overcome with a sense of anxiety, one which she has never felt in her thousands of years on this world. She then stuttered before she could get even a full word out, "I-I'm doing good, how are you?"

The tension between them softened into a warmth neither had anticipated, their laughter dispelling the awkwardness with ease. Ulfar settled beside her, trying to conceal the nervous smile that lingered on his face, but the way she leaned against him with that mischievous glint in her eye was impossible to ignore. Ariendria's hand brushed his as she steadied herself, her gaze meeting his, and in that moment, words seemed both unnecessary and vital.

Ulfar spoke first to break the silence by saying to Ariendria, “So... I—I must admit,” he began, his voice softer than she had ever heard it, “I never imagined I'd find myself this... this clumsy with words. I'm, well... rather fresh out of them actually.”

Ariendria's cheeks tinted with a blush that matched his own. “I think it's endearing,” she replied, her own voice wavering slightly, though she held a full composure. “Quite ironic, a warrior who's faced countless men in battle, and dreamt the darkest evils of the world, yet here, with me, he stumbles over words. Perhaps, that makes you all the more intriguing, Ulfar Val.” A faint smile hugged her lips as she spoke to the man.

He chuckled, the sound low and genuine, as he looked down at her hand now resting near his. “I should warn you, Ariendria, if you continue with such compliments, I may become unbearable.”

Her eyes take on a shimmer as she gazes at the man, one who has only been seen in this world a few other times. She then says, “Oh, then I shall have to keep them to a minimum,” she teased, her eyes bright with laughter.

They sat there, both enchanted by the other, as their laughter faded into a companionable silence. The world around them seemed to still, each pulse of their shared glance conveying the mutual affection neither had yet dared to fully admit.

A moment later, he spoke again, more resolute, “You know... meeting you has been like discovering something I never knew I'd longed for,” he confessed, his voice laced with both awe and sincerity.

Her smile softened, and she looked at him, eyes gentle yet unwavering. “Then it seems,” she whispered, leaning just a fraction closer, “we both carry the same unexpected longing.”

Lingering in the depths of Ulfar's mind as well as the mind of the fair Ariendria was the long-distant tale of Drewen and Llyena, the Elven man and the woman born of mankind.

Ariendria drew roots to them as her father and uncle, Lord Eluiar of Elendaiél and Raseiré, who fell to a shortened life before the birth of his niece Ariendria.

The tale was one that echoes the same sentiment as the Tragedy of Vaxar and was a reason as to why humans and elves were told to never entangle themselves in the romantics of mixing their races. But to Ariendria, it was quite a different story as she was born of a father who was half human, though her mother was of pure elven lineage; she was given a choice of life by their creator.

Vaemiea had given her a choice, as was the same one her father and uncle both were presented with; the pair chose the opposite path, as her father, Lord Eluiar, chose the life of an elf. But for her uncle, he sought that of the human, though unlike them she was only a quarter human and did not attribute many of the qualities, oddly though she was given the same choice as would all who would come to bear her father's blood. As the two drifted off in much more endless conversation, this lingering thought was constant within the mind of Ariendria.

The lady elf Taelmíra would come to talk to the two sworn childhood friends of Ulfar, along with his grandest captain, Dex. She sat on the chilled morning, a few days into the newest preparations for their march to the north; she would be posed an odd question by none other than Gunmar.

He said to her, "Tell me, what would drive a dark elf like yourself to throw in with us? What's in it for you, gettin' mixed up in a scrap that's none of your own? I remember, just as any, that your kin nearly had us shackled like beasts back in the First Era. Thought this was a human fight, no reason for an elf to go diggin' around in."

She let out a laugh as a look forged purely of her long, hardened and vast sarcasm came upon her lavender-blue face. She twirled with ferocity her pure white hair, she licked her lips, then let a slight bite of her tongue while it was exposed to the chilling air.

With a snide attitude, she said to the present men, “As a matter of fact, if I were born at that time, then perhaps Draxel would not have failed. But hey, isn't it the old human adage that if you cannot beat them, join them?” She let out a cackle that was filled with enjoyment for her own satisfaction with her remark.

She takes a deep breath, rolling her eyes, she says with a much more serious tone, with an abrupt snap of her fingers, “With all jokes aside, my blade is known for its ability to take life, so up until a few weeks ago, I was simply a blade for hire. Though there is something in this land I have seen once before, and that drove me to the man you call brother. Someone close to me has taken a keen interest in him as well. Perhaps someday you may have his blade on your side.”

As she finishes, the chilled air is hit with a burst of warm air briefly, yet enough to encourage the words she had finished with. The two men looked puzzled, for little did they truly know of the world beyond their continent.

Vivel simply extended his hand in a good gesture, which was ironic to the elven woman who cared not to shake his hand nor have either of their respects. The man kept his hand out while he said to her, “Though my ancient ancestors may have been adversaries, and be it by some miraculous stroke of luck, I would gladly take the help of others.” With an immense amount of hesitation, she grasps the hand of the man in hers, affirming the gesture made by the naive man.

Dex, another man who was greatly shrouded in mystery, was one who had shown up without any call or beckon at the village of Ulfar Valin nearly a decade ago now. He had said a few words to any man other than Ulfar, and now the mysterious Watcher, Judas Preiko. He was a man of large build, neither gluttonous nor flabby, but a man of what seemed to be pure muscle; his build was something of divine craftsmanship. The man stood well over the height of the average man and elf; something of a giant, he stood just over six and a half feet tall.

His armour was of an ancient forge, seemingly something of delmver craftsmanship as noted by Ummar Gruthric, who had said in a short, entirely one-sided conversation with Dex, “That, my dear friend, is the armour of a great warrior! If my eyes do me right, that must’ve been forged in the ancient fires of Mahdrem Dur! The ancient forges of the long-standing Orotian Kingdom under the Mountain, the purity of the delmver craftsman cannot be matched, dear friend. I’ve got a cousin who lives there. I betcha he can tell us more.” He continued after smacking the jagged yet thick plates that covered the majority of the giant man’s body, “Though it does puzzle me how it came to fit a behemoth such as yourself.”

Beneath the jagged and cutting plates that adomed the body of the man was a much more crisped skin tone that had seen many days under the sun. He was also adorned with countless scars showing the years of war the body had been subjected to. There were vast gaps in the armour, such as the gap from his biceps to his elbow, showing the young yet worn skin of the man.

Upon his left forearm was a thick and powerful armoured gauntlet; his right was first wrapped, then had smaller and more sporadic pieces of metal placed upon it for protection. The gauntlet on his left was of pure blackened steel; there was neither gap nor hole within, and to some, they wondered if there even was the hand of a man below. His head bore many scars, one of which ran through his left eye, which was white and blind to the world around. And his hair was a mixture of greys and black that showed not his age but the experiences of the man.

The blade which he carried was one that drew lineage with the blade of his dear friend Ulfar. The large claymore, which was much different from any ever seen by men and dwarves alike, was made from the legendary metal of the world, Erinstihl. The blade was much wider and thicker than the normal blade of that type, nearly doubling both and bearing a length nearing six feet in length, while the hilt was just shy of a foot.

The weapon was that of immaculate forgery, as the blade was many shades of true steel; the blade itself had various words and runes carved into the metal. Each one was mystical and magical; it held a good omen for the wielder of the blade, but only if he knew the words for each letter of the ancient language. The man who stood before the dark elf was something of a reunion, yet the human had no knowledge of who she was other than the past few days, though it was common for Dex to forget the thousands of faces he'd seen.

He took what was only a handful of steps to pace the typical distance it would take a man at least a dozen or more to achieve. His voice was choked with the experience of a thousand years, though it was rough and coarse like a grating sandpaper upon the sound that came from his chest.

He said to her, "It is as if my mind deceives me, I know you from some point in my life. Whether it be before this," he pulled back the black cloak that covered his neck to reveal the Mark of Krahn, "or in this second life. I do know you, though, as you do know me."

That mark—scarred upon the flesh of few since the mortal world became one with hell itself twice; Infernal Crisis and the days before Valkoria—a mark said to be born not of ink or flame, but of pacts sealed in blood and damnation, were it be called the Mark of Krahn or the Brand of Daryun it was forever a symbol known amongst the tomes of Men and Elves.

Her gaze came to lock with him as she thought briefly, recollecting the memories of her past life, she had come to one that dated back to the Second Era when she was serving as a purchased warrior of a small army. Her mind's eye drew upon the image of the man she saw before her, broken and scarred just as he was now. Though his hair was not quite as dusted as now, his face was not as worn and aged, though still young. His physical size had only become something more strained and muscular as the weight of his massive sword had clearly tuned his body for its use.

Then she came to remember their conversation they had, though only once it rang within the dark halls of long forgotten time. Her eyes showed not the ferocity she had just when talking to Gunmar and Vivel, yet it was sombre; she wished deep down, hoping he had remembered their talk many years ago.

With a gulp, swallowing her fears and anxieties, she said, “Once... long ago, you and I had met, both as soldiers of fortune. I remember a conversation we had once, you and I. We had a long talk about our past lives. I know that mark, branded upon your neck, for it comes from the darkest points of this world. Though to the mind of some, these are simple things to be forgotten.” The sombre tone evolves from that of a surface light sadness to near despair.

The toils and engines of war were echoing from the temporal camp established by the men of the rebellion upon the wreckage of their adversary's greatest monument to its religion. It was here that the final march of the war would be planned, as another day came to a close, nearly a week had passed since the duel between Ulfar and Zek Judd had ended the battle. The men had gathered and all sat waiting for their generals to give them their marching orders, but first, the plan needed to be decided.

The group consisted of Ulfar, Judas, Gunmar, Vivel, Travers Aramir, Ariendria, Dex, Rudy, Ummar Gruthic and Taelmíra, who all stood around the top of a barrel which served as the placeholder for a map of the northern half of Onu-Arith. In it, Vivel placed markers of where they currently are and where, based on their scouts, the enemy would mount its grandest force, which was no other than the Creux Plains, which were the vast open lowlands that led into the capital of Valkoria.

The first of those to speak was Vivel, who addressed all by saying, “Based upon what we have received from our scouts, we know the remaining forces of the Imperium will be with Seidel and the army in the plains that lead to the capital. This is an inevitable battle we must win before we can even dream of a siege of the city.”

Ulfar cuts in when Vivel finishes his first part, “The siege plan has already been drafted for the sake of the citizens; we must execute it a certain way.”

Taelmíra raised a question amongst the council, “Why not divide the force, have one lay siege and the other meet the forces of the Imperium head on? Would this not make much more sense and follow a somewhat similar doctrine to your previous battles?”

The wise and ever-watchful Travers Aramir took a long, thoughtful draw from his pipe, the ember within casting a warm glow upon his weathered face. His moustache curled in contemplation, and a subtle yet knowing gleam touched his eye. As he exhaled, a plume of fragrant smoke drifted into the night air, swirling like whispers of ancient wisdom.

When he spoke, his voice was deep and steady, like the echoes of old stones beneath the earth, each word a lesson hewn from years beyond counting. “It is a curious thing in the tides of war,” he began, his tone both a warning and a guide, “to be neither reckless in simplicity nor so cunning as to stumble upon ruin. Remember this well, for the force we shall soon face numbers that are just a mere hundreds more than us—a host not to be taken lightly, yet the number of warriors greatly dwindles that of the past Taelmíra. The armies of men are no ragged collection of untried youths, nor are they without wisdom. Each soldier is but a blade, sharpened and tempered for the fires of battle. And to divide our own who number just higher than ten thousand strong would be to strip ourselves of unity, to place folly before strength, an error even the mightiest force could not hope to mend.”

His gaze settled upon Lady Taelmíra, his voice softening with a touch of paternal care. “And you, most of all, should understand this, my lady. For even the keenest of strategies cannot substitute for steadfast resolve. Remember—hold your ground, keep the ranks, and let not the shadow of arrogance cloud the light of wisdom.”

He paused, as if seeing some distant memory, then added quietly, “In such times as these, we must be not only warriors but also guardians of all that we cherish, all that is good.”

With that, he drew again from his pipe, his eyes drifting to the distant rolling hills, as though seeking the guidance of stars long extinguished but still watching over those who remain. The whole table was awestruck by the words of the old wizard, who, it seemed, each time his mouth opened, a new lesson was forthcoming.

Here, the heavy yet coarse voice of Ulfar broke the tension over who would follow such words, yet it was not a large sentence or speech from the man. He had simply said, “What other concerns are there to be voiced?”

A sense of arrogance came from Gunmar as he spoke, “We're stronger than these milk-drinkers, our resolve tougher than steel. So I say we don't wait a moment longer—let's take the fight to them! Meet them in the open field, where our cavalry can tear through their lines like wheat at harvest. It's time we end this once and for all, put these pretenders in their place, and strip them of those titles they're unworthy to bear!” He raises his fist up in the air as he screams out his last words.

The brief speech struck a chord with the assembled Delmver warrior, who bellowed, “Skald!” In praise of the man's stirring words.

The usually reserved commander, Dex, stepped forward, his gaze steady and unwavering. “I agree with General Gunmar. We must meet them head-on in this grand battle.”

His voice carried a rare blend of stem resolve and a curious optimism that belied his typical silence. It was as though the prospect of the impending clash had stirred something within him, kindling a fire that even his controlled exterior could not entirely mask.

For the first time in the council, the lone Watcher, Judas, lifted his voice. “Yet we must tread carefully.” He cautioned, his gaze moving over each face gathered around him. “A darkness

beyond our strength stirs once more in the realm of men. We cannot be blind to it. This enemy waits in the shadows, and it is there, unseen, that it may strike when least expected. We must keep vigilant, for every step forward invites unseen eyes and threats that do not sleep.”

Judas paused before he spoke once more, his voice took to the air as it was filled with the very sights he witnessed, “We would do well to recall what slumbered in the earth before the war during the times of Tarédiel, the gates which were torn open as wounds in the mortal veil. Such silence was once mistaken for peace, such calm nature—unassuming it consumed an empire which rivalled that of Valin's.”

Those gathered around the war table exchanged solemn glances, expressions hardened by resolve, the weight of unspoken words filling the air like the last breath before a storm. In the silence, each man understood the other, for nothing more needed to be said—this alone was enough to tell Ulfar his path forward.

Ulfar raised his hand, his voice ringing out across the chamber, “Then we mustn't forget it, we must first clear this hurdle, which is the Imperium, a spawn from the ashes of the empire you mentioned, Judas. We must then take the capital, we must take the throne and free this land.”

His words were a fire, igniting the hearts of those present as they echoed him in a mighty hail. Each commander then moved with purpose, roused by the oath, rallying their men, their spirits unwavering, as they readied themselves for the trek ahead.

The journey to the Creux Plains began before dawn broke, a day and a half's march through barren leagues, each step drawing them closer to the clash which awaited. Among the thousands were men who, with quiet acceptance, knew they may never see their homesteads or feel the warmth of their hearths again. They walked with that burden shared, yet undeterred, each mile a testament to their courage. The hours passed slowly, the land around them shifting to the desolate vastness of the plains.

As the morning of the second day came, the crisp winter air greeted them, sharp and biting against their faces, a chill that burrowed deep. Ahead, the sun crested over the eastern cliffs, casting a pale light across the plains, bathing the earth in a faint warmth that barely held back the winter's grip. The men shivered, yet stood resolute, the stillness of the dawn disturbed only by the breath of their readiness. And there upon the plains, under that indifferent sky, lay the two armies—the largest forces of men yet assembled, poised like coiled serpents, prepared to converge at the sounding of a single horn. Winter had come, bringing with it the agonies of war, and there, upon the Creux Plains, hung the fate of all who dared to dream of peace amidst the brutality of battle.

Chapter 12

The Battle of the Creux Plains

These plains were not fools to the tides of both war and history. During the years of the second era, it was here that man faced off with the darkness that swallowed the continent whole. The Creux Plains, before the Imperium erected the city of Valkoria, lay a city which carried the name of Delvatch, which only still stands as the ruins used by the Imperium to garrison their military.

Their once grand pillars of stone and mortar lay only as remains of a long-dead crown, for those Valkorians had fallen with the cities and men who burned by the hands of the Varnathi, the demons of hell itself who poured from the Infernum thousands of years before. Yet their mark still remained in the petrified tree skeletons which decorated the land.

There stood in patience yet groaning anticipation the armies of men, divided in two; there were those of the Imperium and then the Stormfangs, raiders and those who would call themselves watchers donning the banners of the rebellion. Ulfar did not stand as Seidel did, far back in the rear of the army as if he never sought to see the heat of steel clashing with steel. Ulfar was the spearhead of his men, the focal point who would lead the charge, calling out with his deep battle cry. The men lined as a wall of steel armour-clad and mounted upon the strongest steeds of the southern plains of Onu-Arith.

With a deepened breath, the voice of Ulfar carried across the stretch of thousands who bore his banner, "Hold line! Draw thy blade! And hold fast!" His words were simple, but they were just the beginning of a long wind of words to come from the man

who would be king. He drew his blade, the Sword of the King, the Flame of Valkoria, Arenith. As the blades, spears, and axes of the men before him, he rode his steed, clashing the steel against steel as he called out to all:

Rise riders of the storm!
Rise, riders of the new Valkoria!
Hold fast, arise!
Fear not the blasted arms before us!
Arise! Arise!
Spear, blade, axe and hammer shall spark!
Shield shall break, bones and armour!
Arise! Today is a day of blood, of steel, of death!
Today, we shall free Valkoria!
Ride! Ride to the death!
Ride! Ride!

His words reverberated across the field, borne on the wings of the wind as if the gods themselves had woven their breath into each syllable. The sound filled the air like a call to arms from ages past, stirring the hearts of those who stood in its wake. Steel clashed in its own fierce response, striking sparks that danced like ghostly fireflies in the dawn light, igniting the fearful spirits of men who faced what might be their last day beneath the sun.

With a single, thunderous word—"Ride!"—uttered by their fearless leader, a word laden with the weight of destiny and ancient vows, the riders surged forward, a living wave of fury and resolve. Behind him, the mounted warriors moved as one, a stampede of unstoppable might, each hoofbeat thundering into the ground, shaking the earth as if the land itself quivered beneath the weight of their courage.

The clamour rose to fill the heavens, a cacophony of hooves and heartbeats, a deafening roar that spoke not merely of strength, but of the unbreakable resolve of men who would rather die than falter. The very sky seemed to tremble at their approach,

the air thick with the scent of churned soil, sweat, and the metallic taste of impending bloodshed. The cries of battle and the clash of iron joined the rising crescendo, merging into a rolling thunder that surged forth like an unending storm, an anthem of defiance against fate and death alike.

On this day, man would meet his fellow man in the clash of blades and fury, the brotherhood of battle both uniting and dividing them. Their religion told them some would ascend to the feasting halls of legend, to bask in eternal honour beneath the gaze of gods who welcomed the valiant. Their journey would climax, and so it would lead to the endless mead and the glow of warm fires, where tales would be sung of their deeds forevermore. But those who fought under the shadow of the Imperium, those who had forsaken honour for cruelty and tyranny, would not know the glory of those hallowed halls.

Theirs was a fate bound to the earth, denied the glimmering haven above, for the heavens would not open to welcome souls who had abandoned light for darkness.

The ground seemed to fall away before them, the men and horses hurtling forward with the unyielding strength of mountains breaking free from ancient roots. And as they rode, they carried with them not just swords and spears, but a purpose that shone brighter than any blade—the unquenchable fire of a people who would see freedom, even if it meant plunging into the depths of death to claim it.

The thunder of the cavalry was as if the very bones of the earth trembled underfoot, a rumbling chorus heralding a force beyond mortal reckoning, as if some creature of ancient legend had risen to claim its dominion over this world. Hooves beat upon the ground like the relentless drum of fate, each one an echo of storms long past, carrying with it the weight of battles that had shaped the histories of men.

The riders surged forward, clad in steel and leather, their lances raised like a forest of iron, ready to bring down the wrath of ages upon any who dared to stand in their path. Spears soared

through the sky, piercing the air with an ominous whistle before finding flesh and bone. Arrows rained down like a darkened flock, their flight swift and sure, guided by hands trained in the arts of death. Blades clashed, their sharp edges meeting in a cacophony of sparks, sending shards of light into the grey daylight as if stars themselves had descended to join the fray. The cries of men echoed across the field, each shout and scream a hymn to honour and glory, a testament to the resolve that had carried them through countless wars and skirmishes.

These were men who knew but one constant in life—the art of war. Veterans of countless campaigns, warriors who bore scars like badges of pride, they fought not for conquest alone, but for the legacy they would leave behind, for the lands and lives they protected. Their hands moved with the swiftness of practised skill, each swing calculated, each thrust precise, as if the dance of death were as natural to them as drawing breath. Steel met steel in fierce collisions, blades ringing like the toll of distant bells, calling all to witness the struggle that held no favouritism, no mercy.

This was not a battle of valour or righteousness; it was survival, stripped bare to its essence. Here, it mattered not who was noble or wretched; only who could outlast, who could strike true before the other could raise a shield or parry a blow. Every death was swift, yet marked with an eerie finality, as if each fallen man bore the weight of a story unfinished, a destiny cut short. The Stormfangs, proud and relentless, thundered through the enemy ranks in a furious charge that left chaos in their wake.

Men fell beneath their hooves, trampled as grass beneath the tempest. Their spears, like the teeth of some ancient beast, tore through armour and flesh alike, scattering bodies like fallen leaves. Losses were as numerous as they were uncountable, bodies strewn across the field in a grim tapestry woven by the hand of war. And yet, amid the carnage, they pressed on, undeterred, for the only truth they held was that of the

struggle—the desperate clash of survival, the test of strength and will that bound them all.

They fought not for kings or crowns, but for the legacy that would echo long after the thunder of hooves had faded, for the honour that would bind their names to legend, until even the stars grew dim.

The screams and yells of those who suffered a fate far less than that of mere execution echoed on the open scape of land, the ground itself in areas had become the purest of crimson. The Stormfangs had many who rode with the songs to a new life, but many more of their former brethren came to bear a life no more. As Ulfar walked through the field before him, his armour and face covered in blood that was either of his own or that of the countless men to fall by his hand. The man who would be king sought out the enemy's general for the sole purpose of ending this dreaded conflict. It was a mere slaughter by the first hour of battle.

The cavalry and spearmen of the imperium were grossly outnumbered by the forces of the rebels before them. The remaining hundreds upon horseback for the Stromfangs did simple patterns of weaving in and out, cutting down the fools who remained. Ulfar, riding upon the back of Shadowmere faced a soldier who still drew breath few and far between. Yet the ones he did face, he offered life before ending them to their day of judgement. He searched endlessly for the intellectual genius that legends said the renowned General Seidel was. Yet for all he did, each man he put to the grave, he found nothing; he was but a headless man ever in search of such a thing that no longer existed.

Then, in the gleam of luck, a commander of the rival army called Ulfar to do battle with him, an opportunity which could not be passed upon. The man was meeker in build, lacking the traditional strength seen in that of a warrior. Granted, it was a common occurrence when compared to the poor, who did nothing but train and physically push their bodies, which was

common of the men who served in the army of Ulfar. The man charged Ulfar with great speed and agility, clearly based upon his frame, which was his way of combat.

The frail man slashed his blade with Ulfar, sending not his adversary but himself back when he said, "For my General and Queen I shall slay you!" His voice filled with deep-rooted determination that was something of envy, yet even false hope was not enough, for the pure skill of the two fighters was worlds apart. Ulfar had barely swung his blade, yet the man before him met the ground more than once; he was a fool, his arms not worthy of a blade the size of which he drew. The claymore did nothing more than swing the man around.

A chuckle filled the violent air, filled with the clashing of metal, breaking of shields and the sounds of war. Ulfar then said to the man in a voice that was pure, one not of a man but of a king, he had bequeathed the man before him, "For where is your fair general?"

The words echoed through the head of the meagre man whose mind danced through the thought that he was in battle with this, he thought not to err on the side of caution at this moment, only fury overtook his soul as the opponent with whom he drew blade did neither think of him nor his blade but of his commander. The simple question becomes much more, an insult, something of a pure and utter disrespect.

There was a distant roar heard as the trembling of the ground beneath him, the man saw the riders of whom clashed steel with, but his mind still raced when his mouth opened he had not a retort nor an insult, but he had answered him, "Holding the rear."

The words were not what he thought nor what he had desired to say, but for some reason, forever shrouded in mystery to the man as he was charged by the leader of the enemy before him.

The body of the commander froze, his arms locked unable to move as he simply gazed upon the scene before him

which was the man, Ulfar, who took a few steps and with a fine slice of his blade he took down the commander in front of him, the man which seemed to be nothing but a simple weed in the path before him, a simple road block easily cleared with one fell swoop of the blade. The slice was one of precision, for the blade of his enemy was cut clean through, along with the armour, delivering a mortal wound to the man.

Ulfar called for his steed to return to him as Blackmere stepped over the corpses of the countless fallen before him, and a smell of death and blood was thick in the air. The heat of the bodies that piled created a warm odour to arise from portions of the field; this place would become nothing more than a mass burial for the countless men who fought and died.

The stoic man from upon his horse called out to the field before him, appealing to all ears before him. His voice was one of pure echoes, a strength unparalleled by those around them. The voice came across the wind with an immense power that was unseen by any of the mortals who drew breath upon this field of battle.

Ulfar let out a deepened call, “Seidel! Why do you hide?” The words were not of insult but of calling, a beckoning out to the man he so sought to face. The man who was nearly twenty years his elder was one he had dreamed of facing since this campaign began many years ago. He continued, “Come! I beckon to you! Face me, Seidel!”

The words seemed to echo, carried by winds long travelled from distant hills, his voice threading deeper into the heart of the enemy's lines, like a quiet thunder rolling upon dark shores. The lands, once teeming with the soldiers of the proud Imperium, now lay desolate, the battlegrounds scattered with the broken remnants of armour, of banners once held high, of courage now trodden underfoot.

The ranks had grown thin, shadows stretched where men had once stood resolute, and with each passing hour, the ground grew emptier still, as if the land itself was sighing, retreating

from the weight of what had transpired. The light of day, once a fiery comfort amidst the ruin, began to dim, casting a pale and weary glow upon the bloodstained earth. The warmth that the sun had granted was fading now, its golden rays sinking toward the western horizon as if hastening to leave behind the sorrow it could not banish.

Shadows crept longer, stretching as silent harbingers of the battle's end, a countdown ticking in the minds of those who remained, each minute quickening the beat of Ulfar's heart, each tick of the clock seeming to mock his pursuit. He sensed it—the man he sought, the one his gaze so dreadfully lingered for, the one slipping ever nearer to freedom with each waning flicker of daylight, just beyond his reach, drifting like a spectre into the edge of twilight.

The army of the Imperium, which bore little cavalry, lay decimated across the blood-soaked ground, their once-proud banners now tattered remnants fluttering in the fading light. The marred bodies of man's fellow man lay scattered like forgotten dreams, a haunting testament to the tragic futility of their struggle, while those who still sanctified life stood resolute, their hearts beating with the fervour of righteous purpose. As the night grew ever closer, an ominous shroud enveloped the battlefield, casting long shadows over the fallen.

The proud army, once a bulwark against the tide of chaos, had surrendered its defiance, laying down arms that had gleamed with the promise of valour. Blades, shields, and spears now rested upon the hardened ground, merging with the earth in a silent pact of despair, as if the very soil cradled their hopes and aspirations within its unforgiving grasp. Men dropped to their knees in the face of pure defeat, their spirits crushed beneath the weight of sorrow and loss.

The winds whipped around them, carrying a chilling air that seeped into their bones, freezing the hearts of the defeated to a point far beyond the hopes of their earlier selves. Each gust, folding the wind itself, making it ever colder, whispered tales of

glory turned to ashes, a lament for the camaraderie that had once united them in purpose.

In that sombre twilight, as the sun dipped below the horizon of the west, shielded by the mountains that all saw to see the night sky from once in their lives. The battlefield transformed into a graveyard of shattered and dying dreams, a place where valour met its bitter end. Nothing but death took refuge here—only the shadow of death loomed over this land, one fruitful and encouraging to life itself.

The air, thick with the scent of iron and sorrow, bore witness to the silent cries of the fallen, their memories etched forever in the hearts of those who remained, a haunting reminder of the cost of ambition and the fragility of life embodied in the scene that decorated the and once pure and clean.

As the men ranged, clearing the lands and rounding up those who still lay before them on the field of battle, the tolls of war were self-evident. Names such as Ariendria, Dex, Gunmar, Vivel, Gruthic, Aramir and Taelmíra scanned the scene of hell before them. It was something that only was thought to exist in nightmares and not hundreds lay dead, but unimaginable numbers were no more, and they had seen their day of judgement, facing the lord their god for all their sins.

“Men are cursed. Man, ever the dancer in an endless waltz—three steps: revolution, slaughter, harmony. Always in motion. Always the same. And always, men never fail.” Taelmíra broke the long silence amongst those who drew blades, yet she did not address any—she merely bore witness to the curse of Man. The lady elf had seen much of the world and knew of the cynical cycle that the race of Man ever went through, a prevalent flaw in their design, she curiously wondered why it was such.

The scene lay before them, drawing on the past of Dex. He rode upon his horse, a magnificent beast forged from the very essence of battle. The warhorse was a towering figure, its coat a deep, lustrous black that glimmered like polished obsidian under the waning light. Muscles rippled beneath its skin, honed by

years of training and the ceaseless demands of war. Each powerful stride was a testament to its strength, as it moved with a grace that belied its size, hooves striking the ground with a resonant thud that echoed through the air like distant thunder. Beneath the weight of its armour—ornate yet battle-scarred—the warhorse exuded an aura of unyielding loyalty and fierce spirit. Its barding, adorned with symbols of life and death of honour and sacrifice, gleamed dully, telling tales of countless battles fought and won.

The horse's eyes, fierce and intelligent, shone with a fire that mirrored the heart of its rider, a deep understanding forged through the shared trials of war. A flowing mane, dark as midnight, billowed like a flag in the wind, each strand dancing with the rhythm of their advance. When Dex urged the beast forward, it surged ahead with an explosive burst of speed, a formidable force on the battlefield, charging into the fray with the unwavering determination of its master. Together, they were a force of nature, a tempest of iron and fury that swept across the battlefield, leaving only chaos in their wake.

Dex alone rode as his cavalymen followed, a sombre procession under the veiled heavens. He was not of a cheerful or near chipper mood; across his face danced the flickering fires that burned within, casting shadows as dark as the memories they stirred. A dull ache pressed upon his neck at the mark he bore—a silent weight, both anchor and reminder. His mind, sharp and unsettled, spiralled through visions of the past, scenes that mirrored the horror sprawled before him now. The stench of death and blood, raw and unyielding, lay thick in the air, an unwelcome fog that clung to every man, every beast, and every blade, mingling with the earth in a sickly union.

Beneath him, the ground was buried beneath a woven blanket, not of cloth but of bodies, those once-living fibres of man, silent and unbreathing. It stretched as far as the eye could see, a horrid expanse of flesh and armour and torn banners, twisted in final agony, bearing witness to the merciless slaughter.

Here was a sight beyond the reckoning of men—a landscape where courage and despair lay tangled together, broken by a force too brutal to be called battle.

This was no clash of equals but a grim harvest of the weak, an unrelenting scythe through lives that had only sought to defend what they held dear. The question, heavy and unanswered, lingered not only in the heart of Dex but in every living soul upon that blood-soaked field: why had this not been war, but slaughter—pure, heartless slaughter?

The very air hung thick and poisoned, devoid of any scent but that of death itself, an odour that seemed to seep into the skin and invade the spirit. With every step, the stench grew and shrank, ebbing only in minute increments as if teasing those who dared draw breath, each inhale an assault upon the senses, burning like acid in the lungs of the living. Night had fallen, and the darkness was punctuated only by the dull, sombre glow of torchlight that flickered upon the field, casting harsh shadows over the fallen.

A charred scent mingled with the pungent aroma of decay, the combined scents weaving a tapestry of loss that suffused the plains and pricked the eyes of all who bore witness. Men rode in carts, moving slowly through the field, their eyes deepened with despair and sadness as they searched for fallen brothers among the slain. The warriors of the Stormfang army moved with reverence, collecting the bodies of those who had fought and perished with honour, preserving their legacy in memory if not in flesh. Each creak of the wooden wheels, each muted thud of a horse's hoof upon the blood-soaked ground, each solemn sign of the cross marked over a body drew bright sadness into the hearts of the survivors.

These were not strangers—they were the men with whom they had shared bread, laughter, and the quiet moments between battles. Some of these fallen had been friends from childhood, comrades of decades, and the sight of their lifeless forms struck with a sadness too profound for words.

Yet there was one sadness deeper still—a sorrow that festered like an open wound. They could not lay their kin in the earth as custom demanded, to rest beneath the soil that had borne them. Instead, they erected towering funeral pillars, laying down the arms of the dead beside them, building pyres that reached into the heavens as if to send these souls to a purer realm. There, beyond the veils of death and sorrow, lay yet the eternal life, the untouched world their God alone had crafted for his children.

And so, with heavy hearts, they lit each pyre, the flames climbing and crackling as if to carry the spirits of the fallen upward, beyond the shadowed world of men, to rest at last in the peace of eternity.

As the hours passed, half the men erected the structures to send off those who lived and died, venturing into the world of man with the purest of honours. Another half began to build and prepare the weapons of war, the towers, the battering ram, catapult and trebuchet. Each one would be needed to bring down the final block from the throne that would bring an utter end to the Imperium before them. It was a sight not of glory but of pure distress for Ulfar gazed upon the countless funeral pyres before him, glowing a shade of orange typically saved for envy, not mourning, yet he mourned. The loss of his men and even the deaths of the countless that sought to kill the man, he knew that this—this feeling of empathy for those losses was not something he had during even the first stretches of this journey. He reflected upon the journey to find both the Amulet and Arenith, one which was his first real venture out into the world beyond the villages.

The man still resting upon Blackmere took a while as he simply looked over the land that lay before him, one path, one road forged of ancient stones, leads to the one place deep down he never thought he would have the chance to take, Valkoria. In his mind, he still pondered over the times of his past and of the time he slayed the halfling known as Greyon, his blade taking the life of one he should have spared.

His thoughts came to words, “I have grown much, even since those days, but a few months past. Nigh am I the same man who first drew this blade—for the winds of change have brought me here.” The memories of the first battle played through his mind, the quill across the parchment that was his declaration of this crusade, yet was also just a simple continuation of a war that had no end.

His mind was sent reeling, a torrent of visions flashing before him, capturing all that he and those he held dear had accomplished. He could see it vividly—the bonds forged, the sacrifices made, the victories hard-won. Yet a hollow ache remained, a gnawing truth he could not ignore: all would be for nought if they could not successfully lay siege to the capital.

The very heart of the realm was before him, a city adomed with simple wooden walls, yet crafted with an elegance that defied its humble materials. It was as though the wood itself remembered the hands that shaped it, carrying a silent grandeur. He sought to claim it, to seize such a place without laying ruin to its people, for he bore no malice toward the innocents within those walls, only a quiet resolve to bring about a future unmarred by needless bloodshed.

To the northernmost edge of the field of battle, a slight hill rose, a mound that lent a clearer view of the chaos below. Ulfar knew this place well, having glimpsed it in many encounters before. It was the very spot he'd known General Seidel to stand in times past, rallying his men to arms with a voice that carried like thunder. But now, the absence of the General was a mystery that gnawed at him, a riddle woven into the greater tapestry of war. His mind flitted, restless and sharp, like a candle flickering in a room full of shadows, his thoughts dancing with a precision and grace that belied the chaos around him. Yet with every passing moment, the elegance of his mind felt betrayed by an undercurrent of unease. It was as if he were a wanderer lost within a labyrinth of thought, seeking the exit but finding only new corridors at every turn. Each notion and

intuition that surfaced felt detached, as though he had been handed the pieces of a grand puzzle, but each fragment belonged to a different picture.

The world around him seemed cloaked in layers of subtle deception, and he knew not whether to press forward into the unknown or to linger and attempt to decipher the web that fate had woven before him.

Upon that very same small hill sat the horses of seven with a perfect gaze of their next target, Ulfar graced the middle while Travers Aramir and Judas Preiko were amongst them.

Ulfar began to speak as if to state his thoughts to the nation, “This, this siege is one we must take great caution with.” He pauses, a sense of worry is upon his breath, “The people of this city have done no harm to us, and as such, need to be left out of this final conflict. We must do all that is possible to take as little life as possible after the great massacre that happened upon these plains.”

Aramir, who gave a single stroke of his beard, his eyes locked upon the gates of the city, the hit of the elongated blade upon his hip glowed with the emanating light of the amber torches held around it. It was no blade of mortal making, the sword was one that had belonged to an elf in times long before.

It was Judas who said, “Travers Aramir, it is you alone who may pass into the city unchallenged, for you walk as a wizard of the world, trusted and unseen. Yet, if I may inquire, by what need or purpose do you bear a sword, and what tale belongs to that blade at your side, dear friend?”

As the words of Judas take to the winds to be lost forever after they are heard, the wizard has already taken his pipe from under his robe and let fire come to the tobacco held within. A soft orange glow comes from the open top as he draws from the long and delicately crafted object of smoking.

He wetted his lips, rolling them briefly as if testing the shape of his next words. His voice came low, composed, yet

edged with finality. “Firstly, I shall say this: young Rudy shall be the sole companion on this journey by my side.”

A hush fell. The others turned toward him in quiet surprise, but Aramir showed no intention of elaborating. He took a second draw from his pipe, the carved stem aglow with ember-light. When he exhaled, a perfect ring of smoke drifted skyward, steady as his voice. “That I am a wizard does not confine my skills solely to the mysteries of the mystics,” he said, eyes narrowing with quiet purpose. “I am a wielder of the sword as well—and for good reason. When magic fails, when spells fall to silence and enchantments wither like leaves in frost... the blade remains. A steadfast thing. Forged in fire, tempered by time.”

He reached to his side, fingers brushing the hilt that hung beneath his cloak. There was reverence in the motion, as if the weapon itself breathed with memory. “This sword I carry is no common steel,” Aramir continued. “It was forged in the First Era, by the hands of the great smith Fëalbor. Not for himself, mind you, but for a dear friend—Numenonálé, finest among the elven champions, and once companion to Vaxar, King of Valendriel.”

His gaze swept the company, weighing their silence. “Aye, it is a hand-and-a-half blade, well suited for any tide of battle. It bore the name *Shadowcleave* in those days, if memory serves. Though names have a habit of fading, like dust upon the wind.”

He paused, tapping the bowl of his pipe, then gave a knowing glance toward the dwarven member of their party. “But the dwarves know it by another name—a name our dear Ummar Gruthric would recognise: the Orc-Hammer. For in the days of the War of Vengeance, it was this very sword that Numenonálé bore into battle, striking down Valkar’s vile spawn and driving them from the elven lands.” His voice softened then, though the words bore no less weight. “And now I bear it. Not for show. Not for pride. But for purpose... should the hour come when I must

call upon its counsel once more. Must we remember each weapon lives its own life and has its own memories, as do we all.”

After the words of the wise man took to the air, some may have thought he would bore the world with such knowledge of the past, yet in this world so divided by time itself, these small nuggets were as if to find a diamond in the sand beneath your feet at a lake.

Of all the questions to arise from the words of Travers Aramir, it was Ulfar who posed but a single one, “What became of Numenonálé? I have only read of his name in ancient tales and folklore.”

The eyes of Aramir glinted with a quiet, profound wonder, like deep wells into which the lore of ages seemed to pour. One eye narrowed, a crease forming as if in thought, or perhaps the faintest wink, yet the depth within his gaze was unmistakable—a quiet fire, as if the history of the world itself lay swirling in the dark pools of his pupils. From the corner of his mouth hung a wom pipe, its smooth wood darkened by years of use, and from its open bowl curled a thin, silvery thread of smoke. It drifted upward, twisting in the dim air like the tendrils of some ancient spell, faintly perfuming the air with a fragrance as earthy and old as the land itself.

With an almost imperceptible sigh, he shifted his gaze, and then he spoke, “Ah, that is a tale best saved for the halls of celebration, my friend, not for these dark hours upon a field laden with the fallen. Such words are ill-suited for the waning moments of war, when men sit in silence among the ranks of the dead, their hearts heavy with sorrow and shadows. Let us keep that tale for another time, when light and laughter return, and the burdens of battle have faded to memory.” This time holding back the burden of words that seemed to rise, as if weighing what was better left unsaid.

Ulfar nodded in understanding of the notion pushed by the wise wizard. Each of the men and women before him waited

for a telling of what was to come, though they may have thought to wait an eternity, but it was only a meagre minute before he answered their silent beckons.

His voice was stern and filled with atone not of seriousness but that of ferocity, “Travers Aramir and the halfling Rudy will make it to the Great Hall, we will simply attempt to breach the gate, which I do not have the greatest faith in us doing. But it will be the work of Aramir to ignite the beacons of the city, which signal for the gates to open, thus letting us slip right through and to the capital to force the surrender of Anne.” His plan lay simple yet was something needing the purest of precision possible.

It was Judas who posed the retort to the plan of his newfound friend. The simple question that it was almost certain the entire fellowship had wondered as well. His throat was rough and coarse from the tolls of conflict, but he said to Ulfar, “The beacons shall be lit, and their flames will summon all who yet stand to the east. They will come, will they not? Even now, they await the call, ready to rally, for there is strength yet unbroken in those lands, and false hope that stirs in the hearts of men.”

It was a simple thing that did not even dare to venture into the mind of Ulfar, the first kingdom to claim sovereignty over these lands, had crafted a fine-tuned beacon system to call and rally aid at a given moment. But it was not Ulfar who had a solution, for he still only sat baffled by the simple idea he had become oblivious to. It was Taelmíra who had her own plan; it was as if she had this in her pocket from the very beginning, a contingency to whatever troubles she may have found during her time as a hired hand of Anne.

She said to them, “I know the gate guards well, and so long as the final beacon remains unlit, the chain will not carry on. By the time Aramir sets his plans in motion, we shall have no fear of other aid being summoned. Besides, there are whispers in the wind—the cities to the east, places like Heillimore and Rechfield, would gladly raise the banner of you rebels.”

With but a simple nod from his head, the plan began to take root, like the first stirrings of spring upon the cold earth. The young halfling, Rudy, small of stature but sturdy in heart, had ventured across the plains, past the shadowed mounds where battle had raged only hours before.

Now, amidst the quiet aftermath, he moved once more with a silent resolve, the keen eyes of one who had seen too much yet knew there was still much more to face. Though a halfling, Rudy bore the weight of a role far greater than his years or his kin could have foretold. Destiny, it seemed, had chosen him not for his strength, but for his courage, and perhaps a resilience that few others possessed.

The wind whispered low across the plains, brushing through his dark curls, and there was a weight upon that air as if the very land sensed the significance of this small figure striding upon it—a figure who, unassuming yet steadfast, would come to bear a part in the fate of the world that even he could not yet fathom.

The world seemed to hold its breath as the fellowship stood, each member cloaked in a silence born of both reverence and fatigue. They had achieved much since Lady Auréa's decree had summoned them to this task; since then, the winds of change had swept up from the distant south, winding their way to the farthest reaches of the north. Across those lands, men had slaughtered men, yet, for what felt like the first time since the dawn of their kind, they neither craved nor took pleasure in the carnage.

This war gnawed at them, each battle wearing them not merely in body but in spirit, and in their hearts, a flicker of good still glimmered—a reluctant acknowledgement of the price they must pay. They loathed every laborious hour spent upon the blood-soaked fields, yet that small ember of duty within whispered that this crusade was theirs to see through, no matter the cost, even if it claimed their own lives in the end. Only a few knew, fewer still dared speak, that this war had transcended

mortal concerns; it was no longer merely a struggle for land or power but for Varis Mogul itself.

Those who had studied the ancient annals of history understood the bitter irony—that it had been the world of men who first failed to cleanse this realm of darkness, who allowed the shadow to seep into the heart of existence. And now, once again, it was mankind's burden to confront that festering evil, to hold the line against the tide of darkness released by one whose very being had become a blight upon the land. The fellowship stood, burdened by this ancient responsibility, aware that the world held its breath alongside them, as if the land itself awaited either its salvation or ruin.

As the man who dared to seek his kingdom sat atop his horse, the men of his army lay in wait behind him as he gazed upon the forefront of land that looked clean and untouched by the ravages of war. As the silhouette of a man in robes riding upon a fierce horse became nothing more than a member of the darkness of the night, he thought one last time on the plan that lay before him. It was Ariendria that came to talk to the man, Ulfar, who seemed to be dreading coming face to face with the queen; her lips were something coated in honey as her words filled the air around with a soft comfort. Each word was a message of its own, a calming scent in the air, words that were written of pure, pleasant poetry at its best.

The woman, so adomed in her light armour and cloak to keep out the chills of the night, rode until she was beside her companion. She turned her gaze like the spotlight upon a lighthouse on the coast. Her voice carried a sense of awe, yet also was as soothing as a cold drink on a midsummer's day.

She spoke to him, “Ulfar, let not your heart falter at the brink of this hour. You have spent the whole of your life preparing for this very moment; to waver now would dishonour all those who gave their lives to see you here. Trust in those who stand with you—they shall prevail. And you alone shall face the Queen and reclaim what is yours by birthright, sealed in blood.”

She paused, inching her horse ever closer to the man, “The Flame of the King lies forged within your grasp, bound with the Amulet of Hónir for the first time since the days of Talor himself. Let not your heart be troubled, but place your trust in Calánutar, the One above all, Goht. Cast aside your fears, Luvielan. You possess strength greater than you know, and you are not alone—for loyal friends stand beside you. Do not let your spirit be weighed by small worries.” As she finished, her hand rested on those of Ulfar, the elf had brought a sense of calm and relaxation to him for the first time since the war had begun.

The air was soft as Ulfar opened his mouth as if to place a long-winded answer to the world, but all he had was two simple words, so elegant in nature and new to his knowledge, “Lera meir.” So simple yet filled with so much beauty are the words of the elves. The phrase meant more than its simple translation to the Lady Ariendria, as hearing such a phrase never uttered, if ever, by the mouth of a mortal brought her great pleasure; it was only thanks that he said.

It was the night that passed with a short breath, the fires of the torches soon diluted amongst the light of the core star. It was only now a game of patience that was what the men of the rebellion would come to know, as well as the eldest known chess. As they were nearly that of a dozen leagues from the city's walls, they were just about out of sight of even the best of the scouts upon the towers of Valkoria. They would come to train and plan the ride through the city, taking as few lives as possible and paving a path straight to the keep of the city for their King. The days drew long, yet short in time, as many would come to pass before the siege of Valkoria would come to the halls of history.

Chapter 13

A Fool's Reckoning

The High Commander of the armies of the Neirmar Imperium, the General of the nation itself and trusted servant of Queen Anne, General Seidel. He was not a leader of the front like his counterpart but a man who commanded from the rear; his horse was a creature of subdued elegance and steadfast demeanour, chosen for endurance and command rather than fury. Its coat was a soft, light brown, the colour of sunlit earth, brushed to a gleam that caught the light yet did not demand it. Muscles, finely tuned but leaner than those of a charger, rippled beneath its hide as it moved with a quiet, practised grace.

This was a horse born to bear the weight of wisdom and calculation, with legs sturdy and unwavering as old oaks. Its mane, a dusky flaxen hue, flowed like a gentle wave, catching on the wind yet remaining sleek and untangled, much like the controlled nature of its rider. A subtle intricacy adomed its tack—leather tooled with designs that whispered of Seidel's station, understated but undeniably noble. The creature's eyes, deep and calm, held the knowing patience of a steed accustomed to the solemnities of command. It would stand unmoving, untroubled in the midst of chaos, a steady companion to the general's watchful gaze over the field, embodying a silent loyalty.

This was no war horse bred for the furious charge, but a creature of dignified bearing, a sentinel in the shadows, as constant as the general himself, awaiting orders to press forward or stand resolute as the tides of battle surged and ebbed around it.

His eyes panned across the field of battle as if to search for Ulfar before him, though nothing was seen through the rampage of the riders and men driving towards their enemies. His order still rang in his ear; he had beckoned out to a second wave of men upon their horses, spears and shields held within their grasps, the fingers wrapped around the wooden shafts. The points like large arrows sharpened with the intent to take the lives of others, the men stood in line waiting for the words of their general.

Across the whistling wind came the sounds of Seidel's voice, "Second wave, hold! Now charge!" The sound of thunder came from the line of men as they rode their horses, charging towards the enemy line before them. A massacre had already taken place as they rode over the carcasses of horses and bodies of their fellow soldiers before them.

Seidel heard from behind himself what seemed like a whisper, an echo across the wind. The voice was faint and eerie, but it was one he had heard in years past. The voice said to him, "They come from the rear..."

It trailed off then, with the next gust, the words would be repeated in the wispy, almost ghostlike voice that sounded like the grinding of steel upon coarse rocks, irritable.

He finally asked a commander beside him, "Have you heard anything upon the winds? A voice or even an echo from our rear?" As expected, the commander gazed with a confused stare and listened for a brief moment, then attested to hearing nothing with a shake of his head.

The voice seemed to be emanating from the main encampment just beyond the crumbled ancient walls to his army's rear. The voice was like a call for him to approach, a siren's song luring him in as he turned to his men, "I have left a chart within the encampment. I—I must r—re—return for it. I shall be back in just half an hour at most."

He turns the horse, never waiting for a reply from his men, then he turns over his left shoulder, looking back upon the

men who were nothing but puzzled by the actions of their General. A final order comes from him, "Push the advance, slaughter them all, we must use pressure to our advantage."

The muscular horse of his takes short steps, a light trot as he returns to the encampment, his ears still ever filled with the sounds of war, the screams of men that only grew in strength even as he rode farther and farther away. The echoes upon the wind stayed the same, a constant message simply of calling or rather a warning to he who heard it. Yet he did not see it as such, but he saw it as a calling, something beckoning out for him to venture near, deep within his heart. It was not the curiosity that drew him close, but it was the emanating voice that pulled him.

The pull ever grew as he drew closer and closer to this darkened force. It was not the camps or tents that gleamed with a dark shadow, but a path that passed through the camp, moving far to the east, pointing like the curve of a bow. This Shadow ranged the road that Seidel seemed to mindlessly follow as if he were a simple puppet of the force that drew him in. His heart was hardened, pulled by the darkness; it hungered for a power inherently promised by the darkness.

For what could have been either mere minutes or even days, the man rode now convinced he was going to find such a creature whose promise of power was so alluring. His horse seemed anxious with each step of its hooves; the ground was colder than the day should have allowed, and it crunched with each step.

His soul filled with a chill that was unnerving, for a moment his mind came to why he left, an army was to his rear—or so he thought he called out, "You who dare try and flank me, my army! Show yourself, come see who gives you death, fools!" The night began to swirl as wind filled the sky.

It was as if the elements of the world itself had become angered with the words of the man. Trees bent, grasses became uprooted and took to the air, many leaves that once held the grandeur of green now brown and dead swirled like a cyclone

around the open space. Seidel now rested. His mind raced as he swore the sound of hooves came to his ears, the grunts of a steed, even the breaths of a man so close to him.

The world seemed to darken as the moments passed, a dark fog came to live in the land around him, light was taken from the world around him—though not in its entirety. General Seidel drew his blade, something of normal forging, not a special sword by any means; it was more a symbol of status rather than a tool for taking life.

The horse began to yelp and scratch with pure fear as something ominous loomed over them as if the very valley of death had been the place in which they now reside. A screech that was chilling to the soul, it was piercing to the ears of the man; his soul trembled as the very horse he rode bucked him off, fleeing to the dangers of nature rather than staying where darkness itself seemed to reside.

A voice issued from the shadows, as though torn from the very void of life itself, bearing the cold essence of ancient decay. It drifted through the silence, its ghastly timbre slicing the still air like a rusted blade. The sound seemed to carry a scent of death—thick, bitter, unmistakable.

Then came the words, deafening and devoid of warmth, echoing with a low, dreadful intensity: “*You are... a fool to think you will live.*”

Before him, the dense fog began to part, revealing a figure cloaked in shadows so dense that no light dared to penetrate. Its form was that of a void given shape—a silhouette that swallowed the very air around it, formless yet present, as if the shadows themselves had come alive. What little outline remained suggested a hooded figure draped in a long, tattered cloak, the fabric trailing in fragments behind it like the remnants of an ancient, cursed relic.

The figure moved with a slow, spectral glide, and from beneath the heavy hood, there was no face—only a hollow void,

an abyss from which cold, lifeless energy flowed. No warmth, no humanity, only emptiness, a hunger and that was eternal.

The armour was no mere garb of war; it was the regalia of a knight long dead, an ancient heirloom of eldritch make, steeped in shadow and whispering of a forgotten age. Each piece of this grim attire—darkened plates of blackened steel, battered chainmail, and scales as sharp as a dragon's hide—bore silent testament to centuries of unspoken horrors. It was a relic forged in a time when men and beasts roamed side by side, a time now faded into the mist of legend, and yet the armour had not merely endured—it had been transformed, rather corrupted by a curse of such malice that the very metal itself seemed warped by it.

Inscribed upon the armour's surface, faint runes, strange and spectral, pulsed with a sickly green hue, like embers tainted by poison, barely alive yet never fully dead. Chains, heavy and tarnished, draped across the chest and arms, their weight suggesting the burden of ancient bonds long since broken but never forgotten. The chains clung to the figure as though bound by some dark memory, and with each slight movement, they clattered in a hollow, muted chorus—a sound that seemed to murmur in the silence, as if sharing secrets with the shadows.

The armour's faint gleam, not of any earthly shine but a haunted, unnatural glow, shimmered under the dim light, casting about it a pall as if forever marked by the stain of shadow. Its jagged edges were crude and cruel, each twisted scale and scarred plate an affront to the natural order of things. The dragon-scaled patterns etched into the armour twisted life's own designs into grim parody, as though the very artistry of its making had been corrupted in mockery of all that was fair.

The steel was warped, contorted into cruel shapes, and seemed to pulse with a fell vitality, as if something dark and unspeakable yet clung to it. Beneath the chainmail, where flesh should have been, there was nought but emptiness—a churning void that stirred and shifted as though darkness itself had taken form and clothed itself in this ruin of iron and sorrow. As the

figure moved, the armour rippled and shifted, a grotesque harmony of metal and shadow.

The chainmail wove and unwove with unnatural grace, melding into the shadow it cast as if both were one, armour and shadow blurring into a single dreadful essence. The very air about it grew heavy, as though the figure bore with it the weight of ages, a spectre clad not in mere metal but in the memory of blood and betrayal, a creature of ancient nights and cursed midnights, stepping forth from some forgotten abyss where even the bravest dare not tread.

For Seidel knew what dared to stand before him, as another of these cursed creatures came to be followed by yet another, all three were the same yet independent and bore great differences and unique aspects in their armour and weapons, as the two to the side wield battle axes, the one who spoke held a sword.

One of which was greatly known to the world of man, the twist of the hilt which seemed straight at glance but bent upwards and down from one side to the other and smaller chins hung from the hilt as if to stay the hand of the blade for all eternity. The metal was grated and showed the wear of a thousand years, while having the same ominous glow of the wraith who held it. These were not ghosts or apparitions; they were known well in the tales and legends of man.

They were once great warriors, wielders of legendary arms and armour tales which spun through the threads of time itself. They were men of a laborious nature, always seeking their next opportunity to intoxicate themselves with the delicacies of this world, which to them were such things of nightmares and foul themes. They were those who would succumb to the lust of endless potency and persistence of the evil that dwelt in this world.

Each one would come to serve Valkar in the First Era as slaves to his call, endlessly grasping for the power he gave them, such as endless riches and abundant kingdoms. Though all but a

few of these dreaded souls saw the promises of he who first fell come to fruition, as many would fall to blades and be buried by their respective kingdoms far away from the natural world after the fall of Valkar.

Seidel, who stood fast with a steely resolve, uttered a single word—a word that was not of the tongue of man, yet it rang as a spectral echo in the minds of all beings who had ever set foot upon these plains of mortal struggle. The sound of it was strange and hollow, and though his lips barely moved, the name reached out like the tendrils of some ancient and buried truth, lacing itself into the very fabric of the air: “*Nirinathé*.”

It was a name of such ancient malice that it seemed to draw forth the memory of forgotten fears from deep within the earth, an invocation that caused even the wind itself to shudder and fall still.

His voice, though faint and barely a whisper, held the weight of ages, as if the very force of it had been drawn into the vast and brooding world around him. The single word left his mouth, yet it did not die; it hung there, suspended, thrumming like a secret cast into the void. His breath turned cold, exhaling in a misty vapour that wavered before him, as though the air itself had been seized by a ghostly chill, laden with foreboding. Deep within, Seidel remembered the tales whispered in firelit halls, tales of these wraiths who wore the guise of men but had long since left the realms of the living.

He knew them by the name cursed upon the lips of those who had dared to speak of them. For no blade, no mortal steel, it was said, could touch the *Nirinathé*—these wraiths, these fragments of men bound by dark purpose, impervious to all but death itself. And so, knowing this creature's name, Seidel's heart twisted, a cold loathing mingling with a dread he could scarcely bear. It was a dread older than himself, one inherited through stories carried by voices long dead, but alive in him now with searing clarity.

Before him, the figure moved, a being woven of darkness, each step a silent whisper of death's promise. With a single fell swoop, the jagged, ruined blade arced through the air, slicing as though into the very soul of the world. There was a dull, sickening thud, followed by the harsh clang of a sword striking stone, an unholy sound that echoed into the silence as if marking the edge of a world untouched by the warmth of the sun.

All around, the air held its breath; life seemed to drain from the very soil, and even the restless murmur of the grass was silenced, as though in reverence—or fear. The horse, once steadfast beside Seidel, dared not move, for something older than it could understand had seized its spirit and stilled its heart. Here, upon these desolate plains, the very evil mocked by the Imperium, spoken of only in the shadows of whispered counsel, had manifested itself—a darkness too profound, a silence that swallowed hope. And in that silence, the Nirinathé stood, a blackened herald of the forgotten horrors that slumbered in the deep, dark, forgotten cracks of the world.

The darkness did not leave the lands of the world, yet it stayed, drifting like a storm cloud locked between mountains that reached the very heavens themselves. The Nirinathé did not ride back to the ruins in which they had once come, the ruins of Zhal Durath, which had been mentioned in a sole letter that was yet not acknowledged by any who were in the Imperium. The letter had come from the very eyes of Taelmíra whilst on the enterprise she went on behalf of the Queen. The letter was not given to anyone until after she had a few drinks that night at the Midnight's Rider, the very place she would come to see Judas Preiko once again.

For the letter was not just a warning or a darkened omen, but a foretelling of how events would come to pass. The riders of the dark who chased her who had now brought down the fabled General of such a grand army, were just a small part of those who gather within the shadows, unseen by the eyes of all until a light is brought upon such abhorred things of nature. The tides of

the world were beginning to change, and even now, the battle that raged between man and their fellow man was watched not by the fellow mortals of this world but by the creatures that lie in wait, summons of the necromancer in the ruins, and essence of a darkness who once was—who may come again.

There were men who dared to venture from the battlefield in search of their general, nearly an hour after he had vanished, the forces of the Imperium were being ravaged.

The riders of the rebellion were like wolves in the night, slaughtering the sheep of a poor farmer's field, and those commanders who dared venture to find what became of their dear general departed from the field of battle not as men of heroic standing but pure and honest cowards who deserved nothing more than a suffering death.

Men of the army screamed out, "What be of our commanders?" Their voices strained and echoed with the screams of death and the grunts of horses riding. The sound of steel on steel and the breaking of wood and bone.

Another voice screamed with a chilling sound as if the very demons of hell had ascended upon him, "What orders are there for us?" The man's voice was rattled and broken as he continued, "Do we fight a pointless battle for a forsaken land?"

The torches of some men had brought parts of the land to flames, engulfing those of such misfortune to be caught by them.

The commanders who ran were but fools who followed the same winding and drifting path of their dreaded General, disillusioned with the realities of the world, the men felt no angst or worry, but a pure, clarified pleasure of surviving the battle, which would take the very life of the Neirmar Imperium itself.

Those who still lay at the field of battle saw nothing of their dear commanders; it was pure and utter calamity upon the plains of battle, men and horse alike fell victim to the endless chaos and collapse of military structure.

The thunderous clatter of horse hooves broke the silence like a storm beating upon the door of hell itself, each strike upon

the earth a dark herald, as if the very void had reached out to touch the world of mortals. Shadows stretched and trembled beneath the cloaked figures now encircling nearly a dozen commanders who beheld with horror the fallen form of General Tiber Seidel. There had once been only three of these dark creatures, a triad of wraiths, yet now their number matched the commanders in dreadful symmetry—twelve spectres assembled as harbingers of doom. Each wraith was indistinct, cloaked in shadow deep as midnight, yet subtle distinctions marked them.

Beneath each dark mantle lay amours once worn by men—remnants of lives long passed yet twisted by some dark art into tokens of their undying servitude. Their weapons, though differing in design—a serrated blade, an axe grimly wrought, a mace crowned with sharp iron barbs—were bound by a common craft, forged under the same dread hammer, wielded once by men but now by creatures beyond death. Each blade, each weapon, bore the same pale, ghostly light, the eerie glow of the very blade that had struck down their general, like a curse left to haunt the edge.

A word rode the wind, a whisper laced with dread that seemed to freeze the blood of all who heard it. Carried on unseen voices, it was uttered in tones of death and despair, a word whose very sound was a summons of doom: *Nirinathé*. In that single utterance lay the weight of unspoken history, as though the name carried with it the echo of countless battles and the memory of lives stolen by shadows as old as the world itself.

The twelve shadowed figures moved forward, each advancing toward a commander as the Imperium's fools—knowing they faced no ordinary foe—drew their blades with a solemnity that only the condemned know. Each man held his sword aloft, their final act, one of courage against the dreadful creatures before them. But the very air seemed to devour their strength; a shiver of dread seeped from the cloaked figures like a miasma, stifling hope and strangling the light from

their eyes. The commanders' blades, though sharp and faithful in battle, wavered as they met the relentless steel of the twelve.

Each wraith-like figure moved with the grace of shadows, wielding weapons forged in a time of ancient hate, each blade touched by sorcery that could break the will of mortals. One by one, the commanders struck, yet their blows met only the hollow, unsettling void beneath the cloaks—a darkness that swallowed light itself. Their final cries echoed like whispers, thin and brittle against the crushing silence that followed. The blades of the commanders fell.

The ground beneath grew dark with their blood, and soon, only silence remained, broken by the faint hiss of those weapons of shadow withdrawing, leaving nothing behind but the remnants of life torn asunder. Each fallen commander lay where he was struck down, his form now a grim adornment of the carnage, his eyes staring blankly at the heavens. Their deaths were unseen by the world beyond, as if the very earth had chosen to shield the horror from any who might look upon it and despair. But in the shadows of those twelve cloaked figures, it was a silent testament—a ritual of dread carried out without remorse, as if ancient darkness itself had reached from the depths to claim the souls of those who had dared to stand in its way.

The world had seen these creatures only in the darkest of days, yet even then, their power had been whispered in the hushed tones of myth and legend. It was the work of a malevolent force to wrench them from their graves and lose them upon the land once more. The twelve who stood there, the souls damned to endless shadow, were bound now only to the will of that darkness, relentless and unfathomable, as the memory of the commanders' valour faded into the night.

There were screeches of pure and abominable death that came across the land as the night crept on, and there the bodies of twelve men lay to rest, unable to tell any of the horrors which dwell in the land of the living now. As soldiers called out and searched for their leaders there was nothing, each one a stone to

the world, void of life and consciousness—unable to touch the world of the living they came to be one with the void of death itself, it was unknown whether they ventured to the gates of heaven above or faced eternity separate of the Lord of all dining in the suffering halls of hell.

It was then that the battle seemed to eclipse time and came to a halt, for the forces of the Neimar Imperium had faced the fires of the rebellion and were unable to beat this force. The riders and cavalry-based tactics of the Stormfangs were far beyond great and caught the army, which had only dealt with skirmishes, to their knees and took the land back in the hands of the Line of Valin.

The battle passed, and it was Travers Aramir, who saw the bodies of the dead from a distance, who was greeted by the elf Taelmíra and the man, Judas Prieko, along with a few other soldiers. Before any words were exchanged, it was Aramir who dismounted and looked into the bodies that lay before them. The slashes and stabs of the weapons which took their lives were not of the mortal world, at least no longer.

It was Judas who spoke first, “These wounds... they are no work of mortal hands. Each cut carries a darkness so strong that any soul could sense it, even from afar. In all my journeys, across lands both wild and hidden, never have I known such wounds inflicted upon men.” His eyes seemed as if they had seen all the darkness of the land embodied in the wounds which took the lives of such men.

Taelmíra spoke next, “But these wounds are reminiscent of the weapons wielded by the legendary mortal soldiers of Valkar from his War of Vengeance. These mimic wounds most elves have heard in the legends...” She was cut off by a light clearing of Travers Aramir’s throat.

He did not draw from the pipe that saw within his lips, yet he removed it, clearing the tobacco held within. He then spoke, “These wounds were dealt by Weapons of Talmek—the chosen blades, forged in the ancient fires of Gondol. The

hammer that crafted them was wielded by none other than the greatest of mortal smiths. Only a handful would dare to bear such cursed steel, for to wield it is to embrace damnation upon death. But twelve... twelve wielders struck here—twelve who should have never walked in the light of this world again. This bodes ill indeed, for if such dark things have risen from their tombs, the hour is grave. We must make haste; let us see the city fortified, for the siege is surely upon us.” The day passed with an ominous tone, and then came the night, black and without light, and here the end of the Imperium would begin.

Chapter 1&

The Siege of Valkoria

The gates were forged by those who were deemed through legend as some of the greatest smiths of the land in their time. Its oaken boards were nearly impenetrable with the steel that reinforced them. It was only said that a drake of the First Era could bring down this keep. Yet it was no siege or creations of man that would seek to penetrate the walls of this structure; it was the simplistic and easy plan of Travers Aramir, who, along with the halfling Rudy, entered the city of man.

The guards of the city waved and said their praises as they knew of the wizard's power and strength; they saw him as a good omen, and some knew of his true plan that was too soon to unfold. The horse upon which he rode thundered upon the cobbled and laid stone of the road as they pushed to the keep, which held none other than Queen Anne herself.

Just nearing the gates he spoke a soft whisper into the ears of Rudy, "Look there," he gestured toward the tower, where a stack of wood lay, waiting for a flame, "that is where you must go to light the fire. That blaze will send the signal, and the gates will open." His gaze returned, firm and knowing. "Now, while you see to that task, I shall keep our Lady Queen otherwise occupied. When I give the word, run swiftly—do not look back. Go with all the speed you can muster."

Rudy gave a simple nod, nothing more, as the horse slowed and began to trot, nearly reaching the summit of the path where the keep lay.

When they halted in the shadowed corner, where the guards' torches had yet cast their searching light, he tapped the little one lightly with the base of his staff—a wordless signal.

The small fellow darted off toward the tall, imposing tower, its stone walls shrouded in darkness and flanked by sharp-eyed sentries.

He ran, he slipped deftly between crates, stacks of barrels, and any shadow deep enough to shelter him, weaving a path out of sight as he glided through the narrow alleys. The murmur of the city guards drifted around him, yet they were blind to his presence, as if the night itself wrapped him in a cloak of obscurity.

Echoes of words once spoken by Aramir stirred in his memory, as though whispered afresh in his ear: “You, little Rudy, are swift, small, and hold the gift to go unseen, even where the sharpest eye might search. Your kin once dared the very depths of dwarven halls, nimble and daring as they were. Some even bore the name Pippin.”

The wizard's voice reverberated through his thoughts, filling him with a sense of purpose he'd not fully grasped until now. With each quick, silent step, he felt the wisdom come alive within him; he was invisible to the guards who strode past, oblivious to the small shadow slipping by their firelit watch. Even the amber glow from their torches seemed to cast around him rather than upon him, as if he were a mere wisp of mist in the air.

He moved as one touched by a quiet magic, a secret ally of the night. Though his feet didn't even seem to make such a sound as he had reached the very tower he saw from a distance in mere minutes. He climbed the ladder, which led all the way up and on one of the overhanging balconies, he saw two guards who were oblivious to the presence of another person.

He pulled from his pocket a small luna moth given to him by Aramir, who gave him this and said, “Simply ask it what you seek and the little creature will help you in any way, a gift my little friend.”

So then he asked the moth a simple question, “Could ye light this wood on fire for me, please?”

With the request, the moth flew from the small hands of the little one, and the little creature landed on the stacks of wood and sent out small sparks, which slowly ignited the wood before him. He did not know what became of the creature, for as soon as the wood took to the air in ash and smoke, he had run for the guards would soon catch on to something, and he was right. Yet when he looked on his shoulder, the little creature was with him the whole time; it was a subtle yet simple reminder to the little one that even though the guards now looked for whoever lit the beach, causing a chain reaction throughout the city, that he was not alone and Aramir was always watching over.

After the chain reached the gates the final guards did not light the fires but brazenly opened the gate and then came the flood of the Stormfangs army, the riders bolted through the city. Ulfar led the charge, calling out the name of Queen Anne. Army guards upon the walls called out cheers for the riders who came through, and those who did not draw blades but were stopped by their fellow city guards, who showed them they could not win a fight now, a fight that, if they started, was doomed from the very beginning.

It was the sound of a thousand drums which carried through the city and brought a great smile to the face of Aramir, who had not even been graced with the presence of Queen Anne in the nearly thirty minutes he sat and waited. But now he heard the hooves upon the stone, with the burst of the large doors came Ulfar Val, and with that, Travers Aramir, with the wave of his staff, threw the guards back and opened the doors, revealing the throne room.

In her throne, as if to take a final last stand against the rebellion, there sat no other than Queen Anne. Behind her was Almek Muun, her Queen's guard Commander. She was a woman of striking presence, though her beauty did not bloom in the softness of youth or the delicate features that so often captured the hearts of men. Instead, she bore the regal allure of someone shaped by both power and purpose. Her face was fair and finely

sculpted, with sharp cheekbones and a strong jawline that lent her a commanding air. Her skin was pale but warm, like the first flush of dawn, and her eyes, a piercing shade of grey-green, held the steely resolve of one who had seen too much but remained unyielding. Her hair, a cascade of dirty blonde waves, tumbled down her back, catching the light like strands of sun-kissed wheat swaying in a summer breeze.

Though not golden, her hair carried a muted radiance, soft yet wild, much like the queen herself—untamable, unpredictable. She wore it loosely, though often crowned with a delicate tiara of silver, symbolising her grace, but there was a sense of raw power beneath her every move, as though her beauty was but a mask for the steel that lay beneath. Above average in height, she carried herself with the elegance of someone born to command, her posture impeccable, every step deliberate. Yet there was something about her that hinted at a deeper complexity—a duality of grace and danger, like a sword concealed within silk. Though her outward appearance was one of serenity and poise, her eyes betrayed a mind ever calculating, always watching, waiting for the right moment to strike.

In a last-ditch effort, it was Almek who drew his blade and came in between Ulfar and the Queen. He said to him, “You shall not lay hand on my queen as long as I draw breath. My life is hers, and so with it I will slay all of you if I must.” His resolve was admirable, especially in the current situation, outnumbered and defeated.

It was Judas who walked beside Ulfar and told him, “He learnt from me and now I shall give him one final lesson, my dear friend.” He paced forward, and then it was Almek who stood in shock along with Anne herself, behind him. Judas again spoke aloud, “Almek Muun, you were one of the best swordsmen I have ever met, even bringing me to a draw once or twice. I give you one chance, lay down your blade or face God in your final hour.”

Almek rose in a fury, “You dare show your face here, Sir Jamie Harren. It was you who killed our Queen Deidlee! You have no honour, you have no right to talk of the gods!” His voice was filled with anger, yet his words were few.

A grin came across the face of Judas as he said, “My name is no longer the alias of Sir Jamie Harren, yet it is Judas Preiko. And you are right, I do not call on 'gods' but rather the one God, Goht.” And so he drew the blade of the watcher, the blade which was nearly as old as the man himself. Their battle had begun.

Almek struck first, his movements a storm of precision, the kind forged only through years of relentless discipline. His blade, sleek and gleaming, carved through the air in a shimmering arc, swift as a falcon's dive and sharp as winter's bite. It aimed for Judas with lethal intent, a silver crescent promising death. But Judas met it effortlessly, his blade rising like a ghostly shield, their clash ringing out in the quiet like thunder unbound, rippling through the air with the finality of a tolling bell.

Almek did not falter. He pressed forward, his strikes coming faster and faster, each one imbued with the desperate energy of a man whose very soul hung in the balance. Fury burned in his eyes, driving him to the edge of his limits as his blade wove a relentless dance of steel. For a fleeting moment, it seemed as though his ferocity might consume Judas entirely, overwhelming him like a surging tide battering against ancient stone.

But Judas stood unmoved, his composure like granite against the storm. His expression remained unnervingly calm, touched by the faintest ghost of amusement. He moved with an unhurried grace, each shift of his body calculated and precise. His blade, the ancient and ominous Blade of the Watcher, met Almek's attacks with a whispered hum that carried an eerie melody, as though the weapon itself sang of a darker purpose. Each clash was a note, each parry a chord, and the air was heavy

with the dirge of steel. Judas was no longer merely defending himself—he was dismantling Almek's resolve, piece by piece, with every effortless counter strike. He moved as though time itself bent to his will, his years of mastery turning Almek's furious onslaught into mere openings.

With their blades locked, Judas leaned in close, his voice low and edged with the cruel kindness of truth. “You fight well, Almek, but anger dulls the mind. Your blade wavers, even now.”

The words struck deeper than steel, but Almek snarled, his resolve unbroken. With a defiant shove, he forced Judas back and surged forward once more. His attacks were a flurry of desperation and fury, each swing an unspoken prayer to reclaim some semblance of control. His blade cut through the air with wild ferocity, yet it was clear—a bitter truth that hung in the space between them—that the tide had already turned. With each passing moment, Almek's strikes grew heavier, his breath more laboured. Sweat clung to his brow, his movements faltering under the weight of exhaustion. Judas, by contrast, moved like a shadow, slipping through the cracks in Almek's defence with a predator's ease.

The Blade of the Watcher continued its haunting song, the sound cutting through the tension like a blade through flesh. And then it happened—a single, perfect moment. Almek swung wide, his blade slicing through empty air as Judas sidestepped with fluid grace. In one seamless motion, Judas pivoted, the Blade of the Watcher arcing forward like a serpent striking its prey. It found its mark, cutting cleanly into Almek's chest with a finality that silenced the battlefield.

Time itself seemed to slow as Almek staggered, his body trembling as though the life within him were a candle flickering against the wind. His sword slipped from his hand, the metal ringing hollow against the stone as it fell, a final note of a sad song. His knees buckled, and Judas stepped forward, his movements measured, catching Almek as he began to sink to the ground.

Blood bloomed across Almek's chest, deep red against his pale skin, spreading outward like a crimson flower in full, tragic bloom. Judas lowered him gently, almost reverently, his grip firm yet uncharacteristically tender. The moment carried the weight of something ancient, something inevitable.

"You fought well, Almek," Judas said, his voice soft, touched with a strange and fleeting sorrow. "Better than most. But even the best must meet their end."

Almek's lips quivered, as though searching for words, but none came. His eyes—once burning with fury—now held only pain and defiance, even in the face of the inevitable. Slowly, his chest rose and fell for the last time, and the light in his gaze dimmed. Judas stood, releasing the lifeless body with care, as though honouring the man who had given all he had. The Blade of the Watcher hung at his side, its ancient edge gleaming faintly in the light, now stained with the blood of a swordsman who had fought valiantly yet could not withstand the weight of coming destiny.

All attention turned to the queen, who now sat defeated. In her squalor as to be a rat in the desert, nevenmore was she the highest figure of the land. A crown which held no title or weight still rested upon her brow, as she did not even have the strength left to gaze upon those who defeated her.

It was then that Taelmíra had noticed the sound of rain dripping and colliding with the stone below their feet, yet it was not rain. She placed her eyes in a pattern to search for the sound which took her but a second to discover was emanating from Ulfar himself. There was a drip of crimson that had started a small pool below the man. Her voice then erupted from deep within her breast, but before her words came to light, the queen before them all laughed a dreadful laugh.

And it was her voice which came to plague the air, "The man who would be King bleeds." A smile that was more of a grimace came to plaster her face, as the fellowship around him all seemed to be puzzled how such a thing could have occurred.

The woman continued to speak, “A wound that was patched but poorly, one that did not mean to fight in battle.”

He drew Arenith from his hip and said aloud with a pain woven into each word and a grimace as the sword, which was in his left hand, was extended to his side, “Do not act as if one cannot simply slay such a repugnant creature as yourself.” He took in a breath, for he did not move even the slightest move expelled an increased amount of blood from his body.

Then an arrow flew whistling past his head and that of those around him. The arrow came to strike the woman in the knee and bring her down to the ground as if to pledge her fealty to the man before her. The steps of a creature lighter than the snow tapped on the stone. It was Ariendria who let her bow fly. Simplicity softened her words, though each carried the weight of a hundred more unspoken.

In a voice quiet yet resolute, she said, “Only in the shadow of pain do such creatures fall silent.”

A grimace of pure pain overcame Ulfar as Ariendria hastened to his side, catching the man before he fell to a knee. The words of Travers Aramir came to the ears of all next who used his staff to raise the falling knee of Ufar. He said, “A foolish man hides the wounds he bears from battle, yet one of true strength faces them as he would any adversary. A mere wound, such as the one you shield, should not render a man unable even to stand.” He lowers to the level of Ulfar as he continues, “Tell me, was it the blade of a Zealot that struck you? Or one forged and wielded by the hands of the Imperium's smithy?”

Ulfar's face bore the marks of agony, a landscape etched in shadows and pain, as though some unearthly artist had wrought a portrait of torment itself upon his features. His brow was furrowed in a grimace, the lines cut deep like rivers carved into ancient stone, while his eyes, half-lidded, glistened with the haunting reflection of a battle hard fought. His head hung askew, tilted in the manner of one worn by countless burdens, his left

hand pressed tightly against his side where the wound still ached like a curse that would not leave.

Yet beside him, Ariendria's hands—slender, graceful, and bathed in a gentle glow that seemed not of this world—encased his own, their touch both delicate and resolute. Her fingers, woven like golden vines around his knuckles, lent him a strength that spoke of more than mere healing; it was a quiet promise, a steadfast comfort against the storm raging within him. The warmth of her touch seemed to flow like a balm over the jagged edges of his pain, binding him to life and to hope, even as his spirit wrestled with the shadows that sought to claim him.

The voice of Ulfar rang with agony as but a single word came from the mouth of the man, “Judd.” The very name of the man who was all but a prisoner to them, now as they sat with the land before them, theirs and victorious, no celebration nor party to be had, for what would become of their leader who now seemed unable to make establishment of what he just had taken from the world.

Ulfar was then rushed to a bed where the armour that clad his body in what was thought by many to be impenetrable now would come to lie scattered on the ground around the small bed he was upon. Gazing at the wound it was no ordinary wound but one that struck the memory of the two elves, it was not of mortal making. To the unknowing eye, it seemed a simplistic and quite rudimentary gash, yet for those who had lived through the ages had knowledge unparalleled by that of many mortal men. There was a puncture that was deeper than any blade a mortal has ever forged, they all had set their eyes on the weapon wielded by the zealot Judd yet confusion arose for how such a wound could come to pass.

Ariendria spoke, “Not even the enchantments I have known through all the ages of my life could soothe wounds as these. Tell me, Taelmíra, have you wisdom that reaches beyond what I may offer?” She still, with futile effort, placed her hands

upon the wound of Ulfar and spoke a language so aloft it was hardly intelligible. The dark elf joined in as well, speaking another more twisted dialect of the same language.

The voice of Taelmíra broke their attempts as she said, “There are but few in this world who can heal the damage of a Weapon of Talmek, a blade forged by the human smith Halvar Eldaric in the ancient Forge of Gondol in the First Era.” A sense of haste came across the voice of the woman as she spoke again, looking specifically at Travers Aramir, “We must seek out the help of the White Queen, the Lady of Valendriel. She is the only one to have dealt with such injuries as Vaxium undoubtedly faced during the War of Vengeance.”

Travers Aramir stepped out onto the narrow stone balcony, high above the city that sprawled beneath him in a tapestry of rebellion and resolve. The torchlight of countless soldiers flickered below, casting restless shadows over cobbled streets and across the faces of warriors who bore the scars of hard-fought battles. Some were soldiers of the rebellion, marked by grim determination, while others wore the remnants of the Imperium's livery, humbled by loyalty turned to the man now lying on the brink of death within.

He was not alone. Standing beside him, her form both radiant and solemn, was Auréa, Lady of Dremor. Her beauty seemed to catch and hold the dimming evening light, making her seem both of this world and beyond it. She wore a dress that flowed as if spun from the very clouds, the fabric soft as morning mist, falling in cascading layers that pooled lightly around her feet. The ivory hue seemed to shift with the light, at times a warm cream touched by the last hints of daylight, at others a cool, moonlit silver. Intricate threads, fine as starlight, traced delicate vines and ethereal shapes across the bodice, hinting at forgotten tales and ancient artistry known only to the high elves. The sleeves, sheer and flowing, brushed her skin like whispers, moving faintly in the breeze that swept up from the city below, lending her an almost spectral grace.

The female elf next to him turned and graced his ears with her words yet again. As she smiled, there was not a hint of worry for the poor soul who teeters with death itself.

Her voice was calming even to the wizard himself as she spoke, “Do not be troubled on my mother's account. Her powers would surely bring healing, yet there are others in these lands with strength akin to her own. Summon her, indeed, for the shadows that now creep across this realm are but a breath of the ancient darkness she and my father have withstood. Though they have never faced its like, still twice have they endured the weight of such a foe. Send word to her, I beseech you.”

They both stood with full knowledge that no matter what, even with the greatest magic of the mortal world, the lady Dramira could not come to be in their presence in no less than a week.

Travers spoke again, “You know as well as I that Lady Dramira could not reach us in less than a week's journey, and by then, Ulfar will have succumbed to the wound he bears. Time is a precious ally, yet it is one we do not hold now.” A sense of dread came across the man, for he had not a clue of any others who knew the healing magics of the elves in such a way to heal the man.

But deep down, he knew this simple bump in the road was nothing more than a test of their resolve. Goht had laid a simple test, such was bound to happen to the man.

His words came out, “Sometimes, Auréa, I forget even the purpose for which I was sent. It is not mine to steer the tides of history, nor to summon those whose paths lie elsewhere. Were I to call upon Valendriel, she would not heed it, for her fate lies beyond this moment's need. And yet, you speak wisely, for indeed, there are others in this world who wield the gift to mend wounds of such a grievous nature. Once, in a life far removed, I too held such power—not as Aramir the Wise, but by a name long buried, a name *He* has veiled from my memory.”

Aramir continues, “There are indeed others, though they may not rest beneath this ancient roof nor carry Ulfar Val's banner. Dramira's part is not yet called upon, and though many long years have passed since I last laid eyes upon your mother or your noble father Vaxium, the scrolls of history have countless pages yet to fill before their names stand among the chronicles of this age. For now, let us place our trust in Goht, God above, and cast our burdens unto Him. Is this not the course, my dear friend?”

The lady elf Auréa seemed puzzled, bewildered by the response of the man. Questions had come to her mind—unfathomable, and each query swelled in the depths of her mind. Then, with an absurd, abrupt outburst of raw emotion from the typically calm and collected individual, her voice was bemused as she spoke, “For why does one forsake the life around him? Do you not take great penitence in the coming deprivation of life?”

Although many more questions sought to burst from her breast, she held her tongue, seemingly twisting it as her hands trembled, as trepidation overcame the woman, her eyes swelled, then her gaze locked with Aramir as the dread she thought to pose upon his face came upon hers.

Her voice now calm and soft, she then said, “I do apologise for my—my outburst, that was not of me.”

Auréa had fallen to her knees; there, a deprivation had overtaken her mind. She did spiral around the questions she still had, yet she had not a clue why she, one who has seen many ages of this world—a boundless encyclopaedia of knowledge of the very world itself, would falter in this moment. Her thoughts danced through the annals of her mind as if they were leaves falling through the soft breeze on a beautiful fall day. There was a knowledge deep within her heart, for she knew what was to happen, yet she could not do it; her place was not of this time, yet without her, the time she had seen in vision would never come to pass.

She arose, the demeanour of her changing, the doubt that was entirely visible on her physical being had vanished as if it were a simple fire that burned so fervently yet with even the smallest cult of water, and it was abolished, ceased to exist. With no words, she left the balcony where she had been the last few minutes with Travers Aramir.

As she walked out, Aramir said in a last-ditch effort to claim some sort of reason or appreciation for how she changed her thoughts and outward expression, “Where do you go?” The words had fallen on deaf ears, whispers overpowered by the very wind which carried them.

As the doors of the room opened before the dying man flew open before them all, it was Ariendria who spoke, “What shall we do, Lady Auréa? His wound is only getting worse, his head is burning up.” The sense of urgency sewn within her voice was erupting in a pure and dreaded fear for the one she so dearly held.

It was Dex who then spoke, the man of few words uttered, “You are torn, you have no clue. How can one so wise and live so many lives of men yet have nothing to offer? Did the death of your people place such a fear upon you, Auréa daughter of Dramira?”

His voice cut down to her soul; it was a knife that did damage to her that only one had ever reached before, and it was he who bestowed the wound she deeply hid from the world.

With a breath that was deepened by the sense of anger that came over the woman she did not speak yet her stare was one that could even bring the most powerful of mortals to their knees as her complexity morphed from that of a light and angelic to some that that glowed as if the moons had been bled her physical appearance became dominating the raw power that emanated from the figure of the woman.

She was not a towering force, but one that brought even Aramir to fear, then he simply placed his hand upon her shoulder to bring her back to the world of men, soothing her anger with

the simplicity of physical touch. She then moved promptly to the hallway outside the room, even bringing herself to fear what had just occurred.

It was then Travers Aramir who spoke to the room, addressing Dex at first, “Why speak of such scars, Dex, are you not a wayward soul yourself? The loss of her home is a grief even you must feel keenly. You do know she once ruled over the ancient city of the Dremoré Vamir, a place steeped in ages, sheltering thousands under her care. And yet, in those dark days when war came in Malachar's wake, her city fell, and with it, the lives of many she held dear.”

He moved closer, placing the head of his staff on the chest of the man, locking eyes, and in an instant Dex would see once more the ravages of the dark army slaying the elves by the dozens, men, children, and women alike. The blaze wrought forth as a woman, Auréa let a single tear fall from her face. Then he came back to the world, the present now unburdened yet also carrying the weight of what horrors Dex now knew the lady elf had faced. A sombre expression, torn and guilty with what he had said with his blunt words, overcame Dex.

Travers Aramir continued, “She is among the mightiest of our time, for there was an age when even Malachar himself shrank from facing her and her fellow kin. Have you seen the ring that rests upon Auréa's finger? It is no mere trinket; her mother bore a circlet not unlike it, brimming with a power that seemed endless. Yet if truth be told, I believe that if these tokens were laid aside, Auréa herself would stand unmatched in strength, a force in her own right. But it is not for me to decree, only for you all to discover. As for the aid we seek, Dramira and the elves whose names echo in the oldest tales lie far from us, their strength too distant to mend these wounds. Yet there are others, closer than we may realise, whose names and deeds are not yet bound in the pages of this history. In time, each will play their part, though we know not yet when that time shall come.”

The group sat in anticipation for what wisdom would come from the mouth of the age-old Travers Aramir, but it was not the wise old man who spoke, but arguably the youngest of the bunch who broke the silence.

Rudy, who stood up and spoke aloud for all to hear. He said, “Aye, we can't just sit here doin' nothin' an' let the man waste away, can we? We've sacrificed so much for this quest, an' here we are, nearly at the end of it, sittin' around twiddlin' our thumbs while he slips away! I only caught about half o' what Aramir was on about, but we've got to do somethin' now, not later!”

His voice echoed through the cold, stone-hewn chamber, each syllable a distant whisper that seemed to hover in the stale, heavy air, as though it were the only sound to ever pierce this realm devoid of life. Around him, shadows cast by stone and torchlight mingled, draping the silent figures nearby in a shroud of surrender, each face hollowed with the weight of despair. The room seemed to breathe a hopelessness of its own, as if it shared in the sorrow of its occupants, bearing witness to the scene with ancient and indifferent stone.

Upon the slab lay Ulfar, his figure fragile in the dim light, his abdomen uncovered to reveal the sickening corruption creeping over his flesh—a mottled blackness as if death itself had sunk its claws deep within. The dark stain spread outward from the wound, twisted veins like blackened roots crawling beneath the surface, their tendrils branching in grotesque symmetry, as if each was the leg of some venomous spider feeding on his very essence. What had once been a mere cut now festered like a parasite, a living blight sapping his strength with a silent, relentless hunger.

His breath, weak and shallow, barely stirred the air, and with every gasp he seemed to shrink further into the shadows, his form as pale as the cold stone beneath him. Agony twisted his face, yet his voice was nearly gone—a faint murmur carried only by the pain that kept him tethered to life. The wound, festering

and pulsing, devoured his flesh, drawing inwards like a dark tide. Around it, the scarring flesh seemed to shift and warp, dying tissue collapsing in upon itself, forming grotesque ridges where life once thrived, as if the very fibres of his being were recoiling from the darkness burrowing its way into him. The slow creep of the blight stole what little life remained, each passing moment a relentless invasion, drawing him nearer to a fate feared by even the bravest souls.

Tears rolled down the faces of Rudy, Ariendria and others of the fellowship as the man slowly faded in and out of consciousness. As the moment of his judgment was coming, there was a noticeable absence in the room. The air, which was still thick and as heavy as the mountains of the land, was growing ever more dreadful with each passing breath from the poor soul whose breathing had soon become hindered. Its mark was deep and ever-growing. There was a sound of a drip of some water in the distant halls, which echoed and filled the silence, adding to the cascading tears from the faces of his companions.

They were right to have such sadness as their very friend teetered on the knife of life and death, balanced on the edge of the fine blade—one wrong move and the blade would divulge a cut so deep it was mortal. The life of Ulfar was but a game of chess, and the side of man had but a few pawns left to protect their queen. The door, which had been open for many minutes, was graced by the presence of Auréa, who had a new and unique quality about herself that was puzzling to most but expected of the old wizard.

She moved forward with quiet grace, each step light yet resonant, as if the very stone beneath her feet yielded to her presence. Before her lay the dying man, his breath shallow, each laboured gasp barely breaching the silence that hung heavily in the room. His muffled screams, caught between life and death, seemed to dissipate into the still air, a grim harmony that reverberated within the stone walls, shadows twisting as if to echo his pain.

The ring upon her hand caught the light, flashing like a distant star or a memory long hidden, its gleam both beautiful and unnervingly potent. It was as if the light itself was drawn to the jewel, caressing it with a reverence unfit for mortal objects, and those who beheld it felt a strange pull, a hypnotic whisper that stirred some deep yearning within. Its radiance played across her fingers, casting ethereal shadows upon her skin, as if it bore secrets bound to ages past.

With her left hand, she parted the air, moving it in a manner both commanding and gentle, as if sculpting the silence itself to her will. Then, with her right hand, she reached out, steady and assured, removing the hands of Ariendria and Taelmíra. Their hands fell away, leaving bare the festering wound, now exposed to all eyes. The wound itself, a dark stain spreading like ink upon the flesh, seemed almost alive—its edges gnawed and frayed, tendrils of decay spidering outward, a macabre tapestry etched into his skin. She began to speak, her voice a delicate weave of sound, each word imbued with a softness that seemed to settle the air around her.

She uttered a few words which were not loud; rather, they slipped like whispers across the room, yet they carried a weight that wrapped around each heart and eased each troubled mind. Her voice, calm and unfaltering, filled the space with a quiet that was both eerie and comforting, as though the very scent of ancient forests and sacred groves had crept into the room. It was a voice laced with magic, one that held the echoes of forgotten spells and woven mysteries, a melody that could bend the soul to gentleness, even in the face of death.

Her voice was like a gentle song, each word unfurling with grace, and even those who did not understand felt a calming rhythm within her speech. “*Vaina en vanar, fala ro thela—bara teir erá, tier anéth.*”

Her tone was lilting and soft as though the language itself held a kind of music, each syllable shaped by reverence. Her words wove a delicate tapestry that seemed to veil the room

in peace, softening the edges of worry and dimming the harsh light of fear. A glow began to emanate from her outstretched hand, a radiance unlike any seen among mortal men—a light so pure and otherworldly that it appeared to touch everything around her with a glimmer of life. The glow was not merely bright but carried within it an essence, as if a piece of the heavens themselves had slipped down to linger at her fingertips.

All present could almost sense a presence beyond, as if her plea had reached toward a being greater and deeper than any could fathom, drawing life's breath into her touch. Some of the gathering looked on in awe, their breaths caught in their throats, for the language she spoke was a mystery even to the eldest among them, a dialect older and more profound than that which they knew. Her voice was like a prayer, and there were words, woven subtly within her plea, that even the elves could not decipher, sounds of a dialect known only to a few. Yet all felt its weight, the vastness of what she spoke, as though she alone bore the wisdom of ancient, forgotten realms.

It was then that the world was filled with awe, and the very words of Travers Aramir were echoed throughout the minds of those present; her power was shown to all there. But it was through the dark torn ring upon her finger, that seemed to corrupt the world around, but was outshone by the presence of the very woman who beheld it and controlled it upon her left hand.

She took in a deep breath while she closed her eyes and, within her mind, uttered a prayer unknown to the world yet instilled in her mind. The world around her rose in awe at the beauty of her work, as she emerged, the mark had seemed to diminish. It was not the abyss of life it had once been, and now the man lay in a soft sleep as the shades of agony that were drawn across the face of the man were gone, and now he just was silent, soft and comforted in a sense of slumber.

Ariendira took in a breath as well, she had been relieved of the pure stress that overcame her, her mind was at ease as the peace of the world encompassed her mind a relief of the pent-up

energy within her. She looked around the room and let out the smile of a young child on their birthday grazing upon all the presents and sweets present. She rose and walked to the Lady Auréa, who seemed to be exhausted by her work; she grasped the soft, pale hands of the woman who was her elder by but a few thousand years.

The smile strewn across her face seemed to tell a tale woven in pure appreciation, the teeth that adomed her smile, white, pure as if to say they were carved from the most elegant pearls. The clasp he had on the softened hands glimmered in the amber, burning light of the wall sconces.

She then spoke to her, “I cannot thank you enough for such kindness.”

It was a series of praises that came forth from nearly all the members of the group, lines and prose all forged in such a facet to upheave the fulfilment of one person. There was all but one who said their praises, while those around her all greeted with tithes of joy. The dark elf sat with her legs crossed and gazed at the woman who brought many great questions to her mind.

She had held her thoughts within, but no longer; her tongue was fierce and sharp like a spear as she spoke, “Why wait so damn long to heal him? Why make the man suffer if you have such an ability to heal the wound?”

Her eyes rolled, and the tone of sass and genuine anger filled her words as they flowed through the air. Her mind thought of all the insults to be thrown at her, yet she did well to hold such scathes to the emotions back from the world to hear. She looked and glared, though nothing came from either of their mouths.

It was before yet another gruelling question came to light, the room looked after the first two queries posed, both interested but also unbothered, simply enjoying the fact that Ulfar would live and survive the wound given to him during the siege of the Parcival. It was then the voice which seemed to echo as she placed a much greater effort in projecting, as her voice

first seemed faint and weak, almost overextended to even utter a few words.

Aur  a spoke, “I apologise.” She whispered, her voice like a trembling breath over the cool air, each word a strain, as if speaking alone drew her strength away. “I could not trust my own power to save him, nor the will to wield the ring upon my hand. Understand this, that should I call upon it without restraint, I could awaken a darkness this world has not seen—a force so deep that even Malachar would quail before it, one even Shulath might have feared. This is the curse of bearing such an item, forged in the fire meant to defy the evils of Valkar; this power is no blessing.”

It was a sombre yet simultaneously joyous tone that came over the room when Aramir said aloud, “Let us take our counsel elsewhere; he shall not wake for some time yet. We must make ready the city for what lies ahead, for we’ve been granted a precious moment to catch our esteemed friend off guard, wouldn’t you say?”

Judas led the group from the dim chamber, his form a shadow that moved with quiet resolve. As he passed beneath the pale light filtering through the high windows, his sword was at last seen in the full, unfiltered gleam of the world. The hilt stood out, a marvel of masterful design, stretching perpendicular to the long, narrow blade with an elegance rarely seen in such weapons of war. Each end of the crossguard was adomed with a perfect sphere, crafted with intricate care, and within each sphere, a gleaming emerald sat at its heart—a fire caught within green depths, flickering with an almost knowing light. The steel of the blade itself was pure, polished to a mirror sheen that reflected the world around it, unsullied by stain or scar, as if it had never known a single blemish.

Its handle was wrapped in supple, white leather, thin yet sturdy, each band wound halfway down to offer perfect balance between power and grace, providing its wielder a command over the blade as natural as an extension of his own hand. The blade

was neither overly thick nor fragile—it held the perfect weight and shape, thin yet formidable, and the steel itself seemed to shimmer with a subtle aura, as if touched by a hidden hand. This aura called to mind the blade of Ulfar, yet there was something mysterious in Judas's weapon, an enigma shrouded in the unknown origins of its make. Neither its true name nor its craftsman was known, nor the metals used to form its unforgiving edge, leaving it as much a mystery as the hand that wielded it. It was just the Blade of the Watcher.

The sword was caught by the eyes of Rudy, who posed an interesting curiosity in such a perplexing item. He looked with wide eyes at the man and said, “Aye, Mister Judas, wit all due respect as yer mate, meanin' nyuh offence, mind ye—but how did a man o' yer standin' come by a blade that looks fit fer a king if ye ask me?”

The eyes of the man seemed to grow to the size of boulders, his pupils seemed to tell of ancient legends spun around such a blade, the eagerness of the ancient wanderer was overflowing as if one were to try and catch the water of the most beautiful falls—the Nithralié Falls in a single oaken bucket. His eyes glistened with the infinite knowledge of the night sky, beholding ancient mysteries and legends upon folklore.

He placed his worn, used, and callused hand on the shoulder of his smaller friend and said, “Ah, my little friend. Master Rudy, there are two tales to answer what you ask. One stretches across the years of my life, yet it is a tale we have not reached—though perhaps we will in time. And the other, simpler, tells only of this blade, for it bears the name *Jarsil*.”

He draws the blade from its long sheath and holds it upright between the two companions, “It bears another name as well, a phrase woven through ancient tales—the *Flame of the Watcher*. This was the sword of Tecar, the man who founded the Watchers of Valkoria. Tecar, brother to Tumás, the second King of Valkoria, wielded this blade. Forged by the high elven King Frenar in the First Era. To men, it stood as a symbol of strength

and peace between the races of Man and Elf. Yet these are tales best told by firelight, among friends at ease, not here, my dear friend.” He rises and motions for the group to continue as they all walk towards the main hall in preparation for the land's new King.

Gunmar encountered a man standing quietly among the shifting shadows and bustling passersby. His name was Grayson, and he bore the look of one who'd seen much yet still pondered the twists of fate that had brought him here. His gaze held a glint of something between reluctance and resolve, as though wrestling with memories that weighed heavily upon him.

The young man, with shoulders squared but expression softened, stepped forward and, in a voice laced with an old loyalty and bitter regret, spoke: “I am, or rather was, a trusted advisor to General Seidel, until the day he dismissed me without reason or cause. I would be deeply honoured to mend the connection I once held with Ulfar, to serve him with whatever strength or wisdom I might yet possess.”

The words carried the weight of loyalty born anew, with a sense of devotion carefully rekindled, like the faint glow of embers on the verge of catching fire once more. Gunmar watched him with a silent nod, reading in his face the marks of a life spent in service and exile, an exile that left Grayson not hollow but quietly resolute. Here was a man who bore both scars of allegiance and longing, his spirit shaped by the path he had walked, now ready once more to tread the road alongside those who still held his loyalty.

Gunmar then turned to the man, his face chiselled like the worn stones of ancient mountains, and spoke a phrase so simple yet brimming with meaning beyond the reach of words alone—words that shone brighter than the hallowed light of the Alundél itself to elvenkind.

Grayson felt himself stirred to his very core as Gunmar's voice, rough and weathered as if sculpted from time-worn granite, rumbled out two words: “Come, then.”

Those words, thick with an accent as ancient and sturdy as the mountains themselves, were weighted like the talons of a dragon reaching through shadow to grasp him, a grip both thrilling and unyielding, binding him as if he were prey caught by some great and ethereal beast. In that instant, Grayson felt himself drawn into a purpose older and greater than any he had known. And so began the silent countdown, each day marking a step closer to the return of Ulfar, whose stewardship over the land would soon rekindle old fires, setting the course anew for those who held faith in his strength and legacy.

Chapter 15

A Kingdom to Come

The smoke had settled, and battles drifted to memory, leaving only faint skirmishes and whispers of war in their wake. Across the broad expanse of Onu-Arith, where once the banners of the Imperium had flown proudly—black falcons, fierce and unyielding upon crimson fields—they had now fallen from the skies. Replacing them, high and true, soared the white and golden standards of the Stormfangs, bearing a noble cross reminiscent of the old empire, glimmering like stars as they claimed dominion under the vast heavens. A new sun broke over the frost-laden morning, casting its cool light across lands burdened by history.

It had been many nights since the rebel forces, kindled by a fire of liberation, surged north from Deidara, pressing ever closer to the Parcival—once a beacon of piety, now reduced to embers and ash, a smouldering relic of a proud, defiant monastery. Not the winter solstice nor some arbitrary calendar marked this dawn, but the sheer weight of triumph and resolve, the passage into the two-hundred eighty-ninth year of the Third Era—a year forever etched in stone as the end of a centuries-spanning civil war, brought to its close by the Stormfang uprising. A mere chapter, a single stroke in the unending scroll of history, yet one that bore the culmination of lifetimes, labours, and dreams.

In the land of men, a fragile peace seemed to descend, blanketing the war-weary fields like morning fog. It was as if, for the first time in an era, the world dared to hope, to believe, to rest. But, as with all things good and golden, shadows lingered at

the edges, for nothing so precious endures untouched by the darker currents of fate.

The land would see the coming of the new year under their King, Ulfar Val. He would put to trial figures such as Zek Judd and the former queen, Anne Hargath, amongst the people, to answer for all they had done in their lives. For many months, these figures would take to pleading their cases, though many of the public noticed the absence of the former General Seidel, questions arose about what had happened to the man, who was something of a mystery.

Many who fought on the Creux Plains never saw their enemy commander; his horse had left the stables, yet his voice had vanished from the field of battle, his sword, for all who knew, had never even left its sheath. Many had speculated that the man knew of the coming defeat and fled the region, though no mention of any man nor rider fitting his description was ever found or heard across the wind. In the weeks after the war's end, one mark of the man had been found; his helmet was found in the frozen mud after the Siege of Valkoria.

It had now been a few days since the events of his wound and the thankful healing of Auréa, yet it was only now that he came back to the world of those who are awake.

It was the face of Travers Aramir who first graced his vision. Ulfar said aloud, "What happened, and where am I?"

He retorted with the low voice of Aramir, "You are within the halls of your own realm, on the seventeenth day of Jeverens in the two hundred and eighty-ninth year of the Third Era. Here, at last, you have stirred from the weeks-long shadow that bound you in silence. It was the wound dealt by Zek Judd that cast you under—he, a man who bartered his very soul to wield a weapon forged by those who serve the most ancient and unyielding darkness. Such wounds are wrought of powers beyond mortal reckoning, and yet, here you are, returned to us once more."

The sweet and calming smile of the worn old wizard was caught in Ulfar's gaze, which brought him a smile and a short hug. Then Travers Aramir continued with a much more sombre tone, "I do apologise, my dear friend, but after the happenings here, I find I must seek counsel with two most powerful allies of mine—Baragorn the Black, head of my order, and the Lady Dramira. I will be absent for many months, though it grieves me more than I can say to miss the days ahead, most especially those spent in your company. But, as you well know, the path of a wizard is far more than the casting of spells or incantations. It is a burden of insight and duty. I hope you understand."

"I assume you all have done your part in laying the work of the King in my absence?" The single question to leave on the wind as part of Ulfar's rough and coarse-sounding voice was of great importance. Inside, he knew they would all faithfully follow through with the path he paved forward, yet he was eager to see the new banners fly and rest upon the throne he so toiled for.

Ulfar was no fool to what Aramir spoke of; he knew there was always the distant threat of darkness's return. "I bid you safe travels, dear friend; may your road pass over warm sands."

Then Rudy jumps up from his chair, his voice filled with a vigour unmatched by many in the room, and he interjects with, "Aye, well, why don't we just round up the lads, march over there, and give this nasty brute a proper thrashin'? Get it done and dusted, eh?"

He seemed confused as to why the wizard needed to leave them; they had done so much together, and now they had the biggest army in the land, along with having over ten thousand men. "Aye, why not take the fight to 'em? We've a grand army at our backs now; seems we could end this business right quick, don't ye think?" He looked around for some sort of support from those around him

The old wizard with his pipe and one hand staff in the other looks at Rudy and says, "That would not work."

With a creak the door to the room opened and in the advisor of the King, bearing the sigil of the Steward Hand, a title granted to the closest advisor to the King on the states of the Realm, Grayson, once a dear friend, had just entered the room to catch the words of Rudy and his pertinent question on how to deal with the dark forces dwelling in the land, "For why not? Could we not muster one final battle and draw an end to the evils of this land?"

With the igniting of his fingers and the drawing of his pipe, the wizard Travers Aramir chuckles and says, "I have walked many years among the race of Men, yet even now, there is much that eludes my understanding. You are ever a wonder to me."

He then turns his gaze to Grayson and then addresses his comment directly, "Oh no, we do not defeat evil in one final battle, but the simple, small victories every day—ones of courage, goodness, and of kindness. Each act is one blow, one candle light in the ever-present darkness of evil, no matter how big or small each one, it triumphs over it all. The evils of the world thrive over final stands, last bastions of hope; it is how *they* triumph many a time."

Ulfar then arose from the bed he lay in and looked upon the room, which was strewn with the remains of his dear friends, companions, and members of the fellowship. They all waited for words to come from the mouth of the man, but nothing came; he simply smiled and looked at them around him, locking eyes with Ariendria, who seemed as pleasant as any to see him awake again.

He stood from the bed, weakened but still strong enough to stand, then he spoke once again, "Thank all of you for staying around. Thank all of you for what you have done as my friends and as my comrades in battle."

His gaze first turned to the little Rudy and his friend Grayson, whom he greeted with a kingly smile, then told them, “The old man is wise beyond our years. We cannot muster here enough forces to win such a battle; we must build a land worthy of carrying the world of Men into battle for goodness. The time has not come for the scrolls of history to read of man's war against evil.”

He turned to Aramir and said unto him, “All is fine, dear friend, the fellowship has completed its task, and now we must look to the future. I bid thee a farewell, dear friend.” To which Ulfar walked and gave his hooded friend, mentor, a hug, one which spoke of the long years since the last time they embraced one another.

It was then that Travers Aramir removed the hat atop his head, gave a short bow, and then took his leave of the room.

Ariendria looked around and said to all, “Let us be gracious for what had happened and say thanks to the Lady Auréa for healing Ulfar. We now must turn our attention to the path ahead, for here we establish the new kingdom of Man. One that is fit to fight whatever evils come to bear. Say hail to the King of Valkoria! Say hail to Ulfar Valin!”

All the voices of the room came together in harmony to scream out, “Hail Ulfar!” It was harmony that echoed throughout the keep, one that rang in the ears of all those who did the small jobs from Grayson, the advisor, to even those who cleaned the rooms of the vast castle.

They whispered throughout the halls as Aramir passed. He heard a woman say, “Have you heard it? The new King, carrying the name of Talor, has awoken, and soon he will speak.”

There was another man who spoke, “If he truly carries the Amulet of the Kings and Arenith, he will restore the power of our people to their former glory, our kingdom will be one again.”

A third person spoke, his voice much softer than the others, “My dad fought in the rebellion years ago. If only now he

could see what was done, I wish I had taken part in this promise of our old kingdom.”

After Travers left the halls of the keep, he ventured into the renewed streets of the city of Valkoria. He saw the men and women who looked quite happy. The banner of white and gold, that of the Stormfangs, adomed the posts and poles that once held the banners of the Neirmar Imperium. During the time Ulfar rested in his home, the other cities had given their banners to him, pledged allegiance to him and swore oaths to a throne that yet lay unoccupied.

As he made his way through the bustling streets, the men and women he passed seemed to watch him with a mixture of curiosity and suspicion. Some cast fleeting glances, their eyes narrowing slightly as if sizing him up, while others offered strange, knowing glares that spoke volumes without a single word. Yet, despite the silent scrutiny, many people greeted him with an unexpected warmth—a friendly nod here, a gentle wave of the hand there, their faces breaking into quick, pleasant smiles that didn't quite reach their eyes. It was as though they were caught between the tension of their unspoken thoughts and a cultural impulse to show kindness, their gestures awkward but polite.

The air around him was thick with the hum of quiet conversations and the shuffle of feet. No one uttered a greeting aloud, yet the unspoken exchanges seemed to fill the spaces between their fleeting glances and gestures. With each step, he passed more and more of them—men in worn leather tunics, women wrapped in colourful shawls, children playing in the corners—all offering their quiet, wordless acknowledgement of his presence.

Their faces, though never fully smiling, carried the weight of their own unvoiced thoughts, and he wondered what they thought of him as he continued on, undisturbed by the many eyes following his every move, until the towering walls of the main gates loomed just ahead.

Before he could reach the gates of the city, a man, someone eerily familiar to him confronted him. Aramir said, “Greetings, dear friend, it has been quite a time since we last met.” The countenance of the elderly man was creased with a smile that was hardly visible through the thick and wisdom-filled beard.

The man before him was quite bewildered and shaken as if he had been through hell and back again. He was yet another wizard, a second of the order that Travers had membership in.

The wizard strode forth, his presence marked not by the typical air of command, but by an almost weary gentleness. Clad in robes of deep, royal blue and navy, the fabric seemed to ripple with a life of its own, shifting like the twilight sky before the fall of night. Each thread appeared to absorb the light, a soft shimmer playing along the folds, as though the very essence of the stars had been woven into the cloth. Around his shoulders, the cloak billowed in quiet defiance of the wind, as if reluctant to move, yet somehow determined to follow him.

His staff, carved from birch wood, was as plain as it was ancient, its pale bark weathered and etched with faint runes that had long since faded from common understanding. The wood, smooth to the touch yet gnarled with age, seemed to hum softly under his grasp, as though it had its own quiet secrets to share—secrets the wizard was too shaken to unravel. He gripped it firmly, as if seeking the strength it could no longer provide, its slight tremble echoing his own.

A beard, no more than two inches in length, clung to his chin in disarray, the white hairs unkempt and wiry. It was a beard that seemed to have grown without care, much like the wizard himself. His face, lined with deep creases of age, bore the unmistakable signs of one who had witnessed much but understood little. His eyes, though sharp, carried the weight of a man often lost in thought, constantly searching for answers in places where none could be found. There was a quiet disarray about him—his steps uncertain, his gaze wandering, as if he had

just awoken from a dream and found the world too real, too difficult to understand.

His hands, though steady in their grip on the staff, moved as though searching for balance in an invisible storm. Each movement was slow, deliberate, as if the very act of walking required immense concentration. The wizard's voice, when he spoke, was low and rasping, a soft tremor threading through his words, as though he were speaking not to the world around him, but to some distant memory only he could reach.

There was something profoundly bewildered in his nature, a sense that the years had worn away at his certainty, leaving only fragments of the once-great wisdom he had so easily held. Yet in his confusion, there was a kind of gentle grace, a quiet humility that seemed to acknowledge the mysteries of the world rather than challenge them. He was a man of ancient power, yes, but also of deep fragility, caught between the unravelling threads of a forgotten past and a future he could barely comprehend.

The words could not be found by the man to be said so, yet again it was Aramir who spoke, "For what purpose have you sought me out, dear friend? It has been long indeed since I last looked upon the guardian of the Aurellian Forest of Onu-Derith. Tell me, what troubles you so that you come with such a hurried heart? My dear Mikel Sovéran, is there something amiss in your land? Speak, that I may understand the shadows that have found you."

The man whose eyes jolted from left to right as if to catch the trail of some shadow that moved without sight.

He looked deep into the eyes of his dear friend and said, "But surely, you've already a hint or two about this, haven't you? I'd wager you've picked up a bit more than you let on, eh?"

He pulls out a cloth which wraps something of great importance, yet small in nature. On it, he bore two rings, both jagged and not gold but black in nature, known throughout all of history for what they were. "You know well enough to whom

these cursed things once belonged, as do I. A darkness stirs anew in the forsaken ruins of Zhal Durath, a force powerful enough to breathe life into creatures thought long dead. I have seen them, Aramir—the riders of shadow, spirits summoned from beyond the veil to walk this world once more!”

His voice became ever more frantic and almost fearful at what had come, “Neither you nor I walked this world in this manner when the ancient power first drew such creatures into being, those cursed by the dark hand of Valkar himself. But if *he* can now command these horrors—those wretched souls that answer only to the mightiest will—we must ready ourselves, for war looms on the horizon.”

It was then that Aramir said to his dear friend in an inquisitive tone, one of not knowledge but of pure wonder, “Have you ventured to the ruins yet, my dear friend?” The face of Travers was contorted as he asked the question; one eyebrow was shifted higher as the other lay quite lower, as if it were at simple rest.

Sovéran looked around and held out the rings once again; his mind seemed to race as if he were being followed and watched. He spoke softly, “That is how I came across these, though I did not venture far within.”

The head of Aramir rose as he motioned for Sovéran to follow with him as he approached the horse on which he rode. The chest of the old wizard was filled with confidence as he turned his shoulder and spoke to his companion and fellow wizard, “We now stand before two paths. The first is to journey ourselves to the ruins and face what lies within. The second, to seek out Baragom and trust these cursed rings, will convince him of the looming shadow upon this world. It would be no small undertaking—a journey of well over a month to reach him. Tell me, dear friend, what would you wager we do?”

Then a third voice entered the fray, one that was aloft of a much higher order than the two wizards, one which was soft

and elegant, as if the very stars of the night had anointed her voice to be their music.

It was the lady Auréa who approached and answered what was posed by Aramir, “We must journey to the forsaken ruins of Zhal Durath, for there we shall confront this sorcerer of the shadows. If he indeed walks this world, then now, perhaps, is our only chance to glimpse his power before it festers beyond measure. We go not only to seek him, but to test the strength he wields—a force that lingers in places long forgotten, where darkness itself still clings to stone. If ever we are to stem this rising tide, now is the time to gaze into the abyss and know the shape of what stirs within.”

Her words wise and knowing set forth the plan of the three as they saddled their horses, in the case of Sovéran his sled of wolves, and rode off to the south western coast of the continent a place that was familiar to Taelmíra who overheard their talk and saw them leave, the dark elf's being shook with the their vague mentions of the shadow who saw her.

The trio of ancient dwellers of this world would take the nearly two-day straight ride to the ruins of Zhal Durath, which would be filled with much silence, as all three had deep fears of what they would find hiding deep within the ancient walls of the collapsing place. And so, as dusk came on the second full day, the mountains which held the ancient ruins came into view of them.

It was a sore sight in the eyes of those who did live in the times it was beheld in the utmost honour of all forts of the land. It was a mangy excuse of what once was, the great craftsmen of ancient men. The three were placed before two paths, and as they were, they ascended the path that would take them through the very front of the ruins.

It was Sovéran who spoke first, coming from his scattered place as usual, “There's a strange, unsettling air about this place, Aramir. It feels as though a shadow lies over

something... something hidden, lurking just beyond sight. Do you both feel it, too?"

With a simple tap of the staff of Travers Aramir on the stone below their feet, there was a visible bubble which covered the entirety of the ruins before them. "That is because, dear friend, a spell of concealment lies upon this place—one I have only ever heard whispers of in the old lore. It is no common magic, no mere trick of the schools, but something that reaches far beyond the arts wielded by mortals. It is a spell of Eins' Tenth Tier, known as *Encarsé*. In the ancient tongue, as written by Anteantodo himself in the books of magic, it means 'to encase.' Such a spell is woven to conceal things of immense power and dread, things whose very presence can stir awe and fear alike. These creatures—ah, we have not seen their kind since the days of the First Era. We must press on, for we must learn what lies hidden within."

He paused a brief second to look at Auréa behind him and grasped her hand in his and said to her, "I would ask you to send word to the Lady Dramira and your father. Tell them of the magic that guards these ruins and bid them to make haste in catching up to us. For once we cross this threshold, no messenger shall find escape from within."

Auréa looked at Travers and told him with a pure and honest promise, "I will send her word, be careful in there, for we do not know how powerful the enemy has already become."

It was then that he nodded his head, and with that, Travers Aramir looked to his dear friend Mikel Sovéran and motioned forward while drawing his blade, Shadowcleave, from the elegant sheath upon his waist. The two wizards moved forward onto the bridge before them, cracked and crumbled, where each step threatened to send the stone fortress cascading into oblivion. Shadows clung to the air, thickening with each faltering footfall, twisting the silence into something more sinister. The peace here was a dark, unholy stillness—a void filled with whispers of an ancient dread.

The very stones beneath them seemed to shudder, as though recoiling from their presence, worn thin by ages of sorrow and haunted by the weight of countless forgotten battles. Black vines, as withered as they were twisted, crawled up the walls like skeletal fingers grasping for the last fragments of the fortress, veiling the bridge in shades of decay. Beyond, a swirling mist loomed, thick and impenetrable, seeping through the cracks in the stone as if summoned from some dark wellspring below. It draped the fortress in an unnatural shroud, a murk that turned everything it touched into faded shadows, hiding much of the ruin yet revealing glimpses of what once was—a dark spire, now broken, reaching hopelessly toward the sky, and the shattered remains of statues, guardians perhaps, now twisted and leering under the weight of time and sorcery.

It was as if the darkness had seeped into the very soul of this place, sinking into every crack and fissure, transforming the once-proud fortress into a dwelling of unrelenting malice. An eerie, otherworldly silence hung over the stones, thick as the mist, broken only by the faintest sound of their own breaths—quiet, careful, fearful. The air was stagnant, clinging to them with a damp, cold weight that gnawed at their courage. Every inhalation tasted of damp earth and the bitter tang of something fouler, like the remnants of old curses lingering in the very atmosphere. It felt as though the fortress itself resented them, and whatever light they carried in their hearts dimmed beneath the weight of its ancient evil.

Then, the sorcerer's taint seemed to hang above it all, like a web spun over the bridge and across the ruins. Here, halfway cloaked by Aramir's warning, his presence was almost palpable, an oppressive force pressing down, filling every shadow with something malevolent, watchful. It was a peace like the dead stillness before a storm, where even the air held its breath, but here it had a deeper foulness—as though something wicked lingered in every particle, in every crevice. This silence was no sanctuary; it was a prelude, a hushed promise of the

horrors that lay beyond. They tread forward, feeling the pull of the spire at the heart of Zhal Durath, and each step forward is met with the quiet protest of stones ground down by countless years of neglect. Yet they knew, even without words, that there would be no turning back.

There was an aurora around them, the sound of feet upon the stone circled the two when Aramir, with all his force, slammed the base of his staff to the ground and said words that were filled with the vigour of a thousand years, “Dolhas vanal arda hamel anterior!”

It was some mystical speech that came from him as the best of pure light came from the point he hit and clashed with the darkness that surrounded him. Then again, the wood of his staff met with the stone, and he yelled out, “Dolhas vanal arda hamel anterior!”

The words echoed through the hollow structure, and then came the screeches of men long since dead. The two wizards stepped forward, entering a more open and flat space, which had a slight incline of what once looked to be a bridge that overhung the vast drop in the middle of the structure.

Sovéran looked around and had his staff at the ready; his back was to the chasm which stopped their advance. He turned to his dear friend and said, “What do we do now? Those screeches, no, they are echoes, yet... they are sounds we both know all too well.”

Aramir, with a felt sense of courage, looked at his friend and then gazed at the black hooded creature before him, and said, “We still have hope, my dear friend, for though we face the very remnants of Valkar himself, it does not do to dwell solely on the darkness. Remember this: for a shadow to be seen, there must yet be a light to cast it. So now, as we stand together, Sovéran, let us hold fast to the courage that lies within the hearts of this world's people. For as long as we remain, we too are a part of it. Come then, and let us face these evils as one, my close friend.”

The creature that approached was the very one who brought down Seidel himself, the one whose rings lay in the pocket of Sovéran at this very moment. The darkness loomed as the blade and staff of Travers Aramir were ready to do battle. In his right hand was the sword known as the Orc-hammer, or rather, Shadowcleave, and in his left was the staff which he so trusted with his life.

The apparition came forward towards the wizard, from the abyss underneath the hood that covered the spot where a head should lie, the void of a creature sprang forth in a rage, the echoed voice that seemed to be death itself came from the creature.

There it spoke, “Tharek yar rulak. Thrakel verath arek.” The words of the apparition seemed to slither through the very air in which they were carried across like the tongue of a serpent in an effort to make those who hear such words cower in pure and desolate fear.

The resolute nature of Aramir kept his courage and will determined and firm in the face of the valley of death that stood before him. There, he said aloud, “You cannot bind me to fear with the frail words of one who trusted in the deceptions spun by him who became shadow and ruin. Your master lies beyond the grave, trapped in the void etemal! There can be no loss in a war that shall never even begin!”

He, with a jab of his staff as if it were a spear, hit the figure clad in black robes and ancient steel armour in the middle of its chest, letting out an explosion of light, sending it back flying against a wall. Aramir's voice belted on with, “Run! Run back to the shadows from whence you came! Run back to the grave in which you were bound! Begone, darkened spirit of man, lost wanderer of the mortal world! Slave of darkness! Nirinathé!” Each word was matched with a strike of his staff, a wooden spear strengthened with nameless magic.

The words of his friend echoed throughout the space, yet the spectre did not retreat because of the wizards; it was first

Sovéran who turned and noticed the black coagulation of smoke behind them, the one that seemed to burn with the fires of the very earth itself, yet had no light, like the void eternal.

But it was neither smoke nor an eternal, ever-present shadow. It was the first Sovéran who spoke, “My dear friend Aramir, do turn around and look closely at what lies behind us. It is not merely the illusions of the world or the deceits we have encountered, but something far darker—him. He is here, Aramir, the one we feared to name, the shadow at the heart of all shadows... Valkar himself. His presence clings to the air, tainting it, reaching out like the roots of some ancient, malignant tree, spreading its rot into every corner. The ground beneath us feels his weight, and the very trees shudder at his approach. This is no longer a mere threat whispered on the winds—he has come, and his darkness has come with him.”

Travers pulled back his friends and gazed into a stirring fire within the shadow. His breath was nearly gone, yet he still muttered a few words, “No, it cannot be.”

The figure that stood before them was scarcely human—a shadow given shape yet devoid of any true form, as though the dark essence of a Nirinathé had been stripped of cloak, armour, and all earthly flesh. This sorcerer was not bound to the usual confines of flesh and bone; he was a chuming mist, a presence that seemed to consume the very light around him. There was no face, no hands, no eyes, yet somehow, an awareness, a malignant intelligence, hovered within the shadow, almost breathing, almost alive.

And then came the voice. It did not merely sound in the air, nor was it confined to the trembling earth beneath them; it invaded the mind, pressing its coarse, guttural sound into their very thoughts. It rolled over them, thick as smoke and heavy as iron, a voice as ancient as forgotten histories and deep as the chasms of the night. Like the slow grind of stone and metal, it spoke not with words alone but with a primal, wordless threat, reverberating through the world itself. The sound was more than

mere language; it was felt as a sickness in the bones, a twisting in the heart—a voice of raw power, a force forged in a darkness that no mortal could name.

This was the voice of a Dark Lord, a presence that had woven fear into the legends of their land, a dread known yet unseen, whose malice stretched across ages. And yet, it was unlike anything they had ever encountered—a terror bound not to past knowledge but to something unearthly and eternal. It was the very embodiment of power unchained, a call to the abyss itself. They stood in its presence as shadows before a dying sun, feeling that they were nothing more than fleeting sparks in its vast and merciless gaze.

The words that took to the air were not those of Morvath but those of something darker and much more rare to the world, especially to the land of man, Sh'r'galth, “Lo tael manaké dori amanuar, fear me—I am he who... replaces Valkar... I shall be the true Lord... of this world, where none... shall defy my will. Through the ashes of the old... I will rise, and all shall... bend before me... for I will return. The age of Valkar... has ended—mine is the coming reign, and none will stand against it.”

The words of the voice were spaced and echoed, adding a deepened, ominous nature to the voice. Then, in an instant, the figure reached towards the wizard, overpowering their magic and sending the staff of Aramir to simple tinder, shards—splinters of wood, accosted in the air as it exploded. For over a thousand years, that was the staff of the wizard, yet no more. In a split second, the shadow of who they had near dread as Valkar himself had broken it.

Travers Aramir then yelled with a voice projected in pure, unresolved power, “Fester yourself back to the shadows, heir of Valkar, slave of darkness! Leave this world of flesh and bone banished back to the void from whence you spawned! You cannot be here!”

There was a return that echoed with a more intense quality than that of Aramir's own. It was the same dark voice, that of a serpent—a spawn of the very essence of the void itself; each word could invoke a lifetime of nightmares on whoever heard it. “You—have no power. You are—nothing wizard. There is nothing for you.” Each word seemed to pierce the ears of Travers Aramir like a needle through the leather that soon becomes a new set of armour.

With his blade drawn and gleaming in the dim light, he forcefully pushes Sovéran aside, the clang of steel ringing through the air. His voice erupts with urgency, cutting through the tension like a sharpened blade as he yells, “Run, you fool! This is not a power for you to fight! Go—wam Lady Auréa, and send word to Lady Dramira. He has begun his return!”

A deep fear took root within the eyes of Travers, an unsettling chill that gnawed at his spirit, yet still his resolve did not waver. His courage was not born of simple valour, but of something deeper—his purpose, a purpose that had eluded him until now. It was then, amidst the chaos, that his true identity resurfaced. The fog of forgetfulness lifted, and in that moment, he remembered who he truly was, his true name, and the reason he had come to Varis Mogul.

The weight of his purpose settled into his bones, grounding him with a newfound clarity. With his hand bare and trembling, he whispered the word—“Välé”—a word older than time itself, one that seemed to echo from the very fabric of existence. As the word left his lips, he pushed his dear friend away, the force of his action sending Sovéran stumbling backwards. In the same breath, he met the shadow's strike head-on with his blade, the clash of steel ringing in his ears like thunder.

His body, old and weary, twisted with an almost unnatural speed, moving to parry and block the relentless onslaught of the shadow's strikes. His blade flashed in the dim light, deflecting blow after blow from the Nirinathé and the Dark

Lord's dark presence. But his movements, though swift, could not ward off every strike. His body, though hardened by countless battles, was no longer what it once had been. With every lashing strike, his flesh was marked—lacerations and cuts slashed across him, each one a testament to the immense power he faced.

A harsh tone took the air as it hummed with the sound of his blade meeting the shadows, the rhythm of metal against malice growing faster, harsher. Yet for all his skill, for all his courage, Travers knew it was only a matter of time before he succumbed to the dark tide. But before that inevitable fall, there remained one last trick, one final act. His memories, now awakened, surged within him, and in that fleeting moment, he drew upon the power of his past.

With a voice that seemed to reverberate through the very heavens, carrying the weight of ages and the echoes of forgotten worlds, he spoke aloud, “Ghotarium Ismaiel Arda!”

The words were like the sound of mountains coming down or the growl of an ancient drake over the valley. And then it all went quiet, and he remembered again who he was. Travers Aramir was but another name he had taken in his eternal life; it was his second time in the world of Varis Mogul. He remembered that a voice far beyond him spoke once again. It was indirect but surrounded him as well; it spun words he could not make out, yet ones he knew, and then it was over.

As Aramir's dear friend, Sovéran, the blue-clad wizard, ran, he heard a thunder come from the heaven above, and a red bolt of lightning came down and struck the ruins where his dear friend stood.

Then the structure of the ancient ruins began to collapse under the feet of the man as he ran. He came to meet the Lady Auréa, who, before he could speak, said, “They come to take us to Vivik to see my mother, let us go.”

Not even an utterance of the events that just transpired before her was uttered by neither her nor Sovéran. Before them

lay not one but two Velreth, striders of the world, creatures which could travel weeks in mere days.

The first Velreth was a towering figure, its sleek, chitinous body shimmering in the soft light of the setting sun. Its elongated legs were braced in a poised stance, as if ready to spring forward at a moment's notice. The creature's translucent wings flickered slightly in the breeze, catching the sunlight with an ethereal glow. Its antennae twitched with a silent intelligence, scanning the horizon for any signs of movement. The sinewy muscles beneath its carapace rippled with latent power, waiting for the moment it would once again carry its rider across the vast wilderness.

Beside it stood the second Velreth, smaller but no less formidable. Its body was a darker hue, more closely resembling the shadows of the dense forests that stretched for miles ahead. This one's legs were slightly shorter, but its agility was unmatched, able to nimbly weave through trees and cliffs with graceful precision. Its mandibles, though smaller than its counterpart's, were honed to a razor's edge, perfect for clearing the way through thick foliage or fending off predators. Its wings, though folded, hummed with an unseen energy, ready to lift the creature into the air with the speed of a falcon.

They mounted their rides, the two left behind the even more decimated ruins, now much more desolate than they ever had been and headed to the west, far beyond the continent of Onu-Derith, beyond the Ocean of Galilee, to the vivid city of Vivik.

Ulfar sat upon the cracked and broken throne that once sat the very line of usurpers which forced this land into a suffering that it need not ever endure. Ariendria stood beside him, and now he would have the crown of the kings placed upon his head in the holy ceremony under the watchful eyes of the

seven gods of man. The room had been decorated with small yet vivid statues of all the gods of the seven; each one had a bust to bring glory to their name, and for the rights of the coronation of Ulfar as King of Man, the King of New Valkoria.

The priest stood tall and solemn before the gathered throng, his voice like the rumbling of distant thunder, echoing through the great hall. He raised his arms high, invoking the divine, as the ceremonial fires crackled around him.

The air was thick with sacred smoke and ancient promises. “Hail, Ulfar Valin, chosen by fate, by fire, and by the will of the Seven. Here, in the sight of gods and men, you take this crown—not as a mere trinket of glory, but as the weighty yoke of duty that binds you to the lives of your people. This day marks your ascension, and it is here that you will swear an oath by which you shall live or die, rule or be ruled.”

The priest turned toward the gilded statue of Vekar, lifting his gaze as though the All-Father himself looked upon this moment. “By Vekar, the All-Father, you swear to uphold wisdom and justice, to bear the weight of your people’s needs with courage and clarity. You are their shield, their voice, and their guidance.”

The priest’s eyes seemed to flash like steel drawn from its sheath as he called forth Talor, the Warrior. “By Talor, the Warrior, you swear to protect and defend, to rise against the darkness with honour and might. Yours is the unyielding hand that holds the blade steady for kin and home, and yours the strength to stand unbroken as the mountains in times of trial.”

A rumble of approval sounded from the assembled crowd as the name of Drukavin was spoken. “By Drukavin, the Storm-Brother, you swear to embrace the fury of battle as the storm itself, to be fierce in the defence of your kin. Wield strength and righteous wrath, as a shepherd wields his crook to defend the flock.”

A deep pause came after the speaking of honours under the name of Drukavin. There were mild chats in the crowd with

one man saying, “You know this is the first crowning of a king in a few hundred years?”

The woman he spoke to said in return, “Are you serious?” Her face was pained and adorned with the colours and ornaments of confusion and bewilderment.

The priest continued his pace, as he walked, he gestured to the forge fires, flickering as if alive, invoking the power of Drenamir, the Smith. “By Drenamir, the Smith, you swear to build and fortify, to hammer out a kingdom of iron and stone, and to forge prosperity for all hands, great or small. For each soul is shaped by the fire of common purpose, tempered by duty to the realm.”

The priest's voice softened slightly, reverent now as he spoke of Viviana, goddess of family and hearth. “By Viviana, the Wife, you swear to protect the bonds of kin and kinship that make a kingdom whole. To nurture your people as one nurtures their own, to cherish the family of your kingdom, as each hearthstone binds the whole.”

A hush fell as the priest evoked Halfar, the Stranger, whom all feared yet honoured for his knowledge of shadows and dreams. “By Halfar, the Stranger, you swear to remember the shadows and dreams, to act with wit and cunning in times of strife. In the quiet corners of the mind, may peace or peril both be found, and you shall wield them as only the wise can.”

At last, the priest invoked the ancient mother of all things, Vaeimea, her presence felt in the heartbeat of the earth beneath their feet. “By Vaeimea, the Mother, you swear to preserve life and to know death, to keep the sacred cycle. Love and beauty are as precious as steel, and you shall foster these gifts in all you rule.”

The voice of the priest grew with intensity and vigour as he spoke, the man seemed to be filled with the very spirits of the gods when his words came to be. The priest's voice grew louder now, rising with the sacred call. “In the name of Ysengard, you swear to walk the path of honour, to grant safe passage to the

brave who fall, to see their legacy borne in deeds unforgotten. So stand now, Ulfar Valin, for upon this day you bear the weight of this realm and bind your life to the gods' own will.”

The priest then lowered his hands, and with a voice as soft as twilight, he spoke the closing words. “By the eternal heavens, by soil and storm, by love and law—you are crowned King.”

The crowd before the man erupted into feverous applause and chants of the name of Valin, yelling and screaming for a speech. There was a single chant that said in unison, “Hail, Ulfar Valin! Hail, Hail, Hail!” The voice of these people present was sent to the rafters of the keep as if to be powered by the will of the gods themselves.

There was no speech from the man, though he rose and said two words aloud for all to hear, “For Valkoria!”

This simply brought more chants and cheers to those who stood before him, now those people whom he ruled. The man's quest was completed, the throne was his, and the night had come, filled with celebrations of mead and other beverages, all sang hymns and songs of ancient tales and even spun one of new, crafted in the most recent pages of the tomb of history..

There was a table that had a bard, and there she began to play his lute, and joined the voices of men singing a song which carried a spoken word element to it, one of which they had dubbed the *Forgo Oppression*:

Forgo Oppression

*We raise to our youth for days now gone past,
For the tyranny of oppression is coming undone,
We shall chase down the scum that plague us at last, in
our steel and our blood, our victory shall be won,*

*For we hail Ulfar he is the true king,
Under his banner our valour shall ring,*

*In this honour we sing and we drink,
In his name our spirits shall link,*

*We're the blood of Valkoria, we will fight for our lives,
and when Ysengard sends us we care not whose soul
flies. In the face of darkness, our destiny arrives, with
courage ablaze, our spirit now thrives.*

*This land was once ours and we'll see it clean,
Of those who have slain our hopes and our dreams,*

*For we hail, hail Ulfar he is the true king,
Under his banner our valour shall sing,
We're the blood of Valkoria, we will fight for our lives,
And when Ysengard sends us we not question who dies,*

*We raise to our youth for days now long gone,
For the tyranny of oppression has now come undone.*

The party to celebrate the newly crowned king raged on, yet he was not there to even enjoy his own celebration. The night was alight with a soft, haunting glow from twin half-moons, casting a gentle blue light over the secluded courtyard, long forgotten and tangled in vines and wild, overgrown flora. Each leaf and stem shimmered in that celestial glow, their delicate forms dancing in quiet contrast to the sturdy stone walls that enclosed the garden—ancient guardians to a sanctuary that time had left untouched.

Only a handful had tread here since its creation, for it was a place neither meant for nor welcoming to the footsteps of many. Within this hidden realm, where the walls framed a small world unto itself, the botanical splendour flourished with rare beauty. Trees spread their branches like veils over bushes laden with winter-blooming wonders, and blossoms unfurled in colours that seemed foreign to the season—a testament to the enchanted

nature of this place. And amidst the marvel of winter blooms, Ulfar's gaze settled upon a pair of flowers that drew his eye like rare jewels glistening in the snow-kissed grass.

Before him, resting upon a slightly elevated patch, once the pedestal or basin of something long lost, were two striking flowers—star-crossed companions. To the right, the crimson-red petals of a spider lily curved with intensity, fierce and bold even beneath the cool light.

To the left, its counterpart: the elusive Queen of the Night, a bloom that dared to open only for a few nights each year, glowing with an ethereal iridescence in hues of deep purple, as though capturing the essence of twilight itself. Together, they made a tableau of contrasts: red and purple, fire and starlight, a silent conversation that spoke of rare beauty and passing moments. It was here that Ariendria appeared, her footsteps soundless, emerging from the shadows to stand beside Ulfar.

Both gazed upon the blooms, their shared wonder a quiet language all its own. Around her neck, the Pendant of Choice lay nestled—a simple adornment to any other, but to her, it bore the weight of a decision that would alter the course of her life, a symbol of how Vaeimea would see her life. The petals glimmered in the moonlight as her gaze lingered on the rare bloom, and beside her, Ulfar held his breath, sensing the gravity that stirred between them as if nature itself understood the weight of her choice.

It was not her but Ulfar who first turned and broke the calming silence. He grasped her soft and chilled fingers within his and spoke unto her, “One cannot make such a choice in the matter of mere months. I have come to learn I am not the one who would ever deserve such a gift. And please tell me why forsake the eternal life given to your people?”

Her eyes softened with moonlight and her skin, typically olive and golden, blessed by the sun, looked more pale than that of the visender, the elves of the snow. The night had drawn her

beautiful hair normally for a green hue to a deep black as if to be the absence of light itself.

Her voice was a soft melody upon the crisp air as she spoke to him, “I would forsake a thousand lifetimes if it meant there was but one I could spend with you.” The air was calming, not chilling; it was as if the air alone could preserve the first moment of pure peace the two had had in the half calendar of them knowing one another.

He grasped the hands of this endearing woman as he spoke to her, his mind repeated over the same question, “But why forsake the life of your people, your friends, and your father?”

His face was not filled with bitterness nor even confusion, but what seemed to be sadness for those who would come to know her as a loss in their lives. His heart yearned for her, yet he knew there was but a single way for such a woman to sit upon the throne with him, yet it was what he dreaded most—cutting her life short. He knew the music of the world that was her life was one meant to echo throughout the world for all eternity. He had sought not to take such a beautiful song from the world.

She unclasped the amulet from her neck, the beautiful pendant, so simple yet intricate, glistened in the shining of the dual moons; it was like a star had been placed deep within. She placed it within the hands of the man before her, and deep within her head rang the words of Travers Aramir, who had told her once; *Yet, when the day comes that he claims that mantle, he shall be a man you will learn to cherish once more.*

It echoed in his rough and wise voice, for he had taken the first step towards the mantle and yet was a different man than even the one who outwitted General Boscogn at Vingólf. He had changed; it was even present in the manner he spoke.

She looked with a resting heart deep into his eyes and said to him, “As my mother lay passing, I vowed to her I would seek not a man flawless nor easy to love, but one who cherished

the song of my heart as it was sung. And so, here before you, I hold true to that promise—for one life with you would bring me more joy than a thousand ages of this world could ever grant.”

Her words were like the echoes of the final chords of a lasting song, one that was beautiful and composed by none other than Goht Himself. She simply looked into his eyes, and the two shared their first kiss as a second Queen of the Night bloomed behind them, and the red spider lily did not die, nor fade, but became one with the two before it, no longer red but glimmering the purple hue of the two around it.

Moments passed, and Ulfar came with one more question, “Will it be as the two tales, Drewen and Llyena, along with Vaxar and Kelana? Sombre and sorrowful.” His voice was lower than previously; it was a question begging for an answer, but a reference to two past examples of the love of elves and men intertwining to form a yarn which could only go so far.

“Perhaps, or perhaps we sail off into the new world when the lamb returns as a lion and the end comes.” She let out a soft chuckle as her joke seemingly went over the head of the mortal man. Shocked, she turned in an instant, “Wait, you're telling me you've never read the Revelations of the Apostle?”

The man thought for a deep second. He knew the name and had seen the book—as it was part of the ancient religion of Jeda. “I've seen it, never read it though.”

She shakes her head in immense disapproval, as she chuckles one more—rather giggles in a laugh never heard by Ulfar. With a deep inhale that pauses the childish gander, “We shall rectify that then.” With the final words, none more were spoken between them in the garden, and the night passed on.

As the weeks passed and Ulfar ascended to the throne of the king, he would take up Ariendria as his wife upon his chest; he bore her token, her choice of a life with him, along with the symbol of the Kingdom, the Amulet of the Kings.

Chapter 16

The Morrow's Daybreak

As hours and days gave way to the timeless passage of the journey, the wizard Sovéran and the lady elf Auréa rode through sunlit valleys and shadowed woods, across two mighty oceans and a continent as ancient as the stars themselves. At last, they arrived at Vivik—a city of wonder and deep-rooted magic, as though it had blossomed from the earth itself, shaped by hands older than memory, woven with the very essence of the forests it called home.

Vivik lay before them like a dream given form, a place where nature and architecture intertwined in harmony so complete that it felt like the pulse of the city was synced with the very heart of the woodlands. The houses of Vivik, formed from pale, glimmering stones, were as smooth and pure as river-washed marble, catching the light in hues of silver and pearl. The stones rose organically, their forms curving and flowing like vines seeking the sky, blending seamlessly with the shades of browns and greens of the surrounding woods, as if the trees themselves had gifted their roots to cradle this ancient city.

Above, the canopy spread thick and leafy, filtering sunlight into a cool, dim glow, as if lit by the twin moons themselves, always full and hovering in the sky's embrace. Under this celestial veil, the city was suffused with a timeless peace, a tranquil hum that resonated through the streets and curled into the minds of those who walked them.

For Sovéran and Auréa, this sanctuary offered solace, a balm to the tumultuous thoughts that had plagued them since their departure from the ruins of Zhal Durath. The wizard's every footfall seemed to float, as if he strode upon clouds spun from the dreams of the ancient ones. The path beneath was firm, yet glowed with the pale shimmer of immortal sands, fine and white as moonlit shores, scattered in a never-ending cascade. Around them, crystalline waterfalls glistened, each one a soft chorus, weaving a melody as old as the earth itself, echoing through the city like a lullaby sung by the mountains.

The elves of Vivik, ethereal and ageless, moved through the streets in a serene procession. Each one who crossed Sovéran's gaze seemed both familiar and foreign, like visions from half-forgotten dreams. Eyes filled with quiet wisdom followed their steps, their glances shimmering with kindness and curiosity.

Soon, a figure stepped forward to greet them: Alíwen, clad in armour of gleaming silver and dark steel, crafted with both beauty and precision. The armour was a marvel of elven craftsmanship, as if woven from the light of starlit skies and the shadows of dawn, plating her form with a strength that was powerful yet graceful, with an elegance that mirrored the very spirit of the high elves themselves.

With a quiet nod and the slightest motion of her hand, Alíwen led them through the winding paths of Vivik, past gardens thick with silverleaf and moss-kissed stone, to the heart of the city, where the central tree, specifically a Celéode Tree, one of the last of its kin, loomed—a towering, ancient being whose gnarled bark and sweeping branches held the House of Dramira.

The tree's vast trunk bore the weight of centuries, its branches stretching wide like open arms, while its roots spiralled deep into the earth, entwined with the foundations of Vivik itself. Each step toward the tree was a step deeper into the heart of the elven world, where time moved not in years but in breaths, and

the air shimmered with magic as old as the dawn. The three walked the spiralling steps up to the house of the lords of this land. Yet, as they entered a terrace just before the final step, Alíwen motioned for a stop, which was reasoned with the approach from the upper stairs: two figures, a man and a woman.

The man, an elf of commanding presence, stood as if he were one with the very roots of the land, his form noble and ageless, forged by centuries of wisdom and tempered by countless seasons. Vaxium's skin, pale as dawn breaking upon snowy peaks, seemed to glow with a faint luminescence, a reflection of the soft light that filled Vivik's woodland realm. His face, unmarred by time yet etched with the lines of deep thought and gentle wisdom, held a serenity that bespoke a soul entwined with both the past and the future.

He wore robes that flowed like water, woven of fabric that held within it the colours of twilight—the blue of distant horizons and the grey of an overcast sea. His attire, subtle yet magnificent, whispered of a kingly stature without the burden of gold or jewels, a symbol of authority tempered with humility. Upon his right ear, an earring dangled, crafted from a rare silver that seemed to mirror the faint starlight; its twin adorned the ear of the woman who walked beside him, a bond between them as eternal as the stars themselves.

His hands, weathered yet elegant, gripped those of the she-elf who stood at his side, the Lady Queen Dramira. A single ring encircled his finger—a simple band of ancient gold gifted to him by the dwarves, bearing a gemstone of untold power. The gem, a deep, earthy green, seemed to pulse faintly as though alive, its glow synced with the heartbeat of the world itself.

Within its facets, one could glimpse fleeting memories of mountains rising from the earth and rivers carving their way through stone—a reminder of the timeless connection between earth and elf, a bond Vaxium himself honoured and upheld. His black hair, falling in dark waves, was like the night sky woven

into his very being, and his eyes, as blue as the ocean at twilight, bore a calm intensity that spoke of endless depths.

Those who looked into Vaxium's eyes saw an ocean of mysteries and a strength that seemed boundless, an arrow aimed with unfailing precision toward the heart of truth.

Beside him, the Lady Dramira was a vision both familiar and otherworldly, the culmination of centuries of beauty and wisdom, radiant yet unfathomable, serene yet powerful. Her skin, once kissed by moonlight in her youth, now seemed to be carved from the very light itself, holding a quiet glow that reflected her inner strength and radiated her inner beauty. It was as if the years had only added to her elegance, weaving a subtle depth into the luminescent glow of her pale skin.

Waves of silver hair cascaded down her back, falling past her shoulders like a river of starlight caught in eternal flow, each strand as if spun from moonbeams yet resilient as ancient iron. Her hair shimmered with an ethereal beauty that caught the light with every movement, as though blessed by the stars themselves. Her eyes, once vivid green as new leaves, now held a colour tempered to the deep, ageless emerald of the ancient forest canopy, deep and dark yet still gleaming with a life that could not be tamed.

Her gaze was that of a queen who had looked upon both the heights of joy and the depths of sorrow, a wellspring of wisdom as deep as the roots of the oldest trees. Dramira's eyes, in their vivid, liquid green, held stories untold and secrets beyond counting, mirroring the elven lands she ruled, complex and layered, hidden and unveiled. Draped in robes of white woven with silver, Dramira moved with a grace that defied time, her steps as light as the morning mist upon the forest floor. Her garments bore no insignia, yet the fabric shimmered with faint runes only visible in certain light, ancient symbols of protection and unity woven by skilled elven hands long ago.

The slender, silver circlet upon her brow glimmered like moonlight on calm waters, and at her side rested a pendant—a

gift from Vaxium—crafted from the rarest stone of the elves, holding within it a shard of light so pure it seemed almost to breathe.

Together, Vaxium and Dramira were a pair that appeared as much a part of Vivik as the trees and streams themselves, a force both grounded and transcendent. They embodied a balance that was rare even among their own kin, an unspoken harmony between strength and grace, wisdom and compassion. As they moved through Vivik, their very presence seemed to draw the reverent gaze of all who passed, each elf bowing slightly, not in mere deference, but in respect to the embodiment of elven heritage that these two represented. They were not only leaders of their people but symbols of something far greater—a legacy of resilience, beauty, and an endless quest for the light that bound their world together.

Vaxium was the first to, with grace, place his feet forward and approach the two who walked up, yet he did not acknowledge his daughter, who graced his presence, but he asked a question, “Where is the third?”

His voice rang out with quiet authority, a deep sorrow lingering in his words. “Three entered the Shadowed Cloud of Zhul Durath, yet only two have returned. I must know—where is my dear friend, Travers Aramir?”

His gaze swept the assembled, searching, as if the answer might be drawn from the very air itself, his tone both gentle and commanding, as though asking a question to which only time could reveal the truth.

Before either Sovéran or Auréa could answer, the beautiful and magnificent Dramira graced the world with her voice, which sounded like Gohr had spun her voice as his very own music, “He—he is beyond us, called to a purpose we cannot yet grasp. The sages have much more to sing of him. But I cannot see him, not yet; he has vanished once again.” Her words were almost like a riddle for those around, yet the four knew exactly what was said.

With that, Sovéran spoke up, his voice broken and frantic once again, and his body language was scattered as he fiddled with the pipe in his pocket and the rings he had taken during his first visit.

His words came clear yet weak from his throat, “We glimpsed there what I could've sworn was laid to rest ages past, back in the First Era, yes, yes! Warriors of Valkar, dreadful things, up from their graves they've come, rattling with ancient fury!”

Vaxium looks to the rattled wizard, “Sovéran, please get to the point. I feel there is little time for your endless rambles.” His voice was violent like folded steel met with a perfect whetstone.

Sovéran gives a nod as he continues, “In there lies a necromancer, oh yes, a foul one indeed, calling them to the ruins—all the way over on the continent of Onu-Arith, if you'd believe it. Here, here, look closely!”

He shows the two rings which broaden the eyes of the elves present, “These... these I uncovered during my first journey to the ruins, a mere scratch upon their surface, mind you—not like the last time. Oh, that last time... that's what troubles me most, yes indeed. We went deeper, much deeper, and there we encountered the necromancer—or rather, sorcerer, he called himself! A dark, twisted thing, and yet he claimed—no, he insisted—that he was not Valkar nor any shade of his spirit, but something... far worse. As Aramir battled him, striking at the fiend with his blade, only one name rose in my mind—a name we've long feared to speak aloud, a name that should never echo again. But it seems, alas, our enemy has returned.” The crazed wizard took a draw off his pipe, which seemed to roll his eyes back into his head, calming the nerves brought to the surface by the retelling of the experience at Zhul Durath.

It was then Vaxium who rose in a fury at the suggestions of the wizard. He spoke aloud in a violent tone, “You dare, Mikel Sovéran, to question my abilities?”

His anger grew as he spoke, as if the simple suggestion of who it could be that came from Travers Aramir, not Sovéran, dishonoured the man, “My own blade met the vile creature when he dared set foot upon these lands, a being of such abhorrence that his very presence tainted the earth beneath him. With my strike, I cast him down, for his wounds were grievous, beyond even the darkest arts of healing known to this world. And yet, a question weighs upon my mind: why now do the Nirinathé answer this summons, when in the Second Era, they refused even the most desperate call? What force has stirred them from their silence, binding them to a path they once shunned?”

Auréa was the one who answered, not the wizard; her words were graceful and exact, answering the queries posed by her father, “It was Aramir’s own words that claimed it—none other, none lesser. You, Sovéran, and Aramir alone have gazed upon both the dread presence of Valkar and this darker force. Why, then, would we turn aside from the wisdom of one so keen-sighted? Shall we summon Baragorn the Black to cast such judgment, or should we heed the voices of those who have seen past the veil, into the very heart of the ruins themselves?”

Her tone became one of sass and distance with her father’s doubt, “It is a simple matter: if the enemy returns, we must ready ourselves for war. It is telling enough that the few fallen warriors of Valkar have risen, stirred by a power greater than his ever was upon this world. We must think of what if the Nirinathé rise to Malachar’s ranks, what if the Great Dragons return or even the Umbrathrox? And this, this alone, speaks volumes—for the foe we face now is nothing like the darkness we endured in the War of Shadows. What looms before us is something far more perilous, more consuming than any force we have yet encountered.” Her voice sought reason in the elders before them. Auréa pleaded like a young child to her parents, knowing their response already.

Seconds passed as the words of Auréa seemed to fall on the very moving air, carried away for none to hear or acknowledge.

It was not Vaxium who first acknowledged their daughter, but Dramira, who then spoke, “I thank you, my dove, my dearest heart, for rooting yourself so deeply within the world, as I once did, long ago, when its shadows and glories were all that held my gaze. Your words carry the weight of truth, and I believe that the vigilant eyes of Travers Aramir would know without error what they have beheld. We must steel ourselves now, for he approaches with a purpose yet unseen.”

Dramira pauses for a brief moment; the weight of her steps seemed to dwarf the words she echoed. A truth yet unseen was held within her mind; her face betrayed and showed little worry of the ill-fated venture. She turned to her daughter once more, “The realm of man rises again, and with it comes a new king, borne of a fresh alliance with the wood-elves of Elendaiél and the stalwart bloodline of Talor, through Ulfar Valin. This new dominion he calls Valkénor, a name clothed in new resolve, yet carrying the mark of the old—the unbroken path once tread by Valkoria, and yet upon it lies a darker weight. So we must ready ourselves, for the dawn of this era may either rise clear or shadowed, and we, dear one, must be prepared for either.”

She walked forward with otherworldly grace and elegance, each step seemingly out of the tales of the gods themselves. She walked to her daughter and wrapped her in a warm embrace and whispered final words, “I have dearly missed you, my beloved daughter.”

The words rang in the ears of the Lady of Dremor, who had dared not go home since the fall of her city to the very man she spoke of during his wretched war. Not one, yet many tears rolled down her face as she returned the embrace given to her by her dear mother, whom she had not graced with her presence in well over a millennium. The tears those two women fell as one,

pure and distraught for the lifetimes of men in which they have been apart.

Her words became choked and stuttered off her tongue, “I missed you too, mother.” As the embrace between the two seemed to span over the course of many years, it was only for a few minutes.

Vaxium raised his right hand bearing the band of pure erinstihl and let his vocals take to the sky, “We shall call upon Baragorn the Black, wise among us, whose counsel spans the ages of this world. His knowledge may yet light a path through these shadows. Then let us turn our ears to Lord Eluiar of Elendaiél, for his words are tempered with insight and foresight alike. Yet for now, we must abide in patience, holding fast to the hope that the fire-born spirit of Travers Aramir shall find his way to us, a flame unquenched amidst the coming storm.”

The world seemed to pause for a very few minutes as the sound of nature around them in the soft lunar glow grew. It was like there was no greater enemy in the shadows, no enemy lurking far from their eyes. It was Mikel Sovéran to speak up and break the silence, his words were long and filled with an unexpected knowledge as if to be said by Travers Aramir himself.

His words were still broken and quite frantic, though, “Ah, now, I daresay, if Travers Aramir is lost to us—may it be only his body, for his spirit is stout and strong as an ancient oak—then surely we are brought to the hour where our strength must match the darkness before us! I cannot shake the sense, no, not a shred of doubt lingers, that he struck a mighty blow against this rising shadow, delaying its hand. Now, perhaps, if we were to call upon all the forces at our disposal—the elves of the wood, the wisdom of my own order, and the Guild of the Mystic Arts—might we not press forward ourselves, to strike at this shadow’s very roots? There must be some way to turn the tide begun at Zhal Durath into a mighty river against the darkness.”

The voice of the man was loud and grew with the worry of his dear friend.

Aur a was the first to interject, telling the wizard the plain truth of their current situation, “Dare I say that we have seen the ruins crumble into mere dust, yet, might it be that we cannot now move against the enemy? For we know not from where they stir, nor what shadows veil their purpose. The fires of the Crevice of Latarvia and Mount Vagar lie dormant, silent as if even their ancient fumes have been swallowed by the ages, untouched since the days before Valkar's wrath and the long days thereafter. We cannot know if Dur-Vagar stands anew in dark splendour, or if it too has faded to legend. All we hold are the murmured tales spun by those who roam the lands of Pharolax, little more than distant whispers on the winds of time. So, my dear Sov ran, we could not yet dare to seek out this enemy, let alone cast the first stroke in battle.”

The group of them were just about to break into a disgruntled form of argument, which would do nothing but make matters worse and delay their coming talks with Baragorn, when Vaxium broke first to say, “The Guild of the Mystic Arts has never deigned to meddle in the true affairs of the world. Not since Judas Preiko has one of their order ventured forth, and even he did so only for his own gain, in pursuit of lore and knowledge alone. They shall do nothing but pore over their dusty tomes, relics of weaker men.”

Vaxium's tone was snide, his face seemed to curl like he bit into the ripest of all lemons. The doubt on his face cast little hope to the wizard.

The Elf continued, “As for Galadrielle, who now leads them, she would dare not lift a finger, should we even call upon her aid. Do not forget it was they who stood idly by, aligned with the Delmver, when the enemy's armies took the city of Dremor. They watched unmoved as the fires of the Void consumed the ancient forests, and still they stood silent when the dark forces nearly breached these very walls. In such a time, we cannot

count upon creatures whose hearts are so easily swayed from the world's true plight.”

Sovéran began to speak in retaliation to both parties, his words were stuttered and sporadic, yet brief, “Perchance—just a chance—one of us could go to the Archellium on Onu-Tel, and plead for her aid! I beg of you, let us not linger or let caution bind us while this enemy gathers strength in the dark! Even now, he grows, slipping beyond our sight. If we wait, hope itself may fade, swallowed by shadow.”

He said then, “Lady Dramira, I beg of you, seek her out there—at the Archellium. She may be stubborn, yes, but your wisdom may reach where others cannot. Please, go to her...”

“Enough!” The single word to come from the mouth of Vaxium was just plenty to end such desperate pleas of the wizard. Though even the elven king knew that if they were to gain the help of the Guild, it might swing the odds of a conflict in the near future into their favour. His mind swirled with the words and descriptions of the flames engulfing the city of Dremor, the dead elves which littered the since-abandoned city of his daughter.

In his mind's eye, he recalled the tales of flames so purple and blue they changed, it was as if the sun itself had come out at night, yet shown the colour of lavender or amethysts. The fire, which was not hot yet cold and still burning, burned the city and even the stone to a crisp. He dreaded the enemy in which he had fought so many years ago, and it was he who gave the king the eternal limp he would have until the Day of Reclamation.

He feared that if it were true, the enemy had returned that there were none left in this world who could handle such a force, he had lost faith in the world of man many ages ago for only once in his long life had he seen the strength of man—long ago and with that he saw it vanish with the death of Talor by the very same man who came to be the dark lord of the Second Era and heir to Valkar.

It was then an odd feeling, an ominous od came over them. It was as if, then in that very moment, when Vaxium remembered the vivid red eyes of the dark lord, his presence, even for but a brief moment, engulfed the world again, as if to be willed into existence.

An elf messenger was carrying the name Andar, who approached, and with a pure urgency, he said, “Lord and Lady of Valendriel, I bring an urgent message!”

“It cannot be, speak now.” The words of the Lady Dramira were as if she knew what the man would come to say long before the words even came to his mind. She had felt it, the world had felt it for all but that briefest of moments once again. Her eyes pierced the man, not calming nor bringing angst, yet affirming his message was of truth.

Overcome with the gravity of his message, he licked his lips, his gaze settling anxiously on Vaxium. In a voice edged with quiet dread, he began, “Smoke and ash rise from Vouldorth. Mount Vagar has erupted—its first fire since the days of the Second Era. Orcs have been sighted in the lands of men, and whispers carry tales of black riders, faceless beings that traverse the plains and lands of this world.”

His voice faltered at the mention, as if the mere thought of such shadows drained his courage. “And there are rumours—” he paused, gathering himself, “rumours that tell why we’ve heard no word from our Visender kin in the Hundabald Mountains. Word spreads of a roar, deep and thunderous, rolling through the land.”

A tremor betrayed him as he swallowed, his voice barely above a whisper; fear encapsulated each syllable. “It is feared that Talen, the great city beneath, has fallen. The birds have fled, and ash chokes the valley, rising from the village at the mountain’s base.”

All those who heard the blurted message of the elf were shocked, all except one; the Lady Dramira had but the reaction of as if she knew, as if she knew it was all to come and if she

knew that this was but the way of the world. The darkness had already grown in the few months, yet they were all but helpless. Hope was still in their grasp, yet they could do nothing more than simply wait for the tides of fate to turn, and the pages of history had not yet been written for such a war to happen.

Alíwen raised her hand to slap the elf whose status was much lower than hers, “You dare to come to the spire of the King to spew such lies?” The voice of the female elf was harsh and brutal, fitting of the head of the Altari, the most elite and strong of the female elvish warriors. “Have you any proof of such claims in the world?”

It was the look of Dramira upon Alíwen that broke her resolve with such ease; the gaze that seemed all knowing and all wise, though younger than Alíwen, she commanded a presence of power that even seniority could not triumph over.

She spoke softly, gracefully, magnificent in a way, “Calm, he speaks of a truth, one of the world we all shall come to burden.”

A calm dignity settled over the elven king as he gazed upon the assembly of elves, his eyes meeting those of the wizard who stood before him.

Vaxium's voices, firm as an ancient oak and clear as the twilight breeze, carried through the woods. “We shall not yield to fear. There are twisted tales that speak of his survival, that he yet stirs in shadowed corners, though no lifeless form of his did we see returned to the earth. He will not have a body for some time more, if ever.”

His gaze shifted, and in a rare moment of humility, he bowed his head. “There remains hope yet in the world—for the race of men will take their place upon the pages of history once more, not as they stood in the last crusade but as they stood in their glory, in the heights of the First Era.”

He paused, and the silence of the glade held his words. “I would have scouts sent to the Gundabald Mountains to uncover what has transpired in Talen. And yet,” he cautioned, his

voice grave as ancient stone, “should the rumours hold true and a great drake, one we all know quite well, still breathes. It will be he who now guards the mountain’s halls; let none be so unwise as to wake it from its slumber, it will come to, yet send riders to look for those who are refugees.”

It was then that Dramira turned to the party of two before her, the jewels and precious metals struck across her glimmering in the soft light, her words like the threads of a delicately woven tapestry of tranquillity, scenic and majestic in nature, came from her mouth. Both ever wise and knowing her spoken nature was one for even the eldest to behold, each word would seem to be dipped in the very buckets of knowledge that drew all to this world.

The voice, soft and simple yet intertwined with the tales of life itself, spoke, “There is much yet to be done, though the sands of time slip ever swiftly. If indeed the enemy has risen once more to cast shadows upon life itself, then we must gather in trust, as Travers Aramir did when he placed his faith in the hearts of humankind. And so, let us await the morrow’s dawn, a light to meet the dark, in hopes that our courage will hold firm and our resolve stand unbroken.”

She smiled at the two, “Come, let us take our leave, for the path before us is long, and there remains much still to be spoken, much that the quiet of twilight alone can bear witness to.” As such, the group now waited as all they could do was wait until the forces of darkness had shown themselves once again and the world of man had risen to be the powers of the world and players in the stage of events as those are to come.

For over two years had passed since that day in the gardens, and now it was their time to be wed. On the third day of the festival of lights, but a week prior to midsummer’s day on the two hundred and ninety-first year of the Third Era, the streets of

Valkoria would be fervent with the flora of the land. As flowers and other makings of people had cluttered the store-strewn streets, the festival was not the talk of the town, but that of the King's wedding was what claimed the minds of many.

Their queen would not be one of pure Valkorian lineage, which many had assumed the staunch man would choose, yet an elf of a faraway, hidden kingdom. She was no ordinary elf, for the sages and poets would tell of the simplicities and niceties she had done for him whom she was endowed to. Though the wedding was smaller than the normally expected festivities of the world, Ulfar had made sure to invite all those close to him, from little Rudy all the way to bringing his childhood friends from his village to the city.

The dress of the to-be queen was far beyond the sewing hands of any mortal, as it was stitched by the elves of her homeland, Elendaiél. The gown flowed like moonlight caught in silken threads, its fabric shimmering with a subtle iridescence as if woven from the essence of starlight itself. Delicate silver embroidery traced the edges of the neckline and arms, adorned with gemstones of seafoam and crystal blue, each facet catching and scattering light in soft, ethereal glimmers.

The sleeves fell in sweeping cascades from her shoulders, billowing like clouds caught in a gentle breeze, giving her an otherworldly grace as they trailed elegantly to the ground. Down the front ran a thin silver sash, flowing from her waist to the hem, a nod to the lineage she bore and the noble blood that marked her as worthy of the title of queen. Truly, it was a gown fit for one touched by ancient elven magic, timeless and enchanting, crafted not just to wear but to weave her spirit with the legacy of her people.

As she walked down the simple aisle crafted of wicker benches and chairs, she caught the gaze of Ulfar, whose attire was fit for he who was now king. His robes were woven of rich midnight-blue velvet, the colour of deep night over distant mountains, adorned with intricate silver threading that swirled

across his chest and down his arms in patterns reminiscent of ancient Valkorian runes. His mantle, clasped at his shoulder with a silver brooch in the shape of a roaring wolf, fell in layers, edged in fur as white as winter's first snow, a mark of his fierce yet noble spirit.

Beneath the cloak, a finely crafted leather tunic embossed with faint symbols of his lineage hugged his form, its sleeves cuffed with silver, as if to bind his strength and courage into every thread. Around his waist, he wore a belt of dark steel, adomed with a single sapphire that mirrored the colour of his gaze—steadfast and unyielding. The right side of his waist was marked with the beautiful sheath of Arenith, which even now was by his side. His boots, polished and laced to his knees, bore the marks of countless journeys, yet shone as new; they were not the shoes of a courtly king but of one who had eamed his crown on the battlefield.

Across his chest lay a ceremonial sword, its hilt inlaid with ancient stones, a reminder of the legacy he now bore. Yet for all the grandeur of his attire, it was the quiet pride in his eyes, softened only by the sight of his bride, that marked him truly as king.

As she gaited down the aisle way, it was as if time itself had stopped, and for what was truly a brief moment of time, she became that of an eternity. For this brief moment, the world had been recreated, and thus abstained from the darkness and evils ever present. In this moment, it was just the two, Ariendria and her King, Ulfar, who was frozen as many men are at this point of their lives, yet he felt the will of Vaeimea not through the Amulet of the Kings but of the pendant.

He knew that her life was that of his no more and no less; their endowed creator would see both are greeted in heaven's halls together, or so he hoped. A choice to forsake a life immortal was one she had made, and through it, she was still an elf, but a mortal elf. The question lingered in the depths of the mind of Ulfar: could any elf do such a thing, live the life of a

human, yet the voice of her father, Eluiar, had answered this question ever so briefly.

He had said to him, “She alters neither the course of her days nor renounces the life of the Velmar. Yet it is not by the will of Vaeimea, but by her own choice, invoking the ancient power of Calánutar, that she binds her fate to yours. Thus, when your life draws to its end, she too shall pass beyond the circles of this world, bound to follow you into shadow and beyond.”

The look on her father's face was stern as with each step, the great Lord Eluiar guides his one and only daughter to the man who will be her doom. Though even filled with the emotions of her shortened life, he was not angry or displeased with her; he had only love for his daughter, whom he so cherished.

As he guided the light of his world to the altar, crafted of an ancient stump of a long forgotten tree, he said one phrase to the young Ulfar, “Aramaneathé.” Which simply meant blessed in the tongue of man. It was not much, but the world alone meant worlds to Ulfar, for he had hoped to have the blessing of the one who gave her life to him, and now he had.

As now the two stood before the same priest who swore Ulfar's oath to the throne, he stood between the Lady Airendria and Ulfar for the first and the very last time. The ceremony began as the new High Priest of the Seven, Saint Peter of Bethê, raised his hands, cloaked in white and silver robes that mirrored the light of the festival flames flickering all around.

His voice, deep and resonant, echoed across the gathered crowd, holding an authority that seemed to reach the heart of all who listened.

“Today, we gather beneath the heavens, upon the earth, and before the watchful eyes of the Seven, to bear witness to the union of King Ulfar Valin of Valkénor and Lady Ariendria of Elendaiél. This is no mere bond of king and queen; it is a weaving of two souls, two legacies, and two fates, entwined until the world itself shall cease its turning.”

He looked to Ulfar first, his tone solemn and steady, filled with both the weight of duty and the joy of union. “Ulfar Valin, King of Valkoria, do you swear before the Seven, to honour, cherish, and protect Lady Ariendria, as you would the very heart of your kingdom, for as long as your days shall endure?”

Ulfar, his gaze unwavering and steadfast, his voice strong yet softened in her presence, replied, “I do here swear it, by the light of Vaeimea and the strength of my people, from now until the end.”

The priest then turned to Ariendria, whose face was radiant and calm as starlit water. “Lady Ariendria, daughter of Eluiar, do you willingly bind yourself to this man, to walk by his side through light and shadow? Do you forsake not your kin, yet choose to set aside the immortal life of your people, to share with him the burdens and blessings of mortal days, to bear both joy and sorrow as mortal men do?”

The woman, beautiful and kind, elegant to the eyes of all, stood there with a smile born upon her face. Ariendria's voice, though soft, carried a strength as ancient as the mountains. “I do, by my own choice and by the love that binds my heart. In this life and in the one beyond, I shall be his, and he mine, now and evermore.”

At this, the priest's hands lowered, and he looked upon them both with a solemn, knowing smile. “Know this, beloved: by oath and love are you bound, and may the grace of the Seven be upon you, granting you strength to endure and joy to fill each day. You are made one, and none shall part what has been joined in this bond.” He gave a slight nod to Ulfar, indicating that he could now speak.

Ulfar grasped the hands of his dear with her hands in his, firmly together, almost one as they are now, his voice filled with the pride of his people and the love he bore for her. “Ariendria, my light, you are the dawn that ends my darkness. You have bound yourself to a mortal fate, yet I swear by all that I am, we

shall face whatever comes together, unbroken, until our lives are one with the land of our fathers.”

Ariendria smiled, as if to be a child who saw the first gift of all his years, and it was no meagre wooden sword, yet a toy which was wished for through all the ages, her voice carrying the grace of her homeland.

“And I, Ulfar, do swear—though I leave my kin and the life of my people behind—that it is with a willing heart, for I belong here, with you. May we take joy in the days that are given to us, and may the memory of our love shine as a light, unbroken, even in the shadows that may come.”

The priest lifted his arms once more, his chest expanded as he took a deep breath, readying to let out words that were powered with divine might. “By the power of the Seven, and by the hearts that bind you, I declare you as one. May the love of Vaeimea be upon you and guide you both in all things. Let none set asunder what is now made whole.”

A cheer rose among the people as the two stood hand in hand. Lord Eluiar, standing close, nodded approvingly to Ulfar with a look that bore both pride and sorrow.

He placed a gentle hand on Ariendria's shoulder, mumuring, “Aramaneathé. Blessed be, my daughter. The stars have granted you the rare gift of choice, and it is my honour to witness such a path unfold.”

The two turned to face the people of Valkoria together, the cheers of their friends and kin filling the air as they took their first steps as one. And so, beneath the lights of the festival, with vows exchanged and blessings given, Ulfar and Ariendria stood not only as king and queen but as a testament to a love that transcended the boundaries of race and time.

For the first time since the First Era, the union of man and elf had come to be; it was a sight to behold for those so bound to the tides of time. But it was not a meagre accident as it had been with Vaxar, it was the will of Goht who sought to see such a bind happen, one which seeks to usher in a

connection—transfer of the world from that of the elves to that of man for what years are left in the time of this world.

The party would rage on, and the celebration of the new crown would take the focus of the world of men for the remainder of the festival of lights. Just after the completion of the ceremony, a large reception would begin where food, dance and worlds of different celebrations would take place all at once, and the city would be a hub of endless activity. The couple who walked the streets, which were bustling with activity, shops and bards and bands and musicians playing the music of man.

A small child, little in stature but full of fun and smiling broadly, he said to them in a chipper voice, “Are you the King and Queen? You both are awesome!”

Smiles spread across both of their faces, as Ariendria knelt to the young one's level and said warmly, “Oh, of course—we are not here. Take this.” She removed a small silver ring from her right hand and placed it gently in his tiny, eager hands. “Speak of the ring to no one, for in days to come, should you still bear it upon your hand, a place in our court may yet await you.”

She winked at the child and ruffled his hair, leaving it delightfully tousled, prompting his laughter as he nodded with wide-eyed excitement, promising to guard the secret. As they rose and moved on, others stepped forward, each bringing heartfelt greetings and words of blessing for the couple. Elders bestowed their solemn well-wishes, offering blessings for health, long life, and wisdom in their union.

Young mothers smiled as they offered Ariendria wildflowers, their children in tow, waving shyly from behind their skirts. Artisans and craftsfolk bowed low, sharing tokens of their craft: woven trinkets, small charms for good fortune, and a few delicate strands of flowers to wear.

From deep beyond the crowds of men and women gleefully looking towards the king who holds the Emerald Jewel were two figures who yet dressed fair, the elf wearing a long

blackened dress, one which flowed with the curvature of elven craftsmanship and the man bearing his usual armour with its elegant cross just shimmering more than it usually does. Judas and Taelmíra both stood with a smile.

Judas nudged the she-elf whose hair was gleaming in the broad daylight, its white seemed to be as pure as the snow which dusts the tallest mountains, “You mentioned in Deidara your father, please now seems as good a time as any, does it not?” Neither looks at the other one with their gazes fixed upon the newlyweds of the world of men.

As the King and his new queen moved through the joyous crowd, Ariendria and Ulfar found themselves enveloped in a chorus of voices, each bearing gifts of words and well-wishes as the people of Valkoria came forward. A child, barely tall enough to reach Ariendria's waist, tugged at her gown and held up a simple wooden charm shaped like a star. “For you, my Queen! I made it with Papa.” His wide eyes sparkled with pride.

Ariendria accepted it with a gracious nod, her hand resting gently on his. “A gift crafted by your hands? I shall treasure it always.” Her words were genuine and heartfelt as the simple gift moved her heart leagues. She panned her gaze across the many who continued their joyous celebration and partying, ignorant of the notion that their very own King and Queen stood amongst them.

Taelmíra and Judas walked parallel to their dear friends as she motioned for his wood pipe, unsheathing her own tobacco. “How do I even begin, oh my father!” Her voice grew as she laughed after the utterance of the word father.

“Perhaps we leave the rest for later and talk about why he told you to come here?” The inquisitive tone of Judas seemed to undermine her humour, crafting a sinister glare on her face, one filled with the deceit of many men.

It quickly fades as she lights the tobacco, “Well, that's easy, my father is quite familiar with the Valkorians, granted, he

was a fool in his younger years. He knew the tale of Uriel's last words, yet he mentioned it to me as the 'tales and prophecies of long dead men' or something along those lines." She paused as she drew another deep breath from the pipe. The power of the elven tobacco made its mark in the smoke, which she exhaled. "He simply told me that if this Amulet of the Kings is found, then he must know, but he has little care to do it himself."

Judas took the pipe from his dear elven friend's hands and drew deep on the pipe as he blew out a horse which galloped across the sky in front of them, "So the old fool sends you in his stead and waits until Ulfar becomes useful?"

She smiles as she waves away Judas' creation as her mind races and she comes to a realisation, one which takes the form of sarcastic disbelief, "You already know my father, don't you?"

He places his hand on her shoulder as he takes the pipe from her mouth before she can even take a drag. He speaks in a snob-like manner, "Oh yes, and you two are quite similar, though I met him after he matured slightly more."

She lets out a belly laugh as she glares at Judas and speaks in her native tongue, "Mek duiar aranan mách." The gaze of Judas tells her he knew each word she said, though all it did was make her laugh even more as the two stumbled in step with their newlywed companions.

"It can be quite detrimental to lie to yourself." Judas pauses as he retorts, the elf he knew expected him to know her language, "You know this, right?" Though all she does is simply shake her head back and forth while taking Judas' blackened wooden pipe back once more.

Nearby, an elder in faded green placed his hands on Ulfar's shoulders, his voice a deep murmur. "King Ulfar, may your rule be just, and may the spirit of your forebears guide you in every darkened hour." The gift was soft, comforting, while also containing that normal calming quality of an article forged with the mindful hands of an artist who so did enjoy their craft.

Ulfar nodded solemnly; his face was one to greet those so joyous around him. His voice was different from the harsh young man who climbed the jagged mountain long ago; he had matured. “Your blessing honours me, elder. I shall carry it with pride.”

The gesture of good faith brought great joy to the heart of the King, who had not much time to truly know those who swore oaths to him. Each step for the young man brought him deeper into the culture of his new kingdom, one that his will and restless determination, along with the bodies of thousands of lost comrades, came to build and cultivate over the course of decades.

Two young girls skipped up to Ariendria, filled with nothing but pure and harmless joy, each holding a wreath woven of mountain wildflowers. They smiled shyly, offering their gifts. “They’re for you, my Lady. We picked them at dawn.” They showed love on their faces, but also a deep-seated admiration for the beautiful queen before them.

Ariendria knelt to accept the floral crowns, her voice soft with gratitude, her smile showing the pearls of teeth she bore. “Then your gift carries the first light of day and the fresh spirit of youth. I am touched by your kindness.” Upon her brow rested the second crown. It was elegant and reminded the lady elf of the one she saw on the head of Lady Auréa in her youth, simple yet calming in a sense. The smell of the flowers gave her inner peace.

An older woman, bent with age but with eyes full of life, placed a woven bracelet in Ulfar’s hand. “For protection, Your Grace,” she whispered. “Worn by my own sons before battle. May it shield you as it has shielded them.” Her voice was aged and seemed to carry the notions and legends of wisdom far beyond the years of many men.

Ulfar’s voice was quiet as he slipped the bracelet over his wrist. “You honour me, good mother. May your sons’ courage live on through me. I shall honour them in all I do, my lady.” He

bowed his head in humble service to the aged woman, to which she had no sure reaction, only that of pure admiration.

Nearby, a blacksmith with rough, sooty hands extended a small, forged pendant shaped in the form of a wolf. “For strength and loyalty, my Lord,” he said, his voice proud. “And for your Queen, that she may always know the might of the one who protects her.”

Ariendria accepted the pendant with a grateful smile, glancing up at Ulfar. “I shall wear it with pride, a token of the hands that labour to keep this land strong.” The simple notion of even the small wolf drew on the past of the forest elf, her youth being one with the canine that roamed their forest. Though she did know once in time, since losing the world of man, the Valkorians who first dwelt in the lands of Onu-Arith had tamed the long-since-thought-dead direwolves.

As more voices filled the air with greetings, a small boy piped up, “Can I be a knight, too?” He brandished a wooden sword, his face alight with hope. The hands firmly clasped on the hilt of the blade as if he already was beholden to the armour of the ancient Watchers of Valkoria.

Ulfar laughed warmly, kneeling to look him in the eye. “A knight, are you? Then practise your skill and honour your family, and who knows? Someday, we may see you at the head of the charge!” He held his arms in such a manner to uplift the words of the boy, a fist held high as if to motivate the young boy to pursue such a path in his life.

The boy beamed, running back to his friends, proudly repeating, “The king said I could be a knight!” He jumped up and down and told all of his friends around him as if to wear such words with a pure, undissolved pride that would outshine even the Durenstar on the darkest nights.

Another child, holding tightly to his mother's hand, called out shyly, “Thank you, my Queen, for making the King smile.” His mother blushed, but Ariendria only smiled, her eyes kind.

“Thank you, little one,” she replied, her voice light and warm. “You have no idea how much your words mean to me.” Her heart was warmed with such a fire that was forged of a true and pure love for one whom she held dearly; her gaze turned from that of the little one before her to her king, her husband, who was with the small boy who had taken a keen interest in the magnificent hilt of Arenith on the hip of Ulfar.

As the crowd thinned, they continued forward, their steps lightened by the love and blessings that had been given. The sun was lowering in the sky, casting golden rays upon their path, and as they drew near the keep, both Ariendria and Ulfar felt the strength of their people and the promise of the future within their hearts. They knew for the first time in many years that the land of man could once again become the pillar of strength that their creator had always intended. It was time to usher in a new world, one with the protection of both the elves and that of mankind. With this, they returned to the keep of the city to be greeted by a pleasant sight, though sombre and foreboding in tone even from a great distance.

The posture and body language of the dear friend who lay before them perplexed them; it was like the sky of the night had gone dim; no longer did it bear the two moons. Neither did the far-off planet of Sol with its glimmering ring dance in the night. There were no constellations such as the watcher of the north, who bore the northern star as the tip of its blade held high above his head, or the shield of Numenonálé with the red star of life gracing the very middle of his grand shield, the one which the stories said spared his life in fights with Valkar. The night sky was gone, and they knew it was Auréa who stood before them.

Before any words could leave her mouth, Ulfar blurted a question, with joy in his voice and happiness across his face. His voice was still heightened from the day that had now passed. “Lady Auréa, what has become of our dear friend Travers Aramir? Have we good news from the council he had with Lady Dramira and the head of his order?”

The woman gazed at the two as if to question whether she would speak now or let the moments of happiness linger for just a few more passes of the clock. Her voice came out soft and stretched, like silk stretched so thin it had become a new form of glass, “We... we have lost him. Our dear friend, Travers Aramir. He never made it to my mother. Two years ago, he, Mikel Sovéran, and I jourmeyed to the forsaken ruins of Zhal Durath. There, he faced the sorcerer who lingered within. And then, in an instant, a bolt of red lightning cleaved the heavens, and the ruins, as if in response, the lands became one with the earth once more. Since that day, we have heard nought from him. I am truly sorry, my dear friends.” The Elf shook her head, and there was a sign of distress in her visage; her voice tapered as she finished her last words.

Tears began to well in the eyes of Ulfar, as Ariendria began to comfort him, though there was nothing a soul in the world could do to bring such a man, so deeply connected to one, comfort at such a time. It was as if a very portion of his heart had been slain, yet deep within, he did not believe the man to be dead; perhaps it was the hope held within all men, yet he yearned for this to be some wicked jest, nothing more.

His voice was soft, the joy held left, and as the tears rolled down his face, one on each side, he spoke, “It cannot be. I refuse to believe such has happened.” He shook his head, and each memory of the bearded old fool came to mind, his youth, which left him a grandfather-like figure to the young boy. Yet he dried his face, and the stern look of a commander, not a king, came to his face. He walked forward, then she spoke again, the lady elf.

“There is more to tell you.” Lady Auréa motions for the two to follow her as they pass into the keep of the castle itself. The joys of celebration had now ended for the king, and now he would look forward to the first steps he would warily take as king.

May it be a symbol or an omen, but the world of men was now one of strength again; a king had risen, and the sparks of flames unseen had formed into a great fire which brought light to a continent once covered in a shadow. But it was not enough as the light of man grew, so did a greater shadow. One shadow which now loomed over the world beyond, and Ulfar would not stop at the place his people had run to, but he would declare that his new kingdom, Valkénor, would stretch the continents of man, and take back their ancient home of Onu-Derith. He would deliver this in the Decree of Man, declaring forthright that he would sit on the throne of the City of Koory, Argolin.

It was not the cities or land that enticed him, but the intrinsic idea of taking the homes that his people truly belonged to, not the ones of wood and simple clay that made up nearly all the so-called cities of Onu-Arith. This was a continent at constant war for centuries; if the walls were not for a time, before such as Vingólf, man never gave themselves enough time to forge something for the ages. Only three years after Ulfar's marriage with the dear Ariendria he again would be on the move and once again the world of man would change, and a familiar figure, a vassal of history whose pointed ears and toasted skin and hair that seemed to bum of an etemal flame would come to forge once more a man whose name would not be lost to time.

This was not an ending but thus a beginning, as in the west, far from the growing, reborn world of man loomed a deepening shadow, one that crept through the darkness of night as a salamander of evil in the leaves of autumn. The stir of the animals grew restless as now the world felt a darkness for the first time in over a thousand years. It was this which brought to life a new prophecy, one which was lost to the toils of history, bumed in the ancient tombs, lost in the fires of war. The words still echoed in ancient places, which only the ravens and tales spun by many authors came to be known. *The Prophecy of the Last Dawn...*

APPENDIX A

THE LANGUAGES OF

VARIS MOGUL

In every age, the tongues of the world have whispered truths and woven secrets. Each one holds a different accent, rasp, guttural or tongue-heavy sound. Yet they all have held their places in history, from being the greatest and most common language of the world to being something dead and used only in ceremony as proverbs. From the soaring cadences of the Elven Thalorian to the guttural defiance of Morvath, language in Varis Mogul is more than communication—it is power, history, and identity. This appendix offers insight into the chief languages spoken by the peoples of the world: the noble High Valkorian, the melodic Thalorian, the harsh Del-Thelory, the brutal tongue of Morvath, and the cursed, nearly forgotten language of Sh'r'galth, forged by Valkar himself. Within each, one finds a reflection of their speakers' hearts, hopes, and hidden darkness.

High Valkorian (Old Speech)

The ancient tongue of men was once spoken with poetic grandeur across the Old Valkorian Kingdom. It was especially favoured in spoken-word poetry and ceremonial speech, bearing a tone both majestic and romantic. Though largely lost to time, the language survives on the distant isle of Kelkenheath, where

the last remnants of the Valkorian bloodlines dwell alongside the dragon riders who fled before the birth of Talor.

Words:

- *Valin* (VAY-len): Shining or bright lord
- *Varna* (VAR-nah): Burned one or fallen flame

Phrases:

- *Le Veikí's enil ón alumineo evieé*: The King's yield of forever light
- *Deo un al gratias*: Glory unto God

Thalorian (High Elven)

Thalorian is the noble and lyrical tongue of the Vamir Elves, particularly spoken by the Thaloré — a high lineage that includes figures such as Auréa, Vaxium, and Dramira. Among the many elven dialects, Thalorian is the most widely recognised, with regional variations altering only slightly in pronunciation or spelling. However, other elven tongues may diverge significantly in script and syntax. For mortals, especially humans, Thalorian is notoriously difficult to master, bearing little resemblance to languages like High Valkorian, Dwarvish, or the Mogul Standard.

Words:

- *Lindé*: (LEEN-day) - Beautiful, used in extreme circumstances

- *Ferandír*: Literally “hooded/cloaked traveller, pilgrim, or wayfinder.” Often used to refer to Travers Aramir by those who know only of the wanderer who appears every few years.
- *Luvíelan*: A possessive form of *Luvíel* (darling), meaning “my darling.”
- *Calánutar*: (KAH-lah-on-utar) - Lord above all, another name for Goht used by the Elves.

Phrases:

- *"Meir vaeries dara thalé narathé te alathé endiré vea, almé mara fathé eà taimar en duiar marair hina."* — Translates as: “You shall face a darkness unknown to all who live, but hold fast—the time of man has come.”
- *"Vaina en vanar, fala ro thela—bara teir erá, tier anéth."* — Spoken by Auréa while healing Ulfar of a wound from the Weapon of Talmek. Translates as: “Light of the soul, proceed toward receiving—he will be protected, he alone.” This is a fragment of a longer prayer recorded in ancient accounts of the War of Vengeance.
- “Lera meir.”: (LAY-ra MAY-ear) it means 'Thank you' in its most simple form. Often spoken by novices of the language.

Del-Thelory (Dark Elven)

Del-Thelory is the tongue of the Dark Elves, particularly those of the Vaidir bloodline. While it shares some linguistic roots with Thalorian, its tone is harsher and more guttural—a language shaped by shadowed halls and ancient bitterness. Few elves on the surface speak it openly, but deep within the Narthal Reach and across the subterranean continent, it flourishes as a common tongue of trade and governance. Its continued use reflects both the divergence and kinship of the Vamir and Vaidir tribes.

Words:

- *Mek*: You
- *Duiar*: Humans, mankind, men, the race of man
- *Aranar*: To annoy, cause nuisance, or inconvenience
- *Máth*: Me (object pronoun)

Phrase:

- "*Mek duiar aranar máth*" — “You humans annoy me.”

Morvath (Orcish)

Morvath is the brutal tongue of the orcs and other creatures of shadow, spoken rarely in the lands beyond Vouldorth and often regarded with fear or revulsion. Its guttural sounds and aggressive cadence mark it as the harshest of the known languages. By the Third Era, it is only heard in the darkened reaches of the land held within the Vouldorth mountain ranges, where the orc clans and dark warbands still thrive. To utter its words is said to invoke ill fortune, and in many cultures it is considered a dark omen or even a curse.

Phrases:

- "*Elenkath, Elf, Unthrel altek thrakel hedar en naz shadows. Thrakel narakana hedar frar merak!*" — Translates as: “Elf, Elf, I see you hide in the shadows. You cannot hide from me!”

Sh'r'galth (Language of Valkar)

Sh'r'galth is the language forged by Valkar himself — not inherited or evolved, but uttered first from his own mouth, etched into reality through will and malice. It was taught to Malachar as part of the dark lord's preparation of him as heir and servant until his foretold return. Beyond these two, few mortals or immortals have ever learned or dared speak it. Among them are Travers Aramir, Dramira, Vaxium, and Eluiar — each bound to destiny in ways unknown. Even among the hosts of darkness, Sh'r'galth is rarely heard, its syllables reserved for high incantations or oaths. The Nirinathé, Malachar's sworn blades, are fluent in it and use it as a secretive language among themselves.

Phrases:

- "*Tharek yar rulak. Thrakel verath arek.*" — While untranslatable in full, the word *Tharek* is often used for "enemy" or "sworn foe." The phrase is best rendered as: "Sworn foe, come to us. Sworn foe, here to die."
- "*Lo tael manaké dori amanuar*" — A phrase only ever uttered in the deep void during the First Era. Its meaning defies exact translation, but roughly conveys: "I am the coming darkness wizard."

APPENDIX B

THE PEOPLES OF THE WORLD

The world of Varis Mogul teems with diverse peoples — ancient, mighty, cursed, and forgotten. Each race bears the mark of its creation, whether wrought by divine intention, dark sorcery, or the wrath of the gods. From the immortal elves and cunning dwarves to the corrupted orcs and the divine-born Ilékin, the races of this world are as varied as the lands they inhabit. Here, we catalogue the major peoples, their tribes, subraces, and essential traits and histories — forming the cultural and mythic foundation upon which the legends of *The Morrow's Dawn* rest.

Humans (Duindarr — Blood of Eden)

Dalmithe (Firstborn of Vaeimea):

Short-lived, mortal, power-hungry yet blessed with free will. The original mortal race.

Valkorians:

Second race of men, longer-lived (up to 400 years), scholarly and magically adept. Carriers of lost human nobility.

Elves (Vamitharr — Children of Vaeimea)

Vamir (High Elves):

Firstborn of the Elves, they are commonly known as High Elves or those who bear a much lighter skin tone, often being of white or the palest of humans. They are regarded as the most noble and highborn of elves, with them crafting beautiful and large cities such as Vivik or Dremor. These elves are treated as the stewards of the world and are often seen as the most knowledgeable and wise of all beings in the land. There are a few generations, as they live quite long, and their ability to avoid war and deadly conflicts has led many of those who came to be at the dawn of creation to still be living by the turn of the Third Era. They are often the primary forces opposing and leading the offence against darkness and evil. They act as teachers to the humans and hope to steward them to become the main forces against evil in the world. Though they are often avoidant of conflicts, they are known for having some of the most iconic warriors of history, such as Vaxium and Numenonálé. They are influential figures amongst the humans, though there is a tension between the two races of elves and men, which has led to hatred between the two.

- *Tribes:* Thalor(é), Dremor(é), Teldar(é) [became the Vaidir], Eardor(é)

Vaidir (Dark Elves):

The dark elves, or the Vaidir, are one group of elves that many do not consider to be as pure and just as the rest of their fellow elven cousins. They came to be in the early stages of the War of Vengeance, already possessing differences from the Vamir they were still taken as one of the main clans, though after nearly all the clan bent a knee to Valkar they became darker in both skin tones ranging from browns to deep purples and blues and in their spirit often preferring war more than their Vamir cousins. Though in the eyes of Vaeimea, they are not

fallen creatures, which is why the missing presence of the Alundél has harmed them as well.

- *Kingdoms/Tribes*: Teldar(é)

Velmar (Forest Elves):

These are the elves who spent most of their lives in the rough woodlands of the forests. Their cities differ from the Vamir in the aspect that they do not use any stone, mostly wood, bark and leaves to craft their buildings with very few floors that even have small stone patches. They often build their homes in tandem with the trees, towards the canopy, using the leaves of the trees to protect from the elements. They are a much more tribal group, having few cities but incredible numbers in comparison to the Vamir. They are often taken by the Uruks and dark forces to be the newest of the army of darkness through torture, eventually turning them into the orcs of the Dark Lord. There are very few of this breed of elf who come to have the recognition and notoriety of their High Elven counterparts, except for Lord Eluiar and the legendary Captain Eid.

- *Tribes*: Noltar(é); known for blood oaths and nature rites

Veileiar (Blood Elves):

The subrace of elves, which are often called the Blood Elves. They are much more tribal and camp-based in comparison to the elves who dwelt in the cities such as Vivik or Dremor. They are revered as some of the greatest soldiers and often the best warriors out for hire. They are known for a ferocity in battle that rivals the more savage Vaidir. They differ in appearance from that of the other elves, with a more burnt orange or reddish orange skin tone, with longer ears that will bear earrings

for the battles they win. They were much more plentiful during the First Era, though thousands were felled during the War of Vengeance and Ravage of the Shadow, which would drastically lessen their numbers going into the Second Era. By the Third Era, it was unknown how many still lived in Varis Mogul. Dramira had believed it could be no more than a couple of thousand between the surface and the reach down below. It was known that at least three hundred were alive at the end of the Second Era as the Neimar Imperium employed their services to gain the upper hand.

Visender (Snow Elves):

The Snow Elves, who typically dwell in the higher reaches of the world on various mountain ranges and on the various snowy plains of Varis Mogul. Vaxium refers to them as their “kin” (Chapter 16, “The Morrow’s Daybreak”), showing the close bond between the two groups of elves as they share many traits of their physical appearance, often being mistaken for one another. Yet the Visender are shorter, have a more pure white skin tone matching the snow, and are less sophisticated compared to the Vamir. It is worth noting that there have only been a few Snow Elves who cast their names with the greats of History, Finvaren, who dared to call the strength of Valkar into question during the War of Vengeance and faced him later at the request of Valkar at his Fortress on Mahri. They were one of the few groups of elves which did not actively participate in the entirety of the War of Vengeance. The deeds of Finvaren’s children, specifically his son Fingalor, would leave two names tied to the tombs of history.

- *Tribes:* Sindar(é), Elvin(é), Drex (Free Elves)

Volder (Cave Elves):

Light-sensitive, short-lived despite being immortal. Pale, reclusive, patriarchal. Little is known of this kin who dwell within the caves and vast tunnels of the world, having few interactions with other races or even other clans of their own subspecies. There are a few legends of great warriors coming from these peoples, yet nearly all of them were lost in the countless wars of the First and Second Era.

Dwarves (Delmver — Known as the Unintended)

Dumas:

Miners and master craftsmen. Greedy, strong, 3.5–4ft tall, infamous for awakening ancient terrors. Hearty fools are what describes them best; many would dig through the core of the earth if their tools allowed them.

Damar:

Military caste. Disciplined, tactical, Recht-steel forgers.

Dakar:

Dark Delmver of Narthal Reach. Isolated, shadow-dwelling, hated by surface kin.

Orcs (Oriencarr — Blood of Orichal)

Vamiaeir:

First orcs, born of tortured Vamir by Malachar's dark magic.

Ugha-alé:

A creature not born yet created as a race to be the perfection of orc warriors. They are a crossbreed of the first orcs made from the dark magic corruption of the Vamir and Ogres. They have retained immortality yet

have the strength and ability to reproduce in mass, where the twisted Vampir, many had lost their ability and became infertile when trying to mate with their fellow orcs during their corruption by Valkar during his War of Vengeance. These orcs are much stronger and faster; they often raise Shadowbeast growing with them and bonding as one being with their pets. They are a feared group, and most are said to dwell in the lands of Pharolax.

- *Tribes:* Korgath, Malgor, Vorrak, Hundabald

Normir:

Corrupted Velmar, infertile and numerous, twisted through Vouldorth's poisons.

Morgarith:

Fungal orcs made by cursed battlefield spores. Reproduce only through death and decay.

Undead & Accursed Races

Keltar:

Undead made to hunt the undead. Blended among humans. First: Vanessa (Vaeo).

Liches:

Creatures of darkness, they are not of the living or the undead; in truth, they are creatures that voluntarily, and in very few cases involuntarily, gave up their mortal lives for a great increase of power. Oftentimes, they do this as the sacrifice of their natural bodies, as well as binding themselves to the spiritual realm, making them nearly impossible to slay as well. There are very few

weapons which can slay a lich, and far fewer which can slay one without destroying the animark, which is what contains their soul, allowing them to have the power and seemingly invincible nature they do have.

Vampir:

Origin unknown, drinkers of Valkar's blood. Divided into Alfina, Eilin, and Inun. Circle of Blood coven.

Wraiths / Ghosts / Skeletons:

Spirit-bound undead, often cursed or soul-tethered.

Creatures, Beastfolk, Goblins & Monsters

Direwolves:

These are large wolf creatures which stand around the size of the average workhorse, with thick fur coats that protect them from the harsh winter elements. They lived in the northern lands of Onu-Arith, Onu-Derith and some of the southern parts of the southern snowlands of Igodan. They were at one point tamed by the Valkorians and used as companions, as dogs are used in times now. There were some packs known to be living on the lands of Onu-Arith as far up until the hundredth year of the Third Era. The then Queen, mother of Anne, Deidara, ordered the mass hunting and extermination of the beasts as they were symbols of a dying culture in her mind.

Dumir Vas (Trolls):

Giant, 25ft, slow but immensely strong.

Dumir Nal (Ogres):

10ft, strong and dumb.

Drakers:

They are a subspecies of dragon falling under the wing of the lesser dragon, meaning they are smaller in size and much more wild and intelligent. Often, they are still difficult beasts to tame and will take years for a single child to form a bond with the creature. They are not as common as horses or even other creatures such as direwolves. Often, families would have many more eggs than dragons, with only a few eggs from each generation actually hatching. At most, a single family was host to twelve live dragons, with many only having five or fewer. They take many years to age, even enough to breathe a steady stream of fire from their mouths, and nearly four to five decades to even be of enough strength to carry a small child while flying; most would come to enough strength to carry an adult around their hundredth year. Many of these creatures only make it to their eight or nine hundredth years.

Drulle / Dakon (Goblins):

Forest/cave goblins, 3ft, cunning and dangerously adaptive.

Shadowbeast/Sargór:

Traditionally ridden by Orcs and more specifically the Ugha-alé. They are large, muscular beasts standing slightly taller than the average horse, though significantly more robust. They have a thick, dark, leathery skin that grows patches of midnight black hair at the arch of the back and towards their rear, their skin so black it seems to absorb all light, giving them a shadowy appearance. This is a great camouflage advantage, leaving them much more deadly at night. They have two glowing red eyes that seem to penetrate deep through the darkness, adding to the eerie, ominous presence.

Velreth:

Commonly known as “Striders” they are large chitin-covered beasts that stand nearly three to four times the size of the taller men, often much taller. These beasts have six elongated, multi-jointed legs, each one capable of propelling the creature with powerful, spring-like leaps. Its body is sleek and covered in a tough, chitinous exoskeleton that glistens in the light, shifting in colour to blend with its surroundings. From the creature's back rises a long, curved spire-like structure that acts as both a stabiliser and a guide for any riders or cargo. Its thorax is equipped with two large, transparent wings that fold tightly against its body when not in use. These wings, though seemingly delicate, allow the *Velreth* to glide for short distances when crossing particularly treacherous gaps or navigating over mountainous ridges. They are often used for fast transportation across the world, yet are only able to be used by those with the deepest connections to the world, as it takes many years to tame even the smallest of beasts.

Werewolves:

Jinro: Wild, lunar-bound, cursed.

Rojin: Purebloods marked by Halfar, refined and hidden.

Divine Creations and Ilékin**Talrah:**

These are the beings first created by the direct hands of Goht and are divided into three main categories: the Amaér, Eleikin, and the Ilékin. The latter of which would be the likes of Travers Aramir and the order of wizards, Drewen, and Eldarion, though their group

would be divided into lesser categories. These were the beings who drew life in the lays beyond the mortal veil of Varis Mogul, primarily the Garden of Light, aka Ghotanór, which is seen as the pinnacle of heaven and holds multiple realms, including the Undying Haven, or the Void.

- *Amaér, Magar, Thelar, Anastae, Muru*: Ancient spirits and personifications of nature and virtue.

Eleikin:

Immortal entities created in the likeness of Goht. They take part in the eternal war of light and dark. There are only two known to the world, the Maiden of Light, protector of good, Vaeimea. Then there is her brother, the First Dark Lord of Varis Mogul, Valkar.

- **Vaeimea (The Light)**: The radiant embodiment of life, peace, and love. A divine being who once walked among mortals, her true form is seen only by Dramira. Associated realms include:
 - *Duloriendé (The Undying Haven)* – a heaven for mortals
 - *Helogard* – resting place for warriors, mostly elves
 - *Ysengard* – domain of Talor, connected to Helogard by the Hall of Valingard
- **Valkar (The Dark)**: A dark being born alongside Vaeimea. Twisted by pride and ambition, he became the corrupter and forger of the Orcs. He rarely reveals his true form, except to his chosen, like Malachar.

Ilékin:

These are the very entities that form the pantheons of countless races and tribes of both elves and men. Though they are seen as gods and demons amongst the denizens of Varis Mogul, their hierarchical nature gives a sure power dynamic between them, with the most powerful being Gelmwae and Melvaris in their long history. They were formed of the Talrah (essence of the universe) by the very hands of Goht Himself; they are the third and final creation of these beings. They hold much power and prowess when they venture into the world of Varis Mogul. This group contains figures such as Travers Aramir, Mikel Sovéran, their whole order, and historical figures such as Drewen (based on the elven telling of the legend) and Eldarion, who slew Valkar during the War of Vengeance. These beings do not often interact with the world of Varis Mogul, unless they are sent on specific missions.

- **Gelmwae:** King of the Malakin (Light). Oversees Gohtanorë and serves as a divine guardian.
 - *Deidrea:* His queen, embodiment of wisdom and grace.
 - *Melvaris:* His fallen First Hand, seen to have a deep connection with Malachar, yet the full nature of their intertwined relationship is shrouded in mystery
- **The Malakin (Light):**
 - *Dreldaria*
 - *Elvaris*
 - *Drewen*
 - *Viviana*
 - *Drenamir*
 - *Drukavin*
 - *Eldarion*

- *Aerlos*
- **The Malakin (Dark):**
 - *Slyrala*: Fallen to excess
 - *Krahn*: Master of carnage, death, and blood
 - *Ventricula*: Lord of mischief and illusion
 - *Calichestar*: Mad god of torment and paranoia
 - *Hentorus Arcanum*: Keeper of forbidden knowledge
 - *Umbrathrox*: Lord of Shadows
- **The Iktarians:**
 - *Valomir/Urgoth, Ulrich/Urmir, Baragon the Black/Balain, Travers Aramir/Myamir, Mikel Sovéran/Mirioth*
- **The Valekin:**
 - *Oros - Orman, Nomadus, Tidel, Millitos, Grimforge*
- **Elemental & Spirit Forms:**
 - *Vana (Spirit of the Forest)*, protector of Pharolax
 - *Meline (River Styx), Delexar, Oru Dana (Mountain Hent)*
 - *Malgaldur (Mount Melgar), Helios (Mount Hallar), Mustfel (Mount Vagar)*—divine spirits bound within sacred mountains

Half-Races

Dulmir:

These are smaller creatures which draw ancestry from the cross-breeding of both humans and dwarves, creating their smaller height. During the First Era, it became a common occurrence for Dwarves to marry and have

multiple families, specifically with Dalmithe humans who had lifespans just about half of the Delmver. They would exhibit the height of dwarves while having all the other features of a human, even proportional sizing, which was more uncommon for the dwarves. These creatures were peaceful and did not meddle in the affairs of the world often. They were said to live typically with others of their kin, though some had ventured to the continent of Onu-Arith before the establishment of the Neimar Imperium and came to play roles in the rebellion of Ulfar.

Notable Governments, Orders & Factions

The world of Varis Mogul is shaped not only by races and individuals but also by the powerful orders, factions, and mercenary companies that wield influence across the continent. Some serve the divine, others their own ambitions — but each has left an indelible mark on the story.

Altarí:

A small group of strictly female elven warriors. They are led by the sister of Vaxar, Alíwen, who is regarded as the strongest female warrior to ever live in the world. She is a unique figure amongst the lands of the world, as are these fellow women who are given some of the finest light armour. They are a smaller group whose numbers have dwindled as the centuries have gone forth, correlating with the declining population of the elves as they age in the fallen world. There have been a few attempts to rebuild the ancient order, yet none have garnered much traction, eventually dying at the feet of their leader, Alíwen.

Guild of the Mystic Arts:

Formed by the legendary writer, philosopher, and mage Anteantodo during the waning years of the First Era. This is

a governing body which operates a handful of Mage college campuses across the world, with the main campus being located on Igodan, the native lands of Anteantodo. This Guild would always be headed by a mortal, whether they be Valkorian, Dalmithe, or Delmver. The man, Judas Periko, would come to be the head of the Guild for only a few years as he sought the grand knowledge of the extensive libraries and documents which the guild would house as one of the biggest libraries in the world, with documents that span back to the awakening of the first generations of many different groups. Their current leader, Galadrielle, is often seen as a more snide and crude person; the elves fear having to seek her help as she is quite reminiscent of the leader during the War of Shadows when the city of Dremor fell, and none came to aid.

Hykellion Kingdom (1E 1821 - 3103):

One ancient kingdom of man which inhabited the lands of Onu-Arith during the First Era, which was founded by Rijarl the Greater, who left Valkoria to form his own kingdom. Eventually, the blood of the Dalmithe would flush out the Valkorian longevity, which would be the downfall of the people. As the line of the king waned, the lands would progressively be left as many fled to the human lands of Igodan. It was a kingdom during the rule of Rijarl the Greater that mastered the powers of building magic and would bring great cities such as Vingólf.

Neirmar Imperium:

Founded in the waning years of the Second Era, somewhere between 2E 4900-4960, it was the first major governmental structure to take hold amongst a vast majority of the Valkorian people since the Desolation of Valkoria. Formed by the work of Heimarr Seidel and Ava Hargath, they would rally their coin and hire a group of Veileiar, blood elves, as mercenaries to help give their forces the upper hand on the force of Valkorians who sought to restore and turn the land

into what it had been like during the ancient Valkorian Empire. After a round first few decades, those of the realm would have been beaten into submission, causing them to be less rebellious for the next few generations as the toll of those killed rose to quite a high number in the attempt to seat Ava Hargath on the throne of Onu-Arith.

Line: (years on throne)

- Ava Hargath (2E 4960 - 3E 0098)
- Deidlee Hargath (3E 0098 - 3E 0251)
- Anne Hargath (3E 0251 - 3E 0288)

Red Dusk:

The Red Dusk is a cult that worships one of the fallen Ilékin(or Aeílkin) known as Krahn. Known by many names across the eras and lands, they are a shifting, elusive force. To some, they are *The Children of the Veil*, harbingers of a hidden destiny. To others, they are *The Cindersworn*, fire-touched and ash-marked, bound by the flames of forgotten pacts. In whispered fear, they are called *The Silent Dawn*, heralds of a dark age when no song rises and the sun itself falters. And in the oldest records, they are named *The Covenant of the Crimson Veil*—a pact sealed in blood beneath moons weeping red. They have a codex of seven books written by this obscure figure of the First Era, simply known as “Mala” which is a word that some scholars believe carried weight in the ancient languages of the world, yet has lost all in the modern sense. They are known to brand those who follow faiths such as Scalvic and Jeda with the Mark of Daryun.

Stormfangs:

A subgroup of the rebellious factions of men on the Island Continent of Onu-Arith during the beginning of the Third Era. This faction would come to reinvigorate the rebellion, which had cooled down in the years of Ulfar’s youth, when Ulfar took the last name of Stormfang in an effort to draw

fear into the Imperium. Ultimately, this was the main body which made up the most devoted and elite of the forces of Ulfar's Rebellion. Many of these men were ones who had grown up in the villages surrounding Ulfar, owing their lives to him for deeds he did and seeing the growth of the one they saw become a leader.

The Nirinathé:

They are neither living nor dead; they walk both the physical world and that of the spiritual. Once great warriors of men, yet no longer are they of anything other than the Void. Cursed with life, they cannot obtain the promised great power and lead the kingdoms that were said to come to them. They are not just endless, and those of Valkar are servants to him and him alone. They were imprisoned in the tombs their first bodies were buried in by the magics of both Baragom the Black and Dramira after they were seemingly slain during the War of Shadows in the Second Era.

Valkorian Empire [Old Valkoria]:

Formed by the line given the Amulet of the Kings by the human Melin during the First Era. It was the allegiance of nobles and various holds across the northern reaches of the continent of Onu-Derith. Founded by Tón the Elder during the waning years of the second millennium of the First Era. The line of the kings would follow the eldest son of the sitting crown until the ascension of Talor, who would give his life without marrying or even bearing an heir. This would lead to a separation of the houses of the kingdom as General Taklu ascended the throne. As generals began to take over the throne, their line would eventually end in the three-thousand and fifty-first year of the First Era and then would happen the event known as "The Desolation of Valkoria" which was a massive seismic earthquake that would sweep the lands inhabited by the valkorians. There would be crevices that opened and let fires burn across the

scape, and there would be eruptions of various mountains, causing destruction and killing tens of thousands. From the ashes, the Valkorian humans would now have fewer numbers than the Dalmithe.

- **Line of Valin:** The divine bloodline of those destined to rule the Valkorian people. It was also the only humans who were seemingly immune to the corruptive power of Valkar, as these kings were bestowed many gifts from the Dark Lord, yet none of them had any effect, making the great elves wonder if they drew from the blood of the Thaloré. Their line would only stretch through four kings and just shy of a thousand years, when Talor would be slain in combat with no knowledge of a bom heir, until in the Third Era, a man named Aelfred would come to know his lineage and pass the knowledge down to his son Ulfar.

- 1) Arslan
- 2) Tirún (1E 0896 - 1045)
- 3) Hurgon (1E 1045 - 1200)
- 4) Hónir (1E 1200 - 1497)
- 5) Térún (1E 1497 - 1674)
- 6) Tulór (1E 1674 - 1938)
- 7) Tón (1E 1938 - 2219)
- 8) Tumás (1E 2219 - 2419)
- 9) Tavar (1E 2419 - 2675)
- 10) Talor (1E 2675 - 2712)
- Thousands of years pass—
- 11) Aelfred Val
- 12) Ulfar the Reclaimer

Watchers of Valkoria:

The Watchers of Valkoria, or simply Watchers, were founded by the brother of the seventh king of Valkoria, Tecar. They were seen as the most vigilant and elite of orders, held in a higher regard than that of the king's guard at some points in

their history. They were sworn to many oaths and kept a vow of celibacy, along with some, very few though, going to the point of making eunuchs of themselves. Traditionally, the Watchers of Valkoria were an order of rangers or guardians of ancient Valkoria who were given different armour, which was more conducive to the manoeuvrability needed by those who spend much of their lives in nature. Shortly after the death of Talor the Hero, the seers of the order had claimed to see a vision of the empire's impending doom. They would support Talku for the first half of his rule, then eventually broke off, fragmenting across the world. Some of the watchers would venture to places like the Narthal Reach and Velkaris.

Dramatis Personae

Alíwen: Awoken 1E 0000.

She was a Vanir who came to be at the dawn of creation and was a sibling to Vaxar. She is one of the greatest female elven warriors to ever grace the blade and was often seen in such a light amongst the elven people, regardless of ethnicity, that she was due a certain respect whenever she graced one's presence. She is the leader of the Altarí, which is an elite guard of women warriors who are masters of light, hit-and-run conflicts, along with scout and surveillance missions.

Almek Muun: Born 3E 0200, Died 3E 0289.

Served as a member of two Queen's guards under both Deidlee and Anne during the third century of the Third Era. He was a proficient knight who trained under the guise of Judas Preiko while he served as Lord Commander during the reign of Queen Deidelee. His skill as a swordsman was unrivalled during his time as the head of the Queen's Guard. He would take the first oath of his life to the mother of Anee

and would swear after Queen Deidlee was murdered by Judas that he would take the murderer's life. He was one of the few men that Anne would take the advice of with full intention of using it; he was strongly against her holy crusade against the church, which, towards the end of her rule, she had realised that her mistake lay within her foolish war. He would come to the halls of Valingard having a love for the Queen which never could be reciprocated, as he took a vow of celibacy when becoming a member of the guard.

Anne Hargath: Born 3E 0220.

She is the only daughter and youngest child of Deidlee Hargath and the cold who ascended to the throne after her mother's passing. She is a stout and beautiful woman whose pride and hubris are her ultimate downfall. She bore the regal allure of someone shaped by both power and purpose. Her face was fair and finely sculpted, with sharp cheekbones and a strong jawline that lent her a commanding air. Her skin was pale but warm, like the first flush of dawn, and her eyes, a piercing shade of grey-green. Her hair, a cascade of dirty blonde waves, tumbled down her back, catching the light like strands of sun-kissed wheat swaying in a summer breeze. Though not golden, her hair carried a muted radiance, soft yet wild, much like the queen herself—untamable, unpredictable. She wore it loosely, though often crowned with a delicate tiara of silver, symbolising her grace, but there was a sense of raw power beneath her every move, as though her beauty was but a mask for the steel that lay beneath. She would come to give up her struggle the moment she recognised why Travers Aramir had entered her keep, her mind had broken, and she had realised she had lost everything. The once strong, stout personality would become something meek and broken as if she were a shell of her former self. During her trial, the public would strip her of all titles yet charge her with no crimes, leaving her to be a free woman. Being around the

age of Ulfar, Judas believes she could be of some use to them for some time.

Ardenfell: Born 2E 0025.

Twin brother of Ariendria and prince of Elendaiél. He has taken after his father's skill with the blade and has become, as many argue, one of the best of the wood elven warriors to ever grace Varis Mogul. He was noticeably absent from the wedding of his sister, as he was greatly opposed to her marriage to a mortal human.

Ariendria: Born 2E 0025.

She is of the Velmar born of her father, Eluiar. She is a skilled warrior and one who holds great knowledge of the history of both the elves and the world as a whole. She has spent many moons under the study of Auréa during her years and has come to seek certain rumoured prophecies come to life. She is a firm believer in the story that Malachar was not slain at the end of his crusade during his duel with Vaxium, yet he was injured and has lain dormant in the safety of Vouldorth for centuries.

Auréa: Born 1E 1203.

She is the daughter of Vaxium and Dramira, born on the night of the Durenstar, which occurs in the snows of the first month of the new year. It was a symbol of the being who was not a pure elf, yet one of mixed lineage, and an elf who drew one quarter of her blood from that of Vaeimea's favoured creation, that of mankind. She was the only child of Vaxium, the King of the Vanir land of Valendriel. She married Féalbor, which gave her dominion over the vast and beautifully crafted city of Dremor. She is wise beyond her years and endowed with an immense power that in some instances rivals that of even her mother's own. She is a deeply trusted friend of Travers Aramir and one whom she often finds solace in the presence of. She is often told of as

being one of the most beautiful elves to ever grace the lands, holding that of her mother's beauty, yet also is captivated in the Durenstar.

Ava Hargath: Born 2E 4867, Died 3E 0098.

She was the first queen of the Neimar Imperium, serving as the figurehead of the charge, throwing her family's money to the Veileiar in an effort to win the civil war. This move was successful with her father at the helm, and thus placed her on the throne of the city of Valkoria and established the Neimar Imperium. She lived the most peaceful life of any of the monarchs; her daughter and heir would be her firstborn daughter, Deidlee, who would come to be known as “the Mad Queen” for her loss of mental stability during the last few months of her reign. This would lead to the eldest granddaughter of Deidlee to have her own vying for the throne and be known as the Dance of Queens. She became known as Ava the Able, showing her ability as even a woman to lead a successful country.

Belise: Awoken 1E 0000, Died 2E 4457.

She was of the Vamir and was the wife of Marion and a mother figure to Drewen. She was unable to give birth on her own and was given a gift by Goht. The baby who would come to be known as Drewen would come to be in her and Marion's care and would take the form of a Velmar and come to be their only child.

Celëfaéor: Born 1E 2432, Died 2E 0756.

He was a Vanir born of his father Fëalbor and of his mother Auréa. Regarded in history as the second greatest of elven smiths to ever grace the lands of Varis Mogul. Even in the terms of his father, some of his crafts were unmatched, though he met a swift end at the hand of Malachar as he resisted the temptation of the dark lord who bore an elvish form. He was not quite the fighter of his father, as he

dedicated his life to forging weapons worthy of the most legendary elves to ever live. His story is told through the countless crafts he left in the world of the living, and his various documentations serve as textbooks for those who seek to grow in their craft.

Daryun: Born 1E 0694, Died 1E 0734.

He was the brother of Koory and of Arslan. Daryun was known as the greatest warrior of the early men of the world and was known for wielding a spear/halberd, long sword and bow with elite skill in all three, along with being the greatest horse rider of the time. Daryun would come to face his destiny in the form of his own sacrifice; he would give his life so that his brother Arslan could make his Kingdom of Valkoria his. His two brothers would find his body with a brand upon his neck; they would come to call this the Mark of Daryun and the Brand of Krahn.

Deidlee Hargath: Born 3E 0003, Died 3E 0251.

She was the mother of Queen Anne and the reigning queen before her death. She was one of the major forces that began the oppressive nature of the Imperium, which her daughter pushed even further, eventually collapsing the Imperium. She was one of the fairest rulers of the Imperium during the first decade of her rule, and she eventually became crazed as the rebellion of the farmers began, led by a man who simply claimed he was of Valin. She was driven into madness for the last few decades of her life and was given the name of the Mad Queen. She called for the head of the rebellion, which was the father of Ulfar. She set his father ablaze and began to scream out, "Burn them. Burn them all!" which prompted those most loyal to her to begin burning those who dissented from her and carried certain last names. A member of her own royal guard, Judas Preiko would eventually slay her, going by the name and guise of Sir Jamie Harren.

Dramira: Awoken 1E 0000.

Awakening the first year of the world. She is a Vamir of the Thaloré. She is the wife of Vaxium, mother of Auréa and queen of Valendriel. She is referred to as the White Queen, Lady of Valendriel, amongst various other titles. She is also described as the most beautiful of all the elven queens. She is the direct narrator of most events of history written down and is the true narrator of the life of man, documenting their lives in the tomes of history. Her power and wisdom are immense amongst those who dwell in the lands of Varis Mogul, yet it is unknown if her power compares to that of Malachar or even Valkar. She is one of the wisest on the land and is often approached by the wise Travers Aramir for advice and counsel. She is one of the most powerful of the elves from the years of the Alundél who still live in the world. She is the one which told the elves that their offspring will be much weaker after the loss of the Alundél and that such elves as her, Vaxium, Numenonalé, and even Draxel are power levels that no elf born after the War of Elves and men will be comparable in raw strength to them, this was a foretelling that the importance of man would increase as the world ages.

Drewen: Born 1E 0785, Died 2E 0153.

He was of the Ilékin and direct creation of Goht; he was let down from the domain of God and sent to live directly on Varis Mogul. He was the gifted son of Lord Frenar and his wife Lady Belise, gifted to them by Goht as the child they could never bear. He was given elven features and raised as one of the Vamir. He would come to meet Lady Llyena, who was the half-Velmar, half-Valkorian woman whom he fell in love with. He would father the birth of two children with Llyena, Eluiar and Raseiré. The love of Drewen and Llyena would come to be one of the best-known legends amongst

mortals and elves, which was simply known as *Drewen and Llyena*. He would most resemble the form of the Velmar, or the wood elves.

Duke Balian: Born 3E 0099, Died 3E 0288.

As a sort of hand to the Queen, he was given command over the southern reaches and plains of Onu-Arith. He was regent over the lands which held the villages of Ulfar until recent years, where his money and power had become stretched thin and over the southern plains which held Vingólf. He would never even see the coming of Ulfar, as during the travel to Vingólf, he would leave to the north and vanish following the cobbled path north towards Valkoria.

Eyánur: Born 2E 2433, Died 2E 2673.

He was a sworn warrior and servant to the King of Tarédiel. As the head of Uriel XI's Black Guard, his personal king's guard, he was the personal defender against any attempts on the king's life. He was one of the few guards who were with Uriel during his assassination during the Second Era. He would live his life as an exiled warrior with no claimed honour or dignity since he failed in his one duty. He would document most of the events of the years after Uriel XI's death before going to live in seclusion in the mountains. After his death, Judas Preiko would find his body and lay him to rest in the Hall of Dragons, which was where all the Black Guard were laid to rest.

Fëalbor: Awoken 1E 0000, Died 1E 4324.

He was a Vanir, High Elf, born to the city of Vivik during the dawn of life. He became the greatest of all the Elven smiths, who would later come to "forge cities", even training his own son Celëfaéor in his mythic smithing arts; the two would come to "forge" the legendary Elven city of Dremor in the Second Era. Forger of many items that still hold great power and significance in the world today. He was tricked

and was manipulated by Malachar, who took the form of an elf, then tricked him into forging him weapons and gear of great strength and power, along with teaching Malachar his legendary forging techniques.

Frenar: Awoken 1E 0000, Died 2E 4559.

He was the King of the Nalanor, which is the vast, darker, more eerie woods; he was the adoptive father of the Drewen, who was an integral part in the quest for the Alundél during the First Era. He was a great smith and taught the likes of Fëalbor. Frenar was regarded as the greatest craftsman until his disciple rose above. Frenar was attributed with forging some of the most powerful artefacts of the First Era. He was an important figure of the First Era to the elves, though one shrouded in his own hubris. During the time of the Alundél, he crafted the five gems, which became pivotal items in the elven cultures.

Galadrielle: Born 3E 0040.

She is the current leader of the Guild of the Mystic Arts and is related to the two leaders during the middle of the Third Era when the guild refused to help the Elves of Dremor during Malachar's war. She is a stout woman who fears no one and often is willing to take a risky step if it means she can collect knowledge or even magic items for the Guild to house and keep. She stands around six feet tall and has the deepest black hair. Her eyes are this vibrant shade of emerald green, which often makes people distrustful of her. By the time of Ulfar, she had had a few interactions with Travers Aramir and was unwilling to help his future cause.

General Raul Boscogn: Born 3E 0158.

Born to the noble clan of Boscogn, he was given a step up on others during his youth. He was the son of five children in total, being the very middle child. He eventually swore himself to an order of knights, which was known to many as

the Vigiles Templar, an order that is said to be descended from the Watchers of Valkoria. He took the oath of chastity, and he would come to be one of the finest knights of the order. He would climb through the ranks and eventually come to be one of the heads of the order by his thirtieth birthday. His career would take an inconceivable jump as he was given a promotion from the order to being a general in the Neirmar Imperium, handed to him by then Head General Imanius Turgarthên. He would be given a commission to reclaim the lost cities and forts at the time, which he would swiftly reclaim, along with taking back the legendary Vingólf, which would give him a permanent garrison at the city. He would come to protect the city as the one impenetrable fortress of the Imperium for the next forty years until he lost the fort to the coming threat of Ulfar Valin in the two-hundred and eighty-eighth year of the Third Era. After throwing his hands into the lot of the Stormfangs, he eventually would retire shortly after realising that the Imperium was doomed.

Goht:

Creator of all and master of all. The true God of this world who directly created Valkar, Vaeimea, Varis Mogul and the rest of the Talrah. He also indirectly created all things through them. Though He has never placed his full being on the planet, he dwells within the hearts of all those created in His image and likeness. He is all-powerful, all-knowing, all good and all wise. His power is unknown to the world and many do not know of his true existence he reveals himself to the world in mysterious ways such as sending certain figures to make their presence known in the world and influence so certain events come to be yet he also lets the world take its own path as each of his creations direct and indirect are given the full power of free will.

Grant Denoso: Born 3E 0201, Died 3E 0288.

He was the minister of trade only under the rule of Anne; his policy was open trade, which was always shut down as Anne believed that she did not need the help of others. His wisdom outpaced his years, though he was, in times of great stress, quick to make a poor decision. He would be captured by the Zealots, and he would attempt an escape one night from their imprisonment, which would lead to him choosing death rather than continued torture by the Zealots. His family was not one of stature or grand importance, leaving next to nothing behind in his death.

Grayson Gajeck: Born 3E 0227.

He was a friend to the young Ulfar during his childhood until he was taken with his father to the capital city of Valkoria. There, he would be trained as a steward of the crown and be taught how to be a proper advisor. He would be briefed in small council meetings along with the lords and ministers of the lands. He would take his first position as advisor or Steward Hand, which is the chief advisor to the crown, on the eve of his thirtieth birthday. He would come to serve in the same position under the rule of Ulfar Valin and be a member of his small council.

Greyon: Born 2E 3498, Died 3E 0288.

He was the halfling Dulmir, born to the riverlands of Onu-Derith thousands of years after the Desolation of Valkoria. He grew up with a normal life until he stumbled across the Amulet of the Kings during the early years of his life, which would lead him to fall into a deep well of corruption. He would take the lives of many he once held dear and would flee to the Telmithe Mountain Range in the early years of the Third Era.

Gunmar Temur: Born 3E 0230.

Born to a poor family in the southern villages of the tusk plains. He is a man of powerful stature. By the age of twenty, he had already grown a great beard and was a master of heavy weaponry. As a trusted close friend and near brother of Ulfar, he is his right hand and one of the few generals of his army. He often does not disclose his family name, Temur, as it carries great history with it. His lineage, as well as Ulfar's, is traceable to one of the most noble of Valkorian Houses.

Halfar:

A quite mystical character, he is told of in quite a few legends, carrying many names throughout different cultures. In the Valkorian culture, he is often referred to as Halfar or the Stranger. He is associated with the realm of dreams, and many who are deep in faith claim to have seen him wander their dreams, yet it is also said that anyone who interacts with him in this land of imagination will be marked and cursed forever. Though he is a deific figure, he is regarded as a lesser god, being placed in the category of one who ascended to become a god. In the culture of man, he is the name used most often to curse enemies or others that someone wishes misfortune upon.

Halvar Eldaric: Born 1E 0910, Died 1E 1213.

He was born to a simple beginning and became close friends with the nobles of the new world of man. This eventually led him to take up the trade of smithing, where he spent many years honing his craft until he was considered amongst the best living even within the elves. He was eventually approached by Threll Kelmsman and given the offer to be legendary with the help of Valkar. He would accept this offer and forge some of the most legendary weapons known to man, some of which were dreaded, such as the Weapons of Talmek.

Heirmar Seidel: Born 2E 4876, Died 3E 0032.

Grand Uncle to Tiber Seidel and first Grand General of the Neimar Imperium, he was an integral part of securing enough of the lands of Onu-Arith to claim that the Neimar Imperium had sovereignty over the people. It was his tactics and advice to employ the use of elvish mercenaries that turned the tide of the war and eventually led to the coronation of the first Queen of the Neimar Imperium and the first ever declared Queen of the Valkorians.

Hellion Hugarand: Born 3E 0200, Missing as of 3E 0288.

His family was not born to fame or prowess; he was a simple, smart man who knew how to talk his way into almost every deal or position possible. Though he was much more of a reserved person, he had come to sway the decisions and opinions of Anne a handful of times, such as his support for Anne reorganising the Queen's guard to have three more knights. He may have in the end opposed the Queen, yet he did not hate the woman nor did he believe she was not the true Queen; he simply feared she would become her mother and sought not to have himself tormented like his uncle was. Quite the selfish individual, he was one to prioritise his own life and welfare above others around him, no matter who they were.

Hónir (Valin): Born 1E 1099, Died 1E 1497.

He was the fourth King of Valkoria and the eldest son of Hurgon. He was one of the finest smiths of men to ever live and was able to manipulate the very gem which cursed his father to be a blessing upon his bloodline and that of man. He is the man who forged the Amulet of the Kings during the First Era. As a stout warrior and noble leader, he rallied the armies of Valkoria to fight against the coming Orc armies during the War of Vengeance. He was also the one who purified the gem which was held within the very centre of the Amulet, so when in the hands of his bloodline, it would

be an emerald green rather than the darkened crimson shades. It would also purify the hearts of the line and make them seemingly immune to the natural corrupt nature of the fallen world. He was a noble-hearted and strong warrior, remembered for his just and strong rule while protecting his lands and people.

Imanius Turgarthên: Born 3E 0013, Died 3E 0263.

He was born to a once-noble family of the long-ancient Valkoria. Their status was never lost through the ages; he was the previous high commander of the Neirmar Imperium before Tiber Seidel. He was the soldier who taught Tiber and brought him to the skill where he could lead such a vast military, teaching him nearly everything he knew, though he could never break the hubris of the young man. His skill and name were known throughout the kingdom and were feared, though it is entirely unknown if he had any legitimate children before his death, as he was focused on his military career.

Judas Preiko: Born 1E 0580.

He was born with creation and was sworn to live an endless life as a “Prophet of Goht”. He would eventually come to live amongst the people of the Valkorian Empire and become great friends with Talor, where he eventually became the Lord Commander of the Watchers of Valkoria. Here, he would become the great warrior he is now and find the armour he still bears to this day. After the fall and death of his friends, he would wander the world in wait for the next of the line of Valin to rise from the ashes, and he would come to wield the sword Jarsil. His wisdom and knowledge would be integral in helping Ulfar through his travels.

Káerielle Bildg: Born 1E 4401.

She is the only daughter of Shalld Bildg and his second wife, Amara. Drawing half her blood from that of the Veileiar her

only resemblance is her pointed ears. Bearing pale skin, yellowed eyes, crimson hair, and wings. It is generally unknown whether or not she shows any traits of her mother, as she died during labour and was swiftly buried by Shalld. She is the figurehead of three widely known prophecies, one of which she already fulfilled with the slaying of Umbrathrox known as Anaxis during Malachar's attempt to raise one from the void. To man, she is seen as one of the three divine embodiments of Vaeimea and heralded as a near goddess, often being the form used to show their mother divine in chapels and great halls.

Kelana: Born 1E 0790, Died 1E 1001.

She was one human who awoke as the first generation; she came to meet the elf known as Vaxar, King of the Thaloré of Valendriel. She would come to marry the elf and give birth to three children. Vaxium would be the first and oldest, and would come to ascend the throne after his father's tragic passing. She would not know of her mortality until she was told of it by the elves she had come to live amongst. Vaxar as an immortal elf was wamed by his sister, Alíwen about falling in love yet he did not take her advice and as she passed Vaxar would be left with a void, an absence in his heart and would come to dive into a deepened depression which resulted in his son taking over most of the kingdom and duties as he mourned for centuries until he succumbed to the grief and passed.

King Uriel [Taun] IX: Born 2E 2271, Died 2E 2598.

He is known as "*The Dragon Made*" and the last true King of Tarédiel. Some say he is the true blood of Talor and heir to the Valin dynasty. He birthed three known sons who were slaughtered by men of the Red Dusk. He would follow the fate of his children and be slain by an assassin carrying a blade made from Darkur; this would mark the opening moments of what history would come to call the Infernal

Crisis. Uriel would be granted knowledge in the waning hours of his life, he would tell his guardsmen, specifically one named Eyánur, whom he became accustomed to confiding in. Uriel would awake and look to his confidant and say, “I know when I die, my Blade, Vekatar has shown me my death. On the 23rd of New Green in the year 503 of our lord Drukavin. I will die, and a hero will be born in the coming darkness and he alone will be the force who closes shut the jaws of death itself.” Eyánur held the belief even long after the end of the Infernal Crisis that this was not foretelling of Torgen or the Hero of Tarédiel, yet the coming of the stormborn, the next King of Valkoria, who would return the Amulet of the Kings. The King would be remembered throughout history and be granted a statue in the Hall of Lords in Valkoria, and later visited by Ulfar.

Koory: Born 1E 0690, Died 1E 0835.

Koory was the eldest son of a man named Darelun. He would be one of three brothers. At a very young age, his mind seemed to be affected by the powers of the Creator Himself. He would receive his first divine revelation in the form of a vision, one which showed him and his two brothers' fates, yet he knew he could not talk of this dream to anyone. He would begin at the age of thirteen, preaching the divine wisdom given to him by the figure he referred to as “Goht”, which simply meant “the One Above All.” Koory would go to establish the faith of Jeda and help establish Argolin, the capital of his brother Arslan’s Kingdom. This would be dubbed the City of Koory until the faith died out, and it was simply a title of lost gods in the eyes of the Valkorians. Koory would author nearly half of all the scripture of his church through pure divine revelation. And when he vanished atop Mount Dorel, many believed he had been taken into the Kingdom of Goht. His work would still be around even thousands of years later in the Third Era, with his faith, the church he crafted by the will of Goht still

standing, and the countless pantheons that followed had fallen and been remoulded many times over.

Lalia (Carasan) Val: Born 3E 0197.

She is the mother of Ulfar and the sole parent who raised him for nearly all of his childhood, as his father was off fighting most of his youth. She was an abnormally young mother giving birth to Ulfar at the young age of thirty-four, which for a Valkoria was quite young, as many would wait until they were in their first century to have children. As a young mother, she cared deeply for her son, whom she would be blessed to see most of his life. She was the most loving and caring person to the young Ulfar and dreaded the days when he would follow his father's footsteps and become not a soldier but a ranger, like his father and her father was. As a Carasan adventure was in her blood and she had always sought to venture the world, and was promised such by her son when he was not even ten years old.

Llyena: Born 1E 4704, Died 1E 4979.

One of history's most mystical figures, many did not know when she was or what roles she played in the world, yet all knew one truth about her: she was the mortal who fell in love with one immortal not of Varis Mogul. She was born by mere accident of a Velmar mother and Dalmithe father producing a child who would live the span of life just around that of a Valkorian. Her tale of love is seen as a tragic folktale passed down through the generations as a warning against the intermingling of mortals and immortals. It is a beautiful love story which captures the hearts of many human women, yet reminds the world of the cost of love.

Lord Eluiar: Born 1E 4767.

He was the Velmar lord of Elendaiél, the region in which a vast majority of the wood elves dwelt and the largest of their colonies. He is the father of the lady Ariendria and her

brother Ardenfell, who have both been carefully raised under his guidance. Contrary to most parents of the Velmar, he is active in the lives of his children even as they have come of age. Being the product of an immortal and mortal having children, he is not entirely opposed to such a relationship, yet warns of the consequences for choosing such a life. He is seen as wise even as an elf of the waning years of the First Era, his power as a holder of the Ring of Nardél, which is much less a ring but a form of jewellery known as a slave bracelet, it was the mixture of a ring and a bracelet connected to one another by a chain on the back of the hand. This was the piece of jewellery which belonged to his father, Drewen and was imbued with intense magic and was a piece which was made as a compliment to the circlets and rings of the Vamir.

Malachar: Born 1E 1423.

Born to the human name of Melin, he was thought to be a normal Dalmite human who had dreams influenced by the at the time living entity of Valkar, who sought to seduce anyone he could to his dark side. He was quite the normal boy adopted by a high-class family who sought to take the place of the fallen dark lord, yet he was fighting an internal battle after venturing to Pharolax. He would come to venture with a newfound friend, and he would resist the temptation of evil for many years, then he would come to meet a simple demise, where he would remerge as the elf named Vanduíar and live amongst the elves slowly, with deceit building his shadow without catching the gaze of the wisest in the world. He would come to lead a full-fledged attempt to take over the world during the Second Era, which would be known as The War of Shadows, which was waged through the lands of elves and men in an attempt to take over the world, where Valkar failed. He would come to face defeat while fighting in single combat and was perceived to have died from a mortal wound given to him by Vaxium.

Mikel Sovéran: Born Unknown.

He was another member of the order sent to the world by Goht, though he came to the world just a few years prior to that of Travers Aramir. He was the wizard who was tasked with defending and protecting the Aurellian Forest of Onu-Derith, which shelters the hidden pass to Elendaiél. He was one of the few not of the elves who knew the location of the hidden pass and often was one who guided those who sought the necessary shelter. He was much more sporadic and often crazier than his counterparts, specifically his close friend Travers Aramir. His cloak of a deepened royal navy blue was unique as it drew some similarity to the shades of blue that Aramir's was; he had picked something that was a unique yet still natural tone. His skill was often overlooked because he was seen as almost insane by the minds of certain elves, such as Alíwen and Thaloréa. Baragorn, head of their order, also saw him as unreliable and weak. He was close with the likes of Eluiar and Auréa, who trusted his wisdom and thought his strength a necessary force in the future, as his heart was truly for good.

Numenonalé: Awoken 1E 0000, Died 1E 1436.

He was born of creation, and as he came of full age, he would come to be one of the finest warriors of the early elves, born of the Vamir. He was of paler skin. His skills were known to be the best of all elven swordsmen, and he would come to wield the sword Shadowcleave during Valkar's War of Vengeance, where it would gain that name from how it cut down the forces of the darkness. It would also be known as the Orc-Hammer for how he cut down many orcs during the war, which he thought would come to a quick end in his stand against Valkar. He would be remembered for his intense bravery and sacrifice for the elves. He would come to be the only being of Varis Mogul to lay not one but seven full blows and half of an eighth to a being of the Talrah.

Peitro Hulle: Born 3E 0134, Missing as of 3E 0288.

He was one of the twelve ministers who advised the queen of the Imperium. He would oversee the coinage and stores of the crown. As one of the richer families of the Imperium, he was key in keeping the government and crown in order to maintain power. Queen Anne, who cared not for his life or his coin, always saw him as expendable. She held a view that men like him, who were seen as meek and weak for hiding behind their money, were useless.

Raseiré: Born 1E 4767, Died 2E 0794.

Half-Velmar, brother of Eluiar. He is the uncle of both Ariendria and Ardenfell, though he passed many years before their births. He and his brother Eluiar were given a special choice as to live the life of a mortal or that of an Elf. He would come to be the first king of the hidden human kingdom of Eldorath, which is a hidden kingdom of man.

Saint Peter of Bethê: Born 3E 0101.

He was born to a lower-class family out in the villages far from the capital of Valkoria, where he could still practice Scalvic without fear of the zealots of the Imperium. He would come to be one of the most knowledgeable children of his village on the texts and stories of their gods. He would eventually come to take the oath of celibacy and become a priest of the church. He would climb his way through preaching to many of the villages and doing his fair share of travelling. After a great purge done by Queen Anne, he would remain hidden amongst Ulfar and would come to build quite a rapport with the man, forging a quick and strong friendship, gaining his support in becoming the papal authority of the church.

Saul Nornin: Born 3E 0121, Died 3E 0289.

He was the head minister of war during the reign of two queens, Deidlee and her daughter Anne. He would be one of

the most proficient and smartest of all the ministers. He knew firmly that if the Valkorians in the villages to the southeast ever went with the notion of restoring the kingdom and finding a single man to rally behind, that the days of the Neimar Imperium were over. He supported nearly every decision of Anne and was one of the few who supported the final years of Deidlee and her descent into madness, which he referred to as “A just use of imperial force.” He would come to face his end at the guest of his own will as Ulfar took Valkoria; he would end his own life rather than submit to a peasant.

Shulath:

Bom of darkness, this is a creature of pure unknown origin, though it was known to exist before the coming of those who now inhabit the world. This was the horrid creature which came to Valkar in the first days of Varis Mogul after Goht had placed both Valkar and Vaeimea on this world. This creature would be the corrupting force behind Valkar and lead him to make his revolt against Goht. After this, the creature would vanish from the world, though its effect would be felt throughout the entire life of Goht’s creation.

Tecar Valin: Born 1E 2134, Died 1E 2332.

Brother to the second King of Valkoria, Tumás. He was known throughout the realm as one of the most skilled swordsmen, wielding the Erinsthil blade known as Jarsil. He came to establish the elite core of the Valkorian Military known as the Watchers of Valkoria. He was the first Lord Commander who created nearly every single tradition of the guard, which included a pledge which includes many things, including forsaking personal ties and ambitions, and even swearing to chastity. He passed without ever taking a wife and was often seen in a lesser light when compared to his brother, the King.

Thrindél: Born 1E 0500.

He is the King of the Elviné, the group of Visender Elves that inhabit the lands of southern Igodan, which are covered in snow the entirety of the year, giving them the perfect environment. Combining this with the mountains that are sparingly placed over the lands, the elves have plenty of space to build their lands. He is a holder of one of the elven jewels and survivor of the War of Vengeance, and one of the few who had damaged a drake of the First Era.

Tiber Seidel: Born 3E 0223, Died 3E 0289.

High commander of the armies of the Neimar Imperium. He was held in the highest regard amongst the commanding soldiers of the Imperium. He was born to the high noble family of the house Seidel, which was one of the few houses of ancient Valkoria to carry over to the Neimar Imperium. He was given a step up in society, yet he decided to take his name to the military for the first time in many generations. From a young age, he was a gifted strategist with a solid grasp of bladed combat. As he aged, he eventually, after his fortieth birthday, would come to be given the command over all the armies of the Neimar Imperium after the death of Head General Imanius Turgarhên. His wits would lead him to eventually grow weak in his game of swordplay, and eventually would lead to his downfall as his own self-confidence and inability to work with the sitting queen would create issues among the nobles and hierarchy of the military. It was always said that he had a strained relationship with the great General Boscogn.

Tón Valin: Born 1E 1927, Died 1E 2219.

Born to a more wealthy family, he was given visions by the gods, and he sought to act upon them. He established the Valkorian Kingdom, also known simply as Valkoria or the Valkorian Empire, which was the largest single alliance of men in the world. He was the father of two sons and three

daughters. His heir would be Tumás, and his second son Tecar would come to form the Watchers, never giving his father a grandchild. Tón sought to make his family stand out from others, and during the small skirmishes he waged to forge his crown, he bonded his family with a sub-race of lesser dragons known as the Drakers

Travers Aramir: Born Unknown, 3E 0289, assumed dead.

He was not born of the world of Varis Mogul, yet he was a gift to the world by Goht. Travers Aramir, along with four known others (assumed to be seven in total, yet two have yet to be found), were sent to the world by Goht as messengers of his will, and each was given a specific task for the world. These persons were given access to powerful magic along with great skills in other forms of combat in an effort to make them powerful but not ultimate forces in the world. Travers Aramir was given the specific task, which required him to spend the many centuries he lived upon the world helping the humans and pushing them down a path where they could take on the mantra of being defenders of the world, fighting off the encroaching darkness. It was unknown what specific goals were of his quest; he had only the compassion and care for humanity that made it self-evident that he was to be a steward to them, a trusted friend to many and help them when they needed it most. He had a special relationship with the mother of Ulfar, Lalia, as if to be a grandfather figure to her; he was immensely close with her father and recalled dozens of adventures that they went on with the young Lalia

Tumás Valin: Born 1E 2119, Died 1E 2419.

Elder brother of Tecar and first son of the first King of Valkoria, Tón. He was the born heir to the throne. He was raised with a sort of advantage over his brother, being the first heir and eventual second King of Valkoria; his life was one of more comfort than that of his other siblings. He was a

peaceful king who was not a dragon rider like his father; he was known to history as Tumás the Peaceful, being the only king to have a reign in which there were no wars fought by the troops of the realm. His reign was firm, lasting two hundred years exactly, and he passed away at a simple age. His influence was one of strength and unity amongst the people and is remembered as being the most mellow of all the kings who ruled.

Ulfar Val (Valin): Born 3E 0231.

Born to his father Aelfred and his mother Lalia on midsummer's eve. He was raised in a poor family native to the villages of the southeast, brought up in the faith of the religion known as Scalvic, and he studied Old Valkoria. He learned all he could through the church and through those older than him. During his teens, his father was part of the rising Stormfang rebellion; he was taken to the capital and murdered by the Mad Queen. This would fuel the man to take up the reins of the rebellion after years it had fallen into the shadows, and would raise a large enough army to have a swift crusade through the lands of Onu-Arith.

Ummar Gruthic: Born 3E 0195.

The Delmver man stays clad in thick armour, often decorated with furs, making his already bulky frame look much more than it should. Descended from a long line of mercenaries, he is a venturing fighter simply looking for the best fight possible. He was a fierce and stern dwarf who did not fear anyone and was the first to start some sort of argument or conflict with elves, especially. During his time in Onu-Derith, he had heard of a man named Ulfar who was descended from dragon riders and was no more than curious about what this seemingly legendary man would be capable of. He is commonly seen wielding one or two large axes; sometimes, one of the axes will be replaced with a hammer.

Vaeimea:

She was one of the two formed of Goht and the earth itself, in His divine image; she was pure and eventually came to be given the gift of the Alundél. She would come to fight her twin Valkar as he revolted against Goht in the Gardens, and through this, she would be victorious with the help of Goht and then come to populate the world with creations not in her image but that of Goht. Through her, Goht would interact and build relationships with the world, and she would be the chief goddess of many different cultures and religions. Few would recognise her as less than Goht, with many believing she was the creator of all.

Valkar (Vareiké):

Born to the name Vareiké and forged of the hands of Goht himself, this is one of the two main eternals, also known as the Eleikin, those who were first given bodies of flesh and bone but had them stripped away after they went against the rules set by Goht. He was the more easily swayed of the two, being much more susceptible to the manipulations of outside forces, which eventually led to his rebellion against Goht, prompting the smiting and removal of their bodies. He would come to try and influence the world in various ways, such as taking the body of a mortal fool in the Second Era and eventually corrupting Malachar to be his heir, which would not go the way Valkar had planned.

Vaxar: Awoken 1E 0000, Died 1E 4250.

He was born of creations, marking him with the very mark of creation that dances on the necks of all who were born miraculously. He was the first lord of the Vamir and established the lands of Valendriel in the forests of Arkámëndrón. He is the father of Vaxium and was married to the human Kelana, who is the mother of Vaxium. One of the most powerful kings of the elves, he was entrusted by

Vaeimea with the keeping of Arda, the bracelet of life, which he gave to his son after he came to his tenth birthday.

Vaxium: Born 1E 1000.

He was a Vamir, and son of the great and tragic king Vaxar. He is the husband of the beautiful Dramira and is the lord and protector of Valendriel. During his youth, while his father was still king, he was one who took a great liking to the arts of swordplay and war itself, holding the belief that one can only truly know peace if they are willing to break their moral code and to place themselves within violent conflicts. He is known as one of the wisest and most noble of all the elven kings; his wisdom and knowledge are something sought out by many of the lords of other realms and by younger elves. Though it is understood that his wisdom fails in comparison to that of his wife, Dramira, as he is not a bearer of any items of immense power.

Vernon James: Born 3E 0067.

Died 3E 0288. He was the minister in charge of the navy and most affairs relating to the oceans. As the eldest member of Anne's council, she thought his experience to be wise, but he was far out of touch with the people to have much say. He would be a major background player motivating Tiber Seidel to start a coup, yet he did not make his appearance until their secret meeting. He would regret this as the surprise and stress of being caught and possibly killed or tortured for treason caused him to have a heart attack just after Almek Muun busted open the doors. He would leave behind well over a dozen kids, many of whom had no desire for the political landscape.

Vivel Valdrion: Born 3E 0227.

He is a sworn brother to Ulfar, growing up with him in the poor villages on the southwest plains of Onu-Arith. He was the son of a farmer, and his mother was a seamstress during

his youth. He was told by his father that their name will once again mean something if Ulfar comes into power, then again, he will have a noble name. This was a reference to the historical significance of the name Valdrior during the time of Old Valkoria. He became a skilled fighter during his youth, sparring with Ulfar and Gunmar as they grew up together. He eventually became quite the mind for war and strategy, becoming quite the strategist himself.

Zek Judd: Born 3E 0169.

Born to a family of poor peasants who seemingly had never gotten any benefits from the church during his childhood, which cultivated a hatred for the religion of the Valkorian, Scalvic. Though he would not find out until the last few months of his life that it was all a lie, his family had been part of a cult and the priests of the Scalvic faith had tried their best efforts to still aid the family giving them plenty of money even offering to give the young Zek an education though his father refused as he clung to his cultist beliefs and refused to believe the faith of Valkoria. He in his final hours would internally seek the redemption of the faith though he never would admit outwardly. His organization of the Zealots was a decision that had always caused him trouble as deep down he did not believe the faith should be weaponized in such a manner yet he, in his mind, was too deep to turn back.

APPENDIX C

LORE, RELIGION, AND ARTEFACTS

Faiths

Faith of the Seven (Scalvic):

The divine faith of the Valkorian culture. It centers around seven deific figures who all seemingly make up different aspects of a single God, though it can be inferred to be Goht, the religion never gives a name or title to the figure other than True Creator. In this, they are promised a life beyond in a hall called Ysengard, which is gifted to those who die with honour or in combat. Valkyries will carry them to the sky, where they come to drink and party for all of eternity. Each god is based on one of the Talrah, with the combination being easily attributed as being the powers or aspects of Goht.

Deities:

- **Talor (The Warrior)**

Associated with war, stoicism, prowess, strength, and combat. Embodies qualities like bravery, honour, and martial prowess.

- **Halfar (The Stranger)**

Associated with trickery, dreams, nightmares, prophecies, cunning, and mischief. Known for their unpredictable nature and ability to manipulate situations.

- **Vekar (The All Father)**

The highest deity of the Scalvic pantheon. Associated with wisdom, knowledge, and leadership. Often depicted as the father of other gods and responsible for creating the world.

■ **Drukavin (The Brother)**

Associated with strength, storms, fierce climates, war, and protection. Known for their physical prowess and courage in battle. Often invoked for protection and blessings in times of need.

■ **Drenamir (The Smith)**

Associated with craftsmanship, forging, and creation. Known for their skill in metalworking/forging and ability to create powerful weapons and artefacts.

■ **Viviana (The Wife)**

Associated with family, fertility, and domestic life. Revered as the protector of hearth and home, as well as mothers and wives to the chief deity.

■ **Vaeimea (The Mother)**

Often depicted as powerful goddesses with connections to the natural world and the cycle of life. Associated with fertility, love, and beauty.

True Three (Scalvor):

The faith and religion created by the Neimar Imperium's Queen Anne during the years of her rule. She excluded four of the deific figures and even removed the core idea of a creator, which was a minor issue, but one that could have brought many more to her faith. The exclusion of Talor was one that seemingly was the final nail in the coffin for reign and was one of the biggest reasons as to why her religion was not widely accepted.

Gods:

- **Heliao**
 - The Monster - chaos and evil
- **Judia**

- The Lady of Life - giver of life and all that exists
- **Mortha**
 - The Shield-Maiden - protector of light and good

The Jeda (Jedaism):

The Jeda, or "Those Who Hear," is the ancient faith of the early Valkorians, regarded as the sacred root from which all human cultures—especially the Scalvic tradition—would grow. It is not merely a religion but a covenantal way of life, formed around divine revelations given by Goht to His chosen servant, *Koory the Listener*, and carried forward by prophets such as Judas Preiko. Where others built kingdoms of stone and steel, the Jeda built a kingdom of faith, carved not in earth but in obedience, humility, and praise.

Meaning & Origins:

The name *Jeda* derives from the old tongue, meaning “to hear” or “to listen in reverence.” Its followers, the Jeda, are those who attune their hearts to the voice of Goht, often through silence, fasting, and sacred prayer. The faith teaches that the greatest act is not conquest, but surrender to the divine will—listening purely and acting justly.

Key Symbols and Figures:

- **The Prophet:** In the beginning, this was a nameless figure who authored many of the first books held within the Book of the Remnant. Eventually, as the years passed, this would be attributed to Koory through other documents of the early First Era. The Prophet was the first messenger of Goht to the race of man. He would deliver sermons and teach the blessings and laws of Goht, eventually building the first true church and faith

of the human race. He would prophesy the death of one of the faithful; it was unknown if this was his own or someone else's. This is where the exact identity is known because the brother of Koory, Daryun, would fulfill this prophecy and was known as a devout follower of the faith and even a suspected author of many writings. Nevertheless, the Prophet would be the first head of the church of Jeda, and he would leave a seat empty at his passing. None would come to fill it, and this would leave the faith open to persecution until eventually the Valkorians stopped following as a nation.

- **Circle of Darenir:** A flame-etched ring worn on the right hand, symbolizing the eternal covenant between Goht and the faithful. The circle stands for unbroken devotion, and the flame represents the living voice of Goht, which burns but does not consume. It is a rare symbol even during the height of Jeda.
- **Scroll of the Flame:** Sacred parchment said to contain the first words Koory ever transcribed after hearing Goht's voice. Copies of its verses are etched on temple walls and carried by holy pilgrims. This became the first book of the Book of the Remnant, later known as the Covenant of Jeda.
- **The Psalmist:** An obscure figure revered among both elves and men, the Psalmist is spoken of in hushed tones—nameless, ageless, and ever wandering. Across the lands, tales abound of a human whose name, in its full elvish form, means “Poor Wanderer of God.” Some believe him to be no more than a myth, a symbol of divine inspiration. Others claim he is real — immortal, chosen by Goht, and author of sacred songs spanning thousands of years. Among men, Judas Preiko is most commonly believed to be this figure. Not only do the elves affirm his likeness to the ancient descriptions, but he is also one of the few confirmed humans granted

immortality. Whether he is the Psalmist or merely one among many, his poems — said to be drawn from direct revelation — guide the faithful in how to walk in covenant with the divine.

Core Beliefs:

- *Life is sacred*, for it is breathed by Goht and belongs to Him alone.
- *Mercy reigns above might*—true dominion is not in rule, but in restraint.
- *Temples may crumble, but praise endures*. The true Kingdom is not built with hands but rises from the obedient heart.
- *Prophets are not born of power but of silence*. The greatest among them are not always kings or warriors, but those who *listen well*.

Temple Schism:

At the heart of Jedaism lies a moment of tragic division:

- **Initial Unity:** Koory and Tírun once worshipped side-by-side in the Temple of Belserum, united in word and purpose.
- **The Division:** But when Tírun, tempted by politics, sought to bind the temple to the state, transforming worship into state ritual, Koory walked away.
 - His final sermon—later called *The Judgment of Separation*—echoed through the ages:
“The Temple now bows to a throne, not to the Flame. May Goht’s voice be found where kings dare not listen.”
 - From that day forth, the Jeda became a wilderness faith, preserved not by priestly

bureaucracy but by wanderers, prophets, and hidden saints.

○

Legacy and Fulfillment:

The Jeda faith foresaw the coming of greater voices and deeper shadows. It proclaimed that from its root would grow both judgment and mercy. Judas Preiko, often called the *Last Listener*, is seen by many as the final fulfillment of the Jedan line of prophets—whose writings echo the faith’s ancient cry:

“Praise is the stone. Obedience, the mortar. And the voice of Goht, the breath that builds the eternal sanctuary.”

Major Legends, Lore & Themes

Celéode Tree:

This is a species of tree that grows immensely tall and lives for thousands of years. Very few still inhabit the world, yet they are the only things that can truly attest to the age of Varis Mogul. One of the healthiest examples of this tree is the tree that dwells in the Elven city of Vivik at the very heart of the city, which has the main castle and home of Dramira and Vaxium built into it. These trees are said to be of the pre-dawn times, when it was only Vaeimea and Valkar and the rest of the Talrah. Elven legend tells that Gohtanór holds an endless forest of these trees.

Day of Reclamation:

This is the prophesied final day of the world when the rumours of widespread war and darkness come to be. The sun will darken, seeming to black out as the twin moons become stains of crimson in the sky and as family and plague sweep the world, Valkar will come from the void, his

body his own once more, and he will face Vaeimea. This will be the day that all souls of Vaeimea will be reclaimed by Goht and freed from sin; in tum, they fight the forces of darkness. In glory, Goht will step on the world once more for the first time since the gardens, and He will then bring an end to this world and bid all eternal life in his heaven beyond the veil of the world. This will then call all who lived and died to judgment in the Hall of Gohtar. And with that, the grey veil of the world will recede, and all who are forgiven will seek eternity at peace.

Decree of Man:

Ulfar would address his people in the capital of Valkoria on Onu-Arith on September 13th in the 291st year of the Third Era. Here, Ulfar would make his promise to the realm of man, and in the eyes of many, such as Auréa, Taelmíra, Ariendria, Dramira, and countless other elves who graced the lands of Onu-Arith with their presence, it was again a declaration that the world of man would be the dominant force of this new era. Of the thousands who saw his words come to be right before their eyes, countless more would hear in the days to follow by word of mouth or by message. This would unknowingly be the speech that greatly expanded those willing to bear arms for his crusade.

*Issued by Ulfar Val, King of Valkénor, on the
13th of Setono, in the year of Talor 0291 of the
Third Era*

Recorded by the hands of Judas Preiko

Let it be declared before all nations, across sea and stone, that the age of silence is over. The race of man shall rise again.

I, Ulfar Val, first of my name, king of Valkénor and sword-bearer of Arenith, do proclaim the

birth of a new age. By the honor of Talor and the wisdom of Vekar, I claim the right not only to rule but to restore — not only to defend, but to reclaim.

Long have we dwelt in the lands of exile — scattered, diminished, forgetful of our greatness. But no longer shall we build with borrowed clay or fight beneath foreign skies. The blood of kings flows in our veins, and the fire of our fathers has not gone out.

Therefore, let all who dwell beneath the heavens hear this:

We shall sail across the Ocean of Galilee. We shall set our banners upon the shores of Onu-Derith. And we shall take back the City of Koory — Argolin — our ancient home, stolen but never forgotten.

Upon those lands we shall raise again a kingdom of might and memory, forged in honour and sharpened by war. And here, upon the soil of Onu-Arith, we shall raise its twin — a second kingdom, no less mighty, no less eternal.

Two thrones shall rise. Two realms shall stand. And the world shall know once more the strength of men united.

Let this decree be etched in stone and spoken in every hall: the age of fear is ended. The exile is over. We go not to conquer, but to reclaim. We go not to destroy, but to endure.

So I speak. So it shall be.

In the name of Talor the Just. In the name of
Vekar, All-Father of old.

By right of sword, fire, and flame — I am Ulfar
Val. King of Valkénor. Heir of Argolin. Lord of
the race of men.

Desolation of Valkoria:

Happening during the early years of the third millennium of the First Era the lands of Onu-Derith had become unstable and the once greatest kingdom of men, the Valkorian Empire was far from stable nearing the brink of collapse when there was a famine which swept the lands followed by major floods and slides from the mountains, this pushed the remnants of the Valkorians to flee their native continent for that of Onu-Arith by the year 3100. During the course of the next few thousand years, the Valkorian people would face endless civil wars and the rise and fall of governing bodies until the end of the Second Era, when the rise of the Neirmar Imperium rose to power, until the villages of the east revolted against Queen Deidlee during the early centuries of the Third Era.

Drewen and Llyena:

The romantic yet tragic tale spun of the Telrah Drewen and his love, the human woman Llyena. It is used as a lesson to many elves as a reason not to dare enter any sort of romantic relationship with mortals. Many see this as a pure legend rather than truth, yet Llyena gave birth to twin males, one who would live the life of an elf and the other would come to take the life of a man; these two would come to bear the names of Eluiar and Raseiré. These two would have lines

that were given the single choice of eternal or finite life. This is often told in tandem with other sad tales spun by bards.

Durenstar:

The Durenstar is the brightest of all the stars in the night sky, outshining even that of the northern star. It has been one that has inspired many different pieces of literature, names, and even whole cultures in the times of the First Era. It has always had a deep connection to the elves, as many things it is the true Alundél awaiting the return of Vaeimea to reclaim it and purify the world. The Night of the Durenstar is an event when the star is the only thing visible during the night sky and comes into view during the first month of the new year. On the same night, there is the first snow. This is an odd occurrence which has happened only a few hundred times in history, and anyone who is blessed to be born that night is said to have Vaeimea as their guardian.

Elven Excursion:

The mass exodus of the Dark Elves, Vaidir, during the Second Era, after the city of Courdél was destroyed by a force of Malachar. This led many of the Dark Elves to dwell below the surface of the world in the Narthal Reach. It would eventually play into the mystical aspect of the elves that became more and more prevalent as the world came to the turn of the Third Era, with man seeing few elves.

Erinstihl:

Found at the dawn of the First Era by the elves, it was a mystical and rare metal found in the flesh of the world itself. During the creation of the Alundél, Goht would bring the metal into the world as a by-product of his hand coming in contact with the world. It would be the most difficult metals to work with, requiring a special skill of smithing nearly inconceivable in a mortal life and magics that many metals could only dream of ever possessing. The number of

weapons forged of this metal is few and far between, with only two full suits of armour being forged during the First Era, one by Frenar and the other by Fëalbor. Its mystical properties make it the best for magical items, as imbuing magics into the metal is far easier than actually forging the metal.

Infernal Crisis:

An event of the Second Era that left many scars across the world of Varis Mogul. This event was triggered by a cult known as the Red Dusk, who sought to bring one of the banished Ilékin, Krahn, to the mortal world. In this, they waited for many centuries, planning an assassination attempt on whoever sat on the throne, and then, during the later years of King Uriel XI of Tarédiel's life, they murdered him and his entire direct family, sparing only his brother and his nephews. This crisis would span across all of Onu-Arith and seem across the entire world, yet few places show the scars left like the continent of man. There is no record of the elves even being notified of this crisis, which led to the deaths of tens of thousands of humans. This crisis would mark the end of Tavirel's Taun dynasty and be the catalyst for the nation's collapse in the years following the end of the crisis. Many do believe that each breach that was opened to the Infemum, or realms of the Hand of Valkar, was connected to only Krahn, though it is confirmed by the journal of the figure only known by their title "the Savior of Dragon-Rock" that each gate was linked to a different part of all the domains of the Aeilkin. By what was seemingly a miracle of the gods, this Savior was able to bring an end to the crisis by their own hand.

Mark of creation:

This was a sort of brand that was permanent to the skin of those who were the first to "awake" of the races who served

as the first generation, already adults, allowing for the world to progress instantly. Its shape was a triangle that held four dots inside forming a smaller kite shape within. It was detailed with the Thalorian script “erá” meaning “to be”; this was a reference to the words that Goht had uttered to form the very world these creatures awoke in. To see a Mark of Creation was a sight to behold for most mortals, as their kin who bore them long had fallen into the dirt, meaning it was seen on the immortal and mythical elves, which many humans did not believe truly existed.

Queensbreath:

A small flowered plant that grows in more weedy areas is often confused for a weed itself. Many overlook the healing and medicinal properties left within the plant. It is often referred to as the ‘healing weed’ for its ability to stimulate the healing process for most minor or even medium wounds. One of the most common plants that seemingly grows on all the continents of the world.

Red Spider Lily, Reio-Licty Radia:

It is a beautiful red-petaled flower that grows in a variety of environments, often being something that decorates places where there has been death and comes to bear on the graves of those who have fallen. Often called the hell flower or referred to as a bad omen amongst many cultures and people in the world of Varis Mogul. The Valkorians see it as something called the ‘Iron Flower’, a flower which can even withstand the harshest of environments. Its resilient nature is taken as a symbol to many Valkorians by the Third Era that perhaps their people, just like the flower native to their lands, will rise once again.

Symbol of Legionist:

This is a symbol typically worn in amulet fashion. It is a steel chain with a simple iron cross pendant that also holds

the northern star in the very centre. It is a common piece of jewellery for soldiers to have as it is cheap and quite fashionable in the main cities of the Neimar Imperium. Though many who had one were commanders or in positions of leadership within the ranks of the military.

The Prophecy of the Last Dawn:

When the last descendant of the kings of men arises, the shadow that once slew his ancestors shall again seek to darken the world. But with the will of the divine and the aid of the ancient ones, he shall strike down the evil that once sought to consume all. In the aftermath, a new era shall dawn, where mankind shall rise as the protectors of the world, and the elves, weary from the trials of history, shall find their rest in the heavens through prayer. This is the prophecy of the end times and was said to be a divine revelation revealed to King Hurgon just days before he died by accident.

Artefacts

Alundél:

Given to Vaeimea during the predawn years of Varis Mogul when it still lay as the pure and perfect garden of the world, Goht entrusted her with the idol for the sole purpose of creation. Though Valkar grew angered by this and revolted against Goht, beginning the fall, letting all evil and death into the world. Vaeimea would use the item to create all the races and living creatures of the world, then would bestow the gift upon the elves to help them combat the fact that their bodies would wear with time in the fallen world. It was then hunted again by Valkar and was the core object of his War of Vengeance. Eventually, it would begin to fade, and the

greatest of all elven smiths, Frenar, would seek to store the power in five gems, though he would succeed in storing the power in three of the gems, known as the Luminar, whichí would come to be lost on the world of Varis Mogul.

Amulet of the Kings:

Also referred to as the Amulet of Hónir. Forged by Hónir during the First Era, it is an item of extreme value and meaning to the Valkorian people. It became the symbol of the Valkorian Kings from Hónir until it was lost after the death of Talar. The Amulet was forged with a gem given to the father of Hónir, Hurgon, which was said to be the reason that his family was levied a curse. The gift was from the hands of the Dark Lord himself, and Hónir saw it as an opportunity to smite Valkar and make the gem he cursed be a blessing to the Kings of Valkoria.

Arda, “The Bracelet of Life”:

This was Vaeimea’s gift to Vaxar, the first High King of the Thalaré. It was a symbol of his guardianship of the lives forged by the power of the Alundél by Vaeimea and served as a gift to her first creations. As he descended further into the love he shared for Kelana, the birth of his son would give him the perfect opportunity to place the power bestowed upon his people in the hands of someone who he knew would live much longer than he, his son Vaxium. Though Vaxium rarely uses the power of the bracelet, he wears it as a stark reminder of his father’s own self-pity and greed, which in his mind was his downfall.

Arenith:

It was crafted by the hands of an unknown smith and given to the first King of Valkoria, Tírun, during the later centuries of the first millennium. The sword is one of the few forged out of erinstihl and bears the runes of languages long lost to history. At the turn of the Third Era, this blade had been

forgotten by many who were not students of history. The blade stands slightly longer than even a hand-and-a-half sword.

Codex Prismaris:

The book was written by the hand of Eins Ocu Shae, that detailed his magical practices and how he eventually created his paradise in which he would escape Varis Mogul for. The book itself was said to be made of a unique form of parchment that was found nowhere else in the world, along with an odd leather binding and cover upon which was inscribed in red ink and an unknown rune and language. The book itself would be filled with almost two hundred and fifty pages detailing various runes, rituals, and spells that would allow for portals to various realms such as the Void, each of the five levels of the Infernum, and even his own paradise. Very few could read the runes and language he used to inscribe it, and many attributed this book to why the Infernal Crisis occurred, as it gave the cult a way to access Krahn's plane of the Infernum.

Shadowcleave:

The sword forged by Fëalbor for the great Vamir warrior Numenonálé was said to be one of the greatest blades ever crafted. It is the only blade of Varis Mogul to cause injury to any of the Eleikin, which includes both Vaeimea and Valkar. It was a hand and a half sword which was said to have an ethereal glow, blue as if the very light of the twin moons always reflected off the reflective erinstihl. It was lost to history for many years and was later found and wielded by the great wizard Travers Aramir.

Weapon of Talmek:

These were blades forged by the human smith Halvar Eldaric in the ancient Forge of Gondol in the First Era. They were said to be imbued with the dark magics of Valkar and said to

be a gruelling and painful death. These cursed blades are often wielded by the Nirinathé or other dark creatures born by the first Dark Lord. Very few have even been held in the hands of living mortals, as they often turn to dust or even bring the hands of those touching them to burn or even ash. Each one was a different style and was forged as the legendary swords and blades of those fools who dared trust the promises of Valkar.

Magic System

The magic system of the world is quite expansive and one that many, even of the Guild of Mystic Arts, do not fully or truly understand. They know from the writings and world of Anteantodo that there are at the very least fifteen tiers of magic power levels, each tier containing spells that grew in complexity and power. Anteantodo, who would perhaps be one of the most knowledgeable people to ever grace the world of Varis Mogul in the aspects of Magic, even in his almost four hundred years of life, considered himself to be nothing but a novice in the workings of magic. He had once mentioned that this was an unnatural creation of the fallen world, which was seemingly more living than anything, and one should be wary when playing in the affairs of Goht. The fifteen tiers would be a system which many would never come to know, yet few mortals would ever venture beyond the fourth tier.

Spells

Encarsé:

It is a tenth-tier concealment spell used to hide an aspect of a location from all that comes to pass it by. It is often used by darker forces to conceal their locations or movements.

Dolhas vanal arda hamel anterior:

A spell used by Travers Aramir while in the ruins of Zhal Durath. It is a spell of the tenth tier, yet one which is used to counteract any concealment spell

Ghotarium Ismaiel Arda:

An immense spell that is above a tenth tier, which seemingly summoned an unknown power from the heavens above, resulting in a red bolt of lightning to come down from the sky and strike the wizard who called the spell. It was this spell that seemingly decimated the structure of Zhal Durath, displacing the darkness that lay in wait.

Rielara:

A spell that has a soothing tone when cast as a spell and spoken specifically by elves. The spell has a soothing or relaxing effect on those it is cast upon. Initially, it was first used in more friendly ways to benefit allies and those around you by calming nerves and anxiety.

Välé:

This was less a spell and more a single word spoken by what seemed to be the very voice of all existence itself, one which did not blow to any born or created. As in this very moment, the memories of Travers Aramir once had before his time on the plain of Varis Mogul. The voice rang with a sense of purity; it seemed to be what gave the vigour and essence of all life to what grew and died upon the world, a tone that still rang of immortality.

APPENDIX D

REALMS AND PLACES

Continents & Major Regions

Aurellian Forest:

It is the largest forest on the expansive continent of Onu-Derith and is home to the wizard Mikel Sovéran, who looks over the mystical forest. This place is also home to a few wood elves and countless wildlife. During the times when the world felt the darkness of either Valkar or Malachar, this forest struggled to survive and often would show the first signs of the coming darkness. Its trees were said to speak a language of their own, and legends would say that some of the trees and plants would move, and the forest's shape would change over the course of centuries. Held within was the hidden pass to the city of Elendaiél.

Dalmulog:

These are the barren yet not lifeless plains that once marked the roaming lands of the horse lords until the War of Elves and Men took its bloody ravages there. The land sat as the plains separating the northernmost mountains of the region of Vouldorth on the continent of Pharolax and the lands of man on Onu-Derith. There was unprecedented rain during the few weeks before the battle, turning them into the marshes, which would be the mummifying tombs of thousands of Men and Elves. Even after thousands of years, the plains still sit with water on their surface, and often it is said that some puddles will bear a crimson mist from the

endless blood spilled on these lands. The horse lords had mostly been slain in the battle, and the few who dared travel through the marshes tell stories of men and elves still fighting beyond the grave; some have even told of the weapons, armour, and bones of those becoming one with nature.

Hundabald Mountains:

Mountains at the southernmost parts of Arkámendrón, home to a tribe of Visender, snow elves, that have not been heard from in far too long. There have been legends spun that a drake with the powers of the dragons of the First Era dwells within the ancient city of Talen, which dwelt within the mountain built in the snowy high peaks. This range is also home to the Hundabald Orcs, a strain of the Ugha-alé that are stronger, fiercer, and faster than their normal counterparts, which is a seeming adaptation to the harsher conditions.

Narthal Reach:

This is a great chasm which lies beneath a great expanse of the world. It is home to all sorts of life, ranging from the Vaidir to the cave elves who dwelt here long before the rest. It is a home of misfits and mercenary bands that seek a hidden refuge as their base of operations. It is a haven to the undead of the world, being a place with the absence of both sunlight and starlight, only that of the dual stones, which shine a softened light upon the darkened place. It is a unique and ominous place where only the lost or those who seek escape go.

Ocean of Galilee:

This is the small ocean that separates the lands of Onu-Derith and the continent to the northeast, Onu-Arith. It was named after the legendary ship that went by the Minister

of Galilee, which ended up sinking between the two continents early in the history of the First Era.

Onu-Arith:

In the Elven language of Thalorian, it translates to “the Jewel of Hope,” and in the ancient tongue of the Valkorians, it means “Bastion of Hope,” showing that even in its early dates, it was recognized for the possible importance of the continent. This was indeed the bastion of the hope that many surviving Valkorians fled to after the cataclysmic events of the First Era’s Desolation of Valkoria. Their land had a widespread famine, and many of the houses sought the shores of new lands to settle with hopes of having a new beginning that could give them a new promise in life. This would lead to the families seeking power, and though they left their home, the war that had begun never ceased.

Onu-Derith:

Home of the Valkorian people, who were displaced during the First Era to the sister continent of Onu-Arith. It is an expansive continent that, at its southernmost section, connects to the continent of Pharolax with a mountain range dividing them. It has some of the most beautiful scenery and is the place to which Ulfar seeks to return to his people, so someday, he dreams of the green plains as a promised land, one that has been waiting for its people's return. The land is one that even thousands of years after still teems with the remnants and long forgotten relics of the Valkorian people, foretelling that one day, they shall return to this land and reclaim their lost knowledge and culture. There is a single prophecy that was long lost to history and became something of a mere legend, which told of a Valkorian reclamation that would occur during the times of the return of the Line of Valin.

Sandurin Peaks:

A smaller mountain range to the west of the continent of Onu-Arith, lying in the middle of the continent, held the ruins of Zhal Durath. It was a place where few dared to ever go, as during the times of the War of Vengeance, Valkar inhabited the fortress for just a few years, forever tainting the space with his fallen nature and darkness.

Tellmithe Range:

The large and perilous range of mountains that spans the northeastern part of the continent of Onu-Arith. These mountains are notorious for being jagged and having endless tunnels carved out within them. Many who dare to venture to these mountains will find themselves lost in the caves and running out of food and water within days.

Vouldorth:

Surrounded by three of the largest mountain ranges in the world, the region, also known as the Plains of Hell and the Forever Shadow, is the home of all things evil in the world. Sitting near the relative middle of the region is Mount Vagar, which is the largest active volcano in the world. Both Valkar and Malachar called this region their home during the campaigns, with Valkar being the only one to gain a sure foothold outside the region with Zhal Durath and other fortresses. This desolate place is no home to the lesser mortals of the world and is seen as one place no man ever should have to see. Sitting just south of its northern mountain ranges, the Trell Mountains, is the main fortress of Dur-Vagar, built by Malachar during the Second Era. There are only two gates into the land to the south of Dolin's Pass, where Valkar had a large gate constructed. And then to the north east on the border with Onu-Derith, Malachar constructed a second gate, making invasion of the region a difficult task.

Key Sites

Courdél:

The once vast surface city of the Vaidir dwelt in the southwestern part of Onu-Derith, just west of the Plains of Dalmulog. Its walls and structure were almost gothic in nature, having height and jagged points quite different from the soft and round structures of the Vamir. This was home to many thousands of dark elves after the ending of the War of Elves and Men, though it is no longer the haven for them that it once was during the Second Era. Malachar decimated the city, leaving most of it in ruin, the same as the Vamir city of Dremor. This prompted what was known as the Elven Excursion during the Second Era, leading to the Vaidir becoming a rarity and sometimes a mythic being to many mortals on the surface.

Crevice of Latarvia:

This desolate and powerful cut in the earth is the place where Valkar's first body was destroyed, though it left an open wound in the world as if to signify the loss and fall of Valkar and its toll on the world. Its depths would be home to the Forge of Harendol, which was set hundreds of feet into the surface of the planet. This is the place where many dark objects of the world would come to be forged, which crafted many of the darkest weapons and items of the world. It was the home to the forge of both Valkar and Malachar during their times as Dark Lord. Not much is known other than the apparent dangers of the forge due to the immense heat and jagged path to the forge itself.

Deidara:

An elegant yet humble city that makes its living on the open farm lands of Onu-Arith. Here, the family of one of the greater houses of ancient Valkoria would send off members to claim this land. After the passage of thousands of years, the city would face fires and sieges, decimating much of it, with very few buildings being much more than a hundred

years old. This is in line with many towns of Onu-Arith and is made almost entirely out of wood. Many people of the city have learned to prefer the delicacies of minding their own business and have been one of the few towns to remain neutral in the ongoing civil war until they finally threw their swords in with Ulfar.

Dremor:

The vast city that one lay in the heart of the Isle of Mahri. During the latter half of the First Era and over half of the Second Era, it was second only to the high city of Vivik amongst the elves in terms of popularity and sanctity among them. It was a home to a varied group of Vanir called the Dremar, who were much more akin to living life amongst other races and often seen by those in Vivik as lesser or more peasant-like creatures, yet still revered as brothers and sisters. The leader of this city was none other than the only daughter of Vaxium and Dramira, Auréa.

Dur-Vagar:

The immense fortress built by the minions of the Dark Lord during the Second Era. This would come after Malachar was exiled from the lands of the elves in the ending years of the First Era, and after he struck down both Féalbor and Celëfaéor after they had figured out the dark ways of the man. The fortress would comprise many unfathomable towers that were said to be taller than the mountains, yet it also had the sheer size to raise and hold the large army of orcs that was sworn to Malachar. It was forged with some of the magic techniques, though not all were known well enough to be used. It would take many decades, spanning just around two hundred and fifty years, to complete. It was the core base of Malachar, and if he ever ran into trouble, he would immediately flee back to this fort. It was said his very soul was bound to the fortress, making it one of the few places on Varis Mogul where none wished to venture.

Elendaiél:

This is a small vale hidden in the jagged cliffs of Onu-Derith's western coast. With the use of elven magic, it can be hidden from all who are not wanted there. It is the home of Lord Eluiar and is the kingdom he leads as one of the last few hidden kingdoms of elves. His daughter Ariendria is the princess of the land, and his son Ardenfell is the prince and lord if Eluiar dares to leave the city. During the times of the Valkorians, the city had yet to be founded, or else they may have provided the help and support to the humans during the War of Elves and Men, perhaps never breaking the Line of Valin. Though in the Second Era it became a haven of safety for travellers of all races. The grandfather of Ulfar, Arodir Carasan, dwells within the halls as a great friend of the Wood Elves.

Forge of Harendol:

The great forge that lies within the Crevice of Latarvia in the deep reaches of Vouldorth. It is a scar forever left upon the world that was taken advantage of by the minions of Valkar and even himself during the First Era. he would make this one of the few forges that used the very heat of the world's core itself to melt and forge some of the strongest items ever smithed by the hand of Varis Mogul.

Forge of Gondol:

Lying in the northern reaches of Onu-Derith, it is the forge that draws the heat of flowing lava to power its forge. The forge was the very place where Hónir crafted the Amulet of the Kings during the First Era and was said to be one of the few places on the planet where items of that magical and mystical prowess could be destroyed for good. Idril, sister of Hónir and second surviving child of Hurgon drew the building that surrounded the forge, during the First Era.

Mount Vagar:

This is the largest and most fearsome of all the mountains of the region of Vouldorth. It is one of the most powerful volcanoes that has been used a few times in history to cover the light of the sun and create a shroud of darkness on the world. It has been dormant since the flight and assumed death of Malachar during the Second Era. It is often one of the most important parts of any Dark Lord's plans, as it gives his creatures the cover of darkness, protecting those sensitive to the lights of the world

Nithralié Falls:

They are the most beautiful waterfalls in the world, lying within the southeastern region of the continent of Onu-Derith. It is a place that is said to have the cleanest water. It is as if there is nothing in front of you, perfectly crystal clear. Very few have had the privilege to see these falls, yet all know of them through the tales and legends which surround the seemingly mystical place.

Sanctum of Berenith:

It was a revered sanctuary of the Salvic faith, being one of the oldest buildings on the continent. It was the first place targeted by Anne as it held many statues and documents relating to the Scalvic faith. The stained glass had many depictions, and one of which held the Alundél and was one of the only places that had a human rendition of the object. It was the most beautiful building and one which Ulfar spent much time restoring to its former glory.

Talen:

This is the Visender city that lies within the highest peaks of the Hundabald Mountains in the southern region of Arkámëndrón. It was one of the most expensive cities and was the home of one of the two kingdoms of the Sindaré. This was one which had gone silent for the last few centuries, which had left the high elves of the land with a

sense of fear for what their snow elf kin would find within or call to the mountain.

The Parcival:

The once beautiful chapel was a key stop in pilgrimages of the Scalvic faith, yet it was reorganized to be the head monastery of the faith, led by Zek Judd. It was a solid fort with limited stone, yet plenty of wood to reinforce the place to make it much more of a fortress than a religious site. It was a symbol of an old religion that Anne sought to destroy.

Valkoria (City):

Capital city of the Neirmar Imperium and largest city on the continent of Onu-Arith. There are very few who know of its true roots, in that the Hykellion Kingdom had built nearly half the city before the king had sought the comfort of Vingólf instead. It was a strong and hard-to-penetrate fortress that would require having soldiers on the inside to siege without massive loss of life. It was a beautiful white city which upheld its name as a reference to the endless white cities of the Valkorian Empire.

Vivik:

The greatest city of elves was made in tandem with the great tree of the elves. It was a beautiful place and a dream to man, its white stone would be the sole inspiration for the Valkorian cities. As the main city of Valendriel, it was the hub of all elven activity and the home of the Lady Dramira, who made sure the city was a reflection of her own majesty. The canopy of trees that covered the city seemed to let in all the sunlight of the day but would shelter out the harsh weather of the world while allowing the beautiful light of the twin moons and stars into the city below. Many human folk tales would reference the sheer beauty of the city, which no words of any human language could do justice to.

Zhal Durath:

This ancient fortress was once the proud fort of Valkar during the First Era. This was built as a foothold in the lands of men, giving the Dark Lord a way to watch over the humans he was seducing to his armies, though he ultimately failed and abandoned the fortress when Drewen and Llyena took back the Alundél from the Dark Lord. This place would fall to ruin and become an orc stronghold during the years after Valkar's defeat, and eventually Malachar would come to find it and hide there for some time during his war in the Second Era.

Maps

“What is a tale without the soil beneath its feet, the stars above its sky, or the rivers by which its blood runs?” — Dramira

In every great saga, there lies not only the might of kings or the rise of fallen gods, but the land beneath them—the soil that soaks up their blood, the peaks that witness their triumphs, and the sea that carries whispers of their legacy. A world without shape is but a tale untethered; it floats, meaningless, in the void. To give it land is to give it *weight*. To give it place is to give it *truth*.

Varis Mogul is such a world.

This appendix begins with a series of maps meant to anchor the reader in the lands where legends unfold. First is the world map of Varis Mogul itself—etched in old glass and inked by the scholars of Arkámëdrón, it shows the greater form of the planet as known to those who still dare chart the heavens and the seas. From distant Mahri to the burning isles of Semakai, to the forgotten polar realms where light never sets, the world is vast, yet always converging upon the thrones of men and the wills of the gods.

Next, we turn to Onu-Arith, the northeastern continent and cradle of this first tale. It is here that the bloodline of Valkoria once ruled, and where, in the shadow of tyranny and time, a spark is struck again. Onu-Arith is a continent of fractured realms—where ancient forests whisper with elven memory, where dwarven halls lie buried beneath mountains long overrun, and where the cities of man rise only to fall under the weight of their own ambition. From the Vale of Nausica to the high walls of Ysengard, it is a land ever at war with itself, and ever reaching for the divine.

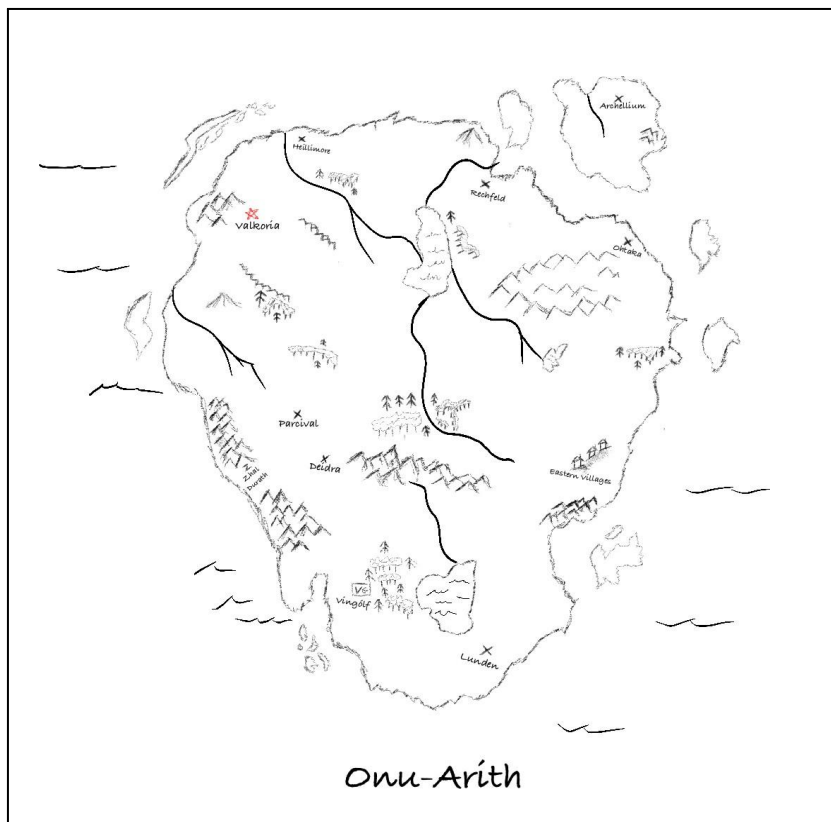
Finally, we descend to the city of Valkoria—a name both sacred and cursed. Once the gleaming heart of an empire forged in blood and bound by faith, it now stands as the last destination of Ulfar Val's march and the first battlefield of his destiny. Within these walls, old powers sleep, traitors reign, and the dreams of a fallen people await resurrection. Valkoria is not merely a city—it is a symbol, a wound, a throne, and a grave.

These maps do not simply show terrain; they bear the weight of prophecy, the paths of conquest, and the footsteps of those who shaped the world. May they guide you not only through geography, but through legacy, belief, and the shape of the song that binds light and dark.

Varis Mogul



Onu-Arith (~3E 250)



APPENDIX E

TIMELINE AND CALENDARS

The Vamel Calendar

Used by the Vamir and the Valkorians, it is the oldest known calendar in the world, along with being one of the most accurate versions of the single-year calendar. It is composed of 12 months, with each month having thirty or thirty-one days, except for the second month of the year, which only has twenty-eight. And once every four years, that month will have another day, and that is a standard leap year.

- **Jeverans [31]**
 - [15] Winter Solstice marks the shortest and coldest day of the year.
- **Helor [28]**
- **Mirokole [31]**
- **Megah [30]**
- **Augun [31]**
- **Jule [30]**
 - Summer Veil
 - The collection of 3 days before the summer solstice and 3 days after spans seven total days.
 - [21] Summer Solstice (occasionally shifts to the 20th or 22nd).
- **Vaeim [31]**
- **Maeror [31]**
- **Setono [30]**

- [1] Autumn begins.
- **Vekir [31]**
 - Moorin's day
 - The last lunar cycle of autumn begins.
- **Nostoto [30]**
 - Veil of the Dying Moons
 - A set of four days in which the twin moons go a deep crimson as they hit their closest point to the planet during each 365-day revolution.
 - Alundé - Day of Remembrance
 - A day set on the 30th day of the month, it marks the end of Autumn and the beginning of the long winter
- **Olokhar [31]**

Historical Timeline

First Era: 5000 years

The First Era was the ushering of the world as a whole, bringing in the beginning of both mortal and immortal life on the lands of Varis Mogul, which was the first command of Goht. These were the golden years of the Elves when a vast majority of the most legendary names did the deeds which immortalised them in song and ink. This would also be an Era defined by the great war with Valkar, known as the War of Vengeance. The Elves and Men would become prominent during this time period, yet the collapse of the Valkorian Line of Valin would lead to a sharp decline in the greatest of all Kingdoms of Man.

0000: Awakening of the Elves in the lands of Varis Mogul.

0001: Dwarves begin to awaken in their burst of creation, such sub-species as the Dumas, Dakar, and Damar form as each sect specializes in their own crafts.

0780-90: Coming of the first generations of Humans to the world of Varis Mogul.

1022: Hurgon is given a mysterious gem from the looming figure of Valkar, which he takes without hesitation.

1145: Hónir would come to possess the gem which Valkar gave to Hurgon as his father descended into madness with the death of all but two of his seven children, Hónir and Idril.

1157: Hurgon, the second King of Valkoria, would fall on his own sword, killing him in a painful, long death as he bled out over the course of a day, alone.

1158: Though Hurgon died only a year prior, Idril and Hónir had lost their father years before; it took her all these years to convince her brother to forge the Amulet of the Kings.

1160: Hónir would declare the Amulet of the Kings the symbol of the Valkorian King from henceforth; it would also serve as an item that decided the legitimacy of the king, as it would have an emerald hue rather than the red which others who held the Amulet would see.

1174: War of Vengeance begins with the arrival of Valkar on the continent of Igodan.

1246: Coming of the Orcs to the world, first seen as tortured and demented beings who were once elves.

1841: Hykellion Kingdom was founded by Rijarl the Greater, prompting the building of two cities on the continent of Onu-Arith, Vingólf and Valkoria.

1867: Vingólf is finished and is chosen as the capital of the Kingdom, making it bound with magic and turned into the impenetrable fortress that would stand as legend in the Third Era.

1973: War of Vengeance ends with the destruction of the physical body of Valkar by the hands of Eldarion.

2676: Beginning of the War of Elves and Men with the murder of Tavar and the declaration of war by Draxel.

2711: Disappearance of Draxel, the lord of the Vaidir, who began war with the men of the Valkorian Kingdom.

2712: Death of Talor at the hands of a human host named Melin at the Battle of the Dalmulog.

2714: Ending of the War of Elves and Men and reclamation of the Amulet of the Kings, though it lacks the green emerald hues that it had when Talor wore it. It now carries a red color and begins to wear on the morals of General Talku, prompting him to kill his fellow General Cartem.

3051: Desolation of Valoria occurs after the loss of the Amulet with the death of General Hood, who only claims stewardship over the lands for four years.

3521: The Amulet of the Kings is found by the creature Greyon while travelling in the lands of Onu-Derith, almost five hundred years after the Desolation of Valoria.

3967: Appearance of a new Orc crossbreed called the Ugha-alé.

4999: Ending the First Era, the world became the time which was encapsulated by the first three thousand years, which was dominated by the constant struggle of light and dark, a song which would forever stir in the lands of Varis Mogul.

Second Era: 5000 years

As the world turned to its next period of time, its Second Era. The world had faced the coming of its first Dark Lord, Valkar. Yet the power of the elves awoken in the dawn of time was just enough, filled with the power of being graced with the Alundél, had the power to form the bastion of light to triumph over the darkness. Here, the world would once again face the tides of darkness, ones which rose in the ashes of Valkar, seeking not to be him, yet to replace him, to rise where he fell. Though the power of a man, even one who had the blood of an Ilékin and even with the titlings of immortal power, could never reach the strength of the Eleikin. The coming of Malachar would be the dominant event of history, which would change the tides of the world and seemingly would prompt the changing of the world's guard, from the elves to man, for the time of one would end and the next would begin.

3300: Malachar declares his War of Shadows.

3459: Destruction of the city of Courdél by the hands of Malachar during his War of Shadows.

3460: The Elven Excursion begins after the destruction of Courdél. This is the flight of the Vaidir, dark elves, to the chasm below the world, the Narthal Reach.

3584: Malachar reaches the Isle of Mahri ranging forth to the city of Dremor laying waste to it and ending the lives of many elves.

3885: Malachar faces Vaxium in the city of Vivik, being injured by the Elven King, he flees, ending the War of Shadows.

3901: Various parts of Malachar's ship, armour, and banners are found in the oceans of the world as the sounds of orcs within Vouldorth fade, giving an assumed death to the Dark Lord,

though the war took many more lives of Elves born in the First Era, dwindling their numbers even more.

4005: Various smaller forces come to be across the world, still fighting in the name of Malachar, yet they are put down with ease, giving even more belief to the death of Malachar.

4121: The Crevice of Latarvia stops emitting smoke to the skies of the world, which was seemingly yet another piece of evidence that served to be the supposed ending of Malachar.

4900-60: Ava Hargath conspired with Heimarr Seidel, eventually taking the money of the wealthy Hargath family to hire Veileiar mercenaries to win a civil war and establish the Neimarr Imperium.

4966: The ancient city of Valkoria would be rebuilt and resurrected, becoming the first capital of the Neimarr Imperium.

Third Era: 5000 years

The Third Era is a young time, one which has seen few movements of the elves, and those who have ventured from their starlight cities are few and far between, as by the ten thousandth year of the world, the elves have grown weary of being pure beings in a fallen world. Those who still draw breath from the First Era and the times before the War of Vengeance have accepted that the time of the elves protecting and being the main race of the world is coming to an end, and in this Third Era, they must help the kingdoms of man grow to the prowess of protecting the world from the forces of darkness.

0220: Aelfred's Rebellion begins with the help of many friends from his childhood.

0231: Ulfar Val is born to Aelfred and Lalia Val.

0241: Aelfred returns to his home to celebrate the tenth birthday of his son, Ulfar, yet is taken away to fight in the civil war he began twenty years prior.

0250: Deidlee Hargath would come to break, she would lay fire across many areas of her kingdom, burning peasants and nobles alike, she would come to be known as “the Mad Queen”.

0251: Deidlee Hargath is slain by the sword of the Lord Commander of the Queen’s guard, Sir Jamie Haren.

0288: Ulfar would declare his uprising after the Imperium attacked his villages. His quest to Valkoria would only take a few months, as the seeds sown by his father Aelfred during his uprising would be grown to help Ulfar on his conquest.

0289: Ulfar takes Valkoria and works towards forming the new kingdom, abandoning the title of the Neirmar Imperium.

0289: The volcanoes and mountains of Vouldorth erupt for the first time since the middle of the Second Era.

0291: Ulfar claims the throne and establishes Valkénor, after the Marriage of Him and Ariendria.

0291: Ulfar delivers the Decree of Man.